Waxing/Waning

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26345317.

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Mature

Archive Warnings:
Rape/Non-Con, Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), drunk!Adora (She-Ra), infected!She-ra (She-ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Episode: s02e05 White Out, Hurt/Comfort, Childhood Trauma, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Rape/Non-con, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Friendship/Love, Happy Ending, Complete

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by ST_Thorns

Summary

Catra successfully captures Adora at the Northern Reach, bringing her back as a prisoner to the Horde, along with She-ra's infected sword. The plan is simple: Use infected!She-ra to squash the Rebellion. But, things get complicated when Catra isn't the only one who wants control of Adora.

Notes

Please read tags and warnings before reading. I won't be writing explicit rape/non-con content, but it will be heavily referenced. Don't let the beginning of this first chapter fool you, this shit will get uncomfortable.

I've taken some liberties with this story because that's what fanfic writers do. Elements do not line up perfectly with S02E05, even if the story starts around there. You'll all figure it out. :)

The Talk

"UGHHHH!!"

"Glimmer! What's wrong?" Adora jumped up from her spot on the floor, ready, at once, for a fight.

"Everything is just so, so . . . FRUSTRATING!" Glimmer threw her hands up in emphasis.

Adora was standing in Glimmer's room in Bright Moon where things had, one minute ago, been fine. Adora's fists were up and expecting a Horde soldier or Catra or, at least, Glimmer's mother. Now Glimmer was pacing around the room very much not in a fighting stance. Adora was left disoriented and asking, "What are you talking about?"

"The Horde is everywhere. My mom doesn't trust me. My powers are limited. Everyone is mad at me. It goes on and on and ON," Glimmer listed, talking faster, grittier with every word. She flushed red as her anger spilled outwards.

Adora's hands fell to her sides as she watched the colossal meltdown unfold in front of her. She was not prepared for this. Glimmer could be so scary.

"AND when we think we have a shot to relax - we can't! You know why?" Glimmer's eyes were wild as she faced Adora. Adora opened her mouth, but it became immediately clear that Adora was not supposed to reply. Glimmer answered her own question saying, "Because every time we do, something bad happens."

Adora reminded herself about rhetorical questions, which Bow had explained to her just last week. While Adora thought, Glimmer let out a string of explicit words with a practiced, harsh anger as she paced back and forth. The edge of her voice made Adora wince. This language would never be tolerated at the Horde. Adora's

eyes moved side to side watching her, the rest of her body unmoving.

Adora grabbed Glimmer by the shoulder, trying to emulate Bow, but the gesture was too rough and too abrupt. Bow was much, much better at feelings. “Take a breath.”

“A breath!?” Glimmer groaned, pulling on her hair. “Adora, that is EXACTLY what I’m talking about!” Okay, so that didn’t work. Adora watched as Glimmer paced, hands in her hair. Sometimes, she grunted. Sometimes, she took an especially heavy step.

“Glimmer, what are you talking about?” Adora asked again.

Glimmer let out a particularly dramatic sigh and said, “I am totally stressing!” punctuating the last two words with a shrill voice. The tone made Adora want to make an exit to the door impossibly far behind her.

“I, uh, I can see that,” Adora said as she anxiously pushed the tips of both her pointer fingers together.

“Ugh, Adora,” Glimmer responded, drawing out the final ‘a’ in Adora’s name.

“We could . . . spar? Yeah!” Adora lit up as she spoke. “That always helps me when I’m stress-”

“-No, I do not want to spar, Adora!” Glimmer said. Why did she keep saying Adora’s name like that? “I want to sleep. I want to win. I want to feel like we’re not just running in circles.” Adora did not point out that Glimmer had been walking in circles for the last two minutes. Glimmer took several breaths, finally working her way towards calmness.

“UGHHHH!!”

Or not.

“I can’t eat or shower or sleep or, or even masturbate without thinking about the Horde!” Glimmer groaned.

Adora stared at Glimmer, frozen in place, and muttered quietly out of the side of her mouth, “Um, what’s that, uh, last thing you just said?”

“Oh my god, Adoraaaaa,” Glimmer groaned. Adora was looking at her in that way she sometimes did, head cocked slightly with a confused frown on her face. Glimmer stared at her awhile, mouth gaping. She became so embarrassed for Adora that she no longer could stay embarrassed for herself. Finally she huffed and said, more to herself than anyone, “Of course the Horde doesn’t have sex education. Why would they do AN-Y-THING good for the world?”

Adora, who was way more fearful now than when Glimmer was screaming, took a step back.

“Adora, sit down,” Glimmer said crossly, apparently finding a distraction from her fit.

“I, I think I’ll stand,” Adora said, shuffling backwards again. She did not like this change in Glimmer’s focus and she did not like that it was directed at her.

“Sit down!” Glimmer commanded.

“Okay, yep, yes ma’am.” So Adora stiffly sat down with her hands in her lap and her whole body rigid. She found something interesting to stare at on the floor as her face flushed hotly.

Glimmer rubbed her face with her hands. Why wasn’t Bow here? Why did she always have to do this? How was this Horde soldier trained to be a killer but not taught basic human - ANYTHING? “I am too young to have to give ‘the talk,’” she whined to no one.

Adora was feeling increasing levels of discomfort and was searching for any way to get out of this situation. “I, um-”

“I have to do it. It’s for your own good.” God, Glimmer was a martyr.

Adora clenched her teeth, eyes wide as Glimmer sat down. Then it was silent for a moment. Glimmer had opened her mouth several times and closed it without saying anything as she became flustered. The silence stretched on until Adora broke it, “Um, are we . . . are we done here or-”

Glimmer let out an enormous sigh to cut Adora off. Seriously, what was that? How did she make such a loud sound out of breathing? “Adora, we need to talk about sex.”

“Sex?” Adora swallowed as her mouth went dry. This was not something they had breached yet in their friendship.

“Yes,” Glimmer said.

“I know what that is,” Adora said, making a brushing motion with one of her hands, feigning arrogance. “The other cadets, you know,” she trailed off with a nervous laugh, squirming under Glimmer’s gaze which was becoming more and more severe with each word.

“What do you know?” Glimmer said. Oh god, she sounded so much like her mother. “You obviously don’t know what masturbation is,” she said heavy with accusation.

“Yeah, that, that’s a new word for me,” Adora said. And more quietly, “Not sure how you could tell.” Adora rubbed the back of her head with her hand, willing distance between her and Glimmer as her skin reddened. But Glimmer only got closer to her face, one of her eyes twitching uncontrollably.

This was the worst. “Listen, I don’t want to do this ever again so if I have kids, it’s YOUR job to introduce the subject. So listen up now. You know when we get older we got our periods and started . . . um,” Glimmer was honestly going to die, “you know, having urges?” Glimmer frowned, feeling absolutely mortified.

Adora stared at her, blinking, but tight lipped. There was a lump in Adora's throat that was impossibly big.

"Like, sexual urges?" Glimmer pressed, voice inflecting upwards as she finished the question, cringing.

Adora turned very red. "Oh, oh Glimmer. Okay, this I know something about. We don't have to get into details."

"Are you. . . sure?" Glimmer said, looking Adora up and down. Glimmer was not sure.

"Yeah, I mean, like you know," Adora said as she motioned very aggressively at her vagina. Glimmer put her face in her hands and groaned. To save her friend some of the burden, Adora said, "Yeah, I get that. I mean other cadets had . . . um, relations. We didn't get a lot of privacy and it was strictly prohibited to, uh touch each other." She paused. "I saw some other kids get disciplined for doing stuff to each other with . . . with their hands?"

Glimmer's sparkle of hope died down. She took a deep breath, refocused, and started in. "You're, at least, not totally clueless." Adora frowned. Glimmer didn't care. "Sex is not a bad thing. When you like someone or even if you're just horny." Glimmer paused, looking at Adora who was squirming in her seat. "You know what sex is?"

"Yeah I mean-"

"-Sex can be a lot of things," Glimmer said thoughtfully. "It's not just, you know, penises, vaginas, other stuff in your pants." Adora stared hard into the floor, eyes somehow even wider than before and cheeks even redder. "It . . . it can be. But it can be more. You can use your hands or your mouth or just," Glimmer smashed her palms together, " . . . push stuff together!"

"Glimmer . . . ."

“Okay, you get that?” Glimmer rushed. Her clothes felt impossibly tight and she was sure every time she saw Adora the rest of her life it was going to be weird.

“Yes. I mean, come on do you know Catra? Of course she found out about this . . . .”

“Oh . . .” Glimmer said, embarrassment renewing in her. “Did you and Catra . . . ?” They grew up together and from what Adora had said, her and Catra were close. It kinda made sense? Glimmer was horrified.

“No!” Adora looked like she was going to pass out or maybe die. Glimmer let out a breath of relief.

“Okay, okay! I don’t know? Sometimes kids like to experiment?” Glimmer shrugged, trying to keep this from being worse.

Clearly, it wasn’t working for Adora. “I’ve never done it!” Adora said quickly as she pushed away from Glimmer, desperate for an escape.

“Me neither!” Glimmer said, too eagerly. “But like, did Catra have sex and talk to you about it or . . . ?”

“Um, I mean . . . if she did she didn’t tell me,” Adora scowled, thinking over the question resentfully. “And she told me everything so . . . and we were always together . . . .”

Glimmer didn’t even want to unpack that reaction from Adora so she just continued, “Sex is supposed to be fun and a good way to relax,” Glimmer quietly added, “at least that’s what they tell me.”

Adora scowled.

Glimmer pinched her nose between her thumb and pointer finger. “Look! I don’t want to do this, but you need to know.” Glimmer stopped when she saw the glare in Adora’s eyes, threatening her to continue. This backfired for Adora, only fueling Glimmer’s stubbornness. She doubted two Horde kids without any sex

education really understood, like, anything. So she pushed forward, letting her shoulders relax. They had already breached the hardest part of this, right? "Adora, did they talk to you about birth control or safety or, like, anything?"

"We got implants to prevent, um, pregnancy," Adora motioned to her arm, "But, other than that, no, not really." Glimmer stared at her, waiting. "Look, they really didn't let us do anything. Hard to when you're being watched 24/7." Glimmer kept staring. Adora got so uncomfortable she asked, "So . . . can you tell me what mas-tur-ba-tion is?"

Glimmer stopped the groan that wanted to come out. Patience, she reminded herself. She could make this less weird, right? "Masturbation is when you, kinda, have sex with yourself."

"What?"

"You know, Adora!" But Adora did not know. Glimmer was losing her cool again. "You touch yourself down there," she mirrored Adora's motion of earlier, "until you orgasm."

"Or-gas-m," Adora tried.

Glimmer just nodded and explained as well as she could, "It's kinda like the goal of sex? I mean, not exactly. You can still have sex and not orgasm, apparently, especially women which is like so not fair but-"

"-I know what that is," Adora said.

"You do?" Glimmer asked, unsure. Thank god for this one thing. She had no idea how to define or explain and it felt too personal.

"Yes, I just didn't know the word," Adora said, proud to have known something. "But masturbation . . . you do that alone?" she asked shyly.

"Yes, why would other people be around? I mean, it's very private," Glimmer said like it was obvious, adjusting to the

weirdness of this whole thing.

But then Adora went quiet. It was not the same, embarrassed, blushing, trying to crawl her way out of the conversation quiet as earlier though. “Does that make sense?” Glimmer added. Had she missed something?

“Are you . . . um . . . are you sure?” Adora asked.

“I, hmm, I guess it doesn’t have to be alone. You can do it to, I don’t know, work up your partner?” Glimmer had heard of people doing that before, right? “Like, if someone wants to watch and you consent to let them . . . .”

“Consent?” Adora absentmindedly rested her chin on her fists.

“The most important thing about sex is consent, Adora. It’s fun and all but not everyone wants it all the time and it isn’t always safe the way some people want it.” Glimmer paused, “You know, like I can’t come into your room without your consent.”

“But you do,” Adora said, pointing an accusing finger in Glimmer’s direction.

“Ugh, that’s not a good example," Glimmer rubbed her forehead with her hand. "What I mean is that anytime you don’t want something to happen, you know, you can say no. It doesn’t matter if you were having fun and now you’re not or if you just don’t feel like it or if you said yes but now are saying no. It’s giving permission for another person to touch you. It’s getting permission from someone else to touch them. No means no.” Adora just kept staring at her so she continued, “Anything less than an enthusiastic ‘yes’ is a no. For kissing, for borrowing things, for touching other people, for sex, for everything. Does that make sense?”

In the time Glimmer was talking, Adora had curled her knees up to her chest and started hugging them, eyes becoming glazed over in thought. The redness on her face had vanished, instead

being replaced by a paler white. “So . . .” Adora began, “if you don’t want someone to touch you and they do, what is that?”

Glimmer looked at her hands, “It’s sexual assault.”

Adora gave Glimmer that clueless look again. “And that’s bad?”

“Yes, just like . . . all assault?” Glimmer responded, trying her best to keep her uneasiness contained as Adora asked questions.

“Oh,” Adora said flatly.

“Oh?” Glimmer asked, extremely confused, but Adora stayed quiet.

Adora looked up at Glimmer. It was the same look Adora had when she failed a mission or someone got hurt, but there was more there. It was a hard mix between shame and fear. All the irritation and awkwardness Glimmer had felt took a slow turn into ice cold dread. “Adora . . . did something happen?” she asked it quietly, like if she spoke too loud, it would spook her friend.

A look of concern appeared on Adora’s face. Her eyes narrowed and her jaw set. “I’m not . . . I can’t . . . .“

Glimmer stared wide eyed as Adora had been earlier. There was a sudden tension in the room and between them that wasn’t just awkward it was . . . painful? What was going on? “Adora, you’re safe here you-”

“-so if, so if someone made you masturbate,” Adora had now mastered the word, “hypothetically,” she added, “and . . . watched e-even though I, I mean you, didn’t want to . . . .” Adora started to trail off as a deluge of memories came to her, forcing her outer shell to crack. She started choking on her last words when Glimmer picked up the conversation.

“Adora, that is,” she swallowed, “hypothetically, sexual assault.” A new feeling pulsed through Glimmer’s bloodstream, distress.

Adora chuckled joylessly, “No way, no it was . . . it was . . . . It’s my fault I. . . .”

Silence dropped thickly in the room, like they were suddenly underwater. Glimmer was afraid to move. No way, Adora was just asking questions right? As Glimmer tried to convince herself that this was just curiosity she asked boldly, “Did that happen?”

At first there was nothing. And then, barely moving her head, Adora nodded and confirmed Glimmer’s fears. The tightness in Glimmer’s body clenched so hard she thought she might throw up.

Glimmer reached her hand out to touch Adora’s shoulder and thought better of it, retracting slowly. Before she could even return her hand Adora burst saying, “But I’m not supposed to tell. If I do she’ll-”

“-She? Who?” Glimmer asked softly, trying to contain her hands from shaking. Trying to be calm when all she felt was this overwhelming, shaky anguish.

Adora stayed quiet for another long moment. The guilt rose in her stomach making her nauseous.

She wasn’t supposed to tell, but Glimmer was persistent. “Adora?”

“Shadow Weaver,” Adora said delicately. So delicate that Glimmer couldn’t believe this was even the same Adora who had beat up battalions of Horde soldiers yesterday. Glimmer stared for a long time and Adora became smaller and smaller.

“It’s not your fault.” Glimmer said once she realized the silence had stretched on. She tried to be reassuring because she wasn’t sure what else to do.

“Yes it is,” said Adora with finality, looking Glimmer in the eyes with an unfamiliar ferocity. Glimmer was taken aback. It was like watching an eclipse as intensity took over Adora’s features.

Glimmer had a million questions. How long did this go on? How old was Adora when this started? How could this have happened? How was she going to fucking murder Shadow Weaver? But none of those answers mattered right now. Adora looked so frail and it was totally freaking Glimmer out.

Glimmer swallowed her extreme anxiety and focused on Adora. "Thank you for sharing. We don't have to talk about everything, not right now, not ever if you don't want. But, I do think you should talk to someone . . . ."

"What? No. I can't." Adora looked at her like she was stupid.

Glimmer looked at Adora as confusion piled atop her other emotions. "What?"

"She'll hurt Catra." Then Adora's face really started to break and all of a sudden, she was leaking out pieces of pain. "If I wasn't . . . good . . . Shadow Weaver would punish Catra. She would never hurt me. She said it was good for me. She said I was stronger. She said she loved me . . . ." Glimmer was almost gagging but pushed it down with all of her strength.

"If someone loves you, they don't threaten you or hurt the people you care about." Glimmer said with a confidence she didn't feel. She had to hold on, for Adora's sake.

"She wasn't threatening me," Adora's voice rose, "she was making me stronger." Glimmer looked at Adora with pity and it sent an angry wave through Adora. "She is basically my mom. She raised me. I owe her. She didn't hurt Catra - I, I did. It was my failures it was-"

"-No, Adora. That's a lie," Glimmer asserted, but she knew she had made a mistake. The hatred Glimmer felt had dripped out in her words and it made Adora flinch away from her.

"Glimmer, you don't know. You don't know her and you don't know the Horde," Adora started to unleash the full anger she felt. Glimmer could not catch a break today. Adora stood up with her

fists balled up again. It was just like earlier when she was ready to fight to defend Glimmer, except now she wanted to fight against her.

Glimmer stared shocked. She was confused and alarmed and, honestly, a little scared.

Glimmer backed away before Adora remembered herself. "I . .. I've gotta go," Adora said as her expression weakened into regret before she turned and ran out of the room.

Glimmer didn't move. She felt frozen in place as the air cleared and she slowly processed the heavy truths in Adora's words. Unfortunately, all of this made sense. As much as she wanted to deny it, Adora had been hurt far worse than Glimmer could have imagined. The nightmares. The fear of being alone. The things Adora sometimes said. The defense of Shadow Weaver. The anxiety. The need for order. The need for perfection. Adora was sexually abused by Shadow Weaver. Punished if she wasn't perfect. And Catra. . . what had Shadow Weaver done to her?

Glimmer took a few deep, steadying breaths, admitting she was out of her depth here. She needed backup. She needed her mom.

The Northern Reach

Chapter Notes

> This chapter overlaps with S02E05 "White Out." Because of this, there are actions and dialogue taken straight from the show script that I did not write. I have, of course, added to and deviated from it. After this, we will completely diverge from the show.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer cracked the door to Queen Angella's study. It creaked loudly, drawn out by the doubt in Glimmer's touch. "Mom," she said with hesitation, "can I come in?"

Angella motioned for her to enter without looking up from her desk. "Glimmer, hello, I was just going to call for you. I have-"

"-Mom," Glimmer said softly. Angella's eyes snapped up as she heard Glimmer's voice break. The tears Glimmer had not shown Adora started to gather at her eyes and her nose started to drip. She wiped at it ferociously, willing herself to be, or even just appear, strong. She held eye contact with the Queen as her jaw quaked.

Angella was on her feet in an instant. She put a firm, loving hand on Glimmer's shoulder, peering into her daughter's eyes with concern. "Glimmer, oh dear, what's wrong?"

Glimmer's heart heaved. The more love and respect her mother showed her, the worse she felt. She had done nothing to deserve the kindness in her mother's eyes. Not like Adora. Adora was kind and strong and good. Glimmer was a brat, or, at least, she felt like one right now.

It tore at her. Glimmer was at a place between guilt of being unworthy and the primal, aching need of a child for their mother. When Angella approached her, the latter won out. She let the sob

she had been holding burst out of her, ugly and raw. She dove into Angella's arms and cried. Glimmer felt regret for all of the pain she had caused her mother. She felt so many things.

Angella had no idea what was going on. But, she did what good mothers do, she held her daughter and waited. She waited a long time. Her work lay forgotten on her desk and she did not spare another thought on it. When Glimmer's sobs calmed into heavy breaths she asked, "What's wrong?"

Gasping in between words and still trying to get a hold of herself, Glimmer said, "I don't know what to do. I just . . . I need advice."

"I'm here for you," Angella reassured, causing another wave of weeping to drive through Glimmer, though her tears were dry. "What can I do?"

"I don't even know how to say it," Glimmer said, finally pulling away from Angella as she half crossed her arms. One hand held her elbow and the other fell down to her side limply. She stared at the ground in embarrassment.

"What is this about?" Angella prodded gently.

Glimmer looked up into her mother's eyes with a hardness that transcended her otherwise red and puffy face. "Shadow Weaver," she said, shaking again, but in a sputtering anger this time.

Angella stiffened immediately. Seeing her daughter's eyes carry so much negative emotion scared her and the mention of Shadow Weaver made her prickle with an aversion she tried to keep deep down inside her. With narrowed eyes and, more aggressively than intended, she said, "What about her?"

"She . . . she hurt Adora," Glimmer said through clenched teeth, her aura burning now.

Angella took a small, unconscious step backwards. "Glimmer, she is wretched. I can't imagine that she wouldn't-"

"-No, mom. It's . . . it's more than . . . that," Glimmer said, her rage ebbing as she filled back up with sorrow. She was unsure of which feeling she disliked more, but was unable to control either.

Glimmer's tone made Angella's skin creep, turning cold. There was a box Angella kept a tight lid on within herself that held a memory. At Glimmer's words, something tore within it, trying to get out. The gnawing ache of an unforgotten pain surfaced as she flashed back to a conversation held in this same room, years ago.

"I'll kill her," Angella said.

"You can't," Micah said dully. "What's done is done. All I pray is you don't love me less." It was like a whisper of some impossible plea.

"Love you less? Of course not. Why would I?" Angella cut herself off as she looked into Micah's terrified eyes and, as she did, her boiling temper simmered into an intense sadness. This was not his fault. How could he not see that? He looked unlike himself. He was usually so confident, but before her now he looked small. Shame can cause even the greatest of us to hide.

"It makes me feel like I am . . . unclean. Like I am tainted and, no matter what I do, I will never be whole. I don't feel . . . good. I could have stopped her but I . . ." Micah said.

"Micah, my dear," Angella said, tenderly, "I understand why you feel that way, though I will not claim to understand what you've been through." She put a hand on his shoulder, he looked away. "But you were a child. She was supposed to be your guardian. She was supposed to protect you. You can't honestly believe . . . " she trailed off as he shrank again.

Micah kept his eyes downcast, darkness filling him as Angella spoke. "She was my mentor. She was everything to me and I . . . I was so stupid, Angella. And I thought I would . . . I mean, it was a long time ago now and . . . ."

“Thank you for telling me. You may not feel it, but, to me, you have never been stronger,” she said with a renewed warmth.

“I don’t feel strong,” he said as he stood shaking.

“Look how far you’ve come, my love. You can overcome this too.”

Micah hugged her, more desperately than he ever had, muttering a quiet, “I love you,” into her shoulder. “I’ll never let Shadow Weaver do to anyone else what she did to me.”

Angella felt hatred then. A hatred so powerful that it felt like it was swallowing her.

As Angella’s memory faded back into obscurity she brought thoughts of Adora and Micah together. She closed her eyes and shook her head. They were both valued by Shadow Weaver. They both were useful for her. But, Angella rejected the idea of Shadow Weaver doing to Adora what she had done to Micah. She thought about Micah’s promise and how she could not, she would not, believe that it had been broken.

Glimmer had watched her mother’s eyes glaze over. “Mom?” Glimmer said quietly.

“What did she do?” Angella asked without any of the dignity she typically held. Her hands gripped Glimmer’s shoulders too hard.

Glimmer’s eyes widened in fear. “Mom, you’re scaring me.” Glimmer backed away.

Angella remembering herself, shook her head again. She still burned with a feeling that startled her. How easily that feeling of hatred returned. “I’m sorry dear. I-”

“-It’s okay . . .” Glimmer said, unsure of what to think. “It’s just, like, how do I even say this? Shadow Weaver - I don’t know the details, but Adora . . . .” Glimmer paused to regroup. “She sexually abused Adora.” Glimmer cringed at the words, as if speaking them made them more true.

Despite knowing deep down what Glimmer was going to say, Angella was still unprepared for this admission. She thought about Micah. She thought about her failures. "That witch," Angella said sternly, losing focus on Glimmer once again as all the things she kept tightly buckled under the surface creeped out.

"I don't know what to do. Adora won't talk to me about it and . . . I'm scared," Glimmer said.

Angella looked at her, softening, but in a struggle to be present. "You can't make her talk, Glimmer. Let her come to you," she said. Come on Angella, be there for your daughter, she thought.

"But she didn't even realize and then she got mad and," Glimmer half-screamed in frustration. "She's totally not dealing with it, mom."

"How did you find this out?" Angella questioned, glad for the distraction of Glimmer's bubbling emotions to cover her own, darker ones.

Glimmer blushed, forgetting herself. "We um . . . were talking and it just . . . came up?"

Angella looked at her in that way that mothers do to make their kids spill their secrets.

"Fine, I was sort of, you know, talking to Adora about . . . sex?" Before Angella could get a word in Glimmer added, "They didn't have sex education at the Horde, okay? I couldn't NOT say anything."

"Glimmer, it's fine," Angella said, gesturing away Glimmer's embarrassment with a small swish of her hand. If Glimmer thought it was embarrassing to talk about sex with her friend, well, she was in for a real treat when she had children of her own.

"I don't know what to do. She seemed so scared, mom. I've never seen her like that. Adora, she's so strong and . . ." Glimmer started to tear up again. "Now it's totally weird between us."

“Think about how she feels, Glimmer. She’s probably always known this . . . whatever happened to her was bad or wrong but she suppressed it, justified it to survive. We all do what we have to do to survive.” It was a reminder to Angella as well. “And now that she’s safe to feel these things . . . it won’t be as easy to forget and move on. She must process it in her own time.” Angella took a deep breath. “All you can do is be there for her, keep Shadow Weaver far away,” she paused, “and educate yourself.”

Glimmer looked at her in question as Angella moved around the room to a specific set of books high on the shelf. She pulled them and handed them to her daughter.

“Mom, why do you have these?” Glimmer asked, perplexed, as she looked at the titles. They involved child abuse or rape or supporting someone through trauma. Glimmer started to have a brain itch. Shadow Weaver had, afterall, trained her father. “Mom . . . did something happen to Dad?”

Angella stared at her daughter, unable to respond.

“Another day, Glimmer,” Angella said after a moment, sitting back down at her desk and picking up the letter she had been reading before being interrupted.

Glimmer stared at her, heart full of dreadful questions, but she knew her mother. This conversation was over. She exited, closing the door behind her, new questions popped up in her mind as she clutched the books to her chest. She centered herself. Adora was here, struggling now. She needed to focus on that.

Angella watched the door click shut, lacing her fingers together with her elbows propped on the table. She laid her head on her hands and started to cry, shaking violently as tears fell and smeared the ink of the page she had been holding, long forgotten now.

Not another one.

"We've detected Horde activity at the Northern Reach," Bow said to those present in the war room. Right now, that meant Glimmer, Adora, and the Bright Moon guards at the door. He looked around the room, everyone looked unfocused and, frankly, weird. Had they even been listening to him? He cleared his throat, "Hello, the Northern Reach?" More blank stares. "No one has been up there for like years, don't we care about why now?" His question was met with exasperating silence. Bow sighed and waited.

Adora made eye contact. Bow smiled, he knew she would be first to break. She said, "Fine, let's go check it out." Glimmer watched Adora like a hawk.

"Just like that?" Bow asked. This whole thing kept getting weirder. Ugh, why couldn't everyone just talk about their feelings?

"Why not?" Adora shot back. She sure seemed on edge. "I can go by myself if-"

"-No way," Glimmer interrupted.

Adora looked at her and it was far from affectionate. What was going on with these two? Bow shifted his eyes between his best friends, feeling the tension. "Well, okay everyone. I agree we should check it out but I think we can go as a team," he said.

"Fine," Adora said.

"Fine," Glimmer said.

"Guess that's decided then. . . . Still, we're going to need a boat and maybe a plan?" Bow tried. He was going to lose it. He could not stand the tightness of the room, it made him feel like he could barely breathe.

"Hard to have a plan when we don't know what we're getting into," Adora said rationally. Bow couldn't believe her. Adora always

wanted a plan. She was the definition of military. Unless . . . well, unless she felt reckless. Okay, something had definitely happened with her.

“We know that it’s cold?” Bow added. It was supposed to be a joke, but no one laughed. That seemed to be happening a lot. He scowled.

“So we have a packing list,” Glimmer said. She sighed. “And we can call Sea Hawk.”

That, at least, got a smile from Bow. Sea Hawk was impervious. He could make this whole thing better, or, at least, give Bow someone to talk to while Adora and Glimmer were doing . . . whatever they were currently doing.

Adora stood, shoving her chair back as she did. “Can we go now or what?”

“Um . . . I'll get in touch with Sea Hawk,” Bow said.

Adora was already turning to leave, saying as she went out the door, “Let me know when we’re ready.”

“Oooooookay, what’s going on?” Bow looked directly at Glimmer, she obviously had something to do with this.

Glimmer squirmed under his gazed and pulled on a strand of her hair. “Um . . . I don’t know?”

“Glimmer,” Bow said, accentuating each syllable.

Glimmer looked at her wrist, which, by the way, didn’t have anything on it, and stood up faster than Adora had. She nearly knocked her chair over, running out the room saying, “Look at the time! I’ll start packing!”

Bow put his head on the table and grunted, frustrated tears coming to his eyes. Why were his friends so emotionally incompetent?

Sea Hawk had come at once, eager to show off his new boat and, if he was honest, hoping for the inspiration to write a new song for Mermista. “The Dragon's Daughter Five! She cuts a fine line on the sea, does she not?”

Bow asked, “Wait, what happened to the Dragon's Daughter Four? . . . Oh, oh, oh! Was it *adventure*?”

Sea Hawk looked back at Bow sadly. “No. Termites. I couldn't save the old girl.” Sea Hawk perked back up quickly. “Anyway, I'm honored to be a part of another daring mission for the Rebellion!”

She-ra rolled her eyes from her place on the ship deck. “Well, you know, we needed a boat to get up here, and you . . . have a boat.”

Bow reprimanded She-ra with a cold look. She put her arms out and shrugged like she had said nothing wrong.

Sea Hawk merely responded with, “Yes, I do!” He laughed, but then added quieter, “Truth be told, I was . . . glad to have something to do. Mermista canceled our plans this week and she's hanging out with her other friends, and didn't invite me to join, I . . . .”

Glad for something to do, Glimmer spoke encouragement to Sea Hawk. Bow hadn’t heard the exact words as his focus was still on scolding She-ra, who looked down and rubbed her neck with one of her hands.

After the exchange, Bow watched Glimmer drop her friendly act. Instead, she paced around, muttering to herself. She-ra, meanwhile, was staring off into the distance. Had they switched bodies? He had never seen She-ra sit still this long before. He remembered their trip to the beach on Mystacor. Disaster. Bow

decided he could no longer wait for Adora and Glimmer to solve this on their own.

"So, can we talk about what's going on? You two are majorly stressing me out," he said. Sea Hawk heard the tone in Bow's voice and took the cue to make himself busy on the opposite side of the ship. Bow felt some warmth in his heart as he listened to Sea Hawk's whistling.

She-ra and Glimmer exchanged a glance and then looked back at Bow.

"It's nothing," Glimmer said.

"Oh no, you're not getting off that easy," Bow argued.

"We're just trying to focus on the mission, okay? We're not fighting," She-ra said.

"I didn't say you were fighting, but since you brought it up, Adora, do you want to tell me what you're 'not fighting' about?" Bow responded.

Glimmer saw She-ra gulp and swooped in for the deflection, "It's really nothing Bow, we're just stressed and want to know what the Horde is up to. It's just . . . it's been a lot all at once, okay? This war became so much more real and it's starting to . . . ."

Bow narrowed his eyes as Glimmer trailed off. But then he burst forward to grab Glimmer in an embrace. "Oh Glimmer! Oh Adora! I know you're avoiding the real issue, but this is stressful!" Bow hugged Glimmer tightly. It felt good. It felt warm. "Can we promise to talk about this later?" Bow asked as he extended an arm out to She-ra, inviting her to join them.

She-ra didn't respond, but she joined the hug, giant arms encircling both of her friends easily, though stiffly. It took a moment, but she let herself ease into it. These were her friends. They cared about her. She was safe here.

And Bow was wrong. Adora wasn't mad at Glimmer, she was mad at herself. She felt that Glimmer must be disappointed in her too. Or maybe she was ashamed of Adora. What kind of hero was she with all of these weaknesses and failures? Since her talk with Glimmer, Adora's mind had been on repeat, racing through the same memories over and over again, so quickly it gave her whiplash.

She felt out of control. Her anxiety reached its height not long after Adora had stormed out of Glimmer's room. She had gone to her own chamber, locked the door, threw her jacket forcefully across the room, and started burning out her emotions with exercise. Her heart had been beating so hard, her breath had been ragged, and then her vision started to blur. She slipped and landed hard on her hands and knees, dripping sweat into a puddle beneath her. The surprise and interruption had, at last, let the tears she had been holding in fall, hot and heavy, to the ground. There were only a handful of times Adora could remember crying as hard as she was then.

Eventually, she had calmed into exhaustion, but the thoughts of weakness and of the echo of everything she fought to forget continued to surge. In some ways, it felt worse now than ever. The words "sexual assault" and "abuse" kept coming up. It made more sense and she hated it because it left her feeling stupid and confused. She re-experienced every touch that Shadow Weaver had laid on her and doubly felt the marks Shadow Weaver had left on Catra. She had the guilt gnawing at her again about leaving Catra with Shadow Weaver. She had guilt for leaving Shadow Weaver too. And she had guilt that she felt guilty at all. This mission was supposed to be a distraction from all of that, but now she felt the pull back towards the darkness.

Right then, Glimmer put an arm around She-ra, no longer relying on Bow to hold them together. It brought She-ra back into the present and she gave a tiny squeeze back. Glimmer smiled.

Before anything else could happen a loud "ADVENTURE!" was shouted by Sea Hawk as they landed on the shores of the

Northern Reach.

“It’s go time,” Bow said, hugging his friends tighter before letting go and shouldering his quiver.

“Maybe, we can talk later?” She-ra said.

“I’d like that,” Glimmer said back.

Bow pretended he hadn’t heard them, but grinned to himself anyway.

She-ra tied the boat down and Sea Hawk inspected her knot work, amazed at her skill for “not being long on the sea.” After giving Sea Hawk a grouchy look, She-ra stood and led them up across the expanse, eventually leading them to a bridge. Once there, the snow started picking up and, soon, it was blowing all around them, making it hard to see. She-ra had no complaints, but the cold made Glimmer grit her teeth.

Long before Glimmer could see anything, She-ra’s voice rang through the wind and snow, “Catra!” The sound almost made Glimmer jump.

After a hard gust of wind slowed, Glimmer saw Catra, Scorpia, and Entrapta clearly. She watched them look up as the wind whipped her face. Of course they were here. It made Glimmer feel like all they did was run around after each other in circles. The cold stung her nose.

“It’s been awhile,” She-ra said. Glimmer thought she almost sounded pleased. Maybe this was what Adora needed right now: a challenge. Glimmer wished it could have involved someone other than Catra.

“Hey Adora,” Catra said, smugly. Glimmer groaned.

Bow sighed and notched an arrow while Sea Hawk unsheathed his sword. Without thinking, Glimmer felt herself tense for battle.

As she knew would happen, She-ra and Catra did their normal banter thing before falling in step to fight one on one. They moved away from the group. Glimmer let them go, knowing She-ra could take Catra, but wondering if Adora was ready for this fight right now. It had only been a few days since their talk and Catra had been a touchy subject. Adora seemed so afraid of Catra’s pain and, now, she would be the cause. She watched She-ra and Catra exchange blows and willed herself to refocus on what was before her. Trust Adora, Glimmer reminded herself. She closed her eyes and, when she opened them again, she had a new target, Scorpia.

“Adventure!” Sea Hawk shouted as he made the first rush towards Scorpia. Glimmer quickly moved in for backup, shifting her mental state with one, long exhale.

“This is not how this night was supposed to go!” Scorpia said. Glimmer didn’t know what that was supposed to mean. What evil things had the Horde been plotting this time? She was glad to thwart it, whatever it was.

Glimmer and Sea Hawk took turns being on the attack and defense, working surprisingly well together. Bow, on the other hand, had already put his weapon away and was chasing Entrapta, who was hopping through the snow like a winter fairy. Bow’s pleas and apologies were returned with only well-meaning, but concerning, cackles.

Everyone was perfectly playing their roles. Glimmer felt herself relax in the familiarity of it.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the battlefield, Catra was not faring as well. She ended up on her back, snow melting and

freezing to her neck, as She-ra pointed a sword at her throat. “Don’t move,” She-ra warned.

“Oh please,” Catra said arrogantly, “you’d never have the guts.” Catra said it with more confidence than she felt.

And yet, She-ra frowned and slowly, almost automatically, withdrew her sword.

If Catra had known that late last night Adora was playing a memory of her over and over again, she would have acted less surprised by She-ra’s present actions. As it was, she smiled and, instead, decided it was She-ra’s weakness and blind nobility letting her live.

While Catra started to move in the present, She-ra flew back into the past, rerunning the memory again. In it, there was an twelve year old bloodied and crying Catra. She crawled into Adora’s bed past curfew as Adora welcomed her in. It wasn’t unusual for them to sleep next to each other, but the state of Catra’s body was shocking. Adora remembered. Adora remembered what had happened to cause it.

That day, Adora messed up two times. The first was in training. She lost their simulation battle, getting knocked out by Catra in the final round. Catra had immediately lit up in excitement for overthrowing the reigning champion. Adora had been excited for Catra too, she loved seeing her jump up and down and recount how she had managed her victory. But Adora felt her happiness fade when she caught a glimpse of Shadow Weaver after, shaking her head and fading into the background.

After dinner, Adora had been called to Shadow Weaver’s chamber where she was condemned for her earlier performance. There was no yelling, but there was a constant stream of disappointment. Shadow Weaver told Adora that she needed to be smarter, faster, that she was letting Catra distract her, and that she should not waste all she had worked for. It left Adora defensive and that is when she made her second mistake.

She defended Catra, claiming she was an excellent cadet and a good match for Adora. Shadow Weaver had grabbed her by the front of her shirt then and said, "She is nothing compared to you. Do not let yourself sink down to her level." Shadow Weaver had pushed Adora away abruptly, causing Adora to stumble. Shadow Weaver almost never hurt her. After that, Adora fell back into line and silence, scared of the force in Shadow Weaver's actions. At her submission, Shadow Weaver calmed. Young Adora took a deep breath as Shadow Weaver told her to remove her clothing.

Adora complied with all of Shadow Weaver's requests after that, trying to be good enough to make up for her failing in training and, later, her insubordination. Every second that past made Adora feel wrong, but she needed to be perfect. At the end, Shadow Weaver had seemed pleased and Adora had felt relief overshadow the creeping sensation left on her skin, feeling like Shadow Weaver was still touching her. Before Adora was allowed to leave, however, Shadow Weaver said, "Send Catra in after you."

The words cut straight into Adora, making her feel more exposed than anything else that had happened in the last hour. She fought the urge to open her mouth and argue, instead settling for an anger that took the form of tears in her eyes as she turned away and walked out of the chamber.

Soon after, Catra ran up to Adora for a hug, but Adora shied away from the touch, feeling clammy and cold. Catra looked at her confused as Adora relayed the orders. Catra went from joyful to despondent in an instant, almost running away. Adora hated herself for it, but she urged Catra to go quickly. She even remembered the words she had used, "She'll be in a better mood if you are on time." It didn't feel like a lie. When she had let Shadow Weaver touch her bare skin, Shadow Weaver did seem pleased. Maybe some of that pleasure would save Catra some pain.

Catra didn't buy it. Instead, she asked, "Will you wait for me?" Adora nodded as Catra put on a brave face before entering the chamber.

Adora waited. Every second was agony. She blamed herself, repeating her mistakes in her mind. She let tears fall down her face as she balled her fists. Tomorrow she would be better. She would be perfect.

It took a long time, but Catra eventually came out stumbling. Adora caught her, glimpsing bruises and burn marks peeking out by the seams of Catra's shirt. Catra was crying and she wiped at her face hard to try and hide it. Adora didn't say anything as she supported Catra back to the barracks.

Catra kept trying to walk on her own and kept failing. Her leg was sporting a dark bruise midway through the shin and Adora prayed it wasn't broken. Once they arrived, Adora cleaned up what she could and redressed Catra, who sat in blank silence. They lied down together and Catra put her hand on Adora's. Adora grasped back, trying to be as gentle as possible but feeling sick. Catra whimpered. Adora wanted to scream and tell Catra why this had happened. How Catra had been amazing but it was Adora who had been weak. It was her fault, not Catra's. But Adora remained silent. She knew if she told, it would only get worse for Catra. Instead, she pulled Catra into a tight hug. Adora swore this would never happen again.

But it did. It happened over and over and over until Adora left the Horde. She left Shadow Weaver. She left Catra.

And that brought Adora back here, in a body that wasn't her own, with Catra in front of her. There were so many things she wanted to say. As the sword dropped to her side, her disappointment in herself grew. This was a war and all she was doing was showing weakness, just like she had on that night so long ago. She was being a coward. And for what purpose? She didn't know. She-ra held eye contact with Catra, but instead of pouring out confidence, all she could muster was regret. Adora was responsible for Catra's hatred. She had put it there.

Catra watched the emotions change on She-ra's face. The Rebellion was soft. She-ra was soft. Catra was strong, she told

herself, and so she made her move. “You know, as much as I love our fights, it's way too cold for this. Why don't we try something new?”

She-ra looked at Catra, confused, too focused on her own shortcomings to have proper reaction time. Another mistake, She-ra cursed herself. Then, something happened. Catra pulled out a disc of too familiar First Ones tech. Before She-ra could move, Catra touched the sword of power with the disc.

The sword became demented. Thick, red veins spread from the crystal, snaking down the hilt and connecting with She-ra’s skin. She-ra felt fire hit her veins, leaving her time for one final cry before the infection took over. Catra watched, horrified. This was supposed to render She-ra defenseless, not destroy her. The sound She-ra had let go made Catra’s insides crawl.

“Catra, what did you do?” Glimmer screamed with rage. Catra felt her stomach drop. But, before she could respond, She-ra’s eyes shifted from blue to blood red and her mouth went from crying out to a deranged grin. Catra felt her eyes open up wide, this was not Adora.

Catra ran back quickly in fear of what She-ra was becoming. Upon her retreat, She-ra turned on the Best Friend Squad and started swinging her sword at them frantically. The pangs of discomfort Catra held started to melt away and were replaced with elation. She-ra was fine. She was more than fine. And now, she was beating up the people who had torn Adora from the Fright Zone in the first place. She-ra swung her sword again as the rebels scrambled. Let them deal with the consequences of convincing Adora to choose this path. Catra imagined She-ra on her side, still with the Horde, like it always should have been. She liked the idea. She liked it a lot.

They went back and forth, She-ra knocking the other three away. As they regrouped in front of her, She-ra slammed her sword into the ice. Whoa, Catra thought, She-ra could have easily killed her earlier. Why had she stopped?

Glimmer, Bow, and Sea Hawk fell through the rift She-ra had created in the giant ice sheet. When Glimmer didn't immediately teleport back up, Catra felt victory swell in her chest. "This is the greatest thing that's ever happened."

Her victory was short-lived. Catra looked back up at She-ra, shocked to see those red eyes already fixed on her. Without any of the hesitation from earlier, She-ra swung her sword at Catra. It was fast. So fast Catra could barely dodge it. Catra flipped over her trying to escape when she felt something close around her ankle.

Next thing Catra knew, she was being slammed to the ground, hard. It hurt. Her skin burned from the chill of the snow and the intensity of her impact. When she could clear her head, she looked up and saw the edge of She-ra sword lifted above her again. Catra screamed, "Adora! Wait!"

Catra's appeal to Adora's humanity was met only with a feral intensity in She-ra's eyes. Catra looked for a way out but found no good options. Then something she did not expect happened, Scorpia.

Luckily, She-ra hadn't expected it either and was easily disarmed. Two times, Catra thought, two times she had underestimated the speed and strength of the people around her today. First She-ra, now Scorpia. Catra felt her heart pounding in her chest. That had been too close.

She-ra morphed back into Adora, unconscious. For a moment, time stopped. Scorpia and Entrapta babbled on but Catra soon became giddy. The adrenaline pumping through her previously out of fear transformed. It changed into the sense of accomplishment she had felt earlier when she watched She-ra fight against the Rebellion. In fact, it doubled. It made it easier for Catra to brush all of the other emotions she had felt off.

Catra stood up, grabbed She-ra's infected sword, and walked over to Adora, who was shivering in her sleep as Scorpia held her.

“That went so much better than I could've ever hoped.” Catra laughed. She grabbed the hilt of the sword and lifted Adora’s chin with it. “Looks like you're mine now, Adora.” Catra shook with leftover energy.

Scorpia looked into Catra’s eyes and they looked as wild and unhinged as She-ra’s had been earlier. This could not be good.

From below, Bow and Glimmer exchanged a knowing glance. Adora was going to need a lot of support after this. Last time she had gone berserk, she had been almost inconsolable. There was nothing worse to Adora than hurting the people she was sworn to protect, no matter what the circumstances were.

Then, all the remainder of the Best Friend Squad could hear was Catra’s laughing as she said, “Come on, get here inside.” Glimmer cringed.

“If Catra thought infected She-ra was bad, wait until she has to deal with drunk Adora,” Bow whispered, trying to keep it light.

“Let’s go, we have to get her back!” Glimmer shouted. “But . . . my magic is exhausted right now. I can’t teleport us up this hill.”

Bow groaned and Sea Hawk flexed saying, “There is no victory without struggle!” as they started their slow ascent back to the Northern Reach.

Glimmer had gotten beaten up by her own best friend, climbed a literal mountain, got stuck in a blizzard, had to run away from giant snow monsters, and, worst of all, deal with Catra’s bad attitude.

So, when Glimmer and Bow finally made it into the lab within the Northern Reach, Glimmer’s fists were already glowing. Bow shot

an arrow that got Entrapta out of the way, now Glimmer was ready to confront Catra and she was not playing around. “Where’s the disc, Catra?”

Catra looked at Glimmer and then replied with that same, infuriating, bored tone she always had, “What, you didn’t like my new, improved version of She-ra?” Glimmer could feel her energy sparking out of her fingertips. Catra was the worst.

Catra, loved messing with Glimmer and she watched now as Glimmer lost control. She was a big, purple blob of frustration and Catra was here for it. Catra laughed again. Glimmer might have been having the worst day ever, but Catra was having her best.

Glimmer growled at Catra. Catra smiled back sweetly.

Then, a loud crack split down the side of the wall, alarming them both. The snow monsters were trying to get in. But they weren’t here yet, so Glimmer kept her attention on the real thing bugging her, Catra.

Before being able to make a move, Scorpia and Sea Hawk bustled in. Stumbling in non-urgently for last place behind them was Adora. She was unstable and was currently holding up - was that a mop?

“Pew, pew, pew!” Adora said. Though they didn’t see each other do it, everyone made the same puzzled look.

The teams reformed. Scorpia joined back up with Catra. Entrapta was there, she was sure, but rolling around somewhere in the background. Glimmer ran back up to Adora who said, “Hey, I know you,” drunkenly. Glimmer hugged her. Maybe it was the day or maybe it was because Adora was extra floppy, but the awkwardness between them was forgotten. Bow and Sea Hawk joined them without missing a beat.

Glimmer’s head snapped up as she heard a less calm and collected Catra say, “Just find the sword. I’ve got Adora.” Glimmer liked hearing Catra’s confidence wane as she went on the attack.

She moved fast enough that Glimmer was able to slam Catra into the ground, searching for the disc. Oh, that felt so good. Catra was squirmy and wrestled back. Glimmer fought to keep her pinned. Every time Glimmer got close enough to touch the disc, Catra managed to wiggle it right out of her way. Eventually, Glimmer knocked it out of Catra's hand, which made her grin and made Catra groan.

As Glimmer celebrated her momentary victory, Catra threw her off and ran, but Glimmer had enough magic now to teleport and tackle Catra back to the ground. There was chaos all around them, but Glimmer's world narrowed to immobilizing Catra. "Just. Give. Us. The. Disc," she strained as she fought to contain her enemy.

Catra responded, "Are you kidding? I've got control of Adora. I am not giving that up."

Glimmer growled. So. Fucking. Frustrating. Right as she was about to drive her knee harder into Catra's stomach, the giant snakelike monsters chose to remind everyone of the danger they were in, roaring loudly before finally smashing through the building walls. Catra and Glimmer exchanged a scream as the monster's jaws opened and drove towards their space on the floor. Both Glimmer and Catra jumped out of the way in opposite directions, evading the almost certain death that would come from contact with those sharp, metal teeth.

Lucky for Glimmer, the monster also decided Catra was the more annoying of the two of them and turned to attack her again. Catra ran, but she wasn't fast enough this time. The snow monster connected with her and Catra slammed hard into one of the surrounding shipping containers, the disc clattering to the ground. Glimmer had to admit, it was a somewhat pleasant sight. Less pleasant was Scorpia getting to the disc first. Glimmer growled again, making her way across the room.

The monster attacked Catra and, as she strained against them, she heard Glimmer say, in an annoying self righteous tone,

“Scorpia! You can end this. You’ve got to break the disc now!”

Catra split her attention between not being eaten and the events below her she let out a warning, “Don’t. You. Dare!” She was not going to give up. She was so close.

Catra did not trust Scorpia to make the right decision. So, before Scorpia could fight her desire to be loyal to Catra and to save Catra, Catra backflipped away from impending doom and snatched the disc back. The beast’s jaws snapped shut with an alarming force. Catra chose not to think too much about the fact that she had been between those teeth seconds before. “Grab the sword,” Catra demanded of Scorpia coldly.

“Oh, I see so we are-” Scorpia said, embarrassed.

“-Get the sword Scorpia!” Catra hissed as her voice cracked. She grabbed Adora, mop and all, and pushed her forward.

“Hey!” Adora said as she tried to run away. “Catra! You’re being a jerk!” Adora pushed the mop head against Catra’s cheek.

“You’re so annoying,” Catra yelled as she threw the mop across the room and slung Adora over her shoulder.

The Northern Reach started to crumble. Scorpia and Entrapta were already out the door. Catra had to steady herself as Adora continued to shift her weight all over the place. “Stay still!” Catra demanded.

Adora didn’t respond as she attempted to catch Catra’s quickly flicking tail. With her occupied, Catra made her exit, sparing a moment to glance back at today’s losers, “Until next time,” and ran off into the snow.

“Glimmer! Do you have one more teleport left?” Bow said in a croaky, worried voice.

“Yes, but Adora-” Glimmer whined.

"-We can't save her if we don't get out of here soon!" Bow said as he grabbed on to Sea Hawk. He reached out for Glimmer, "We have to go right now!"

"Shit" she said. With one more look out the door, Glimmer teleported them to safety away from the building.

Catra laughed in triumph as she ran to their ship. The cold wasn't even bothering her anymore. What a day! Adora slurred, "Hey, do you want to play in the snow?"

"The snow? What the hell, Adora?" Catra responded as Adora squirmed her way out of Catra's grasp, falling to the ground and scooping up snow into a snowball. She threw it and it hit Catra squarely in the face.

"What is wrong with you?" Catra growled as she shoved Adora to the ground. Adora, in response, laughed, plopped on her back, and made a snow angel.

"Uh, I told you, she seems, well, she seems a little off today, don't you think?" Scorpia asked. Before Catra could yell back, part of the Northern Reach made a huge rumbling noise as part of its outer wall crumbled.

Entrapta laughed wildly, "This place is gonna blow!"

"Wildcat, we've gotta go, like, right now," Scorpia said as she scooped Adora up off the ground much more carefully than Catra had. Catra followed, wiping snow out of her eyes.

They got to their boat, setting off without delay. As they drifted, they watched the Northern Reach go up in flames behind them. The monsters were still snaking around, clearly interfering with

the electrical. They screamed a metallic scream as Catra, Scorpia, Entrapta, and Adora made their escape.

“Whoaaaaa,” Adora said as she stared off into the flames with big eyes.

“Can you please secure the prisoner?” Catra shouted at Scorpia. She was done with this version of Adora. She was not a babysitter, she was a criminal mastermind.

“Prisoner? Oh, you mean Adora?” Scorpia looked over Adora who swayed slowly with her elbows on the edge of the boat.

“Who else would I be talking about?” Catra snapped.

“Oh, yeah, I gotcha.” Scorpia said as she tried to wrangle in Adora once again. This whole day, all she had been doing was watching Adora, capturing Adora, making sure Adora didn’t die, and it just went on and on.

Adora ran around, laughing hysterically and saying, “You are a really, really big bug!” and “We are best friends!” and “Catra used to be more fun.” Catra hissed at the last phrase.

“Scorpia, quit messing around!” Catra roared as Adora ran over to her and flicked one of her ears. Catra started to growl a much deeper, guttural noise.

Scorpia pleaded with Adora, “Come on!” She scrambled for an idea, “I - I’ve got some really good snacks below deck.”

“Snacks?” Adora said as she stopped in her tracks.

“Yeah! Um, super tasty things, like um, you know! Come on, let’s go!” Scorpia lied. Adora followed, suddenly compliant.

Catra rolled her eyes. but once Scorpia and Adora were out of her sight, her annoyance diminished and she smiled. She had Adora. She had She-ra.

Not long after, Scorpia reappeared on deck, looking much worse for the wear than she had minutes ago. Catra was still glowing, but the weather was chipping away at her good mood, making her bitter. She was wrapped up in a blanket selfishly on the ship deck.

"Adora fell asleep immediately. Oh man, she sure was in a wild mood today, don't you think?" Scorpia asked casually as she approached Catra, hoping she could still salvage the night.

"Yeah, whatever," Catra responded. "Who cares, this is going to be huge. Entrapta got the First Ones tech AND we got She-ra." Catra laughed. "This is the best day ever."

"Yeah, I, I guess it is," Scorpia said as she sat, keeping her distance from Catra. That laugh Catra had, oh man, it didn't sound totally normal. Scorpia started to shiver, locking her arms across her chest and trying to stay warm. When she looked up, there was a blanket in her face, "Really, I-"

"-I'm going to go check on Adora," Catra said, dropping the blanket on the deck by Scorpia absentmindedly. "Make sure Entrapta doesn't break anything."

"Oh . . ." Scorpia started, looking at the blank space next to her where Catra used to be. "Oh, yeah, you got it," she said with fake enthusiasm. Catra didn't notice, Catra was already walking away.

Scorpia watched sadly as Catra walked into the storage room where she had put Adora. This was not the night she had planned. She pulled the blanket tighter around her shoulders and shut her eyes, clinging to the warmth Catra had left on the fleece.

"Hey Adora," Catra said as she entered the room. Adora didn't reply. Catra waited, watching Adora for a moment before saying louder, "Adora!"

Adora stirred awake muttering, "Not right now. Too tired." She rolled away from the door and shut her eyes once more.

In seconds, she was lightly snoring. Catra sneered. She watched Adora's chest rise and fall. She caught herself watching too long.

She felt conflicted. This should have felt good. It did feel good. It should have felt better. If Catra had been honest with herself and, of course, she wasn't, this is not the way she wanted Adora to come home. She wanted things to be like they were. She shook her head, their relationship had suffered irreparable damage. This was the best outcome Catra could have had. She beat Adora. She would turn this stupid power Adora was so proud of against her.

"Hey Catra," Adora said sleepily, "you awake?" This caught Catra off guard.

"Yeah, of course I'm here. You're on my ship. You're my prisoner," she growled to cover her embarrassment.

"Okay, okay. Good," Adora slurred.

"Good? Did you even hear me? You are my prisoner. Did you miss me that much?" Catra teased sarcastically.

A long moment passed, causing Catra to scoff and turn to leave. Stupid to pick a fight with a stupid person. But then, Catra's ears perked up as Adora whispered a quiet, "Yes." Catra stared for another moment, telling herself Adora was being an idiot.

"Shut up, Adora," Catra said threateningly. "You know you left me. You're not allowed to say bullshit like that under any circumstance. And you know what? I'm glad you left. Getting rid of you was the best thing that ever happened to me."

Adora shifted around uncomfortably, turning to face Catra. “It’s cold,” Adora said. The vulnerability on Adora’s face caught Catra again. Adora better not remember any of this in the morning.

“Yeah and?” Catra questioned but Adora just shrugged and wrapped her hands more tightly around her body. Catra sighed, rummaging through a container nearby the door and pulling out a coat that was way too big, but tossed it to Adora anyway.

“For me?” Adora said with excitement, hugging it to her chest.

“Duh, don’t be stupid. And don’t die of hypothermia. I need you,” Catra said sarcastically.

“You need me?” Adora asked.

To this, Catra blushed, but Adora was being too dumb to notice. “Not you, She-ra. She’s going to help the Horde win a lot of battles.”

Adora went quiet and Catra assumed she had fallen back to sleep. Typical.

Catra put her hand on the door behind her, turning the doorknob until the sound caused Adora to turn around and face her. "Catra? Don't leave."

That hit a nerve. "You don't get to make that request.”

Adora looked up at her, bewildered. Catra looked at Adora, and noticed, for the first time that day, the bags under Adora's eyes and the redness in them. Catra pushed the questions that sprung up in her mind, instead making her exit.

Before she could get far enough away, another "Catra!" came through the door. In response, Catra flattened her ears, flicked her tail in irritation, and marched off tensely to her own corner to sleep. The ship wasn’t that big and she could hear Adora crying for a minute before passing out. The sound of it reverberated in Catra’s core.

Catra spent the rest of the night shivering and awake, thinking about everything. She thought about having Adora back home. She thought about She-ra fighting for the Horde. She thought about what Adora would say tomorrow from her prison cell. She thought about crushing the Rebellion. She thought about - no, this wasn’t about Adora. This was about Catra being the best. She smiled to herself. It was time to end this.

Chapter End Notes

Apologies to the Scorptra fans.

The Used

Chapter Notes

> Warning: I've updated the Archive Warnings to include Graphic Depictions of Violence due to the content in this chapter and going forward.

“Uh?” Adora muttered blearily upon waking. “Where am I?” She was crumpled on her side, jammed against the cold, ragged floor uncomfortably. As her eyes inched across her periphery, her head started to spin. Before a choke surfaced, she let her eyelids flutter shut. To abate the oncoming headache, she moved her fingers to her temples, but stopped when she was met with a foreign weight around her wrists. When she strained to move, her body felt heavy and creaky, sore from its place on the ground. Moving herself upright, she processed that her hands were in shackles.

“What?” Adora blinked her eyes and took in the space around her, ignoring the throbs in her ears. Dark, brick walls. Empty room. Then her eyes fixed on a bright green barrier, pupils shrinking to accommodate the glow. “No,” Adora whispered.

The Northern Reach. The infection. She was back in the Fright Zone. She was in a prison cell.

She stood up quickly and it made her dizzy, almost falling until her hand met the concrete surface of the wall to steady her. Adora took stock. There was no source of her pain, no acute injuries, only a dull achy feeling all over and a fiery pain in the front of her skull as if an icepick had been lodged there. This feeling wasn’t foreign, she’d experienced it once before. Last time She-ra’s sword had caused her to lose it in Dryl, she thought back. The vertigo added to her nausea and a gurgle in her stomach made her feel like she might throw up.

And then, she did.

She collapsed back to the ground and made it to the toilet, heaving out vomit in terse, violent waves. In her cell there was a toilet and a sink, but no bed and no shower. The only other fixture was an anchor for her handcuffs in the middle of the wall, which spit out two long green, flexible ropes until they met the metal bracelets encircling her hands. After she finished heaving, she wiped her mouth. Then she heard the last thing in the world she wanted to hear.

“Hey Adora.”

Adora closed her eyes and felt her mouth turn down into a snarl. While still on her knees, Adora fought to compose herself, gripping the toilet on either side with straining fingers. It took all her stubbornness to retain a gag as she stood and faced her captor. “Catra,” Adora acknowledged curtly.

Catra looked Adora up and down, noticing her pale, clammy skin glistening in the green glow, making her look even more sickly. "You don’t look so good. Bad day yesterday?” Catra smirked.

Every word Catra spoke fueled Adora’s headache. She shut one eye, wincing as she felt a sharp pain stab behind her eyeballs. “Let me go,” Adora commanded as she walked up to the barrier. She wanted to pound her fists against it and see just how strong it really was, but her chains pulled back against her.

“I can’t do that,” Catra gloated. “You see, Hordak is very impressed. Entrapta got her hands on some sort of super battery and I . . .” she paused for effect and almost purred when she finished saying, “Well, I got my hands on you.”

“You can’t keep me here,” Adora said, voice low.

“Oh, I think I can,” Catra put her hand on her hip, “You’re usually the one who does the saving, so who is going to save you?”

“Any one of the rebels can break in here,” Adora said as she pushed her face closer, getting taller to glare at Catra between the barrier.

“If they try, I’ll use my new weapon.” Catra looked at her claws dismissively, flexing them dangerously.

“They can stop anything you throw at them,” Adora spat back. “They are stronger than you give them credit for.”

“I don’t think so, Adora.” Adora grunted in response, baring her teeth in a growl worthy of Catra. Catra was unmoved. “You’re being rude, you didn’t even ask me about it,” she said, feigning hurt feelings.

“What do you want me to say? I don’t care. You can’t beat them.” Adora looked at Catra dead in the eye. Normally, Catra would have found it intimidating, but with these circumstances it made her feel powerful.

“Adora, it’s not me, it’s *us* ,” Catra said, matter of fact, tapping the forcefield between them with a succinct click.

Adora faltered, “I’m not coming back to the Horde. I’m only here because it looks like, for the time being, I don’t have a choice.” She crossed her arms defiantly.

“You’re right, Adora. You don’t have a choice.” With a flourish, Catra pulled out She-ra’s sword, beaming as she did. Adora’s tight posture crumbled from what she saw. Without intention, she dropped her fierce expression. “You will fight for me.” The sword had red lines twisting through its hilt, still pulsing with infection.

Adora felt her mouth dry. She pressed her tongue between her lips. “You can’t.”

Catra felt her mouth water. “Yes, I can.” She grinned, “And I will.”

“Catra, please, no-”

“-Catch you later, Adora,” Catra sang as she walked away. The sword was draped over her shoulder on display like a trophy. Adora was left alone with her receding footsteps.

"We lost her," Glimmer said. The crushing weight of their defeat fell heavily on her shoulders, forcing her to her knees.

"We'll get her back!" Bow said, trying to cheer Glimmer up with an enthusiasm he didn't feel. This wasn't the first time they'd had this conversation, but it was getting worse, especially since landing back in Bright Moon. It didn't feel right to go home when Adora was waking up in the Fright Zone. Still, he had to get Glimmer on her feet. They needed to be confident. They had to be to get Adora back.

"We messed up Bow!" Glimmer yelled, making Bow flinch, though all the bite in her voice was intended for herself.

"We're going to need help, Glimmer, but we'll get her back," he put a hand on Glimmer's shoulder, kneeling beside her. When she looked into Bow's eyes, Glimmer felt a twinkle of hope. Bow continued, "I already called the rest of the princesses, they're on their way. We can plan something and start going after her right away."

Glimmer smiled, "Thanks Bow. You always . . . you're amazing." Bow smiled back, briefly lost in Glimmer's eyes. He helped her to her feet, never breaking their gaze.

"I'm afraid of what they'll do to her in the meantime," Glimmer said, as she looked away darkly.

"What? You think Catra will annoy her to death?" Bow joked. "You know, she's probably gloating right about now."

Bow laughed and, for a brief, carefree moment, Glimmer was infected with it. When it receded, she felt her eyes glaze over as she mulled over the bigger threats Adora faced.

Bow asked, “Hey, what’s wrong? They can’t do anything to her.” He squeezed both of her shoulders tenderly. “She’s Adora.”

“I’m scared that they can Bow. She’s human and she . . . “

Bow gripped Glimmer’s shoulders harder, forcing her to look up at him. “What, Glimmer? What’s been going on with you and Adora?”

Glimmer hit Bow’s chest lightly with her fist. “Adora isn’t safe there.”

The grit in Glimmer’s voice caused alarm in Bow’s body. He played it off, “Well, it’s the evil Horde of course she’s not-”

“-Not just, like, normal unsafe, okay? It’s like, way worse. Catra is the least of our problems,” Glimmer sighed.

“Whoa, worse than Catra, you’ve got to be kidding me!” Bow said, trying again to turn the mood more optimistic. But, as he watched Glimmer’s despair descend, he became quiet.

“Glimmer . . . what aren’t you telling me?” Bow refused to let his grip loosen and Glimmer finally met his intensity. He stared through her eyes and into her soul.

Glimmer sighed in struggle. She didn’t want to expose Adora, but she couldn’t lie to Bow. “I’m afraid Shadow Weaver will get her hands on Adora again.” Glimmer shhed Bow when she saw his mouth open. “That’s why we were weird, Bow. Adora . . . I . . . we kinda discovered Shadow Weaver has hurt Adora more than . . . I thought.”

“Glimmer . . . what are you saying?” Bow’s voice cracked as he pressed his thumbs harder into Glimmer’s collarbones.

And then it was rolling out of her. She told Bow about the conversation Glimmer had with Adora and with her mom and the way Adora had looked so scared. How Glimmer had felt guilty and helpless. Bow listened patiently, recoiling in disgust at what Adora had endured. He stood perfectly empathetic to both Adora and

Glimmer's pain, but he felt his own rage breaking to the surface, despite its long fuse.

"I thought it was urgent before but . . . this." Bow gulped. Glimmer hugged him. "We're going to bring her home, Glimmer."

"I'm afraid we're going to have to fight She-ra to save Adora. They have the sword and whatever the hell that stupid tech is that Entrapta wanted." Glimmer ranted.

"We'll find a way," Bow said, determination absolutely radiating off of him.

"I hope you're right," Glimmer said, leaning forward into Bow's accepting arms.

Adora was thinking.

Everything from yesterday was fuzzy, but she had the basics. She remembered Catra. She remembered when she had Catra under her sword. Stupid. She remembered that damn piece of First Ones tech running its virus through the sword and into her veins. Then, a gap.

That, she could only fill with second hand information. Catra had told her nothing, of course, but Glimmer and Bow had given her every detail of the last time she had been infected. Basically, the infection took her over and made her a mindless killer. "No big deal," she said to herself. Adora didn't know if she could think while she was going berserk as she had no memory of it.

"Why does this have to be so complicated?" She pushed her palms against her skull as she resumed her pacing. One. Two. Three. Four. Five. Pivot. Repeat. The cell wasn't large. How had she ever been okay keeping prisoners here? "Focus," she said.

Adora kept her mind working, fearful of what would happen if she didn't.

Infected She-ra was disarmed at some point or knocked out or something to force She-ra to transform back into Adora. After that, Adora remembered some random events here and there. The same thing had happened last time. Glimmer said she was acting drunk. The comparison didn't help as Adora had never drank in her life.

But what had happened yesterday? She thought she had some sort of pep talk with Scorpia and Sea Hawk, but that didn't make much sense. She remembered a mop. That wasn't very helpful either. She remembered hitting Catra in the face with a snowball. That made her smile.

More seriously, she couldn't remember if Glimmer, Bow, and Sea Hawk were okay. They had to be. Glimmer and Adora were supposed to have a talk. They were supposed to fix things. Adora ground her teeth together. They would get her out of here soon, right? Before anything bad - before anything worse could happen.

Every time she had a moment of clarity, it was enshrouded by thick clouds. There was more missing substance than not. All her memories were disconnected. Catra had come to visit her when they were still on the ship. Did Adora say something stupid? She hoped she hadn't said anything stupid. "Ugh, I probably said something stupid."

Catra. Adora thought back. It seemed every time they interacted, they drifted further apart. It hurt to lose Catra, but Adora couldn't stand by any of her actions anymore. But then, there was the Northern Reach. Adora had let Catra go. Adora groaned. She had a soft spot for Catra. She could have beaten Catra yesterday and prevented all of this. She all but walked straight into this cell.

Maybe her and Catra used to be close, maybe they - it didn't matter now. Adora couldn't rely on their friendship anymore, it was gone. Adora had left Catra and she had no idea what had

happened in the meantime. Catra seemed okay. Physically okay, anyway. But Adora was lying to herself if she didn't think Catra had suffered in her absence.

Adora started getting lost again. She thought about when they were six, nine, when they were twelve, thirteen, fifteen, seventeen. There were too many times where Adora had failed and Catra had been the one to pay for it. And, still, through it all, they had always been there for each other. Then Adora left. In some ways, finding herself in shackles only seemed fair.

"Come on, Adora," she said to herself. She couldn't stay here because she felt some sort of catharsis from the whole situation. There was more work for her, or at least more work for She-ra to do. And if she stayed here, well, she didn't want to think about She-ra being owned by the Horde. She couldn't let the Rebellion's blood be on her hands too.

"I've got plans for you today," Catra said casually as she reappeared at Adora's cell.

"Feels like the only plans you've had all day have been to come over here and talk to me. Don't you have better things to do, *Force Captain* ?" Adora replied bitterly. Since Catra's last visit, Adora had cleaned herself up. She was as presentable as a prisoner could be. Hair in place, clothing dusted off, ready to report for duty.

Catra breathed out hard from her nose. This was only the third time since capturing Adora that she had been by. Was that too much? Maybe it was. Whatever. "As your superior officer, I'm here to prepare you for your first mission, *soldier* ."

Adora stopped her walking and turned to face Catra, pointing a finger at her. "Fuck you, Catra."

Catra laughed. "Language Adora! You could get punished for that, you know."

Adora rolled her eyes and gestured at the cell around her, tapping her foot impatiently.

"Yeah, yeah, whatever," Catra said. "I came here for a reason."

"That's a first," Adora bit back

"Shut up, Adora," Catra laughed again. "Anyway," Catra straightened and cleared her throat, "we've collected intelligence that the princesses have gathered in Bright Moon. That flowery one, the ice child, and that super bitchy mermaid all got tracked on their way to meet up with Sparkles and Arrow Boy. Guess what they're planning?" Catra mocked.

"To kick your ass," Adora said, standing directly in front of Catra, hands on her hips.

Catra grinned wickedly. "They're going to launch an attack at our stronghold at the western edge of the Whispering Woods, hoping to draw you out. We're going to let them."

Adora felt panic edging in, but she hid it with fierce words, "You're really going to make me fight against my friends?"

Catra dropped her grin, "It's never stopped you before, has it?"

"What happened to you?" Adora asked bluntly.

Catra matched Adora's tone, "Things have changed since you left."

It shouldn't have, but it stung. "Maybe you aren't-" Adora began.

"-Listen, you're going into battle today and I'm going to watch as you tear down your friends one by one," Catra said, viciously.

Adora looked at her harshly. "Don't do this."

Catra showed her fangs. "I'm not, but *we* are. Just like old times."

Adora's anxiety lit up. All the signs were there, her heart rate went up, her shoulders tensed, and all the potential outcomes of the

day flashed through her mind. "Catra, please."

"Now you're being polite? I think it's a little too late for that, don't you?"

Adora looked at her and it unnerved her. Adora opened her mouth to beg but Catra wouldn't let her. "It's already settled." Catra's voice cracked, making Adora's eyes gleam with a shred of hope.

Angry she had slipped, Catra more violently said. "We're going now."

Catra entered a code into the prison system and, suddenly, they were face to face. It was the first time they could look at each other without distraction in months. They both stared. Adora tried to plead with her eyes and Catra saw her fear.

Ignoring Adora's pain, Catra asked, "Are you going to do this the easy way," Catra lit up her taser, "or the hard way?"

Adora softened her stance, shifting aggressive posture to standing with her hands, in their shackles, limply between her legs.

"Already giving in?" Catra approached her with another set of cuffs for her feet and hands to transport her.

Adora let Catra rebind her hands behind her back. She tried again to plead with her captor as she felt the cuffs clink into place and tear against already chafed skin. "Please let me go, Catra. This isn't right. Is this what you really want? I thought-"

"-What did you think, Adora? That I'd bring you home so we could have tea and then I'd let you go on your merry way to prance around Etheria with your new groupies?" Catra started yelling as she threw her hands up in annoyance, waving the taser wildly. "Newsflash, you are my enemy!"

Adora's anger revisited her and, with the rush it gave her, she kicked Catra hard in the ribs. As she was knocked to the ground, she dropped her weapon in surprise. Adora moved quickly, trying

to grab the weapon awkwardly, but Catra was faster, shoving Adora backwards.

With her hands behind her, Adora fell with a thunk on her butt, scraping her knuckles bloody against the hard floor. From below, Adora looked up, meeting Catra's furious eyes with her own as she pulled herself up onto her knees and spoke, "And you think I'm the dumb one."

Catra let out a savage noise. "I guess we're doing this the hard way." She flicked on the stunner and slammed it into Adora's shoulder, finding satisfaction as Adora slumped to the ground with a gasp.

Adora groaned as she felt the swelling under her skin start on impact. Catra bound her feet and pulled her upright. "Catra . . . ." Adora sagged, muscles still twitching.

Catra touched her Force Captain badge. "Scorpia, come to the prison block and help me transport She-ra to the battlefield."

Adora's knees went out and Catra let her fall, knees hitting the ground hard. She settled her weight on them and remained kneeling, all strength taken out of her. While they waited for Scorpia, Catra slid down and sat across from her, still huffing. As the seconds passed, Catra's anger died down. "When did you start playing dirty?" she said, playfully pushing Adora’s leg with her foot.

Adora looked up at Catra. Catra saw those tired eyes again. Red rimmed, blinking too frequently and making Adora look skittish. But, Adora managed to retain some of her spunk. "You were being a brat."

Catra smiled. "You're not wrong."

Adora started to smile back, but her eyes dropped to the ground as Scorpia entered the cell. Catra frowned as she watched Adora’s face change.

"Oh my gosh, I'm so sorry it took so long. I was running but then, geez, I ran right into Rogelio and you know how he is, so chatty. He was going on and on about . . . " Scorpia watched Catra's face start to get nastier so she dropped off. "Anyway, here now, reporting for duty."

"Just bring her to where she needs to go." Catra pointed to Adora, refusing to look back into her eyes.

Adora's restraints were clipped into the wall with her hands over her head in a small room inside of a transport. It was bigger than her cell, but she did not get to enjoy the extra room. Aside from Catra's slip up earlier, the Horde wasn't messing around. Adora never had her hands free. The moment she had earlier when changing shackles was the best opening she had. Unfortunately, Catra would be smarter next time. Sadly, Adora knew she'd be useless to escape after being infected, so her best shot was to come up with a plan before. Right now, that meant it was too late.

She was off to the battlefield and she would be on the wrong side. But, if the Rebellion could set her on a path towards the Horde then maybe she could do something not totally awful. Or they could disarm her. It couldn't be that hard, right? She didn't even know how Catra planned on using her, it seemed extremely risky. The Horde used more machinery than the rebels, but She-ra could tear through a tank as easily as anything.

“Knock, knock,” Catra said as she entered the room. Adora grimaced.

“All these personal visits I might start thinking you like me,” Adora said automatically, which earned her a smile from Catra.

“You wondering how this is all going to work?” Catra asked with excitement. Adora only looked at her annoyed since she had, in fact, just been wondering that very thing.

“You know how dangerous this is? I don’t have any control. I can’t-”

“-You princesses really messed one thing up majorly.” Catra walked closer to Adora and put her hand on her chin thoughtfully. “Actually, you’ve messed up a lot of things.” As she spoke, Catra tapped Adora’s metal cuffs with She-ra’s sword. Adora squirmed away, doing her best to stay out of contact.

Catra continued, “You gave us, literally *hand delivered* us Entrapta. And now that I own you,” Adora scoffed. Catra paused to glare, but kept going, “Now that I own you and you are powered by First Ones tech *and* I have the geek princess on my side, well, your Rebellion is in trouble.”

Catra had moved close enough to Adora that she could feel Catra’s breath as she spoke. She could see the way Catra’s eyes looked at her, hungry.

“Entrapta made me this thing,” Catra showed Adora some hunk of metal that clipped to the side of Catra’s head at the temple. “I don’t understand the details, because she honestly would not stop talking, but I don’t have to. All you need to know is that I can get She-ra, even when she is,” Catra motioned to the sword, “to do what I want.”

“What? That doesn’t make sense. I can’t think when I-”

“-Don’t ask questions, Adora. It’s some sort of weird sonar thing. I told you, the details are boring. Oh, and I can turn She-ra off too, just in case I want some quality time with your ugly face.”

Catra smiled wide. Adora looked at her in horror as her hands started to shake. She hoped Catra didn’t notice. “Why are you doing this?” Adora pleaded.

“Because I will do whatever it takes to beat you,” Catra answered.

“This isn't about me!” Adora accused.

“You made it that way when you decided to go play hero,” Catra responded.

“I’m not - I didn’t want this,” Adora said back.

“That’s a lie and you know it. You love saving everyone. You love being the good guy, come on, you’re not that stupid.”

“Catra! This is about the entire world. The Rebellion is trying to save it. The Horde only cares about destruction and power.”

“Then why did you leave? You fit in here perfectly.” Catra lashed out.

“What’s going to happen when you win? Will that be everything you want?” Adora was talking loudly now. She pulled away from the wall to get in Catra’s face.

“Listen, Adora,” Catra said calmly, “I don’t give a shit about any of this or about any of these people. You took everything from me, so don’t you think it’s only fair I take everything from you?”

Adora was about to argue that, no, she would never have done anything to control Catra or take away her freedom, but she flashed back to the cuts, scrapes, bruises, broken bones, blood, and tears she had seen from Catra their whole lives. That had been her fault. Adora settled for silence and searched Catra’s eyes. When she did she thought she saw something soften.

An alarm bell sounded through the transport. “Show time.”

And then, the momentary warmth she had felt was gone.

“So, like, where is She-ra?” Mermista asked, bored. She, Perfuma, Glimmer, Frosta, and Bow were taking out the Horde’s stupid bots. Sea Hawk was there too, but who knew where. Mermista was sure she’d hear more about all his adventures later.

The Princess Alliance advanced through the Horde’s front lines. Eventually, they had to fight real soldiers, but it still wasn’t much of a fight. This was the worst. Like, if Mermista was going to come all the way out here and fight on *dry land* then couldn’t they at least make it fun?

“She has to be here.” Bow said.

“I don’t know. Maybe they like getting the shit kicked out of them?” Mermista replied, flatly.

“Mermista! We do not fight just to hurt others,” Perfuma reprimanded.

Mermista gave her an irritated look, but Perfuma’s eyes burned brightly as she whipped around some flowers. “Yeah, whatever.” They were dangerous looking flowers, okay?

“Time to CRUSH!” Frosta flew through the air, smashing Horde bots and Horde armor like it was nothing with giant ice fists. Mermista liked her attitude.

“We have to keep moving forward,” Glimmer said, “This is a waste of time.” Ever since they had joined up Glimmer had, like, totally been on edge. They all wanted Adora back. Hello, She-ra would have leveled these bozos by now.

“What do you think we’re doing, Glimmer?” Mermista asked. “We’re not just standing around.”

“Ugh, come on, can we just work together for a minute?” Glimmer asked.

Perfuma was way too enthusiastic, but even Frosta, in her weird obsession with Glimmer, was on board.

"Ugh fine, but we're doing it on my count," Mermista said. Suck it, Glimmer. "Ready?" And then they all fell in line. Perfuma summoned up the biggest roots she could find, Mermista pulled water from beneath them, some of which was frozen into ice, and Glimmer did her sparkle . . . thing. But they moved together and unleashed their powers all at once, clearing a path in front of them to the heart of the Horde forces.

Mermista ran forward, making sure Glimmer didn't try to take all the glory again.

They hadn't made it far when a familiar voice rang out. "Looking for something?" There was Catra, popping out of the top of some ugly tank.

"About time," Glimmer said with annoyance.

Finally. Wherever Catra was, that's probably where She-ra was. Was it just Mermista or did everyone think Catra had a thing for Adora? Like maybe it was a weird hate thing or like a very, very complicated crush, but totally obsessed, right?

"Well, so sorry to keep you waiting, your majesty," Catra said as she opened the drawbridge door of her vehicle. This girl was *so* drama.

They had been anticipating it, but it was worse to see. Glimmer and Bow had warned them that She-ra would be herself, but scarier. They had undersold it. Inhuman red eyes, sword clutched so hard in her hand that her forearm muscles were rippling even more than usual, and creepy red somethings wrapped around her sword arm so tightly that it was hard to make out the flesh underneath. Not to mention the veins. They were popping in all the wrong ways. They were swollen and as red as her eyes. Not just on her arms, but on her face and down her legs. Overall, she

was less like the muscular wonder woman Mermista thought was, well, pretty hot, and more like a creepy humanoid monster.

Mermista's normal calm demeanor lurched inside her. "So I don't love this," she said as She-ra rushed them.

"We need to disarm her!" Bow said as he dodged a blow that would have taken him out.

"What are we going to do, cut off her arm? The sword is basically tethered to her," Mermista said as she pulled more water from the ground trying to slow the barrage and also provide water for Frosta to create a shield for them.

Bow looked at She-ra's sword arm, "Glimmer, Mermista's right! The infection is way thicker than before."

"Just knock her out then!" Glimmer cried as she teleported close to She-ra, earning herself an elbow to the temple before she could even get close.

Mermista vaguely heard Catra laughing in the background as she ran to Glimmer's side. "Hey! You can't do anything risky. You're our way out if-"

"-We can't retreat!" Glimmer said as she teleported again.

Mermista grabbed her head and groaned. "Ugh, can no one stick to the plan?"

"We weren't prepared for this!" Perfuma shouted as more of her plants got shredded. How could She-ra take them all out on her own? Mermista looked around, she wasn't. Those useless Horde soldiers, apparently, were less useless when She-ra was able to scatter the princesses about and they were becoming surrounded. Glimmer was out of control, Bow was almost out of arrows, Frosta was doing her best to protect everyone, and Mermista and Perfuma were the only ones on the offensive.

“Hey! Arrow boy, I thought she was supposed to be like a maniac? Why is she only fighting us? There’s other people here too.”

“I don’t know!” Bow said.

“She-ra, stop.” They heard over the chaos of battle.

And just like that, She-ra did stop. Mermista watched as her eyes twitched like some unseen force was holding her back from the destruction she so badly wanted. The rest of the Horde soldiers stood by.

“H-how did you do that?” Glimmer screamed the question up to Catra who was, annoyingly, lounging from atop her post.

Catra looked at Glimmer with an evil glint even Mermista could see. “Because, she’s mine.” And without even a verbal warning, She-ra was back on the attack, relentless and out of control in a way Adora never was. They were running out of time.

“We have to go, Glimmer,” Mermista urged.

“Not yet,” Glimmer said. “I can get her.”

“Come on!” Mermista screamed. As she did, She-ra cornered Frosta and Bow. She knocked Frosta out easily, who crumpled to the ground along with the icy defenses that had protected the rest of them from being closed in on. The soldiers moved closer as Mermista and Perfuma turned to hold them off.

Mermista glanced back at She-ra, who raised her sword and struck Bow without hesitation. He dodged. It was fast enough to save his life, but not fast enough to avoid damage. The sword sunk into his shooting arm. Mermista could feel the impact in her teeth as the blade met bone. Bow let out a horrible scream of pain as blood spurted out of the wound. Mermista felt a surge of nausea and Perfuma immediately started screaming. Glimmer went to him, instantly teleporting him and Frosta both out of She-ra’s war path. Blood literally shot out of Bow in time with his ragged heart beat, soaking all three of them.

“Now!” Mermista said. “We need to go now!”

Glimmer was in shock. Perfuma bound She-ra as tightly as she could. Perfuma and Mermista scrambled to Glimmer as She-ra broke free. Sea Hawk appeared out of nowhere just in time as Mermista screamed, “Glimmer! Now!”

They teleported away, but Mermista could swear she felt air rush by her side from She-ra’s sword as they did.

Adora was back on board the transport, cuffed with dried blood sticking to her shirt, her pants, and her face. She was unconscious. Catra watched her. She had been watching her for awhile. At first, the power she felt was exhilarating. Watching the princesses cry and run home was incredible. Now, she felt something else as she inspected Adora covered in blood. Catra scoffed. It could have been her blood all over Adora just as easily. But reason caught up with her. Adora never hurt her badly, not really. Catra remembered She-ra’s eyes as she had lowered the sword at the Northern Reach.

Catra shook her head. Adora had hurt her plenty. It might not have been directly, but did it matter? Adora didn’t even know what Shadow Weaver had done after she left. After Catra had covered for her over and over. The only reason she was kept alive, at first, was because she was Shadow Weaver’s errand girl. Catra had gotten lucky. It might have been Shadow Weaver who sent Catra to retrieve Adora, but it had been Hordak who had gotten impressed. As long as she stayed on his good side, Shadow Weaver couldn’t touch her.

Without realizing it, Catra’s pulse had increased and her hands had gone clammy. She straightened. That was behind her now.

This is what Adora had chosen and this was the end result. Catra needed this to survive. She had to do this.

“You checking me out or what?” Adora slurred in nearly incoherent speech. “Hey, let me down, please?” Oh right, there was this phase of Adora to deal with.

“No way,” Catra responded.

“Why?” Adora asked.

“You’re a flight risk,” Catra said flatly.

“Why?” she asked again. God, was she two?

“Even this fucked up version of you will try and escape.” Catra pointed at her.

Adora followed Catra’s finger and looked down at her shirt. Catra recoiled. “Were we painting?”

“Something like that,” Catra responded as she slid to the ground, leaning her back against the steel walls as they rolled over bumpy ground.

Adora started to whine. Catra hated it. “This isn’t comfortable.”

“Comfort? This is not a vacation!” Catra said.

“Come on, Catra. Please let me down. Pleaseeeeee,” the whining continued.

“No,” Catra responded.

Adora tried a new tactic. “I’ll rub your ears?”

“What? No!” Catra stammered.

“Why? Thought you liked that,” Adora said, puzzled.

“I mean, I do - I mean, ugh.”

Adora smiled again, “Pleaseeeeeeee.”

“Will you shut up if I let you down?” Catra asked, flustered.

“Yep!”

“I’m still going to leave you cuffed,” Catra added.

“Okay,” Adora said as she smiled wider. Catra disconnected her cuffs from the wall, still making sure they were securely fastened, but let her keep her arms in front of her body. Her feet were still bound anyway and it’s not like she was going to move that fast in her current condition. Adora slumped to the ground, grinning and looking a little too proud of herself. “Hey,” she said.

“You’re such a dork,” Catra said, as she sat back down across from Adora.

“You love me.”

Catra’s ears flattened. “Shut up, Adora,” Catra warned. “We had a deal.”

Adora shut her mouth but still was smiling as she scooted across the room. Catra reached for her taser but Adora stopped right in front of her.

Adora’s hands were in her lap and the bottoms of her feet were pushed together. Adora’s knees touched Catra’s.

"Hey, you’re too close," Catra said as she shoved Adora backwards to the floor.

Adora looked up from the ground and frowned. "You're mean."

"Mean? I'm fucking evil," Catra spat.

Adora laughed, snorting when she laughed too hard. "Quit messing around." Adora lifted herself back up to face Catra again.

"You don't know what I'm capable of," she threatened, grabbing Adora's shoulders tightly in warning. Catra had expected Adora to flinch, but she didn't. Now, Catra's hands felt awkward resting on Adora's body. She took them back, blushing.

Adora let out another short laugh, "Argue tomorrow. Sleep now." Adora navigated past Catra and leaned her back on to the wall. They sat side by side. The entire thing shocked Catra so much she didn't move until Adora was breathing heavy, asleep, not that that took very long. Catra exhaled, thankful Adora wouldn’t realize how ruffled Adora’s behavior had left Catra.

It was easier to babysit when Adora was asleep, right? She growled but closed her eyes and let her head drop backwards to be supported by the wall. She opened one eye and looked back down at Adora before falling asleep.

Catra was jostled awake when they came to a halt. She rubbed her eyes and then rested them on Adora, who was fully lying in her lap. Catra blushed hard as she unwound her tail from Adora’s waist. There was an unexpected mix of warmth and panic in her chest, but it hiccuped when she looked closer. Dried blood was still flaking off Adora’s face. Catra hovered her hand over Adora’s cheek, sighed, and then dropped it.

Groggily, Adora came to. She sleepily said, “Hey Catra,” with a smile, like their friendship had never stopped. Catra reacted by shoving her to the ground.

Adora slowly took in her surroundings. From her place on the floor, recognition replaced confusion. Catra stared when Adora pulled at her bonds and struggled to sit back up, groaning as she did. It was clear that Adora wasn’t totally herself, but she did

seem more clear headed than she had after the battle. “What . . . what happened?”

“You don’t know?” Catra asked. Her body betrayed her discomfort, but Adora didn’t notice.

Adora didn’t hear anything but an increasingly loud ring in her ears as she looked down at her hands. She followed the trail, noticing the colors on her clothes were not what they should be. They were dark and rusty and crunchy. As she examined, all the ease Adora’s body held flickered out. Visibly, her shoulders tensed up towards her ears. Her breath hitched. Her eyes fixated on her hands, unblinking.

Threateningly, she looked at Catra, “What did you do?”

Catra forced on a mask of indifference. “Don’t you mean, what did you do?”

Into the Dark

Chapter Notes

> Warnings: Child abuse, referenced sexual abuse, panic attack, violence, blood

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Bow! BOW!" Glimmer cried. After several, subsequent teleports, the Princess Alliance was back in Bright Moon. The trip left Glimmer trembling all over in exhaustion, but she held Bow close, nestled protectively to her chest anyway. The wound on his arm had gone from spurting blood to trickling, but enough had poured out of him to leave him weak. His skin was pale and slick and, instead of his normal warm smile, his mouth was a hard line.

Glimmer had never felt so scared in her entire life. There was no world for her without Bow in it. Alternating her gaze between his face and his arm, Glimmer felt helpless. The gore in front of her didn't make her queasy, but it being on her best friend did. There was a deep wedge cut down the center of his forearm with small shards of bone littering it. Today, Glimmer learned that, even when hit with a sharp weapon, bones shattered on impact.

Upon their sudden arrival, the Bright Moon staff, who had grown accustomed to Glimmer popping up unexpectedly, responded immediately. Stubbornly, Glimmer clutched Bow tighter, primal instincts telling her to hide and protect him. That did not deter medics from pushing her away with firm hands as she screamed in protest. Perfuma's hand landed on her shoulder, the grip friendly but unyielding.

"They're going to help him," Perfuma said calmly.

Glimmer's fists clenched in anger and her shoulders slumped in grief, her body confused about what feeling was appropriate. Snippets of the medics' conversation landed in her ears, but she

couldn’t manage to place the words in the right order in her head. Everything was on a slant.

Perfuma’s voice cut through her haze. “He’s going to be okay.”

FInally tearing her eyes away from Bow, Glimmer turned to Perfuma, who offered her a loving smile, but said nothing else.

On the other side of the hallway, Frosta watched everything fall apart in front of her. Before this, they always won or retreated unscathed. They were untouchable when they were together. But today, they lost. Today, there were consequences. The shreds of childhood that clung to Frosta yesterday had lost their last foothold.

Frosta’s eyes moved back and forth from one hand to the other, only a small part registering the stain there. With everything that had happened, she thought she should feel despair like Glimmer or fear like Bow or anger like Mermista or something, but she didn’t. She felt nothing.

The medical team put Bow on a stretcher and were off with him in a sprint to the medical ward. Pulling away from Perfuma, Glimmer’s feet move after them, not allowing Bow out of her sight.

Mermista, Perfuma, Sea Hawk, and Frosta were left alone with echoes withdrawing down the hall.

“Frosta?” a voice said. “Frosta!” it repeated, more pressing this time. Finally, she connected the sound to Mermista. “You should get cleaned up.” Frosta didn’t move. “Ugh, Perfuma, you need to help me with this.”

Perfuma approached them. Mimicking her move earlier for Glimmer, Perfuma put a hand on Frosta’s shoulder. “Frosta?”

Frosta was still.

Perfuma said again, “Frosta?” Her voice was even and kind. “WIll you walk with me?” There was a warmth that wrapped around her hands and pulled at her gently.

Mermista crossed her arms, uncomfortable, but glad that Perfuma was here, who was, apparently, an expert in crisis response. Mermista could handle Glimmer and Bow and even what had happened, but she could not handle the look on Frosta’s face. Glancing over her shoulder, Mermista saw Sea Hawk sulking in the corner, quieter than he had ever been. Biting her lip, nervous, she approached him. If Perfuma could do it, so could she. Sea Hawk was her responsibility.

“Sea Hawk, I need you to get up,” Mermista said, as Perfuma slowly ushered Frosta down the hall.

“Oh yes . . .” Sea Hawk said, but his tone was flat. Mermista hated it more than she hated his singing.

Sighing she said, “Hey, I need you. Frosta needs us. We have to figure it out, okay? And I . . . “ she stopped.

Sea Hawk watched Perfuma and Frosta. Perfuma continued to whisper words of encouragement. “I . . . I feel rather . . . horrible,” he said,

Mermista softened. Squatting in front of him, she gently grabbed his chin and turned his head up to look at her. “We lost one battle. We’ve lost others. I know you and Bow are close, but he will be okay.” It wasn’t the same sweet tone of Perfuma’s voice, but it was the most sensitive Mermista could muster.

Sea Hawk’s eyes shimmered. “This is not how adventures go”

“This adventure isn’t over.” She stood and offered her hand to him. Hesitating, he took it. With as much energy as she could, she pulled him up, making his eyes twinkle at her strength.

Sea Hawk huffed out his chest. “My dear Mermista! You have pulled me from my darkness. Now, onward!”

Part of her knew he was only doing this for her sake, but she took it. "Ugh, whatever," she said. Part of her was only doing this for him, too. When he let his hand linger in hers she said, "Fine," lacing their fingers together and holding his palm in hers. Sea Hawk blushed and smiled, big and goofy, but kept his mouth shut. Mermista was thankful.

They caught up with Perfuma. Frosta wasn't talking yet, but she didn't look quite as freaked as she had a minute ago.

"Come on, there's, like, a pretty decent bathroom over here." Mermista pointed over her shoulder and the group followed.

When they arrived back to the Fright Zone almost an hour ago, Catra had seen Adora, not She-ra, go berserk. At the time, Catra fought back, screeching just as loudly. When Adora stood up, dripping with defiance, Catra knocked her off her feet. The screaming match continued until Catra, sick of it, grabbed two guards to drag Adora back to her cell. All the way down the hallway, Catra could hear Adora yelling her name.

Now, Catra was back in her private quarters, furious. Once the door creaked shut, she ripped her mask from her face and threw it across the room. It bounced off the wall opposite with a violent clang and rattled across the floor. With a sputtering hiss, she leaned her back to the wall and slid to the ground, claws moving to her scalp to pull at the wild tufts sticking out. Her ears flattened, Adora's shrill voice rang in the space between her skull. Beneath her, Catra's tail was poofed up, the hairs only now starting to settle.

What had Adora expected? Catra told her exactly how this was going to go. This was the cost of leaving the Horde, of leaving her. Hordak would be happy with today's report and Catra could keep

climbing to the top. The Princess Alliance had no chance without She-ra's power and without Adora's tactics. This war was hers to win.

"What's going to happen when you win? Will that be everything you want?"

Catra stilled as Adora's words sunk in. Tears burned at her eyes. Stubbornly, she blinked them away. It didn't matter what happened after the war. Catra smoothed her mane.

"What happened to you?"

"Get out of my head," Catra growled. Scraping her claws on the floor, Catra embraced the anger that rushed over her. Adora didn't have any idea what happened after she left. Catra hated that Adora didn't care about her anymore like she cared about the Rebels. Watching Adora scream over their pain, but not Catra's, burned a hole in her heart.

But Catra had power now. All it took was a thought and She-ra struck them down at Catra's command. When she thought about it, it had not been as thrilling as she had hoped. Instead, a flood of remembered pain returned to her. All the times Shadow Weaver had used her magic to control Catra's body. Now, Catra was using tech to control She-ra. To control Adora. Guilt wrapped itself around her, but she resisted.

Maybe if Adora hadn't let Shadow Weaver hurt Catra. Maybe if Adora hadn't enjoyed Shadow Weaver's praise so much. Maybe if Adora had taken Catra with her on that first night. Anything, any small shred of consideration, and things could be different.

Another pang resounded, stirring in her a feeling she didn't know she could have anymore. The warmth that spread through her when she woke up with Adora in her lap. It had been natural and soothing, having someone else against her. Feeling Adora touching her.

An itch in her legs caused Catra to stand up and move to her mirror. Instead of being greeted by a hard, war commander, she saw a ragged, scared girl. Deep in her throat a growl rose in her, but it could not mask the raw emotion that looked back at her. As she stared, she saw a younger version of herself.

They were 15 years old, or close. Adora and Catra always claimed they were the same age, even though they had no idea. All they knew was that they had always been together and they would always be together.

To Catra's annoyance, Adora had grown taller than her in the last year. She had gotten better at using her long limbs, but when her growth spurt first hit, Adora was tripping all the time. Catra made sure to constantly remind her about how uncoordinated she was.

Adora wasn't tripping now as they ran down the hallway, she was hot on Catra's tail. And, as they rounded a corner, Adora reached far enough ahead to shove her into the wall. Catra stumbled, losing the inside lane as Adora took the lead.

"Hey!" Catra shouted, righting herself and taking off full speed again. Adora glanced back, sticking out her tongue.

Catra was faster, but Adora blocked the path. Catra couldn't find an opening to squeeze through. They were nearing the finish line. Instead of admitting defeat, Catra launched herself at Adora's back, knocking her to the floor.

They both fell with a whump, breathing hard. Adora turned over and grabbed Catra by the shoulders. Catra gulped. She might have been faster, but Adora would always be stronger. When the Horde's best grappler got their hands on you, it was game over. Still, not being one to give in, Catra fought back. It was only a few seconds before she got flipped on her back, Adora pinning her hands above her head.

"You cheated!" Adora accused.

“Me! You slammed me into the wall.” At her words, Adora frowned, releasing Catra’s hands so she could cross her arms.

“That was a regulation hit.”

“Regulation? Are you making up rules again to make yourself look good? I was winning and you are still the slowest person on Etheria.” Catra propped herself up on her elbows, trying to get her eyes level with Adora’s. With her arms and hips, Catra pushed against her, but Adora was a wall and she only laughed at Catra’s attempts. The sound made heat flow to Catra’s cheeks.

They were both flushed from activity, which hid Catra’s blush as Adora’s heavy breathing sounded around them. Adora smirked, “I got you pretty good, didn’t I?”

“Shut up, let me up.” It had been happening more, this swimming feeling around Adora. There was more electricity in their touch. Catra didn’t say anything about it because Adora didn’t say anything about it.

Adora moved aside, “Don’t be a sore loser, Catra.” She stuck out her tongue again and Catra took the opportunity to pounce. Shocked, Adora fell backwards in surprise, but laughed again when she hit the ground. In Catra’s stomach, there was something making her lazy and happy, a warm, fluttering feeling. She didn’t have a name for it, but it only happened when she was close to Adora. It made her want to be closer.

Catra laughed too, and soon, they were laughing together, Catra straddling Adora’s hips. Adora’s laughter was nerdy and loud and cute and Catra loved when she was the cause of it. While Adora kept going, Catra’s laughter died and she stared down at the girl underneath her.

Adora noticed she was laughing solo and opened her eyes. She flashed a cocky smile and said, “What are you looking at?”

“Get over yourself,” Catra replied. She moved to get up, but Adora caught her. That made her heart drop. Around her own wrist,

were Adora's fingers. The hold was firm and sure, but not forceful. Catra could get away if she wanted to. She didn't want to. So Adora moved her hand and intertwined her fingers with Catra's, so thoughtfully Catra couldn't help but swallow hard. They held hands all the time. This wasn't different.

But the way her heart was beating in her chest she could tell it was. Adora sat up, almost cross legged. She pulled Catra with her, resulting in Catra perching on Adora's lap, with their fingers still tucked together resting on Catra's thigh.

"What, do you like me or something?" Catra said, but it came out more of a whisper than she meant.

Adora was still smiling. It was that dorky, beautiful smile that made Catra smile too. Smoothly, Adora let her free palm touch Catra's face. It was light, so Catra fell into it, encouraging. Adora bit her bottom lip, leaning closer. Catra's mouth went dry as she felt the warmth of Adora's breath. Quietly, Adora whispered, "Can I?"

"-Adora. Catra," a voice cut out of the shadow. "What are you doing out here?"

Catra tore away from Adora, ears twitching. Adora wasn't far behind as they both jumped to their feet. They went to work straightening themselves. Adora fixed her hair and Catra dusted off her uniform. It was useless, they looked completely unpresentable after a day of training and their race. They were supposed to be making their way to dinner right now.

"Catra, did you drag Adora out here?" Shadow Weaver descended on Catra. Had she seen what had happened? Catra should have been more careful. They knew better than to get caught playing let alone . . . whatever was about to happen.

"It was my idea," Adora said, taking a step forward. "I, um, Catra is really fast and I am working on getting faster and-"

"-Adora, why are you lying to me?" Shadow Weaver put her hand on Adora's face, tucking a hair behind her ear. The touch lacked the softness of when Adora had caressed Catra's cheek moments ago. A growl grew in Catra's throat at the possessive gesture.

Adora trembled. Catra hated Shadow Weaver.

"Adora, go clean up, lessons tonight," Shadow Weaver commanded.

"It's Wednesday, it's not-" Adora looked at Catra. Catra spared a glance back for a second. It was a clear night out and they had plans to go look out at the glowing moons.

"-Adora, what did I say?"

Adora looked back at her in shock, "Lessons tonight, y-yes ma'am."

Turning to Catra, Shadow Weaver said, "And you, you are coming with me, now."

"What, no! She didn't do anything," Adora pleaded, stepping in front of Catra protectively.

Catra's eyes went wide. She hadn't even talked back.

"Better hurry, Adora." Shadow Weaver grabbed Catra by the front of her shirt. Turning her head, she saw Adora in a dead sprint down the hall. Somehow, it was even faster than she had run before.

Shadow Weaver slapped Catra in the face to recapture her attention. Stinging tears immediately left her eyes. "Let me go!" Catra said as she squirmed. That earned her another slap in the face in precisely the same spot.

"What were you doing?" Shadow Weaver seethed.

“No - nothing. We were just . . . “ Catra felt more tears and it had nothing to do with the pain anymore.

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes and Catra’s heart pounded in a frenzy. “You do not deserve her affection.” Catra’s stomach clenched.

Shadow Weaver’s hand fisted the back of Catra’s shirt and dragged her forward, nails scratching her neck enough to make her yelp.

Too soon, they arrived at the Black Garnet Chamber. Within the room, Catra was told to sit against the wall. She did, wishing to be anywhere else in the world. The Black Garnet flickered as Shadow Weaver charged herself. Catra was too familiar with this action and she shrunk into herself, trying to disappear.

“Please hurry,” she whispered, curling into a ball.

Adora was not fast enough. The air rushed from Catra’s lungs, choking her to her hands and knees. As she shook, something wrapped around her tail. She wanted to scream, but there was no air. Then, a hand grabbed her chin, jerking her face up. The grip only tightened as she tried to pull away, strong fingers buried into the delicate line of her jaw.

Shadow Weaver held Catra’s tail in front of her in the other hand, squeezing it painfully. The hair around the end of her tail started to smoke, slowly at first and then singeing down to her skin. The acrid smell hit Catra’s nose first, but then the pain on her skin erupted. Fire in her lungs and fire on her body. Her vision blurred with tears and agony and quickly approached unconsciousness. Shadow Weaver was going to kill her. She was sure of it this time. The edges of Catra’s vision were closing in, but the pain of the burn moving up her tail kept her alert.

Then, it all stopped. There was a loud, rushed knock on the door. Catra choked, as oxygen hit her lungs, reaching for air and wanting to scream. With her basic need for air met, Catra became

more aware of the sensitive skin of her tail, which she brought to her chest to protect. Shadow Weaver turned around and opened the door to Adora. Adora stood there, perfectly at attention, with wet hair tangled and dripping. She breathed harder than Catra had ever seen her. Adora's nose twitched as the smell of burnt hair entered her nostrils.

"Very good, Adora," Shadow Weaver said. It was casual, like she hadn't been trying to kill Catra seconds ago. Still on the ground taking deep gulps of air, Catra looked to Adora, fear and pain making her skittish. Adora looked flustered, but nodded in reassurance when Shadow Weaver turned around. "You," Shadow Weaver pointed to Catra, "can go. Don't let me see you until training tomorrow." Catra knew this meant no dinner.

Adora's eyes locked, urging her to *go* and she scurried away with none of the grace she usually possessed. With her tail damaged, her balance was off and she nearly fell over during her exit. The door slammed shut.

Catra collapsed, still calming her breathing. Her heart hurt. Both her and Adora got caught misbehaving - Adora had even talked back! But Catra got tortured and what did Adora get? *"Very good, Adora."* Praise.

After picking herself up, she snuck to the empty shower room and cried. The burn on her tail hurt and, when she touched it, she winced. The fur had burned off the end and, in its place, were bubbling blisters that needed treatment. She ran it under cool water and cringed. She dressed the wound and made it back to the bunkhouse, lying awake, trying to stay calm, and waiting anxiously for Adora.

Adora never told Catra what she and Shadow Weaver did together. Whenever Catra pressed, Adora would say, "Boring stuff. Makes me read extra and do extra training. It sucks." Or she would tackle Catra to the ground until Catra forgot. Adora was going to be the youngest Force Captain the Horde had ever had.

Shadow Weaver wanted Adora to grow and she did. Catra wished someone like that believed in her.

Time passed and Catra's stomach lurched in hunger. Cadets started rolling in to go to sleep. Still, no Adora.

By the time she returned, it was lights out. She was quiet. Probably had gotten a good talking to about how rotten Catra was and how her influence was marring Adora's otherwise perfect performance. She waited for Adora to jump into her bed, but she didn't, that was uncharacteristic.

Instead, Adora walked to her bunk and handed her a full ration bar without a word, then slunk into her own bed. Catra immediately climbed down and elbowed Adora, who flinched away. "Hey," she said.

"I'm sorry. She hurt you badly, didn't she? I went as fast as I could," Adora whispered, facing away from Catra.

"I'm okay. She didn't get much of a chance. If you had run that fast before, you could have beaten me fair and square," Catra said with encouragement as she took a bite and swallowed. She put up this front for Adora. She would not look weak, not in front of Adora or anyone else.

Adora turned to face her. "I'm sorry."

"It's fine. You know she's out to get me," Catra said with a lightness she didn't feel.

Adora's eyebrows drew together and, for a minute, Catra thought she might cry.

"Hey, it's okay." Catra put her hand on Adora's, but Adora pulled away.

"Sorry, I . . . " Adora said. "I should be better."

“Fuck her, you’re the best and everyone knows it. Even she can’t stop you anymore.” Pain flickered in Catra’s chest. Adora never pulled away from her. “Did you eat? You should take half,” Catra offered the bar.

A voice rang out in the dark, “Go to bed!”

“Shut up, Lonnie!” Catra and Adora said in unison. They looked at each other and Catra caught Adora smiling.

They heard Lonnie roll over in her bed, grumbling. This was an almost daily occurrence.

“I’m not hungry,” Adora said quietly.

“You should be. Come on, eat this.” Catra pushed the food almost into Adora’s mouth for her. With a sigh, Adora opened her mouth, grabbing it with her teeth. She chewed and swallowed with a dry mouth.

“Happy?” Adora said. Pointing to Catra’s tail she asked, “Can I see it?”

Tension melted away as Catra hopped into Adora’s bed. She moved until they were face to face, close enough that no one else would be able to pick up on their words.

“I wrapped it up. It’ll be okay. I’ve had worse,” Catra flashed her tail in front of Adora’s face.

“I could smell it when I got there. It’s my fault, I’m-”

“-Shut up,” Catra said. Adora did, searching Catra’s eyes instead. When she found no anger in them, Adora relaxed.

“About before . . . “ Catra started, referencing the moment in the hallway when they were about to . . . do something.

“I . . . sorry. I shouldn’t have pushed you.”

“That’s not what I’m talking about, Adora. After that. We were . . . .”

Catra heard Adora gulp. It was Catra’s turn to bite her bottom lip, wetting it like before. All the swimming feelings returned. She wanted to kiss Adora. Adora wanted to kiss her earlier, she was sure. With confidence, Catra closed her eyes and leaned in, but something stopped her.

Adora moved away, pushing into Catra’s shoulder. Catra tried to reach out, but it made Adora flinch so hard she almost fell out of bed.

“Adora, what’s wrong?” Catra said, a plea in her voice. She felt a pit in her stomach swallowing every good emotion she had earlier. Suddenly, the pain from her burn was excruciating.

They shared a look for a long time and Catra could see the conflict in Adora’s eyes. Earlier, there had been no conflict. Something happened. “What did she say to you?” Catra said, sparking anger into her words.

Again, Adora moved away from her, frightened.

Then, for the second time today, Adora turned and ran.

“Adora, wait!” Catra called out, but Adora was already gone.

Catra pounded her fist into the wall next to the mirror, averting her eyes from it and the memory. Nothing had changed. Adora was always running from her and Catra was always running after her. Biting her tongue, Catra took slow steps to the door. She faced it, wrapping her hand around the doorknob and stood still. All she had to do was go to Adora’s cell and tell her that the Rebels were okay. Likely, Adora would still be mad but she’d be so relieved that -

-That what? What was Catra expecting? If she left this room, none of this would have been worth it. Adora had abandoned her to a group of people she didn’t know after less than a day. One day to

throw away almost two decades of friendship. It had been a long time since she was 15 years old. Maybe then she needed Adora, but she did not need her anymore.

Leaning her head against the door, she let her hand drop.

The next morning came and Mermista and Glimmer found themselves alone. Finally. Perfuma was too level headed. Frosta was, like, deeply traumatized. Sea Hawk was out running an errand for the Queen. And Bow was . . . Bow was recovering.

"Look, what if we, and, I mean, you and me, went after Adora tonight?"

Glimmer sucked in a giant breath, "We can't do that we just-"

"-Glimmer, listen to me. They are probably feeling good about themselves right now. Come on, you know how Catra is." Mermista appealed. Glimmer groaned. They both knew how Catra was.

Shrugging with tense shoulders Glimmer said, "That's true but-"

"-Listen! We can sneak in and get Adora before they even know. If something goes wrong, poof, you get us out. They won't expect it. They think we're beaten and bummed out but we can do this. Stealth mission." Mermista tapped her foot impatiently. She knew Glimmer would give in eventually, but fighting against her was, just, ugh.

Glimmer crossed her arms and raised her voice a little louder. "What if one of us gets hurt? I already messed up yesterday."

"Glimmer, Bow is fine!" Maybe that hadn't been the right thing to say.

Glimmer stiffened. "Fine?! He has pins and screws holding his bones together. It's going to take ages to heal! If I had stuck to the plan, none of this would have happened. What if someone had died?"

Mermista crossed her arms and stood up tall. "You can't blame yourself for shit that didn't even happen. I'm not happy about it either but I'm ready to make them pay and this is how we do it."

"Mermista, I don't know. Don't you think we're rushing it? I'm always getting in trouble for being rash and-" Glimmer put her head in her hands, shaking her head back and forth.

"-Glimmer, we can't keep this up," Mermista cut Glimmer off again. "We were caught off guard, but we have the chance to do the same to the Horde. If we can get Adora, they lose their edge and we get ours back. I'm ready to make them pay."

Glimmer was torn. She looked into the fire in Mermista's eyes. It was enough to spark Glimmer's own.

"Let's go," Glimmer said with finality.

"Whoa there tiger, tonight. I want to be fast, not stupid. We can plan out our mission in that time." Mermista looked Glimmer up and down, "And you need to get a full charge."

Scowling Glimmer said, "Fine, let's start now. Get a chair, we're going to the moonstone." Springing to her feet, Glimmer started down the hall with purpose.

"That's more like it."

At some point, after returning to her cell yesterday evening, Adora had fallen asleep. Between her burnt out post-infection body and

her frayed emotions, it was more like she had collapsed. It was just another way that her body had betrayed her. She hadn't slept well and, instead, spent most of today falling in and out of consciousness, in and out of nightmares.

Now, it was night again. There was no way to be sure of the time, but the darkness was heavier and the nighttime guard was out. It had been an entire day and she still had no idea what had happened to her friends. Her awareness was scattered, like she had woken from a fever and wasn't sure what was real.

After attempting to stand, she fell, slamming her back into the wall hard. She felt sickly and, yesterday, she had hurt someone. Judging by the amount of blood still caked on her, she had hurt someone badly. Or hurt a lot of people. Or hurt a lot of people badly. Maybe Catra was right. Adora wasn't strong enough to be She-ra. Definitely not strong enough to lead a rebellion. She wasn't even strong enough to control herself. How many people would she kill before this was over?

They were the same thoughts that had been haunting her since her mind cleared enough to understand that she had fought a battle, on the wrong side.

Letting out another groan, Adora slumped. She was trapped. Her body had never been her own. Shadow Weaver used her. The Horde used her. The Rebellion, even her friends, used her. Now, Catra was doing the same. Adora winced. She-ra had been her destiny, but this couldn't be what it was meant for. Adora had screwed it up and she felt so stupid.

This shouldn't have happened. Just days ago, she could have beaten Catra. Years before that, Adora could have protected her better. If she had, would this have happened at all? Catra used to be kind and curious and fun and loving. Now? Adora didn't know what to think. Catra was like everyone else. Adora was a thing they could use, not a person. She was good for nothing but to fight. Strong enough to kill but not strong enough to have control.

Adora's eyes snapped to her hands, dry and cracking. Hours ago, she had cleaned the blood off of them, scouring them with harsh prison soap. There were new flakes dotting them that had fallen from her clothes as she thrashed on the floor in her sleep. She rubbed them together furiously, compulsively. Bile rose in her throat as she scrubbed harder and harder, hands burning and shackles cutting into her wrists. She made her way to the sink on her knees and ran water over her hands, hot as it would go. Relentless, she picked her nails beds, feeling queasy as her own blood started to trickle out the edges.

Attention flew back to her stained clothing. She needed it off. It needed to be off right now. The cuffs on her wrists restricted her movement, but she had to find a way. She was panting, skin boiling where the cloth rubbed her. Her nerves were on fire, overstimulated and choking her. Her breathing was hard and ragged. Sweat dripped down her face. The metallic smell pervaded her senses.

In her chest, her heart was pummeling into her ribcage. She couldn't breathe. She wiped her hands and face and any part of her body she could reach. Eventually, she fell to her hands and knees. Bending towards her shackled hands, she pulled at her shirt with one hand as the other kept her balanced between labored breaths, ripping the seams with desperate, shaky strength. Where usually the tight white shirt was comfortable, keeping her muscles warm and compressed, now it felt constrictive. She needed it off. She couldn't breathe. Irregular, loud heaves for air left and entered her lungs, but she received none of the benefit. She was suffocating.

Adora scrabbled at the fabric, trying to keep it between her fingers, but sweat flowed from the pores on her fingertips. Her vision started to blur as she screamed, pulling hard when she got a grip around the collar. A satisfying rip released and she strained her neck against the pull of her own hands. Once she got through the collar, the rest shredded like paper. Frantically, she tore at the remaining strips of her sleeves and threw them away from her.

Sweat dripped down her forehead into a puddle beneath her. Adora's hair was up in a ponytail, but it was disheveled, sideways with loose hairs poking out, now as wet as if she had just come out of the shower.

With the shirt torn off, her breathing started to steady, but her shaking increased. Clambering to change her position, she removed her pants as well. She was left covered in droplets of sweat. Underneath that, goose pimples popped up down her exposed skin. She shivered in her bra and shorts in the corner of her cell.

Shaking from adrenaline and the cold, Adora was drained. The minutes ticked by and she fell back into unwelcome sleep.

A blaring alarm sounded throughout the Horde barracks. Catra pressed her palms to her eye sockets and flattened her ears down, willing it to stop. She hadn't slept since before making Adora her puppet. Eyelids rimmed red and heavy, she pushed herself up and out of bed. Glancing over her shoulder, she caught the time, 2:44am.

"Oh shit," she said. The night had pressed on for so long that she thought it was morning. Only now did she distinguish the sound she was hearing from the bell that she had grown up trying to drown out, that was the intruder alarm.

A knock came on her door. In an instant, she was on her feet. Looking down, she was a little rumpled, but she was dressed in her uniform and ready. Clicking her mask into place and smoothing out her front, she opened the door and was greeted with a messenger.

"I was told to deliver this to you, Force Captain." The guard held it delicately, like it could break if they dropped it, or like if they held

it too long, it would kill them. Catra would be happy if she never saw She-ra's sword ever again in her life. She hated it when Adora had it and she hated it now that it was hers.

With a fierceness she didn't feel, she reached out, grabbing it by the hilt as if she could strangle out its power.

"Princesses have been spotted along the perimeter. You are to retrieve She-ra and eradicate them." The guard stood still, at attention.

Catra's voice cracked in a harsh yell, "Don't you have somewhere to be?"

A look of surprise came over the guard's face before they straightened, said, "Yes, Force Captain," saluted, and walked away.

Under her breath, Catra whispered, "Fuck." She walked across the room and let her fingers run over the controller for She-ra before picking it up with uncertainty and hooking it into her mask so it rested on her skin. Glimpsing back at the mirror, she snarled and slammed the door behind her.

To keep her nerves under control, Catra walked faster. She knew that she would have to do this again, but she hadn't expected it so soon. The Princess Alliance weren't smart but they were gutsy, she'd give them that.

Whipping around the corner, she turned to face Adora's cell, dropping the forcefield that contained her.

Catra stood in front of Adora, who was sitting up in the back corner of her cell. Adora's eyes were red and wild. There were scratch marks all over her face. Her hands were raw and pink. Her clothes were torn and crumpled away from her and she was barefoot. Sweat rolled down Adora's neck, pooling in her collarbones and sinking into the already soaked fabric of her bra. Her muscles were quaking and taunt as she heaved in labored breaths.

Catra had seen her own eyes like that, but not Adora's. It petrified her on the spot.

Almost inaudible over the still ringing alarm, Catra said, "Adora?"

Distantly, Adora heard the alarm and shuffling footsteps, but, mostly, she heard the grinding sound of her breathing. Her eyes became sharper and more in focus as they fell on a glint of metal on the side of Catra's face. Slowly, Adora's eyes slid down to Catra's hand, limply holding She-ra's sword. "No," Adora croaked, clawing at her wrists and the wall behind her.

The sword clattered to the floor. It woke Catra from her daze. "I . . . " she swallowed.

"Catra, no," Adora begged.

Catra picked the sword up off the ground. Adora pressed her back against the wall, her ribs straining at the force.

Catra took several steps forward before going rigid again.

Adora shook all over. "Please."

Lowering the sword again, Catra stared at Adora. Adora stared back.

The connection was severed by a delicate pop in the background. Catra whirled, suddenly face to face with Glimmer.

Glimmer gasped and called over her shoulder, "I found her!" The sound was so loud it made Catra jump. A fist flew directly at her. "Catra, I swear to GOD, I will end you."

Confused and irritated, Catra dodged backwards, Glimmer's fist nearly connecting.

With Catra out of arm's length, Glimmer quickly said, "Adora! Are you okay?"

Adora's eyes widened in shock. After the day she had, with her nervous system on overdrive, everything now moved too fast. It felt like she had been thrust underwater and watched from a distance as the world moved in fast forward around her.

A growl came from nearby. "She's fine, Sparkles, but we'll see how you're doing after this." There was a sudden jerk as something hard was forced into Adora's hand. Unwillingly, her fist tightened around it.

Adora screamed. The usual heroic transformation into She-ra was taken over by a bastardization. Adora's muscles bulged into She-ra's violently. There was a cracking as Adora grew bigger. The blood pumping in her eyes became more forceful, like it had its own agenda. Red creeped into the blue irises and a wicked, crooked grin choked out Adora's scream.

Catra's ears flattened. She wanted to look away, but she couldn't. Letting the instinct to fight and win overtake her, she went on the offensive.

"Oh fuck," Mermista said as she came around the corner. Without another moment, Mermista raised her hands and pulled the steam out of the water vents. It cascaded them in mist, blinding all of them and making Catra yelp. "What the fuck do we do now?" Mermista yelled as she pulled Glimmer and took off running.

Glimmer concentrated and teleported them to a place higher in the cell block.

"There!" she heard Catra yell and point upwards at them. The arrangement of the prison did not give a lot of places to hide. Relentlessly, She-ra kicked her feet against the ground with inhuman power, springing up with strength that allowed her to ascend upwards.

"Holy shit," Mermista said, stunned.

"I just need to get my hands on her and then we can teleport her," Glimmer said as they watched She-ra close in.

“And then what?!”

“We didn’t talk about that!” Glimmer’s voice cracked.

Mermista groaned. “Fuck, look!” She pointed at the nearest entrance to the prison. Horde soldiers were pouring in around them as She-ra landed with a loud thunk in front of them. They were surrounded. “One shot and then we’re out, got it?”

“Got it,” Glimmer responded, letting herself calm into the familiarity of battle. Mermista pulled at the water she could find, knocking it against their enemies. It pushed the soldier back, but She-ra walked straight through the tidal wave.

“How is that even possible?” Glimmer screeched.

Catra landed behind them, startling them both. “Pretty great isn’t it?”

“Well shit,” Mermista muttered.

They were wedged between a shaking She-ra and a furious Catra. More Horde soldiers poured in, taking their place below, above, and around them, pointing weapons in their direction. Glimmer heard the whiz of a weapon charging. If only she could get to She-ra, they could get out of here and then, whatever, it didn’t matter.

“One shot, Glimmer,” Mermista said as she strained to protect them from the projectiles flying at them from every direction.

Glimmer reached out but sharp claws dug into her skin. “It’s not going to be that easy.” Catra swiped again and Glimmer fell backwards against Mermista, who was doing everything she could to hold off what seemed like the entire Horde. Mermista screamed as she pulled more water from the sewer system and let it wash away the soldiers aiming at them from below.

Trying again, Glimmer teleported behind Catra, but this time She-ra lashed out with her sword, keeping Glimmer too far to connect

with her skin.

“You’re not going to be fast enough for both of us,” Catra said as she landed a punch into Glimmer’s kidney.

Buckling over, Glimmer let out a strained groan. Mermista fell back next to her.

Glimmer’s hand closed around Mermista’s and, suddenly, they were back outside on the edge of the woods.

“What the hell?” Mermista screamed. “One shot, remember?”

“I just couldn’t . . . I . . . “ but Glimmer was already crying. “I tried, okay?”

“Fuck, yeah, whatever. We’re fine. At least we learned something.”

“We did?”

“Yeah, that was a really fucking terrible idea.”

They were both breathing heavy, their bodies coming down from battle.

Glimmer went pale. “Adora looked awful.”

“Well?” Catra turned to the soldiers all around her. “Go see if you can find them. Her teleportation can’t get her all the way back to Bright Moon.” They didn’t move. “Now!”

Soon, all but a few soldiers left the prison block. Those that were on maintenance detail looked sadly at the clock as they got to work fixing the damage. On a nearby computer, Catra scanned the cell assignments for a new place for Adora since her old cell had been completely destroyed by She-ra.

She-ra stood, trembling under Catra's command, but otherwise unmoving. Catra sighed. "Drop the sword." The vines that held She-ra's wrist loosened until the sword slipped from her fingers. She-ra's massive body started to fall forward, getting smaller as she did. Catra put her arms out and caught Adora. Unable to stop herself, Catra pushed her nose into Adora's hair, which had come completely undone and was plastered to her scalp. It was hard to detect, but under the blood, sweat, and fear, it was still just Adora. Adora's body was heavy with muscle, but Catra managed to pick her up like she had at the Northern Reach. This time, though, she cradled Adora's body to her chest, one arm under her knees and another around her shoulders. Adora's head lolled into Catra's chest, head barely brushing under Catra's chin.

"Do you need assistance transporting the prisoner?" a voice asked.

Catra almost jumped. Hissing she said, "Do I look like I need help? Pick up that sword and return it to Hordak." The soldier swallowed. "Hurry up, he doesn't like to be kept waiting," she threatened.

Catra walked down the hallway, holding Adora defensively. When she thought they were alone she whispered, "I - I didn't . . . " she trailed off, not sure exactly what to say. She didn't mean it? She didn't want to do it? Catra couldn't think like that. Seeing Adora in panic made Catra unsteady. The memories of her and Adora's relationship that had been at the forefront of her mind the last two days were not helping. To comfort herself, she nuzzled her cheek into Adora's messy hair, not wanting to admit how good it felt.

They slipped into a new cell in a different block, this one mostly empty of activity. Catra strained as she fought to place Adora against the ground gently, not bothering to cuff her. "I'll be right back." Catra glanced over her shoulder before putting up the barrier.

Forcing herself to walk and not run, Catra went to the laundry room. In cupboards outside were clean uniforms, she grabbed pants, a bra, and clean shorts. Her hands paused on the white longsleeve Adora preferred and hesitantly grabbed a size larger than Adora had worn a year ago. Her shoulders had only gotten broader and Catra wasn't sure she'd fit in her old size. On second thought, she grabbed a standard issue, loose, gray gym shirt with a small Horde symbol on the breast and added it to the stack.

With the pressed clothing cradled in her hands, Catra walked down the hallway, less gracefully than her normal saunter, tail swishing back and forth, troubled.

Catra entered the cell to Adora still unconscious on the floor in front of her.

"Hey Adora," Catra said lightly as she put the clean clothing in a neat pile by Adora's feet. Her hand lingered on the fabric as she slid to the ground. In her sleep, Adora looked a little more like herself for the first time since her capture. There was no defiance, no fear, no rage, and no panic, only smooth skin and a light, easy rise and fall of her chest. But, looking closer, her skin was waxy and she had lines on her face that hadn't been there days ago. Where her hands had hesitated the day before, Catra let them move the loose strands of hair away from Adora's face, tucking it carefully behind her ears.

Catra took her hand back and held it in her lap tightly. Even if Adora woke up, she wouldn't remember it. She hadn't remembered how a day earlier she had fallen asleep next to Catra, right? Catra ran her claws along the skin of her own scalp, wrapping her tail around her knees.

Looking down at Adora's body, Catra took stock of the changes of the last year. There were scars she recognized underneath new scars that she didn't. There were probably more in places she couldn't see. There were definitely a few Catra had placed. Adora's skin was still pale, but tanner on her face and hands. Adora's muscles had become bigger and more defined. It was

hard to see Adora in front of her, so familiar but with foreign signs of wear.

Adora's eyes snapped open, but it was groggy and not with the fury Catra braced herself for. Catra held her breath.

Propping herself on her elbows, Adora looked around, eyes settling on Catra. "What's happening to me?" Adora asked, sounding so coherent that it made Catra stop cold. Adora had only been goofy and dumb after the infection. This was new.

"What do you mean?" Catra asked, deflecting.

"I . . . I-" she started.

Adora reached her hand out to grab Catra's, but Catra pulled away. Confused, Adora shot her a questioning look, tears shined in her eyes.

"You need to sleep, okay? I . . . I have to go."

"But I thought-" Adora started, but Catra was already out the door and she didn't keep herself from running this time.

Adora was left, hands clutched to her chest, alone in the dark.

Chapter End Notes

Next time: Shadow Weaver finally makes an appearance.

This chapter was particularly hard to write. Thanks for sticking with me to here.

A Firm Hand

Chapter Notes

TW: Implied Rape/Non-Con, Manipulation

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You did WHAT?!" Bow shrieked.

Glimmer threw her hands up in exasperation, "You *said* you wouldn't freak out!"

"I told you not to tell him," Mermista said.

"Glimmer!" Bow cried.

Glimmer pulled her hair and fixed her eyes on Bow's feet, which were covered with a thin sheet on the bed in front of her. The room was tiny, leaving Glimmer trapped between Mermista and a wall.

Bow cleared his throat, leaned harder against his fortress of pillows, and bore into her with expectation.

"It wasn't even my idea!" Glimmer pleaded as she stood up.

"Hey!" Mermista got to her feet too, facing Glimmer and crossing her arms in front of her.

"Glimmer!" Bow shouted again.

"Yeah, Glimmer," Mermista said flatly.

"Ugh Bow! You didn't see her," Glimmer whined. "Adora looked scared." Bow looked away. "And she had only been there for, like, two and a half days. You remember what it was like when we were prisoners, don't you?"

Bow stayed silent, wincing as he rested his bandaged arm on his thigh.

"Being back at that . . . that place must be so terrible for her!" Glimmer finished with a sad whimper.

"In our defense, not that it, like, matters," Mermista waved nonchalantly, "but we almost got her."

"If Catra hadn't been there . . . . Ugh, Catra. She is the worst!" Glimmer's nostrils flared before her steam evaporated. "We were so close to her," she murmured.

"I get why you wanted to go, but we have to think these things through," Bow replied, evening out his voice.

"What's there to think about? She's our friend, she is not doing well, she *destroyed* us in battle -" Glimmer cut herself off, slapping a hand over her mouth.

"I am well aware!" Bow yelled.

Glimmer looked at his arm. It was immobilized with plaster and underneath she knew it had none of the strength she had learned to depend on. "Look Bow, I'm sorry. I, I really thought it would work." Glimmer slouched into her chair feeling defeated.

Mermista rested her hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "Look, okay, it's done. We're not gonna try again tonight or anything like that." Mermista shrugged, "Gotta say though, it was weird that Adora wasn't already transformed when we got there. The alarm had been going off for a pretty fucking long time."

"Yeah, Catra was just sort of . . . standing there when I teleported in?" Glimmer sighed.

Mermista took a step back. "I'm telling you, Catra is, like, weird for Adora."

"I still don't see it," Glimmer said. "Catra is fucking evil."

“I don’t know, Glimmer, they have a lot of history.” Bow put his chin in his good hand. “Adora spent a lot of her life being friends with Catra and,” he glanced at Glimmer, “. . . you know.”

Mermista shifted her weight to her left leg. “I stand by it.”

“Even if she still cares about Adora, she wouldn’t help us,” Glimmer said. “She hates me, like maybe more than the rest of you?”

“I won’t argue with that,” Mermista said, earning a glare from Glimmer. “What? You said it.”

“Catra did let us go that one time,” Bow pointed out.

Releasing a groan Glimmer argued, “Yeah, and then she let Adora fall off a cliff and then attacked Bright Moon and then *kidnapped* Adora. Am I forgetting anything?”

The room was silent aside from the steady beep of Bow’s heart rate on the monitor.

Mermista let her arms fall to her sides. “Yeah, whatever. I guess she is, like, too much of a wildcard. Honestly, all we need is to distract her so Glimmer can get close enough to poof power She-ra away.”

Bow groaned, “Well, I’m sure we’ll get a ton of practice. We’ve been tracking some of their-”

“-Bow! You’re not supposed to be working,” Glimmer yelped, jumping to her feet again.

“What else am I going to do stuck in this bed? They won’t even let me walk around right now!” Bow’s voice was raised, but in desperation, not anger.

“Just until your pain is managed. Then you can -”

Bow clenched the bedsheets in his good hand. "- I can what, Glimmer? Sit back and watch you all get hurt? We know this cast, even with magic, isn't coming off for weeks. And then who knows when I'll be able to pull the drawstring again." More softly he said, "Let me do this."

Glimmer opened her mouth to argue, but Mermista cut her off. "Look, we need everyone on, okay? Bow is good at this, let him do it. His arm got hurt, not his brain." Bow smiled at her, but Mermista scoffed.

"Fine," Glimmer said, sitting back down once again as she conceded.

"Anyway, we know they're going to go on full assault now. There's nothing to stop them. They've got Entrapta. They've got Adora," Bow spelled out.

"Ugh, Bow. Saying it makes it feel even worse," Glimmer put her head in her hands.

"Glimmer, chill," Mermista said, commanding. "It just means we need to be ready and stop crying about our failures."

"Is it bad if I say I agree with Mermista?" Bow smiled.

"You two are going to end me," Glimmer let her head fall onto Bow's bed. Mermista laughed.

A gentle knock on the door interrupted them. "Glimmer, are you in there? Hello?" Glimmer's head snapped back as Angella walked in the room. "Oh hello Bow. Mermista."

Bow waved energetically. Mermista gave a curt nod and flipped her braid over her shoulder.

Angella's eyes lost their kindness, narrowing, when they landed on Glimmer. Glimmer grimaced. "Commander Glimmer. Office. Now."

Mermista and Bow swapped looks as Glimmer silently rose to her feet.

As she dodged the obstacles scattered around, Glimmer let her feet drag all the way to the door. Turning over her shoulder she made eye contact with Bow.

"It'll be fine," he said confidently.

"Um, no. She's for sure going to kill you," Mermista said, examining her nails.

"H-hey Adora," a shaky voice said.

Adora swerved around at the sound, which had cut in on her attempts to piece together her pre and post infection memories. She was on her feet, pacing on wobbling legs, thinking about how she had seen Glimmer sometime in the middle of the night. She was okay. At least, she was okay before Adora transformed into She-ra. Glimmer had been *relieved* to see Adora. It wasn't much, but it gave her some hope that she hadn't done irreparable damage. Then, Catra put the sword in her hand. The thick haze of contamination burrowed into her and everything faded to black.

Now, it was sometime mid-afternoon and her body was feeling almost normal, aside from being completely wiped out. The exhaustion wasn't surprising, not after spending yesterday wrecked on the floor and then being taken by the infection. But, her hangover had subsided and she did not feel the despair that had hit her so acutely before. Maybe it was getting a glimpse of her friend or maybe it was no longer being covered in blood, but she was feeling more herself.

One hand used the wall as a guide to keep Adora balanced and the other skirted the hem of her shirt. It was rough cotton and

loose and, for some reason, she had put it on last night instead of the white longsleeve she normally would wear. The white shirt still lay on the ground, folded neatly. Something scratched at Adora's mind, but she couldn't remember how she had gotten new clothes on after tearing through her old ones. Regardless, she was thankful for the looseness and lack of blood on her new set. It was a subtle shift, but this cell was different too. It made it easier to detach from the pain and panic she left in the previous one.

"Um, Adora?" the same voice came again.

"Kyle?" Adora asked in surprise, bringing herself close to the forcefield between them.

"Um, ha, yeah. Long time no see." Kyle shifted uncomfortably from one foot to the other while looking down.

Adora's voice was raspy. "What are you doing here?"

"I'm supposed to, uh well, take you to get cleaned up," he gestured at her palm up while looking away.

Adora examined herself. The clothes were clean. At least, cleaner than her, but her skin felt salty. Running a hand through her hair, she found it loose, somehow both crunchy and oily. "Oh."

"You're, um, supposed to be in cuffs," he stuttered.

Rubbing her free wrists Adora realized she had forgotten too. "Oh," she said again.

"Can you please not kill me when I open this?" Kyle knocked on the barrier.

"Kyle, I can barely stand," Adora reasoned.

"Adora, come on, I grew up with you. You could take me unconscious," Kyle giggled nervously.

Maybe it was because she was tired or sick of crying, but Adora laughed back. “Don’t you have backup?”

“Well, of course,” he said, smiling more confidently and pointing over his shoulder. Behind him were two guards twice his size armed with the same taser Catra had hit her with.

Catra. Catra had been here after the fight. Adora rummaged through her memories, but they were shrouded in deep clouds.

“Well, I would really like to shower,” Adora said, putting her hands up.

“Phew. Can you, um . . . you know?” he asked shyly.

Adora looked around. “Oh, yeah, sure.” Crawling onto her stomach, Adora lied down and laced her fingers behind her neck as she heard the buzz of the barrier cut out momentarily.

It was gentle when Kyle snapped the cuffs around her wrists and ankles. “Sorry about this.”

“Kyle, I’m a prisoner,” Adora muttered into the floor.

“I know . . . but . . . I don’t know, Adora. This is weird,” he whispered. He helped her to her feet.

Adora wasn’t sure what to say so she stayed quiet. With Kyle in the lead, Adora followed with two guards behind her. She could hear the dangerous hum of the weapons in their grip. Chained, exhausted, and outmatched, Adora sighed. “Kyle, I am sorry.”

“Huh?” He said as he opened up a gated shower room, moving Adora inside and closing the gate behind himself. The guards flanked either side of the door.

“I miss you . . . and I, I miss Lonnie and Rogelio too. When I left I wasn’t trying to . . . It wasn’t about leaving you, it was about . . . .”

“Adora, we all know why you left. Come on, how many times have we talked about deserting before?” Kyle nervously looked over his shoulder at the other guards. “But, you know, we’re still here. We’re not like, normal family,” he let her behind a curtain, “but we’re all we have. It just is . . . I don’t know. I understand not wanting to be with the Horde. I can even understand fighting for the other side,” he whispered softly, “But, It feels like you replaced us so quickly.”

“I didn’t, I . . . “ but Adora didn’t know what to say.

“Look, I’m going to remove your shackles, okay? I’m not really supposed to . . . .”

“Thanks, Kyle,” Adora smiled at him warmly as he removed her bonds.

“Oh, hold on,” he said as he fished around in his pocket. “It’s not much, but at least you can get clean.” He presented her with a small bar of shampoo, which she took as if it were gold. “Once you start, you’ll only have-”

“-five minutes. I didn’t forget everything,” Adora said, meeting his eyes. Kyle looked away. “I didn’t forget you either.”

This time, Kyle didn’t reply even though his eyes widened. Adora slid behind a curtain and removed her clothing before letting the lukewarm water hit her.

“We missed you too,” he said barely loud enough for her to hear over the water. “Lonnie, Rogelio, we’re okay. We’ve got each other. But, Catra has . . . I - I don’t know, Adora - she’s different.”

“I know,” Adora said, barely audible over the pulse of the water. Adora wasn’t the same without Catra too. Being enemies made the hole left by their friendship widen and shift into something chaotic and dark.

Kyle cleared his throat nervously and said, “She’s the one who sent me here though.”

Adora let the conversation slip as she washed her hair quickly, rinsing it before her time was out. Her thoughts drifted to Catra, trying to analyze every detail of their interactions. Adora wanted to remember what happened post infection so badly. When the water shut off, there was a towel waiting for her. She reclothed and left her hair down to dry. “Is Catra okay?”

“I - I . . . I don’t really know. She doesn’t talk to us anymore and has been, like, extra mean. I think she-”

“-Hey! We can’t be here all day. Quit being buddy, buddy with the prisoner, Kyle!” one of the guards barked.

“Shit,” he mumbled.

“It’s fine, let’s go,” Adora said, offering her wrists back to him freely.

“I think she still misses you,” Kyle whispered.

Catra had been avoiding Adora.

Early yesterday morning had been the botched rescue attempt. It was getting close to evening now and Catra was walking back and forth in her room. She had spent the morning preparing for their next move against the Rebellion tomorrow, but there was no more work to be done. Honestly, without Adora on the Rebellion’s side, this wasn’t even a challenge. The idea of going on the aggressive was less elating as they approached execution of the plan. Catra felt anxious knowing that She-ra was part of it and wondered how much more damage she could do to their relationship.

As the day had progressed, Catra thought more and more about Adora. Witnessing her breakdown yesterday was troubling. And then there were the moments after Glimmer and Mermista had

departed when Catra found herself alone with Adora. Carrying Adora, remembering her scent, and seeing her near hysteria as she woke up had lingering effects on Catra.

"What's happening to me?"

Catra didn't regret it, no, she didn't regret making Adora her prisoner or She-ra her weapon. But, maybe she wished things could be different or easier. "Ugh, just for a minute," she said to herself as she walked down to Adora's cell once again.

This time, Adora was the first to speak. Catra braced herself for a continuation of the screaming match they had back on the transport, but what came was soft and affectionate, "Thanks for letting me shower yesterday. Did you also bring me these clothes?" Adora pinched the fabric of her shirt between her fingers and looked at Catra in question. Catra's jaw would have dropped if she hadn't clamped it shut so tightly.

Purposefully ignoring her question Catra said, "It's just a shower, Adora. You were starting to stink the whole place up. You'll get one every other day."

As she spoke, Catra examined Adora, who looked much more normal today, clean and sane and nothing remotely like she had before. She was wearing the loose, gray t-shirt Catra had brought for her on a whim. Catra shut her eyes briefly and a tension she had been holding for almost two days eased out of her. Before Adora started yelling at her again, Catra said, "Your stupid friends are okay."

"What?" Adora asked as she cocked her head to the side.

"Shut up, you heard me. That's why you were . . ." Catra coughed, "upset, right?"

Shocked but not unhappy, Adora interjected, "Why are you telling me this?"

"Do you want me to stop?" Catra growled.

Adora stood up and approached the wall between them. “No, but . . . the blood.”

Answering, Catra said, “Arrow - Bow’s.”

Adora shut her eyes, eyebrows slanting downward in concern. “How badly is he hurt?”

“God, so many questions,” Catra complained, but Adora’s eyes opened to glare at her. “Fine, he’ll live.” Adora’s eyes bore into her even harder, “Look, you hit his arm. I don’t know how badly because Sparkles got him out right away.” Catra sighed and rubbed her forehead with her hand. “It definitely wasn’t pretty, but don’t they have magic and shit in Bright Moon?”

There was guilt too, but mostly Adora felt overwhelming relief. She didn’t hide it as she let out a giant exhale and dropped her forehead to rest on the forcefield. Quieter, she asked, “What happened the other night?”

Another pause went by. Catra jerked her tail back and forth. “Mermista and Glimmer came here to rescue you. You - She-ra didn’t touch them. They retreated without really doing much. Not much of a plan. They’re not very good at this without you.”

Adora bit her lip, “Okay.” Reflexively, Adora smiled. It made Catra’s heart skip the next beat. Adora added arrogantly, “Wait, did you just compliment me?”

Catra’s ear flicked. “Don’t push it, Adora.”

“What happened after . . . after I went back to,” Adora motioned to her body, “this?”

The question hung in the air and Catra’s erratic heart stopped functioning.

“Same thing as always, you went back to your cell,” Catra dusted off her shoulder to hide a blush forming on her cheeks. “You’re a prisoner, remember? You don’t get out much.”

Adora watched her carefully and noticed when Catra's cheeks reddened. That was something. "That's not what I mean and you know it."

Scoffing, Catra responded, "What do you know, dummy?"

There was warmth in the words. It might have been accidental, but Adora grinned.

Catra deflected, "I don't have anything else to say except it looks like you're not as impressive as you thought you were."

Adora looked at her confused. "What?"

Catra smirked as she crossed her arms. "She-ra isn't all she's cracked up to be, that's all."

"Oh," Adora said. Silence fell. Bluntly, Adora started to ask, "I know you were here after."

Catra spun around quickly, "Gotta go, places to be." Without another glance, Catra waved to Adora as she walked away.

"Bye!" Adora called after. "Thank you." She slumped against the wall, feeling relaxed for the first time since her capture. Everyone was okay. And Catra had come to tell her. That had been unexpected.

"See you, Adora," Catra called back. When she was out of earshot, Catra groaned to herself and said, "What was *that?*"

Despite feeling flustered with Adora, Catra was in a good mood. Something moved in her chest in a way that was familiar, but long forgotten.

“You wanted to see me?” Catra entered the Black Garnet chamber and crossed her arms. She readied herself for a fight and for that good mood to be killed.

“Ah, yes, Catra,” Shadow Weaver said smoothly as she came closer. Her hair flew madly and her steps were slow and confident. Catra’s blank face flickered with a deeply ingrained fear before she replaced it with a scowl. Under her mask, Shadow Weaver smiled. “Tell me, how is Adora?”

A spike of rage wedged itself between Catra’s ribs. “Of course. Why would this be about anything else? Adora this. Adora that. You could just go check on her yourself,” Catra said dismissively.

“I know you’ve been visiting her,” Shadow Weaver took a step forward, now only a foot from Catra. Catra looked away under the burn of Shadow Weaver’s gaze. “You definitely have seen her more than is necessary. You can’t stay away.”

Catra growled, partially at Shadow Weaver’s words and partially at the redness that burned at her cheeks. “Get to the point, Shadow Weaver. I don’t have all day. Since you haven’t been doing your homework you wouldn’t know but I’ve been beating back the Rebellion. The Horde has made more serious ground in the last week than it-”

“-Don’t kid yourself, Catra. Once again, Adora is making you look better than you are.”

Catra’s ears flattened and her hands clenched into fists. “I control her. I make the plans.”

Shadow Weaver grabbed Catra’s chin in her hand, a motion that tripped Catra’s alarms. Failing to look defiant, Catra allowed Shadow Weaver’s touch with a silent whimper. “Does she look at you just how you imagined?” Shadow Weaver’s voice dripped with disgust.

Catra pushed Shadow Weaver’s hand away and looked at the ground, her ears falling back submissively. “What do you want?”

“Every time you try to bring her closer, she gets further away, doesn’t she?” Shadow Weaver dug in.

Catra bit her tongue, trying to stay under control, now regretting her visit to Adora earlier even more. “I don’t give a shit about Adora. Why am I here? Otherwise I’m just going to-”

“-Adora is not going to battle tomorrow,” Shadow Weaver said dully.

That snapped something inside Catra. She blurted angrily, “What?! Of course she is. The whole thing is already in motion. We can’t just stop,” Catra threw her hands out in front of her.

“You’re going to have to take care of this one on your own,” Shadow Weaver paused and added, “or are you too weak for that?” Catra quaked with anger. “You’ll deliver her to me in the morning here,” Shadow Weaver said, motioning to the chamber.

“Hordak will never approve of this I already-”

“-He already has,” Shadow Weaver said with finality. Catra’s face fell. “What? Didn’t he tell you? I thought you two were *so* close these days.”

Catra glared at Shadow Weaver. Every word Catra spoke came out more desperate as she said, “What is wrong with you? Adora left. Adora doesn’t care about you or this place. I’ve been here the whole time. I try to-”

“-Catra, you will never understand.” Shadow Weaver shook her head with pity. “Once Adora realizes her mistakes, she will take back her rightful position and you will take yours.”

Catra’s claws unsheathed. “What?! She’s our enemy. You’d know that if you weren’t so - so . . . .” Catra screamed, tears pricking at her eyes now. This was so stupid. Adora had done none of the work and now Shadow Weaver wanted to go back where they left off?

“What’s that Catra? Do you have something to say?” Threateningly, Shadow Weaver loomed above her.

Catra took in air in gasps, tail thrashing behind her. “I’ll bring her here in the morning. Just don’t get in my way again. Is that all?” Catra was shaking in anger. She wanted to hit Shadow Weaver so hard that mask would break, but the black tendrils under Shadow Weaver’s control closed in, caressing Catra’s bare ankles with malicious intent.

“Yes, now get out.” Shadow Weaver turned her back to Catra as she spoke. Over her shoulder, Shadow Weaver said, “Adora isn’t going to protect you forever. She may have cared for you once, but how much longer do you think it will last?”

Catra turned back around to roar, “I don’t need her to protect me! I don’t need her and I don’t need you.”

“You can’t hide from me. I know you. She will never want you like you want her.”

In a rush, Catra left, clutching her hand to her uniform over her heart, tears falling down her face.

She would show Shadow Weaver what it meant to be strong.

“Glimmer, sit.”

“I’d rather not.”

“Sit.”

Glimmer ground her teeth together.

“What in all of Etheria were you thinking going on an unplanned, unprompted mission straight to the heart of the enemy?” Angella folded her hands in front of her.

Glimmer’s hands started to shake. “Mom, it wasn’t unplanned. And nothing happened! We’re fine!”

Angella raised her voice, “Glimmer, you know that I am relieved to see you here, but we cannot afford your poor decision making.”

“Mom! You didn’t see her! We almost got her. You don’t know what she’s going through,” Glimmer said as she stood back up.

Angella stood to meet her and slammed her palms down on the desk in front of her. “And then what, *Commander* ? You bring her back and the sword is still infected. You get her, they capture her back. Adora is not safe until that tech controlling the infection is destroyed. You need to think things through.”

“We could hide her until then. We’d figure it out we’d-”

“-No,” Angella said, lowering her voice.

“Mom you don’t know what they’re doing to her! Adora she was . . . she was stripped down to her underwear, covered in sweat and, and-”

“-Glimmer! I didn’t forget what you told me. She is a prisoner of war. She is-”

“-Mom! If we don’t get her soon I’m afraid the Adora we know won’t come back!” Glimmer slammed her hands on the desk across from her mother.

They both stood facing each other, breathing hard.

Angella conceded first, lifting her fingers to massage her forehead.

“Come on Mom, we have to do something. I can’t just sit here,” Glimmer appealed.

“I’m not saying we do nothing. I’m saying we need to be more careful,” Angella softened as she looked back at Glimmer. “We need to locate that tech. If only we had someone on the inside.”

Knitting her eyebrows together Glimmer spoke up, “Adora grew up there. There has to be someone who would help us.”

“Then your job is to find out who.”

This time when Catra came to Adora’s cell, there was no greeting. Adora had seen Catra coming and stood up to meet her, smiling.

“Up,” Catra said.

The tone of her voice made Adora drop into a frown. “What?” Adora asked. Despite her better judgement, she had been glad to see Catra after their conversation yesterday.

Catra refused to make eye contact saying, “It’s time to go.” The barrier fell and Catra’s hands were on Adora’s, fixing her bonds for transportation. When the cuffs shut around her wrists, they threatened to cut off Adora’s blood circulation.

Panic started to seep into Adora. “Catra, no. Please. What about-”

“-You’re not coming with me.” The sink dripped in the background, echoing as their words dropped out.

“What?” Adora asked again.

“Shadow Weaver has requested you stay with her for the day.” Catra growled. “God, Adora. Even after you abandon this place,

you still are her perfect little fucking angel, aren't you? Too precious to go fight." Catra said, dejection and rage slipping into her voice.

A different dread hit Adora hard in the gut. "Wait, Catra, I-"

"-Fuck you, Adora." Catra's hands tangled in the fabric of Adora's shirt, pulling her forward. "Do you even know what I've been through? I've given everything, *everything* to this place and for what?" Catra's pupils narrowed into slits.

Adora's nervous system went into overdrive as she struggled to make sense of what Catra was saying. "You don't understand," Adora said meekly. At her words, Catra snarled.

"I think I understand *plenty.* After all, how often did you come back to bed with burns and broken bones and cuts?"

Adora gulped, "Catra, I-"

"-While you were off on your playdates, I was alone licking my wounds." Adora felt her muscles shorten as they tightened. "How often were you told you were worthless? How many times did Shadow Weaver tell me she only kept me alive because of you?" Catra was crying now. "And then you fucking left." Catra pushed Adora backwards with both her hands, "and now that you're back, it's like nothing ever changed." Catra bared her fangs and pinned her ears straight back.

All the progress of yesterday fell through Adora's fingers. "Stop, you don't . . . ." Adora grabbed Catra's hand and held it tightly.

Catra's claws came out as she snatched her hand back. Her nails sliced through Adora's flesh, leaving Catra satisfied when she saw blood drip to the ground. "Shut up! I don't need you and I don't need her either. You deserve each other." Telling Adora about the stupid Rebels, giving her clean clothes, letting herself enjoy Adora's warmth, all of it had been a giant mistake. Adora was in her way again, holding her back.

When the claws struck her, Adora didn't flinch, but when Catra's words did, she took a step backwards. Adora's mouth was open to argue, but she shut it slowly and clenched her jaw. Straightening, Adora followed Catra out of her cell, readying herself for what was coming next and trying to find the words to soothe Catra.

"Catra, I'm sorry. I-"

"-Save it, Adora."

"I -"

"-Adora! Stop talking!" Catra wailed as fresh tears stung her eyes. "Once you're done with Shadow Weaver I'm going to have you destroy the Rebellion. I'll make sure you kill each of your friends one by one."

Catra grabbed Adora and roughly slammed her against the wall. Adora lost her breath and tried to regain it, gasping.

"I'll admit, I went easy on you before because some dumb part of me still actually cared about you." Adora's eyes welled with tears as Catra's dried up. "Now, I feel nothing." Then, Catra laughed.

Adora winced. "Catra, please-"

"-That's not going to work anymore, Adora. We're finished."

With that, Adora was pushed inside a room heavy with a different atmosphere.

The door shut behind her with a whoosh. Wiping the tears from her eyes, Adora turned around and took in her surroundings. She tried to focus, but her heart wrenched in her chest at Catra's words.

The chamber was the same as she remembered. Everything had its rightful place. It was precise, sterile, bleak, as if no living thing had ever existed there, doomed to be lifeless for eternity. It even smelled the same. Thick, cold, and aseptic. The only thing

interrupting the stillness was a sound. It boomed out in a low, shaking vibration that shook her bones, rattling her teeth. Adora let her eyes fix on the Black Garnet. It emitted a dark red pulse, crackling with power that lit up the room in a frightening and familiar way. It was like being caught in a thunderstorm, but the lightning cracked through her bloodstream and thunder pounded through her heart.

Pipes jutted out of the walls and ceiling haphazardly, giving shadows an entire domain to conceal themselves. She could feel her muscles burning as she stood stiffly. The tightness in her reached the hairs on the back of her neck, making them stand up straight. Since leaving the Fright Zone, she had been here only one other time, but, then, she had not been alone. Now, she could hear her heart working to pump the blood that felt like it had clotted thickly in her veins.

Her mind was still on Catra and how their last moments together stung. So badly, Adora wanted to tell Catra the truth about what happened in this room, but that would only give Shadow Weaver more reason to hurt her.

All of her senses were on high alert. She felt raw, like everything cut her more deeply. It was freezing, but Adora's skin burned as phantom touches pierced her skin. She thought of Glimmer.

"If someone loves you, they don't threaten you or hurt the people you care about."

She had known that what Shadow Weaver did to her was wrong. Glimmer's confirmation was all it had taken to tip her from repression into understanding. Seeing Glimmer and Angella interact had always confused Adora. It was simple and loving, with Angella asking for nothing in return, even when Glimmer acted out. When the knowledge that Shadow Weaver had actually hurt her, assaulted her, Adora had been overwhelmed. But, at least, she hadn't felt like this. Now, she was back in the arms of Shadow Weaver and, she realized, her torturer.

How much harder was this going to be with that knowledge? Before, she could fight the fear. She had been special, she had gotten affection too, right? Or had it only been means to an end? Adora shut her eyes and blinked back tears and questions and tried to ready herself for a new type of battle, one that she thought she would never have to fight again and, this time, she had to fight it alone. No longer would she be able to go to Catra for comfort as the final threads of their friendship were severed.

Shadow Weaver stepped into the light. Her hair was flying around her and her arms were open. "Adora," Adora froze, "welcome home."

Finality fell, punching her hard in the gut. Adora's breath caught like fire in her chest. Her mind narrowed and all of her thoughts became fixated on one thing: how much she wanted to run. The fire in her chest grew unruly. Her heart picked up its pace, becoming frantic.

The voice came again, "I would have expected more of a greeting but, considering the circumstances, perhaps silence is more appropriate."

Adora's hands hung at her side. Sparing a glance down, she saw they were trembling, the blood Catra had drawn earlier drying to her skin. Her fingers, involuntary, rubbed together in a well learned, self soothing gesture. Self consciously, Adora noticed it and stopped, but it left her feeling uncomfortable, like the familiar motion was the only thing keeping her from crumbling.

She was afraid to speak. It seemed like she had forgotten how. Like the second she opened her mouth it would come out too loud or too strained. Another twitch went through her fingers. "Shadow Weaver . . . I . . . ." Her voice sounded soft and unfamiliar.

"Tell me, how is Catra? I've heard you two have getting some *quality time* together."

Adora couldn’t answer. Not after what happened in the hallway. Not after all the times Adora had heard that question before.

Shadow Weaver smiled. Adora couldn’t see it under the mask, but she knew it. Despite those eyes being blank and empty, they always radiated their intent loudly. “Or have you lost your fondness for her?”

Adora swallowed. Shadow Weaver’s hair flicked wickedly.

“After you left,” Shadow Weaver continued, “she didn’t know what to do with herself.”

Pushing her fingernails into the pads of her fingers, Adora stood still. The scratch on her hand reopened and allowed blood to seep out.

“Lucky for her, I found something she could do for me.” Shadow Weaver took a step forward. Adora didn’t move. Her back molars were pushing against each other so hard it felt like they might break. “Of course, she wasn’t any good at it, but after my . . .” she paused to listen to Adora’s inhale, “guidance, even Catra has done some good, bringing you home to me.”

Shadow Weaver took a step forward.

Without thinking, Adora spit out, “What did you do to her?” It came out hysterical.

“So you do still care,” Shadow Weaver said.

Berating herself for that mistake, Adora knew she needed to be careful about what she did next. As she tried harder to keep her thoughts straight, the more she was unable to think. All that was going through her head was fear and questions about what pain Catra had been put through in Adora’s absence. And, more recently, what happened for Catra to shift from smiling at her to shouting at her.

Shadow Weaver was standing in front of her now, close enough to touch. Adora screamed inside.

Then, a tender hand was cupping Adora's face and Shadow Weaver was inches from her. The buzz from the Black Garnet sounded louder and it's rhythm made Adora feel even more out of sync. Shadow Weaver was patient, caressing Adora's cheek with her thumb slowly.

"Adora, if you leave me again, I will kill her." Shadow Weaver ran her nails down Adora's cheek, sticking the points in as her words rang out emotionless.

Adora's eyes never left Shadow Weaver's, but she had let them unfocus. Now she looked into the blazing pits, crisp and distinct.

"If someone loves you, they don't threaten you or hurt the people you care about."

With every ounce of strength, Adora made her hands relax.

Leaning into the touch, Adora placed her own hand over Shadow Weaver's. Adora's hands were clammy, but warm compared to the icy cool of Shadow Weaver's. Adora watched and saw it, the shift. Shadow Weaver's eyes opened a little more, her hand became less rigid, and her posture became less imposing.

Adora remembered this. She was good at this. Still, when the words fell out of her, a cold sickness revolted in her stomach. "I missed you." Shame slammed into her as she found the words to not be a complete lie. It was hard for her to hate Shadow Weaver, especially as she swallowed down her discomfort in place of survival.

Closing her eyes, Adora squeezed Shadow Weaver's hand. A tear rode down her cheek and Shadow Weaver wiped it away. They pulled apart and now stood facing each other with the same quiet intensity.

“I understand you were confused. Even you can make mistakes.” Adora bit her tongue, feeling another wave of overwhelming emotion ride through her body like a tidal wave. “But that was the last one. It’s time to learn your place.”

Shadow Weaver held out one hand, palm up in expectation. There was nothing Adora wanted more than to smack it away, but, without hesitation, she took Shadow Weaver’s hand. One by one, Shadow Weaver’s fingers closed around her in a silent pact. It felt like her fingers were tightening around Adora’s throat instead.

“You will still go out and fight against the Rebellion under Catra’s command.” Shadow Weaver sounded angry as she said it, “It’s horrifying, the way she uses you.” Adora looked at her blankly. “Hordak was furious when you fought for the other side. This is the price you must pay. All I can do is bring you here as often as Hordak will let me.” She motioned to the chamber enclosing them, releasing Adora’s hand.

Adora realized, this was not a game, it was a deal. Shadow Weaver would keep her off the front lines sometimes in exchange for, well, all of her.

Shadow Weaver continued, “You were supposed to fight in the attack today, Adora. Imagine the damage you could have done. From what I heard, you did quite a number on the Rebels the other day.”

Adora knew it was the truth and it hurt her in a million, stabbing ways. Fear prickled at her skin again as she remembered just how much blood had coated her.

This was the price. It wouldn’t save the Rebellion from having to fight She-ra, but it could soften the blow. It would give them time to regroup. It would give them something. Adora let go of a breath she had been holding. Her heart steadied for the first time since entering the Black Garnet Chamber.

She could do this. In many ways, Adora had always been ready for this, especially after becoming She-ra. It wasn't the sacrifice she thought she would have to make, but, in many ways, it felt more appropriate.

It startled her, but her body moved. Adora wrapped her arms behind Shadow Weaver's neck and pulled their bodies together gently.

"Thank you," Adora whispered, heart grinding as it shattered.

Shadow Weaver relaxed into the hug, resting her hands behind Adora's back and holding her firmly. Adora didn't move and Shadow Weaver let her palms lie flat against Adora's back, feeling the tight fabric there.

Adora kept reminding herself that she could deal with this. It was familiar. But a larger part of her still was fighting to get away. That part, Adora shoved down again and focused on the warmth of touching another person, wishing it was anyone else. As her thoughts moved, so did Shadow Weaver's hands. Adora felt sharp nails rake delicately against her skin as Shadow Weaver lifted the hem of Adora's shirt up. It was a small touch. It could have been an accident, but Adora knew better.

Her body pumped out a fresh wave of adrenaline and she couldn't help her hands from shaking. *Run.* Her body was shrieking. She rejected her instincts and let her eyebrows crease together. Instead of fear, she thought of Glimmer and Bow and their love. She thought of Catra and there she found strength in her resolution.

Adora unwound her hands from Shadow Weaver's neck and took a half step backwards. Shadow Weaver dropped her hands, watching intently.

You can do this.

Adora could feel tears sting at her eyes, but she held them back. Instead, she grabbed the bottom of her shirt with both hands and

brought it over her head, smearing it with blood from her palm. She threw it to the side and looked at the woman in front of her.

The Black Garnet sparked as Shadow Weaver spoke. “Good girl.”

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for the comments/kudos/subscriptions. I appreciate it, especially on a plot heavy, non beta read, dark story like this.

This chapter brought to you by Keep It Out by Half Waif, which I listened to on repeat while editing the second half.

A New Pattern

Chapter Notes

TW: everything in the tags, post traumatic dissociation

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's head jerked up at a sudden break in the cell door's droning. With a muted thud, a ration bar hit the stone floor. The movement made Adora jump. Buzzing noise filled her ears back up as she held her breath. After a minute, she sighed. Glowing green under the forcefield's light, the ration bar sat with another next to it, today's lunch and dinner. Adora made no move to retrieve either as she fixed her gaze back to the wall across from her, moving pupils from brick to brick.

When she ran out of features to count on the wall, she stretched her hands out in front of her. Every scar and vein were right where they'd always been, but something made her hands feel foreign. Like they were someone else's hands. Or, like she was no longer herself. Exposing her palms, her eyes darted immediately to the cut Catra left through one of them. In the hours that passed since this morning, it had healed over. Picking around the edges, Adora tore off the papery scab. Blood seeped to the surface and Adora pressed against her flesh to force more to trickle out. As she watched, she felt no pain.

Her wrists were covered in tight, white fabric. It stretched up her arms and covered her torso. It was the same style of shirt Adora wore most of her grown life. The Horde symbol she had removed during her time with the Rebellion was back, and it blazed in crimson red against her shoulder blades. Her hands dug into her hair, fingers trembling and clenching against her scalp. Her hair was down, which she had forgotten. It wasn't wet anymore, but, now she remembered, it had been. She shook her head. This was the third or fourth time Adora had forgotten and then recalled she had taken a shower before returning to prison.

Two days ago, she cherished the five minute shower given to her with a bar of shampoo covered in Kyle's pocket fuzz. This afternoon, she had not felt so thankful, even with a pair of clean clothes and no time limit. No matter how she scrubbed her skin, Adora had never felt dirtier.

Unwanted thoughts tugged at her for attention. Trying in vain to shut them out, she felt goosebumps leap out of her skin. She could feel Shadow Weaver's fingers grazing over her, touching her everywhere. Adora watched the hairs stand up on her arms in reaction to the phantom touch. Her heart picked up its pace. So, she shifted back to the wall to restart the counting off the chips and scratches in every brick.

It wasn't working. Her heart rate took longer to slow and her breathing hitched. Clamping down, Adora pushed back as the ache she felt between her legs redoubled its efforts to draw her attention. Rearranging, she laid back against the wall and straightened her legs out in front of her while looking up at the ceiling. Above her was dark, unremarkable concrete. Adora bit her lip gently.

She tried to keep her mind on Bow and Glimmer, but darkness swallowed her. Shadow Weaver's hands on her hips. On her neck. In places she'd never shared with anyone else. With every violation, Adora found new depths of distress. Shadow Weaver had always left her mask on, but today she slid it off and kissed Adora. It was slow and deep. The longer it went on, the longer Adora had to fight against relentless panic. It was Adora's first kiss.

Thinking bitterly to herself, Adora was amazed that, of everything that happened today, that kissing made her feel this hollow. It had been, in a lot of ways, more intimate than so many of the other things taken from her. It meant she had to be face to face with Shadow Weaver, eye to eye. And Adora had to kiss back, not even able to imagine she was kissing someone else with the way Shadow Weaver's scars felt on her lips. The thought made bile rise in her throat.

There had been times when Adora was tempted to kiss someone before and she regretted that she never acted on it. Since joining the Rebellion, she'd had barely given it a thought, but when Catra had come to her cell yesterday, crossing her arms and smirking at her with something more like affection and less like hatred, something fluttered in her chest. Above her now, a light twinkled in and out and Adora remembered something else.

The power went out. It happened all the time. The lights would flicker on and off for a minute or go out completely, but it never took long for the backup generator to kick in and blind them with a burst of light. Today, the darkness remained and, all around them, the adults had broken out into a clamor. Catra and Adora slipped out when it became apparent the power would not return any time soon.

"Come on!" Catra said, running down the hall. "This is so creepy!"

"I can't see. Catra!" Adora ran after her but had a hard time distinguishing what direction the voice was coming from as it echoed down the hall.

Adora gasped as a hand closed around hers. "Follow me." Catra pulled her forward and soon they were back to laughing and running. "This is the best day ever. No training and it's so cool and spooky here in the dark."

In the chaos that had come when the lights went out, none of the adults had made any orders before Adora and Catra could run away. That meant they weren't technically breaking any rules. Adora smiled in the dark, still getting used to the lack of gap in her smile since her adult teeth grew in. "Where are we going?"

Catra yanked her arm, signaling her to turn the corner. "You'll see."

Whatever wing of the Fright Zone they were in was completely abandoned. As they ran, Catra and Adora's fingers locked

together, moving faster as Adora adjusted to the darkness and trusted Catra to guide her.

Suddenly, Catra stopped.

"What is it-" Adora started to ask.

"-Shh," Catra said, putting a finger up to Adora's lips. "Remember when we were trying to change the codes on all the doors?" Adora nodded in response, grimacing at their failed experiment. "This is the door we, uh, you know," Catra said, voice dropping. They had broken it. "They never repaired it so we should be able to pry it open without power," Catra thumped the door in front of them with her palm.

"Catra! We could get-"

"-I wanted to surprise you. Come on." Catra expertly wedged her nails and then her hands and finally her body in between the door and its frame, forcing it open. The door relaxed and made a big enough gap for the both of them to slip through. Once they exited, they were hit with a refreshing puff of cool air.

Not long ago, dusk had turned into dark night. Some of Etheria's moons shined blue light down in front of them, finally giving Adora's eyes something to work with. "Whoa," she said.

Catra led Adora outside and then Adora finally found her bearings. They were up high, overlooking the Whispering Woods, with a clear shot of the celestial bodies in the sky. They almost never got to go outside, let alone at night.

"I didn't know if it would work - awesome!" Catra said running straight up to the railing. "I've never been up this high here, what about you?"

"No way, they would never allow it if they knew we could get up here." Adora gripped the railing with both hands, settling next to Catra with her mouth gaping at the sight before them. "The woods don't look scary from up here."

“That’s what makes them so scary! They’ll lure you in until you get lost in them. You never know what is lurking in there,” Catra said, poking Adora in the side, laughing.

Adora jabbed her back and they giggled. Soon after, they laid down and stared at the sky above them. “Etheria is so big.”

Catra rolled up on her side towards Adora. “Yeah, and someday, we’re going to finally get out of this place and get to go see it, right Adora?”

Adora shifted too so she could face Catra. “We will.”

Catra grinned, showing off her fangs that had grown in sharply over the last year. Moonbeams glinted off Catra’s teeth and Adora suddenly was very conscious of the warmth between their bodies.

Adora looked back and forth between Catra’s mismatched eyes. There was a pull inside her, but she did not know what it meant. Instead of thinking too hard, Adora leaned forward and kissed Catra on the cheek.

When Adora pulled back, Catra’s fingers traced the spot that Adora’s lips had briefly occupied.

“Um . . . sorry,” Adora said. Awkwardly, she pushed herself up into a sitting position away from Catra.

Catra sat up behind her and pulled on Adora’s sleeve until she spun around. “It was nice,” Catra said, touching the spot on her cheek again. “Can I try?”

Adora straightened and coughed. “Yeah, I guess so, i-if you want.”

Catra leaned in and pressed her lips to Adora’s cheek the same way Adora had to hers. As soon as she pulled back, Catra beamed. “I like it.”

The red in Adora’s cheeks moved to burn the tips of her ears. “Me too,” she said softly.

Leaning back against the building, Catra casually laced her fingers with Adora's and stared back up at the sky.

Adora sat back next to Catra, letting their shoulders bump and trying to calm down, but the skin Catra had grazed was burning. Where their hands met was burning. It wasn't bad. But it was a lot. Feeling something she couldn't describe, Adora opened her mouth to speak when, above them, a light flickered.

"Uh, oh," Catra said.

Adora was already hopping to her feet, glad for the distraction. "I'll race you back."

Running and, occasionally, hiding from patrolling soldiers, they made it back to where they should have been. The rest of the night passed as it normally did and soon they were heading to their bunk.

Catra slid into the sheets with Adora. Lights out happened, purposefully this time, and they were left in the dark again.

Adora muttered a quick, "Goodnight Catra."

Before Adora had a chance to turn over, Catra planted another kiss on her cheek. "Goodnight, Adora."

Coming out of her nostalgia, Adora cringed when heard Catra's words from this morning echo in her head.

"We're finished."

The air of finality echoed loudly in Adora's empty heart. After sitting in her cells for hours shaking and pushing down thoughts of all that was happening to her, Catra's words broke something in her. Tears rushed out and Adora cried until she passed into a troubled sleep.

Something rough and clumsy pulled Adora back into consciousness. Her hands were immobilized above her head and fluorescent light burned into her skull. When she put her feet out, her knees buckled and the sharp edges of her cuffs cut into wrists. The walls and floor rumbled. This wasn't her cell and it wasn't the Black Garnet chamber. Halfway through a sigh of relief, Adora choked. There could be only one place she'd still be in chains.

A whoosh cut off her increasing nausea as Catra walked into the room with a toothy grin plastered to her face. "Hey Adora."

Stuttering on her next breath, Adora's eyes widened.

Catra strutted in until she was only inches away. Turning her head sideways, she smiled, wide and predatory. "Did you miss me?" It was flirty, but anger seeped out of the words around the edges.

Then, Adora's eyes narrowed. "You didn't give me much reason to after yesterday."

Blinking at her confused, Catra responded, "Yesterday . . . Adora, that was," Catra counted on her hands, "Saturday morning. It's Tuesday."

In shock, Adora's mouth dropped open with a small, "Oh."

Catra hesitated. When she continued, it was with a light, conversational tone, "Guess telling time is just another thing you're terrible at."

Sternly and through gritted teeth, Adora asked, "Why are you here?"

"Just came by to chat before handing the Rebellion another crushing defeat. Though, when I came here, I thought you were going to be in a better mood after hanging with your pal Shadow Weaver over the weekend." Adora's frown deepened and she

hissed. With feigned shock, Catra continued, “What? Shadow Weaver not worshipping the ground you walk on anymore?”

Anger sparking, Adora threatened, “Not today, Catra.”

Catra tapped her claws on the wall next to Adora’s head with a clicking sound. “Oh, did I hit a nerve?”

“Catra, stop,” Adora said.

Laughing wickedly, Catra said, “God, Adora, you really are something else.”

The urge to scream at Catra overwhelmed her. With her eyes hard and her teeth exposed in aggression, she spat, “You don’t understand.”

A rumbling growl rose in Catra’s throat. With a violent lash of her tail, Catra moved her lips inches from Adora’s ear and lowered her voice. “Shadow Weaver has spent our lifetimes making sure I knew where I stand and where you stand, Adora.” Adora could feel Catra’s breath on her skin. “I understand plenty.”

Swallowing hard, Adora’s anger left her, swept away by guilt. Catra took a step backwards, satisfied with Adora’s silence. She scoffed before turning away, making her way to the door.

As she put her hand on the doorknob, Adora asked, “Is she still hurting you?”

Without turning around, Catra answered, “Why do you want to know?”

Adora answered honestly, “I still care about you.”

Catra’s body tensed all over. Her ears flattened against her scalp. “Then you really are an idiot.”

The doorknob turned and the last thing she saw was Catra’s tail swishing through the door.

"Adora, are you okay?" The question came through her door after a gentle knock made Adora jump. "I know it's been, like, a lot, but I'm here for you okay? So is Bow."

Another lower voice said, "We've got you, Adora."

"I - I'm fine," she called back.

It was a lie and everyone knew it. But it was the middle of the night, Adora didn't want to keep anyone up, not after the day they had. She wiped away her tears and opened the door.

"Oh, Adora," Bow said with empathy as he automatically pulled her into an embrace.

"You don't have to be alone anymore," Glimmer said.

"It's not that. It's . . ." Adora started, but a sob bubbled out of her.

"Catra, right?" Glimmer guessed.

"I don't know why she . . ." Adora tried again.

"Just give her time! She's your best friend, right? This is all so big and scary for you, imagine what it's like for her," Bow said.

"Yeah, but . . ." Adora thought back to earlier today.

Adora pleaded, "Come with me. You don't have to go back there. We can fix this."

Catra responded, "Are you kidding? You've known these people for, what, a couple hours? And you're just gonna throw everything away for them? Ugh. What happened to you?"

Tears freely flowed from Adora's eyes. "I left her. I told her I'd go back and now we're . . . I don't know what's happening. I can't lose her."

"Like Bow said, there's no way she'll stay angry. This is the right thing to do and she loves you, why would she not trust you in

this?" Glimmer asked, smiling, squeezing Adora around the waist with affection.

"I just . . . I'm not . . ." Adora stopped talking and started sobbing into Bow's shoulder.

"Hey, it's okay," Bow comforted.

Slowly, they pulled away, Adora still crying.

"I know! Let's have a sleepover! You can tell us about the Horde and Catra and, when she gets here, it'll be like she was never gone," Glimmer said excitedly.

"Glimmer, maybe we should give Adora a minute to . . . you know." Bow smiled.

"No, a sleepover sounds great. Can we . . . can we go to your room?" Adora looked at Glimmer.

Smiling wide, Glimmer said, "You bet we can. Wanna come over when you're ready?"

Forcing a smile of her own, Adora replied, "Sure, I'll be right there."

Bow and Glimmer turned to leave and Adora shut the door behind them, collapsing to the ground once they were gone and sobbing with less control until she was too tired to keep going. The thought of spending another night without Catra was painful. The way Catra had looked at her, like Adora had betrayed her, hurt even more.

Catra snapped her fingers and, at her beckoning, two guards reworked Adora's bonds until she could move on her own, with

wrists and ankles still bound. When her legs took on her full weight, she started to fall. Catra caught her by the shoulders. Her claws sunk in, causing Adora to cry out. In response, Catra shuddered. She retracted her claws and finished steadying Adora. Looking away purposefully, Catra jerked Adora forward by her chains.

They made their way to the observation deck. Squinting in the light, disorientation blazed into Adora's senses. This was the first time she had been in the natural warmth of daytime in what felt like forever. The sheer amount of space in front of her made it hard to focus on any one thing. They were in an area surrounded by farmland. It was flat and green and it stretched out endlessly to the horizon. The Rebel army was stationed on the perimeter of a town ahead. Directly in front of Adora and Catra was a large Horde battalion, standing at the ready.

Softly, Catra spoke into her ear. "Remember when you and I were looking forward to our first mission together?" Catra pushed Adora closer to the barrier, forcing her ribs into the metal.

Adora's eyes snapped to Catra's, coming out of her haze. "Of course I remember." The softness of the response caught Catra off guard. "I never wanted to leave you." Adora reached out, "There's still time. You could-"

"-I could what, Adora?" Catra whispered, crossing her arms. "You think I can just leave now?" Her voice turned angry, "I know that it was so easy for you but-"

Adora matched her tone, "-It wasn't easy!" Suddenly, Adora's heart was racing. She grabbed Catra's hand. Quirking her eyebrows down and staring at their intertwined fingers, Catra froze.

"Glimmer, look!" Frosta shouted as she pointed a finger up to where Adora and Catra stood.

“Adora!” Glimmer cried, punching her staff into the stomach of a nearby soldier.

Adora stiffened. Catra tore her hand away. “Looks like your friends are here to save you.”

“You don’t have to do this,” Adora begged. Right then, a fire came to life on Adora’s left, startling her.

Catra worked her mouth into a thin, grave line. “Yes, I do.” Another fire lit up. The heat pricked the inside of Adora’s nose and the smoke choked out the blue of the sky.

“We’re coming for you Adora!” Perfuma yelled. She took a deep breath as she took control of the burning plants, twisting them into the sky, half on fire, and slammed them into a group of Horde soldiers.

The Sword of Protection sat nearby. Catra seized it slowly. Once in her hand, the sword gleamed in the light of the fire, red flames licking the blade. Summoning strength from deep inside her, Adora pierced through Catra with a hard stare. It made Catra falter. With Catra in shock, Adora set her jaw and said, “Then you’ve made your choice.”

Adora thought she saw regret on Catra’s face before a powerful scream ripped through her throat. As her vision narrowed, all she could see was the world on fire around them.

“So . . . you’re starting a fire,” Adora wrapped her fingers around her chin “on purpose?”

Bow placed another piece of split log carefully, his tongue hanging out the side of his mouth as he let it fall gently into place. “Yep!” he said as he stood back and admired his handiwork.

Standing back, Adora watched as Glimmer prepped a small pile of kindling. This was exasperating, but instead of criticizing, Adora said “I don’t understand.”

"What's there to understand?" Glimmer offered. "It's a fire. It's warm. It's nice to look at. It's a good place to tell scary stories with your friends."

Adora frowned. "It isn't cold outside. We're not signaling for anyone. We don't need to cook. And don't we have other things to do?"

Bow placed his hand on her shoulder and smiled. "Adora, relax! There will always be work to do, but tonight we want to get to know you better."

"You just said there's work to do," Adora pointed out.

"Shh, right now, this is where the magic's at." Glimmer struck her flint and steel together and spark hopped out, dying out quickly as it hit her tinder. She struck it again and again before groaning.

"Here, let me." Adora took the objects from Glimmer, repositioned the tinder and struck once. The kindling caught and Adora built the fire up, moving the flame inside Bow's teepee and feeding it small sticks until a flame caught on one of the larger logs.

"Looks like we've got a new fire master," Bow said, crossing his arms.

"Some things they taught us at the Horde were useful," Adora said. "Though, I still don't understand the use of this . . . ."

"Oh Adora! It's fun!" Glimmer said, grabbing both of Adora's shoulders and hugging her from the side. "And, it's the only way to eat s'mores."

Shifting her eyes to the side, Adora looked at the ground.

Bow gasped dramatically. "You've never had a s'more!"

"I don't know why this is still your reaction," Adora said, blushing and rubbing her forehead. "This is like the hundredth thing you've been offended by."

Squealing, Bow said, "I'm not offended! I'm so excited! Glimmer! Can you believe this?"

"Somehow, I'm still struggling. Things we grew up with that are so, like, normal, are so new for you," Glimmer said.

Feeling ashamed Adora muttered, "I'm sorry, I. . . ."

"Adora! Don't be sorry. This is so exciting for us. Are you kidding?" Bow swooped both Adora and Glimmer up in a group hug and then, in a steadier voice added, "We love sharing all this world has to offer with you."

Glimmer laughed in the embrace. "That's what friends do." Adora's expression softened and she hugged back, "But you better believe you're going to teach me how you got the fire started so quickly. I've never been good at it, but you are probably, like, a survival champion, right?"

Releasing her new friends, Adora smiled competitively. "I know a thing or two."

"Well let's sit down and you can tell us what you know. We want to know e-ver-y-thing." Glimmer rummaged in her back, "But first, s'mores. S'mores have three ingredients."

"Three delicious ingredients!" Bow chimed in, pointing his finger to the sky and grinning.

"Right, three delicious ingredients. First there's the base," Glimmer pulled a rectangular box out and then grabbed some of the contents, "graham crackers."

"Delicious on their own," Bow said, "but when combined with chocolate and marshmallows, they are INSANE."

Adora cocked her head to the side. "I've never had any of those things."

Bow and Glimmer looked at each other gaping, but their eyes were practically sparkling.

"You've gotta try it!" Bow jumped up and helped Glimmer get a sample of everything. He pulled out a cracker. "Try this."

Adora did and it was sweet and smelled good and her eyes lit up immediately.

"You think that's good, eat this." Glimmer tore open a package and tore off a chunk of the contents. Adora took it in her palm. It was brown and waxy and melting by the heat of her hand.

"Wow," Adora said, swallowing it quickly. "That is so . . . ."

"That's the chocolate! And for the finale, this!" Bow stretched out his hand and Adora cautiously grabbed the object there. It was white and fluffy and very strange.

"This is food?" Adora asked.

"Technically, yes," Glimmer laughed. "Mostly, it's sugar."

Tentatively, Adora raised it to her lips and popped the entire thing in her mouth. It was gooey and strange in her mouth. She chewed and it split open easily. "That is the strangest thing I've ever eaten."

"Do you like it?" Glimmer asked.

Adora laughed. "I love it."

"Just wait until we toast them and combine them to make the most delicious thing yet!" Glimmer pumped her fist in the air.

Bow was sharpening sticks nearby. "You'll probably torch a few, but that's part of the fun."

"Toast them? The marshmallows?" Adora asked.

Glimmer slid two marshmallows onto one of Bow's sticks, "Yes, there's two schools of thought on this. There's the people who just light the thing on fire," Glimmer pointed to herself.

Matching Glimmer's gesture, Bow also pointed at his chest. "And there are those who wait for a gooey, golden brown marshmallow before plopping it down between two crackers and squishing it so it oozes over to melt the chocolate for the perfect bite."

Playfully, Glimmer pushed Bow. "You'll just have to see where you land. Give it a try." Glimmer handed the stick to Adora and jerked her head towards the fire.

Adora set the sugary snack on fire immediately.

"I'll eat that one!" Glimmer said with a whoop.

After a few more tries, dropping some and setting on fire others, Adora was working on the perfect s'more. Where she sat was hot enough that she could feel the skin on her face tighten, but she was focused on the task. Golden brown on all sides. She pulled it out and Bow inspected it with a proud nod.

Glimmer grasped the marshmallow in between two graham crackers, smooshed them together, and presented the snack to Adora.

Practically brimming over in delight, Bow and Glimmer eyed her as she took her first bite. Chocolate smeared the corner of her mouth and before she even swallowed Adora said, "That's the best thing I've ever tasted."

Jumping up and down, Bow and Glimmer scooped Adora up in another hug until they were all laughing.

"We have so much to show you. I can't wait for it all!" Bow grinned.

His and Glimmer's energy was infectious and Adora found herself letting go and, for maybe the first time ever, having fun without

the threat of punishment looming over.

Another knock came, “Time to go.”

She rolled over and wiped her eyes. “What? Where am I?”

There was a brutal laugh as a guard answered, “You’re in the Fright Zone. Shadow Weaver would like a word with you.”

Adora darted up from the floor and immediately regretted it, sharp pain shooting through the front of her skull as she got tangled in her handcuffs. The guards laughed and scooped her up. Then, she was being dragged again.

Puzzled, she tried to pull her thoughts together. There had been fire. Catra. The war. But she couldn’t remember when or how she’d gotten back. Before she could get a handle on it, Shadow Weaver was in front of her, scanning her up and down and saying, “Adora, you look terrible.”

Her racing mind screeched to a halt. “W - what?” Adora touched her head. Some of her hair was still captured in a binder, but the rest was splayed out, sticking all over. The skin on her face was tight and her lips dry. Her clothes were covered in dust and soot. She searched for any sign of blood and found none. It did nothing to mollify the thunderous beating of her heart.

Shadow Weaver cocked her head to the side and then shook it back and forth. “Adora, why do you still protect her when she does this to you?”

Turning her hands over, Adora asked, “What?”

Shadow Weaver lifted a hand to Adora’s face. Spooked, Adora knocked it away instinctually. When Shadow Weaver grabbed her

again, it was not nearly as delicately. “Excuse me,” she said darkly, digging her nails into the base of Adora’s neck. Adora gasped as tendrils followed, curling around her ankles and wrists.

Drawing up slowly, Adora met Shadow Weaver’s gaze. “I - I’m sorry, I just . . . I am losing track of what’s . . . .” Adora was cut off as Shadow Weaver’s grip tightened. It was painful. Adora could feel the muscles where her neck met her shoulder crying out.

All at once, the pressure eased. “You are not aware of what happened?”

Chewing on her lip, Adora shook her head. “I’m sorry I - after . . . things get fuzzy.”

“Of course, Adora, forgive me. It shouldn’t come as a shock to you, but Catra has, once again, used you for her own gain.” Shadow Weaver turned away, facing the Black Garnet.

Stunned, Adora scowled. “What do you mean?”

“Now I hate to be the bearer of bad news,” Shadow Weaver sauntered around, “but yesterday, under Catra’s command, the Horde army burned down hundreds of acres of farmland surrounding Plumeria.” Stopping for Adora’s reaction, she asked, “Do you understand what that means, Adora?”

“What? I mean, yes, I-” she frowned. “Why would she, um, we do that? Thousands of people will starve if they . . . .” Adora studied the floor, “They support the Rebellion.”

“That’s right. Supplies will be stretched thin, even thinner with the refugees this attack has created,” Shadow Weaver said.

Clenching her fists, Adora growled. It was a smart move, but an inhumane one.

“The Princess Alliance did make an appearance,” Shadow Weaver offered. “From what I hear, She-ra was able to beat them back.

Almost killing the princess of Plumeria herself. Her fault, of course, for trying to reason with you while you were . . . out of control."

Closing her eyes, Adora tried to remember, but couldn't. "I didn't . . . I . . . ."

"Now, now," Shadow Weaver cupped her cheek, "nothing you can do. Though," she paused, "if you were to be on your best behavior you may, with my recommendation, be reinstated to your old position someday."

"I'm not coming back to the Horde," Adora said defiantly, pushing Shadow Weaver's hand away.

White eyes narrowed into slits. "We will see about that." Shadow Weaver's words came out much calmer than Adora had been ready for, but there was a dangerous edge to them. "You could still be great, with me beside you." Adora gaped. "Think about it. Right now, go take a shower and get ahold of yourself." Shadow Weaver turned away again, sneering.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver," Adora said.

This time when she showered, Shadow Weaver wanted nothing to do with her, waiting, instead, until Adora was presentable. Adora tried to get her shaky breath under control and rubbed the area at the base of her neck that Shadow Weaver had gripped.

This was happening too fast. Everything had happened too fast. There were fires and Catra had been . . . and . . . everything was disjointed. She was having a hard time feeling like anything felt sane. To calm down, she paid attention to the water droplets hitting her.

"Then you've made your choice." It was the last thing Adora remembered saying. She had seen Catra hesitate, but, in the end, she had gone through with it. Now so many people would suffer. And Perfuma? Was she okay?

As she toweled off her hair, Adora caught sight of herself in the mirror. Bruises where Shadow Weaver touched her were darkening into a deep purple. Her eyes flicked back and forth skittishly over dark patches of skin under her eyes. She looked bad. Abandoning the towel, Adora went to put back on her clothes when Shadow Weaver leaned over to look through the door. "Don't bother."

Blushing, Adora made a move to cover herself, but dropped her hands. Swallowing any dignity she had left, she walked over to Shadow Weaver nude and apologized. "I'm - I'm sorry. I am glad to see you." Her mouth tasted like ashes. It seemed as if Shadow Weaver didn't hear her, instead she leered at Adora's body. Adora bit down on her tongue. When Shadow Weaver finally touched her, Adora felt like she had fallen through ice into freezing water.

Shadow Weaver's fingers traced the forming bruise, pressing down at the very end of Adora's collarbone, right next to her windpipe. Shadow Weaver tucked her hair behind her ears, causing drops of water to patter to the ground. Adora didn't know what to do, but bile was rising in her throat.

"Well?" Shadow Weaver said. "I don't have all day, Adora, I'm a busy woman and you owe me an apology. After all, how much worse would things be if I didn't keep you from battle?"

Muscles in Adora's throat tightened as she worked her jaw. "I do appreciate it. I-"

"-Show me."

Adora knocked Shadow Weaver's hand away. "You said you wouldn't hurt her."

In a high sweet voice, Shadow Weaver replied. "I said I wouldn't kill her. She's fine, Adora. And she has been on better behavior."

Putting her hands on her hips, Adora radiated defiance. "That is not a part of the arrangement."

"Arrangement? Is that all this is about Adora?" Shadow Weaver lifted her hand and flexed her fingers in. The room got colder.

"No - I mean, it's . . . " Adora gulped.

"I care about you Adora, but if this" she motioned around the room, "is not where you want to be, you're free to leave." Shadow Weaver didn't sound angry, but Adora knew she was murderous.

"That's not what I meant, I- "

"-What do you mean?" Shadow Weaver stood taller, her hair practically standing on end.

"Can Catra stay out of this. Please?" Adora slumped her shoulders.

"She's holding you back, Adora. You dropped marks since your last assessment. Some days, you're not well rested. I can tell you're distracted. I know it's her." Shadow Weaver got closer as she made accusations.

"It's not. It's me, I can be better. I will be. Just give me another chance," Adora pleaded.

Suddenly, Shadow Weaver's mask of indifference broke. "I've given you and her plenty of chances. What's changed? You've grown more attached. You think I don't see it?"

Adora was forced backwards, until she slammed into the wall behind her by the force of Shadow Weaver's will. "Please, I-"

"-You what? Adora, I only want what's best for you and I ask for so little in return."

Dark appendages wrapped around Adora's shoulders, waist and legs, pulling her into the wall even harder. "Stop, this hurts, please." Another tendril wrapped around her neck, forcing the air out of her lungs.

Seething, Shadow Weaver said, "I hate to do this to you, Adora. But you must learn."

Adora squirmed under the pressure, feeling her ribs creak as the force tightened around them. Her eyes went wide.

"Now, what do you say? Will you behave and meet your potential? Or are you going to waste it on someone like Catra?"

The grip on Adora's neck loosened enough for her to gasp in air. The tendril lingered, waiting for a response. "I want to be the best for you."

"You stick to that and I'll leave your pet alone."

Adora fell to the ground as the shadows snapped back, hovering softly once again around Shadow Weaver's form. "No get out. Tomorrow, you will make it up to me. Don't disappoint me."

Skittering to her feet, Adora ran back to her bunk, breathing loud. Before entering the barracks, she took a steadying breath and walked straight to her bed, hoping Catra was asleep. She stripped off her shirt and pants, getting into bed silently.

"Hey Adora," Catra hung upside down to greet her.

Adora startled and nearly fell off the bed.

"Whoa, it's just me, okay?" Catra spun from the top bunk and landed expertly onto Adora's. She had a big smile on her face and opened her mouth to speak, but then her features were overshadowed by a frown. "Adora, what . . . what's that?"

Reaching out, Catra touched Adora's neck lightly, making Adora flinch.

"Adora, you have a bruise around your . . . " Catra pulled her hand back, "What happened?"

Still retreating, Adora clamped a hand over the side of her neck. "N - nothing." Glancing down her body, Adora could see dark splotches peeking out under her bra and around her shoulders. Even in the dimness of the sleeping quarters, they stood out.

"Let me see," Catra said firmly, but didn't move until Adora sighed and shook her head.

With her nails retracted, Catra slid her fingers over Adora's skin, prodding the darkest bruises and watching Adora's face for a reaction. Skating over Adora's ribs, Catra felt the underlying bone until Adora pushed her hand away taking a sharp inhale.

Resting her hand down on Adora's knee Catra whispered, "I think your ribs are cracked on your right side."

"You think?" Adora said harshly.

Catra looked away biting her lip.

"Sorry, you're right. I just . . . " Adora huffed in a breath.

Catra caught fresh tears falling from Adora's eyes. "Hey, it's okay." She grabbed Adora's hand.

Adora responded by squeezing tightly. "It's stupid. I know she hurts you all the time . . . ."

Catra caressed Adora's cheek with her free hand. "It doesn't make it hurt less. And I'm guessing this," she stroked Adora's neck, "was not all she had to say."

Rubbing the back of her neck, Adora fell silent. There was no way she could tell Catra what Shadow Weaver had said. "You know I love you right?" she said instead.

"Yeah, dummy, of course I do." Catra smiled. "And I love you too. Come here." Taking her hands back, Catra opened her arms wide. In an instant, Adora gripped her around the waist, hugging her

tightly. "Hey careful, you're still broken." Carefully, Catra wrapped her arms around Adora's shoulders, rubbing her back.

Then, Adora cried. Instead of giving her a hard time about it, Catra held her until the pain and anger settled into fatigue. Slowly, lovingly, Catra helped Adora lie down. Catra slid in behind her and placed a warm arm protectively around Adora's waist. The last thing Adora heard before drifting to sleep was, "I'm here. I always will be."

But Catra was not here for Adora now as Shadow Weaver cupped her cheek and helped her rise to her feet. Adora wiped her mouth before meeting bright white eyes. In the backdrop, black tendrils flicked, looming dangerously.

"I apologize for losing my temper earlier, Adora," Shadow Weaver purred, fingers brushing against the bruises staining her neck. "You know I never meant to hurt you. Sometimes I just . . . get frustrated when I see how *she* has weakened you."

"I understand, it's nothing," Adora answered.

Shadow Weaver set her hand against Adora's bare skin once again. "But you will not make the same mistake again, Adora. You're better than that."

The next time Adora looked up, Catra was standing in front of her, hovering a hand near her throat. Adora took a surprised intake of breath. "Adora, what is that?" Catra asked, flatly.

Adora wanted to pull away, but the back of her head met the wall. Glancing down, she saw Catra's claw pointing at a spot on her neck. She stuttered out a "W-what?"

Tipping the very end of her claw in, Catra pulled the collar of Adora's shirt aside. Louder, angrier, Catra asked again, "What is that?"

The bruises, Adora remembered. She glanced sideways. "It's nothing."

A soldier peeked in through the door. "Force Captain Catra, we're arriving at our destination. We need you up top."

Catra whipped around and roared forcefully, "I'll be there. Now get out!"

Rumbling low in her chest, Catra asked again. "Tell me how those bruises got on your neck, Adora."

Raising her voice in challenge, Adora countered, "Why do you care?"

The snarl rising in Catra's throat was audible. "I have to do this," she said evenly, straightening her mask and pulling the sword up from where it sat in the corner.

"Yeah, I've heard that one before," Adora cast her eyes aside, disappointed. "Just get it over with." Slumping, Adora waited for the transformation. When it didn't come, Adora looked up and found Catra staring at her, conflict in her eyes. "Catra?"

Then, the metal of the sword made contact with Adora's hands and, seconds later, She-ra, bulging with muscle and with the need to destroy was standing in the bay at Catra's command.

Catra clenched her jaw, nerves on fire, and looked up. She-ra's red eyes and feral smile greeted her.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks again for all the comments. I love hearing from everybody. The entire time I wrote this, I exclusively listened to LOTR music with The Shire theme in it. When the writing

got dark, I pictured Adora and Catra as hobbits with cute shirts and suspenders dancing around with each other on tables. Unsure what that says about me.

A Breach in Protocol

Chapter Notes

TW: If you're this far, you know. Everything in the tags.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Perfuma’s stable, but she still hasn’t woken up,” Bow reported. Finally discharged from the medical wing himself, he faced what remained of the Princess Alliance in the war room.

Glimmer rubbed the bridge of her nose. “We can’t keep doing this.” The sound of Perfuma’s screams haunted everyone, but Glimmer experienced a special guilt. She was responsible for both commanding the team on the battlefield and for teleporting them out of dangerous situations. She failed on both accounts. When the fire hit Perfuma, Glimmer couldn’t get to her. Not until the flames fell away. When the dust cleared, Perfuma was left covered in ash, clinging to life.

Perfuma had been singled out by She-ra, given she had the largest advantage on the landscape. Instead of fighting, Perfuma had dropped her magic and tried to reason with Adora. It didn’t work. She-ra might not have taken her down personally, but it allowed the Horde soldiers to sneak through the Alliance’s defenses and attack her themselves.

Bow’s eyes were empathetic. “Glimmer, she’ll be okay. Your aunt was able to treat most of the burns. They won’t even scar.”

“Yes Bow, I know. But what if we hadn’t made it back in time? What if Casta hadn’t been here on a visit already? With Perfuma out and you,” she fumbled for words.

“Out of commission?” Bow offered.

“We’re running out of firepower quickly.” Glimmer put her forehead on the table. “This isn’t working.”

“Firepower might be, like, not the right thing to say right now,” Mermista said sarcastically. Mermista and Frosta had struggled in the last battle. The fire dried out the air and the land and, what little water they could muster, only managed to help intermittently. They had been ineffective. When Bow gave her a hopeful look, she shrugged and asked, “Okay, fine, but, what did we learn?”

“Who cares what we learned if this is the cost? We can’t fight them.” Glimmer slouched in her chair. “They’re stronger than us.”

The room went quiet. Even Bow’s eyes fell, downcast. Sea Hawk hummed to himself but, after a kick under the table from Mermista, he stopped. Looking around awkwardly and finding no relief, he started to fiddle his fingers in his lap instead. The guards at the door looked at each other, shifting weight from foot to foot in the uncomfortable silence.

Frosta rose to her feet and slammed her palms on the table, making everyone jump. “We already paid the price, so why don’t we focus on things in our control? They have numbers and more weapons than us, so what? We have to keep trying otherwise we might as well hand Etheria to the Horde. Personally,” she stood straighter, “the Kingdom of Snows will not give up so easily.” Huffing, she sat down and, this time when silence fell, it was to allow surprised glances to be exchanged between everyone else.

Since her shock at seeing Bow injured, Frosta had become a different, more mature version of herself. She was still fiery, that wasn’t likely to change, but she’d become more focused and driven. It wasn’t just about knocking bad guys out, it was about protecting her people and her friends. Mermista gave her a subtle thumbs up. Those two had become a dynamic duo, their magical gifts and personalities complimented one another. It drove Glimmer crazy.

Spinnerella spoke up. “She’s right, you know.”

“Look, we’re going to keep losing if we keep trying the same thing,” Netossa said. Glimmer glared at her, “What? That’s just

fact. We're getting weaker and they remain the same. Losing Perfuma is an especially big loss. As long as we're near plants, and we always are, she was our best weapon."

Mermista groaned in the background, but didn't disagree. Out loud.

Netossa stood. "Glimmer keeps trying to teleport She-ra but can't get close. So why don't we try something new."

"Such as?" Glimmer said, putting her chin in her hand and staring hard ahead.

Still stewing, Frosta said, "Catra." She crossed her arms and leaned back with a scowl on her face.

"Bingo." Netossa smiled. "Do you want to explain to the rest of the class?"

Frosta shrugged. "She's the one controlling She-ra. Every time we see She-ra, we see Catra. She's always the one giving commands. We take out Catra, the Horde loses control of She-ra."

Netossa took back over. "We don't know a lot about the tech infecting her since the expert on that particular subject works for the other side." Glimmer tapped her fingernails against the table. "But we do know that infected She-ra should be a loose cannon. When Adora first was infected in Dryl, she went after anyone in her path. Same story at the Northern Reach. She attacked Bow, Glimmer, and Sea Hawk, but also went after Catra. But, since Adora's capture, every battle we've met her in she is only after us.

"We thought it was weird the first time, but ever since Mermista and Glimmer came back from their . . ." Mermista and Glimmer exchanged a sheepish look, "rescue mission, we've been looking for the remote."

"Catra has that weird metal thing on her head. I thought it was just some ugly Horde fashion accessory but . . ." Mermista flipped her hair over her shoulder.

Netossa smiled. “That’s right. Frosta noticed it too. And Perfuma. We can’t beat the monster-”

“-She-ra isn’t a monster, she’s our friend!” Glimmer interrupted.

“Glimmer, calm down,” Bow whispered, tenderly grabbing Glimmer’s raised fist and lowering it down.

“We can’t beat infected She-ra, but we can take away the Horde’s advantage,” Frosta said.

“That’s right. We get rid of the controller and we’re back on an even playing field.” Netossa sat down smugly.

“Isn’t that a little risky?” Bow asked.

“Sure, but no less risky than facing her head on in battle as she tears us to shreds,” Mermista sighed.

“True. Then the only option is to disarm her,” Bow’s eyes sparkled. “For us and for the Horde.”

“I’m not saying it’s perfect, but it will give us some slack,” Netossa said. “Instead of only taking out us, She-ra might take out a few Horde soldiers on the way. If we can stay out of her path, we have a chance to bring Adora home.”

“But how are we going to get to Catra?” Mermista asked.

Glimmer glowered. “Leave that to me.”

Bow squeezed Glimmer’s shoulder as she stared around the room intently. Mermista cocked an eyebrow in her direction.

“Catra’s fast, but if she’s busy trying to keep me from teleporting She-ra, she won’t be able to stop me from getting close to her,” Glimmer pounded her fist into her open palm.

Bow smiled. “We’ve got this.”

“Good job, honey,” Spinnerella said to Netossa quietly as she patted her hand underneath the table. Netossa smiled.

Perking up, Glimmer addressed the room, “What do we know about the Horde’s next move?”

“I thought you’d never ask!” Bow said as he pulled out his tracker pad. “We know they’re working on securing the border here and here,” he pointed to the map, “it seems logical that their next step would be right here.”

Mermista and Frosta exchanged a look, fire rekindling inside them. Sea Hawk smiled at Mermista and she even smiled back, cracking her knuckles. When Sea Hawk’s smile widened even more, Mermista quietly warned, “Don’t push it.”

Glimmer listened to the rest of the conversation, but was focused on only one thing: taking out Catra. If the rest of the alliance could hold the line, she could do it. She had to.

Catra hovered over Adora’s body. Even sleeping, she looked tired. Dark circles stood out under her eyes. Her cheeks were sunken and her lips were chapped. Eyes moving down, Catra fixated on the discoloration peeking out on Adora’s neck. Hooking two claws underneath Adora’s collar, she pulled the shirt aside. Splotchy, dark purple marks dotted the skin where Adora’s neck met her shoulder. Surrounding the dark area were lighter, yellow bruises that extended down past her collarbone.

Cautiously, Catra stretched the fabric further, angling her head to peek underneath. She breathed in slowly when she found the edge of the injury. When she prodded, the muscles of Adora’s shoulders were hard and inflamed, causing Adora to whimper and shift away. Catra waited, but Adora did not wake up. Pulling up Adora’s sleeves, Catra saw that her wrists were badly battered.

Fresh cuts and healed scars alike crisscrossed across them. When Catra checked, there were similar, but less harsh marks, across her ankles.

Grasping the hem of Adora's shirt, Catra pulled up, exposing her ribcage. Relief washed over her at the sight of scarred, but otherwise undamaged, skin. Blushing, Catra covered her back up, hands lingering as Adora's chest rose and fell. She unfurled her tail from Adora's bicep and sat on the ground, leaving space between them. Refusing to look away, Catra let go of the tension in her own back. Adora was okay.

Adora was okay, but someone was bold enough to leave evidence of harming her. And Catra had a good idea of who. A growl rumbled out of her throat.

At the sound, Adora groaned awake. Shielding her eyes from the lights on the ceiling, she grumbled, "Too bright."

"Hey dork," Catra said softly.

Adora propped herself up and blinked several times. "Catra? Hi."

Catra's cheeks heated up in response to Adora's slurred speech and flirty smile. Their interactions when Adora had lowered inhibitions were always . . . interesting. Today would be extra weird with all that had happened between them in the last few weeks. Clearing her throat, she asked, "You're not going to remember any of this, are you?"

"Why wouldn't I?" Adora tapped her forehead. "This mind is a trap."

"Right," Catra said. Adora stuck out her tongue. She definitely wasn't going to remember this. So, when Adora grinned at her, smiling wide, Catra smiled back. "Can I ask you something?"

Adora tried to match Catra's seriousness. "Yeah, of course. Ask me anything." Sitting up and scooting close, she propped her chin on her hands until, unsteady, one of her elbows slid off her knee.

When her hands fell from underneath her, Adora nearly fell over. She looked at her arm like it had betrayed her before tucking it to sit loosely on her lap. She returned her attention to Catra like nothing had happened.

Catra sighed. “How’d you get the bruises?”

Immediately, Adora’s hand shot to the nape of her neck, flinching when she pressed the tender skin too hard. “It’s nothing.” Adora’s face screwed up. “J - just fell? I guess?”

“You fell?” Pointing at Adora’s throat she said, “On your neck?” Catra groaned.

Adora nodded overenthusiastically.

Catra’s tail thumped on the ground. “You expect me to believe that?”

Adora raised an eyebrow and responded with a tentative, “Yes?”

She didn’t understand why Adora was so hesitant to talk. But, then again, she had always been regarding Shadow Weaver. “So, I should just assume it was Shadow Weaver then?” Catra asked, crossing her arms and examining her nails.

“Yes!” Adora put up a finger, “I mean, no. It wasn’t . . . It’s not.” She rubbed the back of her head nervously.

Catra’s nostrils flared. “Did she do anything else to you?”

Adora’s head jerked back. Her hands dropped and so did her carefree mood. “W - why would . . . No.”

Grabbing Adora’s shirt, Catra pulled her forward. “Adora, tell me what’s going on. Just this once.”

Eyebrows furrowing together, Adora’s eyes flicked between the ground and Catra’s intent ones. “Can’t.” In the fog of her brain,

this was a fact Adora knew. It was simple. The less Catra knew, the safer she would be.

“Adora, come on!” Catra yelled.

Shrinking away, Adora grabbed Catra’s hands with trembling fingers and pulled them off.

Catra pulled at her hair and groaned. The anxiety inside her grew. Adora was not making this easy. “Why are you like this? I don’t even know why I’m here.” Rising to her feet, Catra became more irritated. “I’m trying to help you, okay? Though I don’t know why. You’re a prisoner. You left. You don’t even know what she did to me when you were gone!” Raising her voice to a yell she continued, “It’s not like she - Adora?”

“I - I’m sorry.” Pulling her sleeves over her hands, Adora wiped her eyes, soaking up the tears that had appeared. “You’re mad at me.”

Catra’s hands dropped and her eyebrows crept up. “What? What’s going on? I’m not mad. Well, I am, but . . . I’m just . . .” She knelt and put her hand on Adora’s shoulder. Adora flinched away.

Looking at Catra with steely eyes, Adora warned, “Don’t touch me.”

“I’m not going to hurt you, just relax.” When she reached out again, Adora knocked her hand away. Catra scowled. “Adora, it’s okay.”

Adora stood abruptly, but once her feet hit the ground, she stumbled sideways into the wall. Catra jumped to her feet, trying to steady her, but Adora pushed her away again. Angry and slurring Adora yelled, “Don’t! I can’t . . . I don’t . . . .” Frustrated, she grunted. “I can’t remember what day it is. Or where I am. Or what I’ve done. Who I’ve hurt.” Adora cried freely now, both her breaths and eyes wild.

“Adora, calm down!” Catra yelled. She hissed when her voice came out loud.

Adora fell backwards. She splayed her hands out behind her and caught herself against the wall in a half squat. Shaking and starting to sweat, Adora asked, “Why are you doing this to me?”

Retracting her hand, Catra stared at her, a hard glare turning into a soft, embarrassed glance as she turned her face away. “I - I don’t . . . It wasn’t supposed to be like this.”

“I keep forgetting things,” Adora said softer, using the wall to right herself. “I don’t even know if I’m awake or not sometimes.” Adora wavered, hiccupping on a sob. When she wiped her face, her legs gave out.

Catra caught her, lowering them both back to the ground. Adora weakly beat at her chest as sobs took over her voice. Loosening her hold on Adora’s shoulders, Catra, instead, wrapped Adora in her arms. When Adora’s hands fisted Catra’s shirt and her body shuddered, Catra squeezed her tighter.

“I’ve got you,” Catra whispered, pressing her cheek against the top of Adora’s head. She breathed deeply through her nose, letting Adora’s scent calm her as she tried to do the same for Adora. Feeling Adora’s ribs through her shirt, Catra trembled. “I’ve got you,” she said again.

At her words, Adora cried harder. Catra stopped talking. Catra stopped moving. In the time that passed, Catra’s legs fell asleep as they supported most of Adora’s weight. Eventually, Adora’s weeping softened to shaky breaths and, finally, into slow, even ones. Her hands relaxed, releasing her death grip on Catra’s clothes, now stretched awkwardly. Adora’s fingers traced along Catra’s collarbones in a featherlight touch. “Why are you here?” she sniffled, resting her head against Catra’s shoulder.

Catra swallowed hard. The pads of Adora’s fingers were soft and her voice was softer still. Catra licked her lips. “Did you mean it?”

Adora readjusted so she could look up at Catra. “What?”

Feeling something melt inside her, Catra felt uncomfortable, vulnerable. But Adora wouldn’t remember this. “When you said you cared about me. Did you mean it?” Catra asked, so quietly she wasn’t sure Adora heard her.

Adora cupped her cheek and Catra felt the heat from her hand turn into a deep blush that spread down to her neck. Adora looked into her eyes, blind to the discomfort of the situation. “I never stopped.”

Closing her eyes, Catra lifted her hand and placed it over Adora’s. “I - I’ve . . .” Catra took a steadying breath. She did not complete her sentence. “I need you to tell me what happened.” Catra shook her head and let out an annoyed breath as she fumbled. “I made you transform today, but I . . . I know it’s confusing and everything but . . . Adora?”

“I need to sleep.” she said as her head started to fall. She jerked it back up, but it fell again. Catra let her hand down to her side, missing the touch instantly.

“Adora, I . . .” Catra felt Adora go slack. “Shit.”

Rearranging, Catra leaned back against the wall and let Adora’s head fall in her lap. Sighing, she let her fingers comb through Adora’s hair, tears streaking her face.

Last night, they had arrived back well after dark. Before Catra could move, two guards came to retrieve Adora. The intrusion into her and Adora’s space made Catra feral. She both couldn’t let Adora out of her sight and had to let her go. When they were rough with Adora’s body, she yelled at them, unable to control

herself. The soldiers were shocked but, in the end, were more afraid of Catra than anything and complied.

Once they were gone, Catra was left disheveled and alone. Everything else was a blur. She had made her way to her room only to stare at the ceiling all night, waiting for the next moment she could go to Adora. Every minute passed like an hour as Catra found herself stuck in a liminal space.

Leaving Scorpia in charge, Catra snuck away and was whirring through the cell block to a place that somehow was starting to feel more familiar to her than her own room.

"Catra, what are you doing here?" Adora asked, crossing her arms as she approached the front of her cell. Adora had woken up in here, back from where she couldn't remember. Memories of Shadow Weaver and Catra and different rooms all jumbled together. Until Catra had pointed it out, Adora hadn't realized she had been forgetting entire days. She had no idea how long she had been here, but, at least today, she felt coherent, aware.

"We need to talk," Catra said tersely, letting herself in. She stepped close to Adora, whose eyebrows quirked up. "Do you remember our last conversation?"

Adora's hands unconsciously ran over her bruises. "Before I transformed?"

Catra cleared her throat awkwardly, "After."

Adora narrowed her eyes. "Oh." Frowning she said, "You know I don't."

Catra laughed bitterly. "Of course, you don't." Despite knowing better, Catra felt a deep pang in her heart. "Nothing at all?" she prodded, voice straining.

Adora scanned her. "Why are you being weird?" Furrowing her brows, Catra looked away. "And no, I don't remember anything. Why?" Adora tapped her fingers on her arm and huffed.

“It - It’s nothing.”

“Look, you of all people should know I’m not . . .” Adora clenched her jaw, working the muscles. “I don’t remember a lot, okay?” Her hands balled into fists. “Last thing I remember is you making me transform into She-ra *again* . Before that, I remember you setting fire to civilian land. And while I don’t *remember*, I know you made me hurt the Rebellion. I know Perfuma was badly hurt. And what I also remember is that, you, Catra, told me you were done with me.” Adora lifted her hands. “So why is it that you are here asking me anything?”

“Well, maybe I changed my mind.” Catra said, lifting open palms in a sign of peace. Her claws still stuck out as Adora’s words hit.

Adora laughed, dropping her arms and standing with her hands on her hips. “Wow, how did I win you over?”

Catra’s eyes flickered to the floor. There was a pile of ration bars there. Those should have been delivered at every meal, not all at once - oh. “Fuck.” Adora *had* been dropping weight. Catra looked at her now, clothes falling more loosely around her than they had. “Why aren’t you eating?”

Taken aback, Adora replied, “I am . . . I’m fine.”

“You don’t look fine, Adora. And it’s not just that you - you seem . . . off.” Catra rubbed her face and then the back of her neck with her palm.

Adora stomped on the ground as she stepped forward. Opening her mouth wide, she roared, “I’m a prisoner of war.” Flattening her ears, Catra cringed. “Of course, I’m off! I’m kept in the dark all the time except when Shadow Weaver-”

“-Shadow Weaver.” Catra wrinkled her nose. “That’s what I want to talk about Adora. You -”

The buzzing of the barrier cut off and they both jolted away automatically. Gliding into the room nonchalantly, was Shadow

Weaver. “Hello Adora. And Catra,” Shadow Weaver’s eyes fell on Catra, “why am I not shocked to see you here? Can’t stay away, can you?”

Adora shifted her eyes between the two of them. Shadow Weaver had never visited her in her cell before and even Catra’s visits had become sparse.

“What are you doing here?” Catra growled.

“Same as you, paying Adora a visit.” Shadow Weaver walked up next to Adora. “Though, it is convenient you are here, Catra. I have business with both of you.”

Overwhelmed by the happenings, Adora tried to retreat into the corner. There were too many voices and people and she was supposed to be safe in here. Then, Shadow Weaver placed her hands on both of Adora’s shoulders, stopping her cold. Adora’s posture became more upright at the contact.

Catra met Adora’s eyes, trying to read the expression there. “What do you want?” Catra asked, claws unsheathing.

“I require Adora tomorrow,” she said simply. Adora absently rubbed her fingers together as the rest of her stood ramrod straight.

When Catra’s eyes flickered down to catch the motion, Adora stopped with a sharp inhale. The protective instincts Catra felt when the guards touched Adora ramped up until she could barely understand what was going on. “What? So you can hurt her more?”

Shadow Weaver’s eyes flashed to Adora, tightening her grip. Adora hissed, “Shadow Weaver didn’t hurt me.”

Catra’s pupils dilated until her irises almost disappeared. “Come on Adora, we all know what happened.” Snarling, Catra bared her teeth at Shadow Weaver, “Get away from her.”

Shadow Weaver held her ground. “Feeling a little prickly today, aren’t we?”

Adora stepped forward, blocking Catra’s path to Shadow Weaver. “Catra, stop it. You don’t know what you’re doing.”

“Adora, are you dumb? She left those,” Catra pointed, “on your neck. Who knows what else she is going to do.” Catra’s voice dropped in threat, “Or what else she’s done.” Adora was close enough to touch. All Catra wanted to do was reach out, pull Adora behind her, and rip out Shadow Weaver’s throat. But then, Adora’s eye bore into hers, momentarily disarming her mounting anger.

“Oh? And what do you need Adora for?” Shadow Weaver moved closer. Adora broke eye contact, shrinking back as Shadow Weaver stood tall. Catra’s eyes stayed on Adora. “Maybe to destroy more towns? Kill more innocent lives? Murder the people she loves? Or maybe,” Shadow Weaver’s voice became sultry, “you just enjoy her doing what you want. Does it feel good, Catra?”

With her ears pinned flat, Catra fought back, “Last I checked, you’re still part of the Horde. This is Hordak’s plan, not mine. I’m just competent enough to carry it out.” Adora glanced away, disappointed.

“Last I checked,” Shadow Weaver grabbed her chin, wrenching it to face her, “You wanted credit for capturing She-ra and making her the Horde’s newest weapon.”

Catra snarled, deep and guttural. Jumping back, she let her hand fall, swiping at Shadow Weaver’s face. Just before, she could connect, Adora’s hand caught her wrist and held it back. “Catra, don’t.”

Catra clenched her jaw. “Adora! What is wrong with you?” Her hair fell around her face, despite her mask holding it back and she looked between Adora’s fear and Shadow Weaver’s smug expressions.

Adora squeezed her hand, drawing her attention, and pleaded frantically, “Please stop!”

Glaring, Catra jerked her hand back and snarled again, this time at Adora. “Just because you’re terrible at your job, doesn’t mean I am. What do you want with Adora anyway? She left this place. She left *you* .” In frustration, she let out a rough scream. “And you, Adora, why are you defending her?”

“Catra, you don’t know what you’re talking about,” Adora said, quiet and warning. “Shadow Weaver only wants what’s best for me.”

“Oh, of course, how could I forget?” Catra slammed her hand into her forehead. “You two are perfect for each other.” Adora’s face fell as Catra glowered at her.

Turning back towards Shadow Weaver, Catra argued, “It doesn’t matter.” Crossing her arms, she hid her shaking even though adrenaline still coursed through her veins. “We’re scheduled to go into battle already. You can’t change the plan last second. Not again.” Catra’s ears moved to pick up a disappointed sigh from Adora. It made her angrier.

“So, you admit it. Adora, Catra wants to take you off again. You already hurt the archer and the Princess of Plumeria. Who’s next? Perhaps Princess Glimmer or Mermista or even Frosta? You know She-ra doesn’t discriminate. Next time, perhaps she’ll kill.”

“Cut it out Shadow Weaver,” Catra said curtly. “We’re at war. There are casualties. Or did you forget what side you fight for?”

“I thought you would have known better what it’s like, losing your freedom, Catra. Or should I remind you of the feeling?” Shadow Weaver lifted her arms. Pure power sparked out the tips of her fingers. Adora’s head whipped up, wide eyes meeting Catra’s.

Catra fell backwards. Or she would have if her legs hadn’t become suddenly rigid. Without her telling them to, her arms locked out straight and tightened against her sides. Her tail bristled as she

started to scream. Every time she fought to move, her body did the opposite of what she commanded. Her heels lifted off the ground. It became harder to breathe. Even as her heart beat hard in her chest, her blood could not find its way to her brain. Choking without a noise, she wished with everything her lungs would stop burning. Tears streamed in her eyes, obscuring her vision as something dark eclipsed her view.

Gasping Catra crumpled, doubling over. After gulping in air, she looked up from the ground. Slowly, things came into focus. The red Horde symbol. A blonde ponytail. A person. Adora. Adora's arms were stretched out on both sides, purple and red sparks crackling around her fingers. As the ringing in her ears died down, Catra heard pained grunting. Adora took the hit in Catra's place.

"You're lucky this time, Catra." Shadow Weaver dropped her hands. Adora fell to the ground, gasping for air the same way Catra just had. Catra winced when her knees hit the ground, and again when her elbows followed. Chest rising and falling rapidly, Adora's forehead fell too. "Adora must still see something in you. For now." Catra still stared at Adora. Straining, Adora caught her eye and offered a faint smile.

"You need to leave her alone," Catra managed to say, fighting to get back on her feet.

White pits widened in shock and anger, but before Shadow Weaver could speak, Adora did. "Go," she rasped.

Mermista cleared a path through the dense brush in front of her. When the vines snapped back and scratched her cheek, she dug her palms into her eyes. "It feels like we've been here before."

"Don't be dramatic. We've been following the tracker the entire time!" The tracker pad continued to beep as Glimmer shook it in

the air.

Mermista blew a stray hair out of her face. “That’s not what I mean, Glimmer.”

“What my dear Mermista means is,” Sea Hawk started, faltering as Mermista stopped to tap her foot and cross her arms. He cleared his throat. “I mean, you finish dear.” He smiled and grandly gestured her way.

“I mean, the Horde attacks something. We show up. We get beat. One of us ends up in the med ward.” Then, to herself she muttered, “I’m sick of getting our asses kicked by non-sexy She-ra.”

“What was that last part, my dear?” Sea Hawk said, fingers brushing through his moustache.

Mermista glared at him, mouthing, “Nothing.”

Frosta pounded two ice fists together, materializing them out of thin air. “Today will be different. Right, Glimmer?”

Glimmer rubbed her temples. “That’s the plan, as we’ve discussed at least one million times already.”

“I’m just saying,” Mermista said, “it does feel familiar.”

“It’s time we change that,” Netossa said, popping up behind them.

Spinnerella came up behind her. “That’s right, today we put a dent in their armor.”

“I hope you’re right,” Glimmer said with a sigh.

“Come on, we’ve been over this. It really couldn’t get worse, could it?” Netossa argued.

Mermista huffed. “Um, yeah, it definitely could.”

With a collective sigh, the group marched on. If Bow's intel was good, they would rendezvous with the Horde soon and Glimmer didn't want anyone to be distracted. They were coming up on a town near the woods that somehow wasn't yet under the Horde's control. Towns like this were becoming rarer and rarer as the weeks without Adora went by. Slowly, Hordak was closing in on the Whispering Woods and Bright Moon and, otherwise, cutting off their supplies. Glimmer was lucky the princesses had decided to focus their efforts in defending this territory as the Ice Kingdom and Salineas remained untouched for the time being.

That would change soon and, Glimmer knew, they would get spread too thin. They needed Bow back. They needed Perfuma back. And, most of all, they needed Adora. They needed She-ra.

Spinnerella sidled up next to her. "Are you okay, Glimmer?"

Pausing to make sure they were on track, Glimmer replied. "Yeah, I mean. I'm just nervous. Adora doesn't . . . We have to get her back. Every time we fail I feel like she keeps getting a little further away. It's been weeks at this point and I've only seen a glimpse of her twice before she transforms." She cast her eyes to the side. "I'm afraid of losing her. Afraid of losing everything."

Spinnerella's hand squeezed Glimmer's. "Adora knows we won't give up on her. She's strong. You have to believe she won't give up on us either."

"I hope you're right," Glimmer said.

"I am," Spinnerella smiled, dropping Glimmer's hand. "I don't know Adora like you do, but I know she had a hard childhood and you and Bow have been wonderful friends to her, helping her through that. You'll get through this too."

Glimmer let herself smile. "She's done just as much for us. We won't let each other down."

"I know you won't." Spinnerella fell behind a step

Turning over her shoulder, Glimmer said, “Thanks, Spinnerella. And thanks for being here.”

“I fight for the Rebellion, Princess Glimmer.”

“If you’re done doing,” Mermista pointed at Glimmer, moving her finger in a circle, “whatever, I think we’re here.”

Glimmer looked up, ahead of her was a clearing and, beyond that, smoke.

“Adora, sit down.”

Adora sat. There weren’t many options in Shadow Weaver’s sparsely decorated chamber and she found herself sitting on a hard bed. She’d only been here for minutes, but the topic of conversation hadn’t changed.

Yesterday, after Catra left, Shadow Weaver was angry. So angry, she left Adora without a word not long after Catra did. It gave Adora nearly an entire day to herself to stew about what had happened and have anxiety build into today. Catra hadn’t come by again, though Adora didn’t know if that was a good or bad thing.

Adora’s feelings were complex. She was mad at Shadow Weaver. She was mad at Catra. But, she also was indebted to Shadow Weaver for keeping her away from battle today. And Catra . . . what had she wanted to talk about? And why had she fought against Shadow Weaver for Adora’s sake. Nothing made sense. Adora needed to know what happened.

Breaking into her thoughts, came Shadow Weaver’s relaxed, but threatening voice, “Catra is getting a little too . . . comfortable. Don’t you think?”

“I’m not sure what you mean.” Adora knew exactly what she meant.

“Yes, you do, Adora.” Shadow Weaver knew it too.

“She talked back to you yesterday. She saw, you know, these,” Adora pulled at her collar. “I didn’t tell her it was you,” Adora backpedaled when Shadow Weaver scowled, “I mean, I know that it isn’t what it looks like. Catra was just trying to protect me.” It wasn’t the right thing to say, but Adora didn’t know what to do. She hadn’t expected Catra to notice, let alone try to fight Shadow Weaver.

“You don’t need protection, least of all from her.” Shadow Weaver grabbed her, “She’s a monster, you know?”

Adora absently rubbed her bicep. Since Catra had entered her cell yesterday she had been racking her brain trying to remember the conversation Catra referenced, but she couldn’t. Not even a shred. What had happened? Had she said anything about what else Shadow Weaver had done to her? She was confident she hadn’t, but something must have happened to give Catra a change of heart.

Then again, Catra had showed signs. Small hesitations. Her heart hadn’t been into teasing Adora this week. Ever since their big fight, it felt like Catra was avoiding her more than going out of her way to wreck her. A line formed between Adora’s eyebrows as she thought on it.

Shadow Weaver saw it. “Do you not agree?” Her voice became less controlled, “What do you see in her? After all she’s done to you?”

“I-“ Adora didn’t know.

“-Adora, she is distracting you, hurting you, she’s-”

“-I know,” Adora said. “She’s done a lot of bad things but, still, please, just leave her alone. She’s not,” Adora paused,

“important.”

The Black Garnet sparked in the adjacent room. The room felt darker and colder.

“Please,” was all Adora managed to say. Adora flitted her fingers across Shadow Weaver’s neck, hoping to melt some of the tension away there. It felt forceful and it came out clumsy.

Shadow Weaver let out an exaggerated sigh. “If she crosses me again, I will have to punish her, whether or not I have to go through you next time.”

“It won’t come to that.” Adora knew it didn’t come out as confident as she’d hoped. She knew she needed to distract Shadow Weaver. She knew that she would lose another part of herself today. Adora closed her eyes slightly longer than a blink and opened them again with resolve.

Shadow Weaver put her hand on Adora’s thigh. “Let’s hope so. For both of you.”

Lost in her thoughts, she hadn’t seen Scorpia standing in front of her. “You okay, Wildcat?”

“I’m fine,” Catra said. The entire ride, Catra had been replaying the events of the last two days in her head. She was furious at Shadow Weaver and Adora. It was the same game it had always been. But something was off.

“O - okay because for a minute there it looked like you didn’t hear anything I just said.”

“Can . . . can you just repeat it to make sure I caught everything? You know you talk too fast.” They had arrived at their destination

a few minutes ago, but Catra couldn’t focus.

“No problem, Force Captain.” Scorpia winked at her. “Well, it, uh, it appears we have some company.”

Catra snapped her head up. “What do you mean?”

“The Princesses are here.” Scorpia pointed a long pincer at the horizon. Sure enough, the band was all there, sans one archer and one Princess of Plumeria.

“Ugh, of course they are. Come on, let’s go take care of them.” Adora wasn’t even here, why were they bothering? This wasn’t worth their time.

Scorpia and Catra ran to the front lines together. The dwindled Rebel force was doing what they do, destroying robots and flinging useless foot soldiers across the field.

A fight might just be what Catra needed to clear her head. She found her favorite target. “Oh, hey Glitter, aren’t you getting sick of this yet?”

Catra yelped as Glimmer teleported near her and punched at her instantly. In the background she heard Scorpia say, “Oh hey, what are you going to do with that ice? It is sure neat seeing ice in the middle of-”

"-Where is she?!" Glimmer screeched.

"Come on Sparkles. Aren't the two of you besties? Or, oh no,” Catra put her hands out as she dodged again, “has Adora been missing your playdates recently?"

"Catra, where is Adora?!" Glimmer demanded. Glimmer was not in the mood.

Dropping her playful tone, Catra started to fight back in earnest, claws skimming the air as Glimmer barely moved out of the way in

time. "It's none of your business. You should appreciate the day off. I see your boyfriend still isn't here. How is the arm doing?"

"He's not my boyfriend!" Glimmer kept punching and kicking while Catra dodged easily. "Ugh, Catra, I swear to GOD, I will end you," Glimmer spat.

"Only if you can catch me," Catra smirked as she retreated, running on all fours top speed and cackling.

But Glimmer did, indeed, catch Catra, teleporting nearly on top of her. They tumbled to the ground and Glimmer, driven by some new sort of power, ended up pinning Catra down. Grabbing the front of Catra's shirt, Glimmer pulled them eye to eye.

Catra put her hands up in surrender, smiling slyly. "Look, I don't know where Adora is. She's not here or you'd all know, believe me. She's back at the Fright Zone hanging out with Shadow Weaver, doing whatever it is they do."

"Shadow Weaver?!" Glimmer screamed, dropping Catra, who fell against the ground with a thud.

Catra jumped to her feet, dusting off her uniform. "Jesus, yeah, calm down. They're probably off having a picnic or-"

"-You cannot leave those two alone together!" Hot, angry tears started dropping out of Glimmer's eyes as she grabbed Catra again.

Catra's chest felt tight around her chest. "Why?" She grabbed Glimmer's hand with hers and threw them off with a growl.

"You need to go find her." Glimmer shook Catra. "Right now." Catra could swear she heard a seam rip. When did Glimmer get strong?

All her muscles tightened with anxiety. " *I* don't need to do anything. What the hell are you talking about? Adora is a

goddamn prisoner who gets to go out of her cell because she's all buddy buddy with-"

"-Do you even hear yourself? Obviously, that is not normal," Sweat dripped down Glimmer's temple. "Haven't you ever thought Shadow Weaver was a little *too* obsessed with Adora? A little *too* close to her." Glimmer pleaded as her grip loosened.

Catra threw Glimmer off her. Panic started rising in Catra, burning every nerve ending as Glimmer's words hit home. "What are you saying?"

Glimmer glanced away, not sure how to proceed. "Shadow Weaver has been manipulating Adora her entire life."

"I don't know if you've noticed, but Shadow Weaver manipulates literally *everyone* around her. It's the only language she speaks. What makes Adora so special?"

"You of all people should know what makes Adora special," Glimmer punched, connecting this time as Catra's confusion made her slow. Catra slashed back, drawing blood from her arm. Glimmer went to wipe it away but kept talking, "And you know that Shadow Weaver has always been on her to be the best. Haven't you noticed anything strange?"

Catra had noticed a million strange things. "Our childhood was not exactly normal," she screeched. Catra hit her tail against her leg, trying to keep the hair there from standing on end. "You need to shut up. You don't know what you're talking about."

"Yes, I do, Catra. And I think you know it too." Glimmer was scared as Catra became increasingly frantic.

Catra shoved Glimmer to the ground, claws at her throat. Glimmer yelped as she looked directly into Catra's eyes. Furious, Catra flexed her hand, drawing blood as she gruffly asked, "What are you saying?"

Instead of fear, Glimmer looked enraged. She yelled even louder, "God, do I have to spell it out? Shadow Weaver is . . . what? Sexually abusing her? Raping her?" With every word, Catra pressed harder. Straining, Glimmer choked, "Fuck, I don't know at this point."

Catra's eyes went wide. Her claws pressed into Glimmer's shoulder and throat, puncturing the skin beneath. "Shut up!" Catra hissed.

Glimmer kicked her hard in the stomach, effectively knocking her back. "Shadow Weaver abused Adora as a kid, sexually abused her, and I don't see why it would stop now. Especially if they're hanging out while She-ra is supposed to be here instead," Glimmer punched again. "Think about it for, like, ten seconds!"

The punch connected with Catra's cheek, but she barely felt it. Her body went numb and, this time, Catra did shut up. The bruises. The flinching. The fatigue. "No."

"Goddamn it Catra!" Glimmer grabbed her shoulders and shook again. "You are the only one who can help her.

"Help her? Why would you think I would have any power?" Catra was screaming. Screaming so loud that Glimmer stumbled back.

"She put up with this for you. She told me that when you were kids she-"

"-For me? What the hell? What do you know?" Catra growled. But her mind flashed through memories. Adora dripping wet after sprinting to the Black Garnet chamber. Adora apologizing repeatedly when Shadow Weaver had hit her. Adora beat herself up when she made a mistake. Adora pounding on the door of Shadow Weaver's quarters. Adora dragging her back to bed when she couldn't walk. Adora holding her at night. Adora stepping in front of her yesterday.

Glimmer watched Catra, who had started to shake and stare at her own hands. "Shadow Weaver would hurt you if-"

"-Shadow Weaver has hurt me plenty so I don't know what the fuck you think it is that Adora is doing for me," Catra kicked Glimmer hard in the side.

Glimmer crawled to her knees, refusing to break the cadence of their conversation. "You're still alive, aren't you? Did things get better for you once Adora was back at the Horde?"

"Get away from me!" Catra said as she turned to run again.

Glimmer teleported again and grabbed Catra's hand. "Catra, please-"

Catra sunk her claws into Glimmer's palm. "Get away from me," she said so low and hoarse that Glimmer pulled her hand back.

Glimmer dropped to the ground, realizing how out of breath she had become and watched Catra run away.

“I mean, yeah, she was totally freaking out!” Glimmer let out an exasperated groan. “But I don’t know what that means! She ran away. Is it good? Is it bad?” She groaned again. “I just don’t know if we can hope.”

“Of course, we can hope,” Bow said. “Catra was Adora’s *best friend*. And, even if they’re enemies now, there’s no way she would be okay with this. Right?”

“I don’t know, Bow. Catra is nothing like Adora described to us when we first met her. I’m starting to think she’s fallen too far.” Glimmer had been retelling the story of the battle to Bow for the past twenty minutes.

In the end, they had won today’s battle. That normally would have felt good but they did not achieve their main objection: Bring

Adora home. Instead, Glimmer had to talk to Catra, plead with her even. And had it made any difference? She didn't know.

Bow was an attentive listener. "It doesn't sound like she knew Glimmer. Maybe she was in shock?"

"How could she not have known?" Glimmer growled.

"We didn't know until recently. The Horde was a really messed up place and, I think, Adora is better at hiding her pain than we even realized." He nodded with his head in his good hand. His arm was healing, but it was still a long way from its former strength.

"You think there's any chance Catra will do anything?" Glimmer sighed.

"I don't know, but it was worth a try." He smiled. "We saved a town today, let's celebrate that. We have other plans, you know. Like the original plan from today. Next time we see Adora, we'll bring her home."

"Oh Bow, sometimes you're so confident I even can believe it." Glimmer swallowed. "This can't keep going on. I really hope Catra can see through her hatred." Glimmer tilted her head to the side, "She was, like, really freaking out Bow. I've seen Catra mad before, but she was terrifying."

"You did a good job, Glimmer. I know it wasn't easy, but I'm proud of you." He grinned. "You need to take care of yourself."

"Yeah, but . . ." she went to stand.

"No buts, you fought Catra one and one and you had to talk about some hard stuff." Carefully, Bow caressed Glimmer's face. "We need you fully rested. Based on what you've said, I wouldn't be surprised if Catra, at the very least, did something drastic."

Glimmer hummed. "You might be right," she sat back down and let her head fall back.

By the time Catra made it back to the Fright Zone, Adora was back in her cell.

"Miss me?" Even as she said it, Catra cringed at her tone. It sounded too normal and she felt anything but.

Adora rolled her head to face Catra. Her eyes were blank. Catra scanned her body quickly. Nothing seemed out of place, but, if Glimmer was right, there wasn't necessarily anything to see. "How was your day with Shadow Weaver?" she asked. It came out as a taunt and Catra mentally cursed herself.

Before turning away, Adora's hands started to shake. She slid them across her pants, smoothing out the wrinkles as she fought to stay in control. Adora had been back for a little while, but she didn't feel all there. It was something she had come to expect after a session with Shadow Weaver. Her body felt foreign. Everything felt far away.

Watching intently, the dread inside her began to pull again. Catra dropped the barrier and entered the cell. Removing the edge from her voice, out came a concerned, "Adora?" Adora stayed silent, refusing to look back at Catra.

"Adora, look at me," Catra demanded quietly, dropping down to Adora's level, but leaving space. And so, Adora turned, making eye contact with Catra. The look left a slow, lingering chill that clung to Catra's spine. "Adora?!" Blood started pumping in her ears, "What did that witch do to you?"

Adora flinched but quickly replaced her face with indifference. "Nothing."

Catra's heart tightened. "Adora," Catra said gently as she reached out to touch Adora's cheek.

"Don't touch me," Adora growled as she slapped Catra's hand away, looking more scared than angry.

Catra’s hand hung in the air. "Adora, I . . . .” She frowned and searched for the right words. “Glimmer told me.” Adora’s eyes immediately snapped back to her. “Please, talk to me," Catra begged, not even caring as her voice cracked.

"What did she tell you?" Adora asked. Catra started to break out in a cool, anxious sweat.

"She told me what you wouldn’t." Catra hissed. "Is it true? What Shadow Weaver does to you?"

The question hung as Adora’s blank face shattered into anger. She reached out and pushed Catra down. "So what? You know now? Are you here to gloat?”

“No!” Catra said immediately, but Adora would not give her any more time.

“You want me to tell you about how she takes off my clothes? How I stand there shivering as she touches me?” Angry tears welled in her eyes, “You want to know what she does to me? What she makes me do to her? What Catra? What do you want? Are you happy?”

That admission cut through Catra like a knife. The final piece of denial she had was washed away by a tidal wave. Her stomach sank and the room started to spin. She started hyperventilating, but Adora had no patience for it.

"Get out," Adora grunted. “You wanted me to suffer. I guess you got your wish.”

"What? Adora, no.” Catra’s voice broke every time she spoke. “Why didn’t you tell me?"

"Get out," Adora repeated, quieter. "I'm your prisoner, remember? I'm a weapon. Don't get soft on me now." In a more forceful tone

she said, "You're the same as she is, you know. She uses my body and so do you." Adora picked up a chipped piece of brick and threw it against the wall. On contact, it shattered. “I know you hate me for the attention she gave me. I hope you know now it was only because she wanted something from me. Everyone wants something from me.” Adora looked back at her, eyes flaring.

Catra’s world was closing in and she couldn’t think as she struggled to even breathe.

“I was told I was perfect, my entire life. And I was expected to be.” Tears started to gather at Adora’s eyes. “I was told I was worth something and, I know, it wasn’t right to tell you that you weren’t.” Adora sighed. “But what you don’t understand, Catra, is that I was also told I couldn’t depend on anyone else. That I didn’t matter in the big picture. I was told to be selfless. I was told to not want anything because I never, *ever* belonged to myself.” Adora slammed her palms against the ground as tears streamed down her cheeks. “Now get out.”

Catra’s tail lashed all over the place. She scratched at the ground, leaving long, ragged lines in the brick. "No."

Adora scowled and flared her nostrils.

“Why?” Catra asked, quietly.

“You think I have a choice?” Adora yelled, pulse visible as it beat against her neck. “Catra, get out of here. I don’t want to talk about this. Not with you.” The energy Adora had fell away and, all that was left, was a scared girl huddling against the wall.

Catra reached out, but thought better of it and pulled away. “Adora?”

“She keeps me out of a battles and,” the next words hung in Adora’s throat.

“And what?” Catra asked.

Adora looked away. “Nothing.”

Catra’s voice came out raw. “Adora, please.”

“I have nothing else to say.” Leaning her forehead against her knees, Adora fell away.

“Adora? Adora!” Catra tried, but Adora would not budge. Catra’s own heart was still making normal function impossible as it beat against her. Catra rose to her feet, shaking all over. Catra’s eyes flitted all over Adora, trying to figure out what to do until she was blurting, “I didn’t make you fight.”

Adora blinked several times before peeking out of her protective ball. “What are you talking about?” Catra looked at her, frozen in fear. “Catra, what did you say?” Adora snarled, lifting her head higher.

“I’ve been trying to tell you. Last time you transformed into She-ra, you didn’t fight. You,” she said, shoulders slumping, “stayed in the holding room.”

“Why?” Adora breathed through her mouth.

“Because, Adora,” Catra knelt in front of her, “I still care about you too.”

One more time, Catra reached out her hand. Instead of knocking it away, Adora stared at it, thinking. Briefly, she reached out and skimmed her fingers across the Catra’s. Then, going rigid, she pulled back and tucked her head down. “Catra, please leave me alone.”

Steeling herself, Catra tore herself away and set her mask on straight. “No promises.”

Chapter End Notes

> Hey all, the feedback for this story keeps pouring in and I really appreciate it. Thank you all for reading and sharing

your experiences. I love hearing about your reactions and what you're excited about next. Some of you have been concerned I won't finish this story which is totally valid, but I'm trying to update about every two weeks or so. If it's slower than that, don't be alarmed. It takes a lot of time to flesh out and edit these chapters. Just know that the time in between is what makes the story enjoyable.

If you're feeling some sort of relief from this chapter . . . good. Enjoy it while it lasts. :)

Oh, and some commentary on the name of this work: Waxing and waning are words used to describe someone's mental state as they shift back and forth in delirium. You can probably see how it applies here.

Breaking Point

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The second Catra left Adora's cell, she shattered into rage. Molten fury pulsed through her veins, expanding to her fingers and dripping off the tips of her claws. Shadow Weaver would pay for this.

Seething, Catra tore herself from the prison block. It was late, too late, when she walked down the corridor to her quarters. As she strode forward, her hand skimmed the wall absently. Adora and her used to race down this hallway, streaking past annoyed soldiers as they knocked into each other. Her nails caught on the concrete when she came to a junction. For a moment, she stared ahead, silence filled by the hum of machinery and the burning smell of hot metal. Her eyebrows turned downward and a rumble rose in her throat.

In this same spot, so many years ago, someone had grabbed Catra's tail, yanking her backwards. She remembered the sting of her eyes and the loud yelp she let out before falling to the ground, scared and humiliated. What she remembered the most, though, was looking up and seeing Adora, already holding out a hand to help her up, smiling. Later that night, Catra traced the bruises on Adora's knuckles, swelling with pride about having the best friend in the world.

Catra's hands folded into fists. Standing up straighter, she left the hall and made it to her room. Closing the door with a gentle click, she took her mask off. With it, her composure also left her. Grabbing her hair, she let out a guttural yell and slammed her hands against her desk, causing the drawer to bang around inside. She didn't care about those in rooms near her hearing. She bared her teeth and pushed the contents of her desk to the floor.

Pens clattered on impact. Papers gently floated down, littering the ground.

Catra sat on the end of her bed and stared ahead without seeing. She kneaded her forehead with the heels of her hands. “That bitch,” she said, voice raspy and unfamiliar. It was so obvious now that she knew. Adora never talked about what she did with Shadow Weaver in private. Their alone time had been going on for as long as Catra could remember. Groaning, Catra felt sick for her years of jealousy, for hating Adora for being Shadow Weaver’s favorite. Her ill feelings at Adora inverted, souring further into Catra’s blood. “Why didn’t she tell me?” she whispered.

The signs were all there, though, Catra had just been too stupid to put the pieces together. The nights where Adora would flinch away from being touched even though they spent every other moment glued together. How sometimes Adora would worry about someone watching her change. Even how Adora sometimes knew things about sex she had no business knowing. Her knowledge shocked even Catra who actively sought out any information that was not strictly allowed.

Slamming her fists against the bed, she sat up straighter.

“You want me to tell you about how she takes off my clothes? How I stand there shivering as she touches me? You want to know what she does to me? What she makes me do to her? What Catra? What do you want? Are you happy?”

Catra curled her legs up and wrapped her tail tightly around her ankle. She ripped off her shirt and belt, throwing them into a heap on the floor. After a few minutes, her breathing evened and a dangerous sense of calm overcame her. Inspecting the walls, the floor, and the few furnishings of her room, Catra found no attachment. Her whole life she had fought to be recognized. To matter. To be something. And the one person who made her feel that way was chained to the wall below her.

"And tortured by me," she sighed, adding her pants to the heap, leaving her in a Horde issued tank top and shorts.

Winning this war and beating Adora suddenly seemed childish. Shadow Weaver's preference for Adora over Catra had turned out to be something else so much more sinister. Shadow Weaver had hit Catra, sure, but what she was doing to Adora was worse. Catra bit her tongue and growled. Shadow Weaver didn't deserve to even touch Adora. No one did.

So Adora had left her. It made sense now, didn't it? Shadow Weaver was hurting her and Catra didn't end up being any better in the end. Adora had only been kind and, even now, still fought to protect her friends. And, Catra remembered Adora stepping in front of her the other day, to protect Catra. Adora somehow still even cared about Catra. Catra's eyebrows furrowed and her hands fell limply on her lap.

Her eyes stung. Two days ago, Adora had been in her arms, looking at her with affection. Adora didn't remember, but Catra would never forget.

"When you said you cared about me. Did you mean it?" Catra asked.

"I never stopped."

A sob rattled out of her chest. That moment may be the last they ever get together. More sobs joined the first and Catra cried. She cried for a long time, making promises well into the morning, only stopping as she slowly took in the blaring noise of the morning alarm.

When she touched her face, it was still wet. She wiped the last of the tears aside and stood up, got dressed, and smoothed her hair. Looking in the mirror, she studied her eyes. They held a promise. "Adora, I'm coming."

“I know you don’t believe it,” Perfuma said from her bed, “but she didn’t hurt me. I know it was on purpose.” The room was full of flowers of all different types and colors but with Perfuma’s distinct signature. There were plants on the nightstand, hanging above the bed, in the bed, on the floor, everywhere.

And they were also in Mermista’s way. She pushed past them and exclaimed, “Perfuma! You almost died. How can you say she didn’t hurt you?”

“Well, of course I know that!” Perfuma said, still with an air of calm. “The Horde isn’t going to stop but, it doesn’t change the fact that She-ra didn’t hurt me. She stopped.”

Mermista pressed her fingers to her temple and pulled down, groaning loudly. “She-ra is not and cannot hear anything we say. She hurt Bow. She has punched Glimmer I don’t know how many times!” Glimmer narrowed her eyes. Mermista threw her hands down on the bed. “You just have to promise me you won’t try to reason with her again!”

“She-ra?” Perfuma’s eyes opened wide. “Oh, no, you’ve got it all wrong.” Her hand kept combing through her hair and stopping awkwardly, like she expected it to be longer. But, after the fire, it had been cropped to above her shoulders. It was taking some getting used to.

Bow stepped up, “What do you mean?” His arm was still in its sling and he awkwardly bumped into a particularly large flower, which happily bobbed up and down as it spurted out pollen. Glimmer sneezed loudly.

“Bless you!” Perfuma said, smiling as she flexed her powers and pulled the flower aside. “And what I mean,” she said smiling, “is that I wasn’t talking to Adora.” Perfuma took a deep breath and looked to the ceiling. That day on the battlefield had not gone as

planned. She had endured more pain than she ever had in her life, but she had seen it and it had made it worth it.

“Um, then,” Glimmer interjected, “who were you talking to?” This was the first time Perfuma had woken up and Glimmer was not quite sure of her sanity at this point.

“Catra, of course,” Perfuma giggled. “She was standing there, not far back and I looked right in her eyes and she looked back.” Perfuma opened her palms in her lap and two seeds broke into green stems and into brilliant white flowers in front of them. “I opened my heart to her,” Perfuma lifted her hands, “and she let me glimpse into hers.”

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other and Mermista just gaped, saying, “What did you talk about?”

“I told her that she never has gone too far for forgiveness.” Perfuma looked to each member of the room, eyes twinkling. “Look, I don’t know her, but Adora does. And Adora used to trust her. Is it really that far of a reach?”

“Perfuma,” Glimmer said, “did she say anything to you, you know, actually?”

“Not with words, but She-ra’s sword was raised above me and it never fell. What more evidence do you need?” Folding her hands into her lap she said, “Unfortunate that the Horde soldiers interrupted our moment, but I survived. I’m okay and look we made a real connection.”

Glimmer almost fell into Perfuma’s bed. “You really believe that?” Bow put his hand on her shoulder.

“Of course, I do,” Perfuma touched her chest with her fingers, “People are not all bad nor are they all good. Catra is not all evil. She’s fighting for something, but I don’t think it’s destruction.”

Glimmer contemplated the words for a minute as she replayed her and Catra’s conversation from the day prior in her head. “I talked

to her too," Glimmer said. Perfuma looked shocked but then smiled and nodded. "Catra, I mean. Yesterday we met and, I don't know, but, Perfuma, she seemed conflicted and scared and, well, I don't know."

"Glimmer, Adora has told us what it was like for her and Catra in the Fright Zone." Perfuma laid her hand on Glimmer's and on Mermista's, who frowned. "Catra and Adora grew up with only each other and then this war ripped them apart. How would you feel if the same thing had happened to you and Bow?"

Bow and Glimmer went rigid at the thought. "That would never happen," Glimmer said.

"You don't think Catra and Adora thought the same thing?" Perfuma asked. "They never felt safe a day in their lives, Glimmer. Adora has told you as much."

Glimmer's eyes sank to the nearest flower as she thought. If Bow had left her, she would have been furious. And hurt. And confused. But she could not imagine it. He had always been in her life and always would be.

Perfuma filled the silence. "Catra's life hasn't been easy and, suddenly, she's faced with a choice. She can keep doing what is comfortable or she can take a stand up for what's right. She already chose not to hurt me, who knows what else she's capable of?"

"How is that going to help us though?" Mermista pulled her hand back and crossed her arms. This was getting too mushy for her.

"Catra still cares about Adora." Perfuma turned to look at Mermista, "We have to believe in her." Mermista scowled. "I'm not saying we don't plan for everything, but I think we put our hope in her, help foster her doubts in the bad, so that she can flourish in the good. Glimmer already did a great job yesterday."

Glimmer's mouth fell into a hard line and Bow chuckled. "Glimmer was very, very patient yesterday, right Glimmer?" Mermista

laughed. Glimmer smacked her forehead with her hand.

“I can’t believe this,” Mermista griped.

Perfuma smiled patiently again, “Evil destroys, but kindness can rebuild.”

“You really believe that?” Glimmer asked.

Perfuma smiled genuinely. “With all my heart.”

Adora was alone. She stayed curled up in the corner, cheeks warm and fingernails digging in as she rubbed them across her palms. Her eyes stayed open, staring down at her folded-up body under dim light. Burying her head further, Adora whimpered, wishing she could change into She-ra just to feel some remnants of strength again.

Catra knew. She knew that Adora let Shadow Weaver do this to her. It made Adora feel weak, like Catra could see every imperfection inside her. Sweat poured out, glistening across her skin. Her breathing was losing its rhythm. Adora put her hands back to the ground, feeling as small shards of concrete pressed against her skin, the slight pain grounding. She tried to stay focused on the moment, but she shivered as each hair on her body prickled uncomfortably.

This was all Adora’s fault. If she hadn’t gotten captured. If the sword had chosen someone else. If she had made Catra leave with her in the first place. If she had made the right decision at any point in the last year, Etheria wouldn’t be dying. Instead, she was bargaining with her body to save the Rebels some time, but it wouldn’t be enough. She wasn’t good enough. Squeezing her eyes shut, Adora held back tears.

Her chest started to tighten in a way she was becoming familiar with. It always started the same. Heavy breathing. Restricted chest. Sweating. Shaking. Panic. Fighting to breathe.

But this time, a different voice gave her the air she desperately needed to not lose herself in a panic attack.

"I've been trying to tell you. Last time you transformed into She-ra, you didn't fight."

Shaking her head, still trying to calm down, Adora didn't know what to believe. If it was a lie, it was perfect. Adora wouldn't be able to remember anything and she had no other source of truth. Catra had been manipulating her, but this wasn't her style. Still, she had grown cruel since their time together growing up.

And she had made Adora fight other times. She hurt so many of the Rebels. She set fires to Plumeria. Even when Adora asked her not to. Even when Adora begged. Adora couldn't imagine what else Catra had done or made her do while under infected She-ra's power.

Then again, in the last week, Catra had been increasingly protective, going as far as attempting to physically attack Shadow Weaver. Adora knows she would have too, if Adora hadn't stood in the way. The look in Catra's eyes when she had first seen the set of marks Shadow Weaver had left her scared Adora. It was honest and blazing with anger. And that was all before Catra knew what she knew now.

"Because, Adora, I still care about you too."

Adora touched the place where her fingers had grazed Catra's. It lacked the warmth that had come with Catra's contact. Instead, it was cold and clammy, a reminder that Adora was alone. Still, Catra had reached out to her. Again and again, but, this time, it was Adora pushing Catra away. Tears came to her eyes as she recalled the image of Catra shaking in front of her, angry and scared.

“We all do what we have to do to survive,” Adora conceded to empty air. She let her forehead fall backwards against the cool wall, repeating Catra’s words in her head like a mantra. She could almost believe it if she tried.

Sighing and standing up, Adora walked back and forth in her cell a few times on shaky legs. When she made her way to the stack of ration bars, she squatted and picked one up curiously. Adora wanted to believe Catra so badly, but the idea of putting hope in her old friend gave her a sinking feeling in her stomach. Taking a deep breath, she tore open the bar and resumed her walk. She paused her chewing as the grainy texture coated her tongue, absorbing the nutrients greedily.

Lifting her shirt, Adora looked at her stomach. Skinny. It had only been a few weeks, but she could see her ribs poking out. Adora needed to get it together. When her knees buckled, she pulled herself back up, groaning, and continued to walk. If there was even a chance Catra was serious, Adora needed to be ready.

Catra opened the door with a bang. “Where is it?”

Scorpia shot up, stunned. “Catra? You’re here! I mean, of course you are, but, you know, it has been a while and, uh, hi.”

Catra blew past Scorpia and scoured the room. “Where is Entrapta?”

Entrapta burst out of a ceiling panel, “Hello!”

Stumbling back and grabbing her chest Catra let out a hiss.

“Whoa there, Wildcat. You seem a little tense. What’s up?” Scorpia tilted her head and Entrapta shrugged, flipping down her face shield, and going back to work.

“I’m fine,” Catra ran a hand through her hair, “but I need to know where the disc is.”

“Normally I love guessing games but,” Scorpia paused, “you seem like you’re in a hurry. So, what are you talking about?”

“The disc!” Catra cleared off a table, throwing small pieces of metal and wires on the ground. Scorpia stood back while Entrapta slid back her face mask and whipped out her voice recorder.

“Subject X099 is exhibiting some,” she paused, eyes scanning Catra head to foot, “unstable behavior. Symptoms include: shaking, growling-” Scorpia nudged her. Entrapta’s mouth fell open as she said, “Oh!” and then clicked the device off.

Jumping in front of Catra she said, “Hi Catra!” Catra tripped over a box on the floor and screamed when she turned up to Entrapta. Entrapta’s eyes widened and she gaped before breaking out in a smile and excitedly saying, “Here’s a disc!”

Catra ran over and tore the object from Entrapta’s hand before throwing it on the ground. “No, not that one. The one that controls She-ra.”

Entrapta cocked her head to the side, picking up the piece of metal she had just given Catra with tender care. “Oh, you mean the disc that infects First Ones tech with a virus? Oh, ho!” Entrapta said, putting her hand under her chin and leaving a smear. “That piece of technology has been taken by Hordak. I’ve begged him to let me look at it further but he says that it needs to be kept in a very special, safe spot. There are so many mysteries to unravel with all that First Ones’ code!” Entrapta cackled with delight while waves of anger pulsed out of Catra.

“Whoa, whoa, Catra. Why do you need that?” Scorpia grabbed her shoulder, eyebrows creasing. “Are you okay?”

Catra pushed the hair out of her face. “I just need it.” In the background, Entrapta’s eye lit up as she propelled herself around on her hair. “Entrapta! I’m talking to you.”

“What? Oh!” Entrapta bounded back and landed inches from her. “I am li-sten-ing.” Scorpia shot Entrapta a thumbs up and then pointed to her eyes with two fingers. “Oh right! Eye contact. I am showing I’m engaged.”

Catra ground her teeth together. “Entrapta, do you know where the disc is?”

“Ah, nope! I don’t know!” Entrapta said. In a loud whisper she said, “If you find it can you let me know?”

Catra grabbed her shirt, letting go as soon as she felt the grease under her hands and wiping them on her shorts while sticking out her tongue. “What do you mean you don’t know?”

“Um, hey, over here,” Scorpia poked out. “Catra, you heard what Entrapta said. Hordak took it. It’s under lockdown.”

“It was interfering with all of the First Ones tech we have in the lab!” Entrapta said, gesturing wildly. “It was amazing actually. When we first brought it in her things started going berserk! We had to lock the doors and -”

“- Scorpia, do you know where?”

“No,” Scorpia responded, grimacing when Catra’s shoulders fell.

Squeaking desperately, Catra said, “We have to find it.” Letting out an anguished scream, tears started falling down her face.

Entrapta slowly slid over Catra’s shoulder. “Oooh, I think she’s sad.” She looked back at Scorpia and said, “Right?!”

“You got it buddy,” Scorpia said. “Catra, what’s going on?” Catra groaned again. “We can help you, but we need to know what’s going on. Right, Entrapta?”

“Right!” Entrapta said. Looking around she asked, “Wait, what are we talking about again?”

Exasperated, Scorpia pulled her hair. “Look she’s in,” this was turning out to be a much different day that she planned. “We’ve got your back, Wildcat, but you’ve gotta tell us what’s going on.”

“I can’t tell you okay!” Catra scrubbed at her face and stood up straighter. “I - never mind, I’ll figure it out.”

“Catra, come on. We can help you. Look,” Scorpia smiled, “we don’t even really even need to know. Not if you’re not ready. We’ll help you anyway. It’ll be like a - a treasure hunt!”

Entrapta let out notes of excitement in a perfect arpeggio. “A treasure hunt! With tech?!”

“This is important,” Catra said. “Not some stupid game.”

“Tech is very serious business,” Entrapta reassured.

“Hey,” Scorpia said soothingly. “Hey, look at me. We’ll figure it out okay? We’re the Super Pal Trio!” Catra’s eyes still scanned the room. “Um, Catra? Remember? Super . . . yeah never mind.”

“What?” Catra looked back up. “Yeah, yeah, friends and whatever. I remember.”

Scorpia smiled gently and put a pincer up in front of her. “Of course!” she said, with determination. “We will figure out the location of that disc and report back ASAP.”

Catra sighed. “I would appreciate that.” Blushing slightly, she added, “Thanks.”

Eyes glittering, Scorpia scooped Catra up in a tight embrace. “We’ve got you, Wildcat, promise.”

“This is urgent!” Catra cried, while pushing Scorpia away.

Nonplussed, Scorpia squeezed hard one more time before returning Catra to her feet. “Hey, have you slept at all?” Scorpia

asked. “Not that you don’t look great, you just, uh, seem like a little more,” she jumbled, “more . . . “

“Irritable?!” Entrapta offered.

Letting out an awkward laugh Scorpia said, “Well, not exactly the word I was going to use but . . . .”

“No,” Catra said flatly. “I don’t know. Just,” she rubbed her forehead, “find it.”

A knock came to the door, startling Scorpia and Catra. In the last few seconds, Entrapta had managed to find a circuit board and was welding wires to it, humming some sort of tune.

Scorpia answered the door. “Um. Hi?”

“Hordak needs to see you,” the soldier replied.

“Me, oh wow, may I ask the occasion?” Scorpia asked.

“Not you,” she pointed at Catra frowning, “you.”

Striding forward, annoyed, Catra snapped, “I’ll be back later,” before following the soldier out the door.

Entrapta and Scorpia looked at each other and shrugged. Entrapta started to use her hair to swing from the ceiling, but Scorpia caught her. “Entrapta, we’ve got a big project today and I need you, okay? I can’t do this without you.”

Looking first at Scorpia’s chest then bringing her eyes to Scorpia’s face, Entrapta asked, “Are you talking to me?”

“Yes, you. You’re the only one who can do this. Are you in?” Scorpia smiled.

“I,” Entrapta looked puzzled, “No one ever asks me for help.”

“I’m your friend,” Scorpia said, “and you’re mine. Can we track down that infected piece of tech or what?”

Entrapta let out a cackle of delight. “What are we waiting for? Let’s go!”

Angella had been spending more and more time alone, burying herself in every task she could find while battles raged outside her woods. Aid to towns across Etheria. Fire control around Plumeria. Even the Salineas, recently unaffected by war, was taking in refugees they didn’t know what to do with. Angella had tried to intercede but Mermista was adamant that people would have a place to stay and they would figure the rest out. Figuring the rest out had personally cost her an enormous headache.

She sighed and leaned back, staring out the window. When had things become so complicated? Angella rubbed the bridge of her nose, concern growing over who would be the next victim of this war. Her own daughter was out there fighting and Angella was stuck inside. Suddenly, the paper in front of her seemed appalling and she pushed it off to the side.

Standing, she moved to the balcony door, opened it and strode through, letting her wings stretch as she placed her hands on the railing. “What would you do, darling?” she said into the air, wishing her words could carry to wherever Micah was, beyond this world.

Micah had always been the brave one. The wind gently blew back Angella’s hair. Out here, she could admit that she was afraid. There had been so many times over the years she had felt great despair, but there was always someone or something to pull her out of it. Now, she stood alone, staring at the horizon. They were losing this war.

The door slid open behind her, startling her.

“Hi mom,” Glimmer said, walking up to the railing, gripping it tightly in both hands. Glimmer had been running around all morning, but she wasn’t getting anywhere. Her nervous energy was unproductive. Every minute she was still and safe at Bright Moon was another moment Adora wasn’t. Another minute that the Horde was painting Etheria red. Bow reassured her patiently that they were doing all they could. For once, she didn’t believe her best friend.

“Glimmer,” Angella said, regarding her daughter. “How are you doing, darling?”

When they made eye contact, Glimmer’s lip was already trembling. Angella rushed in as she broke into tears. “Mom,” Glimmer choked, “I don’t know what to do.”

“Glimmer, it’s alright,” Angella soothed. “It’s okay to feel overwhelmed in these dark times.” At her words, Glimmer only sobbed harder. Angella’s heart hurt. She couldn’t tell Glimmer that the situation was hopeless, even if she had just been thinking the same thing.

“I’m not good at this!” Glimmer cried. “You have always been so calm and strong. And dad,” she wiped her nose, “I just feel like anyone in the world would be better at this than me.”

Angella enveloped her daughter in a hug. “Glimmer, you are ten times as strong as me,” she said solemnly.

A hiccup came from Glimmer as she became confused. “That’s ridiculous and we both know it.”

Angella held her shoulders firmly. “Now you listen to me,” she frowned. Glimmer’s eyes widened and she nodded. “When this world thinks of the Rebellion, they think of you, not me.”

“They think of She-ra, mom, not me,” Glimmer said.

“She-ra is only part of it, Glimmer.” Angella laughed dryly. “Aren’t you the one who convinced Adora to join the Rebellion? You

command the Princess Alliance." Glimmer wasn't convinced. Angella sighed, "Let me tell you something. Before you came out here, I was feeling defeated myself. How's that for the Queen of Bright Moon?"

"What?" Glimmer rubbed her eyes, tears still falling, but slower.

"Just because I'm the Queen doesn't mean I don't feel all the same things you do," Angella said. She laughed more warmly, "Between the two of us, Glimmer, you are far more courageous than me. I'm here in this castle all day long. You are out there fighting for your friends and what you believe in."

"You have to be here," Glimmer said. "People need you to make decisions and you always do what's right."

"Oh, Glimmer, if only that were true," Angella replied. "You sound so much like your father. You are so much like him. Brave and full of conviction. You, my dear, always do what's right. So, what is wrong?"

"I don't know. I talked to Catra and it sounds like Perfuma did too. It just feels like a stupid idea, that's all," Glimmer said, hiding her face.

"Talked about what?" Angella asked.

"Adora."

Raising her eyebrows in surprise, Angella replied, "Well, it can't hurt, can it?"

Glimmer scoffed. "The Horde is on the move to attack again soon and the only thing we've been able to do is make one of their commanders angrier. I'm so afraid of what will happen."

Angella said, taking Glimmer's shoulder. "Trust each other."

Glimmer's mouth turned into a thin line. "I'm afraid."

Angella took in her daughter. “Me too. But, Glimmer, you have never let that get in the way before. You are so brave,” Angella tucked a stray lock of Glimmer’s hair behind her ear. “You are my inspiration.”

Pulling herself into Angella, Glimmer hugged her mother tightly. “If I don’t get to give up, you don’t either.”

Stroking Glimmer’s hair, Angella sighed. She did not feel any of the release that Glimmer did, still unsure. She looked to the sky again and took a deep breath. When her gaze returned to Glimmer’s face, her heart shifted. Inside, the start of a fire she hadn’t felt in a long time. “It’s a deal then.”

“You wanted to see me,” Catra said, standing from a low bow. It had been a long time since she had stood in Hordak’s throne room. Usually, she could exude an easy confidence here, in control of her own affairs with enough success to keep Hordak appeased as he ruled in the background. But now, with everything going on with Adora and Shadow Weaver, Catra felt like a live wire. She was skittish. Her mind raced back to Scorpia, praying they found the disc quickly. Sweat and panic soaked through her uniform.

“Ah, yes, Catra.” Hordak slid his fist out from under his chin and stood tall, clasping his hands behind his back. “The progress of the Horde in the conquering of Etheria has pleased me.” He started to descend the steps. Catra swallowed and shook at every footfall. “Things are going well with Entrapta in the lab, as well, I’m sure you’ve heard.”

“Yes, Hordak,” Catra drawled.

“What I’d like,” Hordak continued, “is to finish this once and for all.”

From behind the throne, Shadow Weaver slinked into the room. Catra's bloodshot eyes met hers in a rabid stare. "Despite having every tool at your disposal, Catra, Etheria still isn't under Horde control," Shadow Weaver said, hovering down the stairs until she flanked Hordak.

"You," Catra growled. "What are you doing here?" Hair on end and claws unsheathed, Catra glared at Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver eyed her suspiciously. A sound started in Catra's throat that sputtered out in a violent hiss.

Hordak arched an eyebrow and looked between them. "Whatever it is between you two today, please take it elsewhere. I don't have time for such petty spats. I have an empire to build."

"Professionalism was never your strong suit," Shadow Weaver muttered, turning away.

Catra ran at Shadow Weaver who looked surprised until she raised her hand and wrapped Catra in black tendrils, restraining her. Catra yelled, spraying spit across the floor at her feet. "Apologies, Hordak. This one has been," Shadow Weaver contemplated, "under much stress."

"Stress?!" Catra screamed. "You witch."

Hordak leveled with Catra, "What's gotten into you?" He gave her a disgusted look and threatened, "If you're not up for the job, I'll find someone else who is."

Catra's chest was heaving. Closing her mouth, she took several deep breaths through her nose and the ghostly ropes around her arms and feet loosened. This was not the time. Shadow Weaver was using Hordak as a shield. While her heart still hammered in her chest and her blood boiled, she let her shoulders drop into a collected attention. Hordak, turned away, taking several steps from her. Shadow Weaver merely sighed and clasped her hands behind her back.

“I will start accompanying you on the battlefield, Catra, to ensure we are,” Hordak glanced at Shadow Weaver, “making the most of our time.”

“What?” Catra’s eyes snapped back to Shadow Weaver with a new fury. “You never took issue with what I was doing before. We’re making progress. I’m doing everything you’ve asked!”

“And yet,” Shadow Weaver intercepted, “we are no closer to capturing Bright Moon than we were months ago. With She-ra,” Shadow Weaver caught Catra’s gaze, “we should be able to squash them immediately. And, perhaps, we will with more capable hands.”

Catra’s eyes hardened. So, this was the game Shadow Weaver would be playing. Another rumble in her chest started to rise, but she pushed it down, her tail showing off her resentment instead. “We’re working on it. This is a war, not a single battle.”

“Ah, yes, but we have more power than ever, don’t we? Entrapta and I are close in our,” Hordak put his chin in his hand, “research and I want nothing standing in my way.”

“But-” Catra started.

“-This is not up for debate,” Hordak snapped. In the background, Shadow Weaver crossed her arms. “You will still have your duties as Force Captain, but I will be there to supervise.” He smiled cruelly, nodding to Shadow Weaver.

“One princess has already been taken out and, with She-ra, we should be unstoppable,” Shadow Weaver said, curling her fingers into a loose fist in front of her.

Catra wanted to scream at her again. She had put Hordak up to this, Catra knew it.

“Catra, I will be requiring the remote you use to control She-ra,” Hordak said.

Blood froze in Catra's veins. "Why do you need that? I can take care of her."

"Oh, I'm certain you've done everything in your power," Hordak said with condescension. "But, from now on, I will be in control of our most powerful weapon, as is proper of my position."

Shadow Weaver eyed Catra, waiting for her next move. Catra's mouth went dry. "Yeah, okay, whatever," was all Catra managed to say. "What else do you need?" She threaded her hands together behind her back, not wanting anyone to see them tremble.

"That is all. You may leave us," Hordak said with a wave of his hand.

Catra turned to leave.

"Oh, and one more thing," Hordak sounded from behind her. "Our next attack has been moved up. We march two days from now."

Catra's ear flicked but she did not turn back to face them, knowing full well the dread she felt inside was showing on her face.

Panic. Catra was panicking. She skipped training. She skipped dinner. In her room, she was wrapped under a blanket, trying to stay focused. Ever since her talk with Hordak and Shadow Weaver, things felt even more dire. She had to get Adora out of here. Now. Before it was too late.

Torturous minutes went by as Catra plotted, coming up with no ideas that weren't extraordinarily risky. When midnight hit, she decided to make her move anyway. She made her way to Adora's cell on quiet feet.

"What are you doing here?" Adora asked, "It's past curfew." On the other side of her cell's barrier, Catra was standing in front of the computer, avoiding her gaze. Adora hadn't heard her until Catra rapped lightly on the door. "We need to talk," Adora said, though she wasn't sure what of the many topics she'd been reviewing they needed to talk about first.

"We can talk later," Catra said as she fiddled with the keypad. "Right now, I'm breaking you out." The door fell away with a crackle and they stood face to face.

Adora took a step back as she registered what Catra had said. "You, what?" This was not exactly what she was expecting.

"Are you deaf now too? I'm getting you out. Can you please be quiet?" Catra stepped in and whispered. "If you hurry, I can cover until you get to the edge of the woods." Catra reached out to Adora, unshackling her hands deftly. Catra caught the shackles and lowered them to the ground softly. Behind her, her tail swept side to side. They needed to hurry.

Shadow Weaver's words sounded loud in Adora's head, shaking her bones

"Adora, if you leave me again, I will kill her."

In shock, Adora found the first words that came to mind, "I can't leave." She rubbed the raw skin of her wrists, standing back defiantly.

"Well, duh, you're not supposed to," Catra urged, "but I think we can break a rule just this one time."

"This is dangerous," Adora said, sweat starting to pool at her temples. "You don't understand."

"What, Adora? More secrets to tell me?" Catra snipped.

Scowling Adora ground her teeth together and said, "Catra, I told you before to leave me alone."

“It’s your lucky day then, because I decided not to listen to you,” Catra still whispered, but more forcefully. “Aren’t you even going to thank me?”

“Catra, stop,” Adora said, matching Catra’s gruffness. “Will you just listen to me? For once? The Horde is going to find out you helped me.”

“We don’t have time right now. It'll be fine. I'll make up some excuse and boom, back to normal," Catra argued, catching Adora’s hand and pulling her forward.

"Catra," Adora tore her hand away, “No.”

"No, what?" Catra tapped her foot, becoming more annoyed.

Adora was still standing in her cell with a look of intensity directed at Catra. "No, she'll kill you." A thick silence filled the air as Catra read Adora’s body language.

Despite her quickening pulse, Catra broke it. "Who? Shadow Weaver? She doesn't have that power anymore." Adora looked at her sternly. “Look, I don’t know what Shadow Weaver did, but Hordak is going to start coming into battle. He is going to control She-ra. I won’t be able to help the Rebels.”

“Oh, was what you were doing helping?” Adora said, narrowing her eyes. “Because, to me, it seems like you have been trying to destroy us for the last year.”

“Fine, whatever, Adora.” Catra groaned. “You can be mad or whatever, but go do it back in the comfort of your little castle.”

“I told you,” Adora glared, “she will kill you.” Catra swallowed. Adora looked away and, more softly, grumbled, “I don’t know why you came anyway.”

"Shut up, Adora," Catra growled as she grabbed Adora by the collar and pulled. “I’ll be fine.”

“No, you won’t,” Adora said, holding her ground.

“Well, then, it’s just what I deserve, isn’t it?” Catra hissed.

"Catra!" Adora said as she pulled back until they were stuck in gridlock. "No. You’ve done some . . . bad things, but this is not okay!” Tightening her hand around Catra’s, Adora removed it from her and took a step backwards. “The possibility of my escape for your life is barely a good deal.”

“You’re kidding, right?” Catra cried quietly. “Etheria needs you. Your stupid friends need you. Who needs me? You left before. What’s so different this time, Adora?”

“Shut up Catra.” Adora took another step back. “The world needs She-ra. Without the sword, I’m nothing but an idiot who thought they could change things.”

“I’m not going to argue about that, but can you please have this crisis later?!” Catra asked, pupils fully dilated as anxiety spiked through her.

“Shadow Weaver will kill you,” Adora said quietly. “She promised me that.”

“So, you’d rather risk the entire Rebellion? Come on Adora, you’re stupid but not this stupid.”

“If I don’t get the sword back, the Rebellion will fall no matter what I do,” Adora said dejectedly.

Catra pulled at Adora’s sleeve again. “That is a different problem. Right now, you need to go or they aren’t going to have a chance at all.”

Adora grabbed Catra’s hand and pulled it off again, but this time, she held it tightly. “Why are you doing this?”

Catra’s nostrils flared before she looked away, thinking. Knowing she didn’t have much time, her eyes caught Adora’s again quickly.

She took a deep breath and tersely whispered, “Because it was a mistake, okay? Keeping you here. I messed up, so can you just go back to your other friends and get far away from here?” Fresh tears dripped out of Catra’s eyes. “Please, just go, Adora.”

Adora laced her fingers in between Catra’s and traced a finger down Catra's jaw. With her head spinning, Adora pleaded, "Come with me."

"You know I can’t. Not if we want you to make it out." Catra said, her heart rate increasing at a dangerous rate that had nothing to do with the urgency of the situation. "You should hate me.”

Adora pulled her hand back. “I don’t.”

"You need to leave."

"No," Adora said again, resolve she hadn’t felt in her entire time imprisoned welling inside her. Relief fell through her shoulders. Catra did care.

"What is wrong with you?" Catra said again as tears started coming down her face. “Do you want me to beg?”

Adora looked Catra up and down and then turned away coldly. “You need to get out of the prison block before you get caught.”

Catra’s mouth fell open, tears trailing down her face. She did not even bother to wipe them away. Instead, she pulled at Adora’s hands again. "Please, Adora.”

Adora sighed and wiped away Catra's tears with her thumb, taking a step closer to the door.

Finally, Catra thought. But then, Adora squeezed her into a hug. Catra’s breath hitched and she let out a desperate whine. It was their first real contact in over a year, at least that Adora would remember. Catra stood frozen in the warm, loving embrace. Catra hated that she wanted more of it when every second made it harder to get Adora out.

Adora choked on a sob and said, “I missed you.” Catra didn’t know how to unpack the words or the actions with the urgency she felt pulsing through her. If anything, this made her want to move faster. Catra leaned into the embrace, returning it tentatively and, then, thinking it may be the last time, as hard as she could. The pressure pushed air out of Adora’s lungs, but she fell into it, whispering, “I missed you so much.”

"I missed you, too, okay?” Catra said, pulling back but not releasing Adora’s shoulders, “But, you really have to go." When Catra started to pull away, Adora held firm around her waist.

"Why are you doing this?" Adora asked as she moved one hand, bringing them to run her fingers slowly down Catra's cheek.

Involuntarily, Catra shivered. Her body screamed at her to move, but she was spellbound by bright blue eyes staring into her.

Catra swallowed and licked her lips. "I - Adora . . . ." A light, warm breeze blew past Catra's cheek, Adora’s breath.

They stood frozen in the moment until Adora slid her hands to the front of Catra’s shoulders, squeezing lightly. For a moment, everything stopped. Catra’s eyes bore into Adora’s, inches between them. When another warm breath tickled her skin, Catra let her eyes close, taking in Adora’s scent. She heard Adora take a sharp inhale and, then, Catra was being pushed by Adora’s strong hands. Blinking rapidly, Catra took several steps backwards to regain her balance. Her eyebrows creased as she looked up at Adora’s face, full of determination.

Adora’s pupils focused on something else. Catra followed her gaze and gasped. She reached out, crying, “Adora, don’t!” But before she could close the distance, Adora slammed her hand on the prison alarm.

Adora had time to brush Catra's hand before she fell back into her cell. She whispered, "Get out of here," as the prison barrier

reappeared. Catra did not move, her eyes staring into Adora's, wide with shock.

Catra put her hand on the barrier, Adora put hers up on the opposite side, almost touching. "Go!" Adora demanded.

Catra didn't move. Lights were flashing and alarms blared and she started to pick up the faint sound of heavy footsteps running towards them. "Please, go," Adora said again.

“I’ll get you out of here, I promise,” Catra said. As her heart broke, Catra turned and ran.

Breathing hard by the time she slammed her door behind her, Catra let her unrestrained sobs. After all this time, Adora was still trying to sacrifice herself for Catra. It was so stupid.

Tomorrow. Tomorrow she had to figure it out or Hordak was going to do something unforgivable.

Catra couldn't sleep the rest of the night. When morning finally hit, she ran to Adora’s cell, but, when she got there, it was empty.

Chapter End Notes

> We're gearing up in this story for sure now and I'm really excited about what's coming. Hope you are too. Thanks for reading.

> I made a tumblr if any of you do that.

Retribution

Chapter Summary

CW: Implied non-con, manipulation, panic attack

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra ran. Adora wasn't in her cell. Or the one next to it. Or the one next to that. Every empty room fueled her desperation until she was tearing up and down the prison block, muscles aflame with anguish. Adora had to be here. She had to be. Skidding around a corner, Catra nearly lost her balance. The prison guard might have relocated Adora, she reasoned. Maybe they thought her cell was faulty. Catra drove harder. Guards yelled at her to slow down. Other prisoners just yelled at her. Despite her heightened senses, she didn't hear any of them. She was too busy straining to hear the one voice that mattered.

Hordak's attack was tomorrow. Adora wouldn't be with him or on her way to battle. Not without Catra. Grinding her fangs together, Catra came to the conclusion she'd been avoiding. There was only one other place Adora could be. A dark shadow passed through her heart, chilling her to the bone.

Panting, Catra came to the end of the prison block. Sweat streaked down her face, dropping unnoticed to the floor. She let her forehead fall to the stone wall, trying to cool off her body and slow her racing mind.

"Hey!" a loud voice shouted.

Too lost in herself, Catra didn't hear. Her thoughts flew by at a breakneck pace as she anxiously played out her next move. It couldn't possibly end with her and Adora both alive and free.

“Hey, Catra!” it sounded again, accompanied by a scuffle of footsteps. “I’m talking to you. I’ve got words.”

When a hand reached up to shake her, Catra smacked away. Collecting herself, she muttered, “Not now, Lonnie. I’m busy.”

Lonnie put her hands on her hips and stood back, scanning Catra’s face with a wary eye. “You don’t look busy.”

“What do you know?” Catra spat.

Kyle held shaky hands in front of himself, eyes shifting back between the both of them. Behind him, Rogelio loomed. He grunted and crossed his arms, clearly showing that he did not approve.

“This is not optional. We need to talk now,” Lonnie said, turning her head. “Isn’t that right, Kyle?”

“Um, well,” he said, peeking out from behind her.

“Kyle!” Lonnie yelled, flailing her arms.

She looked at Rogelio who shrugged with a look that said, *“What were you expecting?”*

“Whatever this is,” Catra flicked her wrist, “I don’t have time for it. Don’t you have better things to do than follow me around anyway?” she asked with a sneer. Catra made a move to push past the trio, but Lonnie grabbed her shirt. Catra’s tail puffed out in displeasure. A snarl rolled out of her, right into Lonnie’s face.

“No, you don’t understand,” Lonnie curled her fist, unperturbed. She pulled Catra closer, “we’re going to talk now.”

Kyle waved awkwardly in the background. Catra knocked Lonnie back and bared her fangs. “Watch your tone, cadet.”

Lonnie’s nostrils flared. “Tell me why we came here again?” She turned around and looked at Rogelio and Kyle for an answer. “Did

you really think Catra would listen to us?”

“Of course not. Are you dumb?” Catra said. As she walked past them she said, “Now, get out of my way.”

Kyle looked at Lonnie and Rogelio frantically. Both gave him pitying looks, like they knew this would be the outcome all along. Catra was already all the way down the hall. Taking a deep breath to steel himself, Kyle shouted, “It’s about Adora.” The sound of his own voice scared him.

Catra stopped, pausing before spinning around and marched towards them while asking, “What about her?” Kyle tried to cower behind Lonnie, but Catra pulled him out to face her. “Well?”

“I, um . . .” Kyle stuttered, looking away from Catra. He looked again to Rogelio who muttered something that sounded like encouragement.

“Come on Kyle!” Lonnie said, tapping her foot.

The muscles in Catra’s neck flexed, barely containing all the things she was about to yell if Kyle didn’t have anything important to say. If they had information about Adora, she needed to know. If they didn’t, they were wasting precious time.

Kyle whimpered, but with Rogelio’s ushering, he said, “I’ve been in charge of taking her to the showers.”

Lonnie sighed with relief. Kyle was the one who had instigated this whole ‘find Catra for help’ thing. Only because he’d given her half his lunch and, maybe, because he had a good point, did Lonnie agree to be his muscle.

“Of course, it’s per your order so you already know that,” Kyle said, rubbing the back of his head. Rogelio groaned and Lonnie smacked her head with an open palm. So much for being bold.

“Spit it out, Kyle!” Catra shook him.

“Seriously,” Lonnie groaned.

“She’s been acting odd. Sometimes she doesn’t even recognize me.” He looked down, fogging over. “Look, I know she’s your prisoner and she left us and we’re fighting her and-”

“-Kyle, enough,” Lonnie took over, pushing Catra off Kyle. “Catra, I know she hurt you, she hurt us too, but something is happening to her and we,” Lonnie motioned to herself, Rogelio, and Kyle, “aren’t going to let her rot here. We’re going to break her out. I told Kyle you’d just make this harder but he insisted that we ask. So, are you in or not?”

Catra looked at the ground, grabbing one elbow as her arm fell limply to her side. “I tried.”

“You what?” Kyle sputtered.

“I tried, okay!” Catra looked up, eyes darting around. Lonnie flinched. Quieter, she said, “I tried and she wouldn’t go."

Rogelio motioned with his hands and Kyle said, for the both of them, “What are you talking about?”

“And why?” Lonnie said, narrowing her eyes. Rogelio merely scanned Catra over, suspicious.

“I told her to go. She wouldn’t. That prison alarm wasn’t an accident,” Catra swallowed. “Adora set it off.”

“Why would she do that?” Lonnie asked.

“The sword is still here and it’s still infected,” Catra lied. “She wouldn’t leave here without it.” Catra was not about to tell them that Adora had stayed for her. No one would know that if she had her way.

“You’re lying,” Lonnie said.

“Why would I lie?” Catra seethed. “Telling you I tried to break out our highest profile prisoner is not exactly giving me a leg up in the Horde, is it?”

Lonnie and Catra stared each other down, hot, angry energy emanating off of both of them.

Kyle cleared his throat. “Lonnie, if we want to help Adora, you know Catra is the best person to help us.”

“Listen to your pet, Lonnie,” Catra said.

“What is wrong with you?” Lonnie asked, shoving Catra. She made a move to hit Catra again, but Rogelio caught her forearm and shook his head.

“Fine!” Lonnie said, ripping herself out of Rogelio’s grip.

Letting out a grunt, Catra said, “Look, okay, I never thought I’d say this but Kyle is right.” Everyone looked at her, cocking their heads in sync. No one looked more surprised than Kyle. “Stop being weird about it.” She brushed the front of her uniform off. “I am the best person to help you. But right now,” she looked away, tail falling and ears sagging, “I don’t know where she is.”

“Oh,” Kyle said. The group traded glances. “That complicates things.”

Catra’s anxiety flared. “You think I don’t know that?” Her ears flattened back and she was breathing hard again. Rogelio gently brushed her shoulder, looking at her eyes with understanding.

Lonnie sighed, running a hand down the back of her neck. “What’s the plan?”

“Are you deaf? She’s not here. She’s not in the prison at all.” Catra’s claws came out. “I know, I checked every cell.”

“You did what?” Lonnie asked. “By yourself? How long have you been here?”

“That isn’t the point,” Catra exclaimed. “We can’t break her out if she’s not here.”

“Whatever. Fine. You said we need the sword anyway,” Lonnie said. “Where is it?”

“Hordak keeps it in his chamber. I don’t know where the disc that infected it is either, but,” Catra sighed, conceding, “Entrapta and Scorpia are already looking for it.”

Kyle nodded. “We’re on duty tomorrow for the assault. If there’s an opportunity, we get out. Just let us know what we can do to help.” Everyone gaped at him again. He blushed. “We used to be a family, okay? And Adora is part of it. We don’t have a lot,” he slammed his fist into an open palm, “but we still have each other. We can do this.”

For once, Catra didn’t feel like making fun of Kyle. Solemn expressions descended on all four of them. Catra spoke first. “I think I know where she is right now,” Catra grimaced, “but you just,” she rubbed her forehead, “act normal for now.”

“Catra,” Lonnie said with a warning tone.

“Look, I,” she swallowed, “I want . . . I need your help, but I don’t know right now. Right now, I just want to make sure she’s okay.”

Kyle looked away, frowning and eyes watering.

“Okay as she’s been since coming back anyway,” Catra said, pained. This time, when Lonnie reached out and touched her, it was gentle.

“We can do this, we,” Kyle looked at Rogelio, “we’re a team. Remember?” Rogelio nodded in approval and stood a little taller, placing his hand proudly on Kyle’s shoulder.

Briefly, Catra made eye contact with each of them, “Keep your mouths shut. No one else hears a thing about this.” She glanced over her shoulder. “Now, I really have to go.”

Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle exchanged a wordless glance. Kyle said, “Then go.”

Catra didn’t need any more encouragement. Before she took off down the hall, she turned to glance backwards and said, “Thanks.”

Behind her, Kyle looked at Lonnie with wide eyes. “What did she just say?” Lonnie’s mouth fell open in disbelief.

Adora jolted straight up. Her pupils widened in the darkness, but there was nothing to focus on. Slowly, she stood. Beneath her, the ground felt solid, but, without her sight, her balance was compromised. Cautiously, she stepped forward. Her foot hit the same smooth ground she felt beneath her fingers. After a few more steps, Adora adjusted to her blindness and started walking, then running.

She ran faster and faster, feet echoing with each slap of the ground. It was still dark, but the noise of her breath and the air pushing back her hair made her feel more solid, more real.

It all ended with her next step. It didn’t land. She started to fall.

Adora screamed, filling the void. She braced herself for impact, but it never came. As time went on, the feeling of falling faded. There was still nothing under her feet, but when she reached out, her hand felt something corporeal. She grabbed onto it. Moments ago, it felt like a rough cliff face but, now, it felt the same as the floor, seamless. Tentatively, she rose to her feet, vertigo following her as the wall became the floor.

Her eyes caught a pinprick of light directly overhead. Grunting, Adora looked around in the darkness for a way up, finding nothing. She stared into the light and sighed.

“Adora,” a voice echoed around her. Adora spun around, fists up as the voice sounded again, “Adora.”

It came from all sides. It was gentle, but it reverberated loudly in the emptiness. Adora looked up at the light again. When she did, it twinkled in response, the slight shift in its appearance blinding. She reached out in front of her, trying to find another wall, but found only empty air.

The voice came again, “Adora.”

Knowing that she was stuck either way, Adora lifted a foot, as if going up a step. Shocked, her foot connected. Groping in the vastness of the dark, she took another step, upwards. Letting out a puff of air, Adora climbed. The light seemed to be getting closer, but she had no way to judge distance.

She kept climbing. This time, each step was slow and tentative. She did not want to repeat the same mistake of trusting in anything as she had before.

After some time, she stopped. Everything looked the same. Annoyed, she stared at the light. With a steady hand, she reached up and, to her surprise, felt warmth when she pressed her finger into it. It twinkled again and then her world exploded. From the tip of her finger, a rainbow of colors burst out all around her. Instinctually, Adora crossed her arms in front of her face and sank back into an athletic stance. Blinking until she was certain she wasn’t blind, she stood up tall and opened her eyes, finally able to see the floor beneath her feet.

The room was vast and white. The floor went on forever. There were white columns surrounding her on two sides and, above, were thick, bouncy clouds. The exact opposite of the void.

“Hello Adora.”

Adora’s eyes shot forward. The voice was no longer scattered and echoing around her. It came from in front of her. Finding it, Adora saw, first, shoes. White and gold. She scanned her eyes up the

body in front of her. The outfit matched the boots, She-ra's uniform. But there were differences. The boots were cut to the knee. Instead of shorts, there were long, tight pants beneath the skirt. Adora settled on She-ra's symbol. It was larger. The person wearing it broader, accentuated by shoulder plates that extended straight out rather than at an angle like Adora's She-ra.

Finally, Adora met the eyes of the person in front of her. They flashed a translucent blue before settling into a dark brown as she shrank into someone only barely recognizable. "Mara?" Adora asked.

"Hello, Adora. I've been waiting for you," Mara said, coming closer to grasp Adora's hands in her own.

"Mara! I have so many questions for you," Adora said, "Where are we?"

"Adora, you're asleep," Mara smiled sadly. "This is a dream."

"Oh," Adora said, crestfallen, "So none of this is real."

"Just because it's a dream it doesn't mean it's not real." Mara said. Adora cocked her head, but Mara continued to speak. "We don't have a lot of time. You'll wake up soon."

Adora was starting to remember. If she was asleep, she'd wake up back in the Fright Zone. "No," she whispered in horror.

The world started to fall apart around them. Pillars crumbled. Everything around them started to blur. Adora desperately clung to Mara's hands, willing herself to stay.

"Adora, listen to me." Mara said, steady as the ground around them shattered noiselessly and faded away. "You are brave and strong." She smiled again. "You have always fought for what is right. I know you'd do anything for Etheria." She squeezed Adora's hands and, with their last second of eye contact, Mara said, "But Adora, you are also worth fighting for."

Right as Adora opened her mouth, Mara dropped her hands, and, with a sad smile turned away.

In an instant, it was gone. Adora woke up in a cool sweat, shining in the dim light of the Black Garnet that peeked under the door.

Adora tried to remember the dream. As she tried, the details became muddled. The harder she clung, the fuzzier it became. It felt so real moments ago. Now, it was fading into obscurity.

Mara's words stuck. But what had they meant? Adora fought for herself. She wanted to make the world a better place for everyone, she was included in that, right? At that thought, Adora's eyebrows furrowed.

Grabbing her head, exasperated, Adora realized she was not in her cell, but in a bed. Remembering slowly and then all at once, Adora let out a whine. After Catra tried to free her, Adora had felt almost whole again. But, as Catra disappeared, Shadow Weaver came. Without a word, her cell was opened and Shadow Weaver tightly bound her hands behind her back with magic. They ended up here, in Shadow Weaver's room. After locking Adora in her bedroom, Shadow Weaver left and hadn't returned, leaving Adora to jump in and out of a paranoid sleep all night.

A bang startled her. The dream would have to wait. Right now, she was in Shadow Weaver's bed. Her body dove into survival mode.

The door clicked before swinging open. "Adora, you're awake. Good." Shadow Weaver flexed her fingers, flooding the room with dark light.

Startled, Adora bounded to her feet, relieved to find she was fully clothed. "Shadow Weaver," she stuttered, "hi."

"Good morning, Adora. There is breakfast for you," Shadow Weaver motioned to her nightstand.

“Thanks,” Adora muttered as she tore open the ration bar and started to eat. Adora chewed awkwardly in the silence, feeling heat creep up her neck as Shadow Weaver stared from the doorway.

“You will be staying here from now on,” Shadow Weaver said, “for security purposes.”

Adora choked, coughing as all feelings of hope given to her by Catra and Mara were snuffed out. She put the ration bar down, forgetting it immediately. This was the last place she wanted to be. A place she had learned to fear in childhood and that fear had only grown as an adult. Focusing on her breath, Adora steered herself away, shutting down her fear response. Shutting down everything.

“Does this not please you?” Shadow Weaver asked. “This is something of an upgrade, I would imagine.”

“It’s good,” Adora said. “Thank you,” she jumbled. “I haven’t slept in a bed for a long time.” She ran her fingers along the sheets, disgusted by the implications of being here.

Sick of small talk, Shadow Weaver jumped to more pressing matters. "Explain to me what exactly happened last night."

Abruptly, Adora stood and said, "I don't know." Her response had been too fast. She cringed now that the words left her.

"You wouldn't lie to me, would you, Adora? Not after all I've done for you. Gave you a home. Raised you from a baby into a superior warrior. Forgave you for making the mistake of leaving the Fright Zone.” Shadow Weaver came nearer, “Allowed you to sleep in my bed."

Adora’s fingers twitched. “Something happened with the barrier of my cell. It faltered, but I didn’t leave. I triggered the alarm. You can trace it," she lied.

"I know where the alarm came from.” Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed. “Did Catra have something to do with this?"

"What? No way.” Adora gasped and shook her head violently. “Catra only visits me when she needs She-ra. She captured me. Why would she free me?" Adora asked, gulping. Flyaway hairs stuck to her forehead and she pushed them, trying to hide her lies.

Shadow Weaver knew. "Free you? Is that what she was trying to do?"

"No. She captured me. She," Adora tensed, “she doesn’t care about me. She just wants to use She-ra.” Adora’s eyes found the floor as her heart ached. After last night, the words felt like betrayal.

“Adora,” Shadow Weaver cupped her cheek, trailing fingernails down her skin. Adora wavered slightly, the cold touch brutal in juxtaposition to the memory of Catra’s warmth.

A hasty knock sounded on the door. Shadow Weaver grunted, ignoring it. Then the door whooshed open, crashing into the wall behind it. Shadow Weaver groaned with irritation. “You will stay here.”

Shadow Weaver shut the door to her room behind her, locking it from the outside. Adora pushed her ear to the door, straining to hear. When she did, her stomach dropped.

“I know you have her in here,” Catra said, voice cutting through the buzz as she breezed past Shadow Weaver, walking immediately up to the bedroom door and jangling the handle. Letting out an irritated cry, Catra went back on the offensive, “You can’t keep her here. What do you think you’re doing?”

“Hello, Catra,” Shadow Weaver responded, frost thick in her voice. “What sort of disappointment do you bring me today?”

“Cut it out!” Catra yelled. “Open this door. I’m taking Adora with me.”

From her side, Adora pushed against the door. She grabbed the doorknob and twisted, yanking on it as hard as she could. It rattled, but did not give. Catra’s ears perked up. “I know she’s here. Let her out and I won’t go to Hordak to tell him that you’re giving prisoners special treatment.” Catra snarled and pounded on the wall. “Open this door right now or I’ll break it down.”

A sparking silence filled the other room. Shadow Weaver broke it, “Very well.”

Adora jumped back. There was a quiet clink and then the door creaked open a crack. Catra grabbed it, throwing it back. Running in, she cried out, “Adora!” and extended her hand.

Reflexively, Adora reached out to grab it, smiling. Midway through the air, she stopped. Shifting from Catra, Adora settled her eyes on Shadow Weaver, looming behind Catra blazing white eyes behind her mask. The smile and color drained from Adora’s face and her hand fell to her side.

“Why are you here?” Adora whispered.

Jerking her eyebrows together, Catra wavered, hand still in the air, before turning on her heel. Taking a step backwards, Catra used her body to shield Adora from Shadow Weaver. Catra stood tall, wishing she hadn’t stopped growing before Adora so she could hide her now. “We’re leaving,” she said to Shadow Weaver.

Blindly, Catra reached backwards, moving her fingers urgently. Tenderly, Adora grazed the back of Catra’s hand. It was tempting. She wished to walk out of here with Catra and never come back. But it wasn’t that easy. Squeezing her eyes shut, Adora pressed Catra’s fingers to her palm, closing her hand into a fist. For a moment, Adora lingered and, then, let go.

Standing in the doorway, Shadow Weaver watched the exchange with expectation. When Catra registered what was happening she

turned around and asked, “Adora?”

“I’m sorry,” Adora said with regret.

“Come on,” Catra said, cocking her head to the side. Her hands fell lightly on Adora’s shoulders. “It’s okay.”

“I think *you* should go,” Shadow Weaver said, making her presence known by entering the room. She sidled next to Adora, standing on her right. Taller than them both, her shadow pressed down on them like a dark cloud.

Catra growled as her hands fell away. Adora hissed at her in warning. Catra settled back on her heels. “I’m not leaving without you,” Catra said to Adora, less confident than before.

“Oh?” Shadow Weaver interjected, “You’d prefer somewhere you can keep an eye on her? Perhaps, a place you have the security codes for?”

Catra puffed up. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“I know what happened last night, Catra.” Shadow Weaver smiled as Catra’s gaze flickered to Adora, who looked down. “And, while I don’t have any evidence to give Hordak, the only reason you’re still here is because Adora chose to stay.”

Behind her, the Black Garnet sparked, energy radiating off and sparking against the sensitive skin of Catra’s Achilles. Fighting down creeping fear, Catra said, “You don’t know what you’re talking about. You can’t touch me.”

“Who’d miss you if you’re gone?” Shadow Weaver snarled. “You think you’re irreplaceable,” Shadow Weaver laughed, “you are nothing. Not to the Horde. Not to me. Not even to Adora.”

Catra’s nostrils flared. “That’s not true.” Her ears flattened back as she raised her fists, but Shadow Weaver waved her away.

“Believe what you will,” Shadow Weaver said.

Adora jerked her head slightly, trying to warn Catra to stop.

Refusing to take the hint, Catra doubled down, “Stop manipulating her. I know what you do to her.’ Voice rising, throaty and hoarse, she added, “And I’m not going to let you touch her ever again.”

Adora’s heart hammered in her chest as tension made the air thick. Adora’s palms were sweating, even as the rest of her skin pricked with chill. Catra should know better than to pick this fight. Screaming internally, Adora tried to think of something to do.

Lashing out with her tail, Catra barked with her fangs bared. Not backing down, Shadow Weaver held her hands in front of her. Red light cracked around both of them.

“Oh?” Shadow Weaver said, walking forward. “Do I detect a hint of jealousy?”

Adora’s gaze shifted to Catra, with one eyebrow raised.

Flustered, Catra searched for words. “Just because I feel,” she clamped her mouth shut. Adora stumbled, eyes going wide. Shaking her head, Catra locked her focus back to Shadow Weaver. “I would never do what you do to her.”

Like a vulture, Shadow Weaver descended on Catra. Without Adora’s face to reassure her, Catra felt very alone and exposed. She winced as Shadow Weaver drew nearer.

“Don’t you though?” Shadow Weaver asked.

Ripping from her throat came an inhuman growl. “I am not like you!” Catra yelled, claws unsheathing as she slashed the air in front of her, the tips of her fingers missing Shadow Weaver as a black tendril came to her defense.

“I’ve watched you for years.” Shadow Weaver folded her hands in front of her again, composed. Adora unconsciously took a step away. “You have been so obvious, Catra.”

“Catra, what is she talking about?” Adora asked.

“I’ve seen you undress Adora with your eyes,” Shadow Weaver said. “All this time, you’ve just been waiting for her to want you back. When you found out she never would, you decided to force it on her instead.”

“That isn’t true!” Catra yelped. “Adora, look at me,” Catra said softly. “You don’t have to listen to her. You don’t even need to listen to *me.* Adora, I . . . .”

“Catra?” Adora asked softly.

“Adora, it’s not true. I mean, I,” Catra opened her mouth, searching for the right words, “it might look like that but it’s not about owning you. I just . . .”

“You just what, Catra?” Shadow Weaver prodded.

“I learned my lesson, okay?” Catra yelled as tears sprung up fresh in her eyes. “Adora, please believe me.”

Shadow Weaver laughed. Catra’s tail bristled at the sound until each hair stood on end.

“She was angry when you made other friends,” Shadow Weaver held up her hands. “Angry when you rose in the ranks. Angry when you were promoted and going to leave her behind. And, most of all, angry when you left her.”

Every word made Catra’s ears fall until they were plastered against her scalp.

“She couldn’t support you despite the fact that you did not choose this path for yourself, Adora. A massive responsibility has always been on your shoulders. One that Catra would never understand.” Shadow Weaver rested her hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Catra has been too self centered to let you go. And now? She owns you, just like she’s always wanted.”

Catra saw the sweat begin to form on Adora's skin, not noticing as the same thing happened on hers.

"Adora doesn't want you," Catra growled.

"And you think she wants you?" Shadow Weaver countered, laughing again. "Why does it bother you so much, Catra? Is it because Adora wants me to touch her in ways you've only dreamed of?"

Adora reddened, shrinking away as she froze, mortified. Her eyes started to unfocus as she shut down.

"Stop it!" Catra yelped. "Adora," Catra pleaded, "Adora, don't listen to her."

Shadow Weaver pulled Adora closer, now standing behind with both hands on Adora's shoulders. Under her grasp, Adora started to shake. "Or is it the things she does for me? I'm sure you've wished for her caress every night of your miserable life."

Unable to make further eye contact, Adora stared at the floor. Her face burned under Catra's gaze, the shame hurting as much as the memories that were hurdling at her from every direction. The taste of her mouth turned sour.

Smirking beneath her mask, Shadow Weaver asked, "Do you wish you could reach out and touch her now?"

Catra reached forward and grabbed Adora, pulling her away from Shadow Weaver. "I told you," Catra glowered, "to stop." Adora was stiff, but Catra held on to her, hugging her around the waist as if that would protect her.

"Adora," Shadow Weaver said. Catra heard Adora's breath hitch. "Your soft spot for her has made you weak," Shadow Weaver replied. "I will end this today."

She should have seen it coming, but it wrenched at her heart all the same, when Adora pushed gently against Catra's chest and

stepped away. Flaring her sadness into determination before Catra's eyes, Adora turned away. Catra reached out towards her, but she had gone too far.

Cool, dark shadows wrapped themselves tightly around Catra's ankles. She felt herself sinking, as if she were already falling down a pit as Adora moved further and further away. Catra had failed. Who would save Adora now?

The Black Garnet let out a shrill, high noise. Catra braced herself, but she would never have been prepared for what happened next. The lights flickered, but when they came back, Adora's hands were peeling off Shadow Weaver's mask. The next moment moved in slow motion. Adora wrapped her arm behind Shadow Weaver's neck and, with her free hand, stroked Shadow Weaver's cheek so lovingly that Catra cried out in real pain. Her bounds went slack, but Catra didn't run. She stared, frozen, as Adora rose to her tiptoes. A hacking breath exited Catra. All she could do was watch Adora kiss Shadow Weaver. The blow came like a punch to the gut, taking all the wind out of her.

Unable to resist, both hurting Catra and having Adora, Shadow Weaver returned the kiss. Softly at first and then possessively.

Adora's hand trailed down Shadow Weaver's face and, not tearing her mouth away, it dropped behind her back, shooing Catra towards the exit. The blood in Catra's veins had stopped cold in her veins. How could Adora expect her to move? She couldn't tear her eyes away from the horror in front of her. Her heart shattered and the pain it left in her chest was unbearable.

Shadow Weaver's hands slipped under Adora's shirt, the pain intensified. Adora motioned her away with more urgency. When Shadow Weaver moved to kiss Adora's neck, Adora's eyes snapped open and she met Catra's. She smiled with as much love as she could muster and mouthed, "Please." That hurt the worst of all.

Adora turned away and Catra's body moved on its own. Before she left, she heard Adora's shirt hit the ground. Once she exited the chamber, she threw up.

Catra slumped down in a chair, heart racing as she hyperventilated uncontrollably. Her mind was foggy and the floor looked like it was tilted to the side. Before she knew what was happening she was gasping, wheezing for air. Visceral pain pounded through her chest every time her heart beat. It felt like it was going to explode. Or maybe that it already had and blood was pouring out, clogging her lungs. She felt like she was going to die. Gripping the bottom of her chair, Catra tried to tell herself to breathe, but she couldn't. The air was too thick and she couldn't even see with the tears obscuring her vision. She told herself to wipe them away, but she couldn't move. Her hands felt stuck. Everything felt stuck.

Then, she fell off her chair and painfully sucked in air that did not bring her oxygen. Part of her mind told her to get it together, she had to do something. The other part, the part that was in control, told her she was weak. That she let Shadow Weaver hurt Adora again. That it was her fault. That she couldn't breathe and that she was dying. Trying to sit up, her lungs burned and her skin clung to her clothes with sweat. Her hair fell damply against her forehead and her body burned.

In the background, a knock came on her door, but Catra didn't hear it. She kept trying to find air but, even though she knew somewhere that she was surrounded by it, she lacked access to it. Like she no longer deserved to breathe it. The knock sounded louder, more frantic before someone burst into the room.

"Catra!" Scorpia said, concern written across all her features. "Hey, hey, it's okay," she softened, kneeling down and regrouping instantly. She looked Catra in the eye and said, "Just breathe with

me okay? In and out." Scorpia took deep breaths in silence, waiting patiently as Catra's chest rose and fell with more ease. It took a long time for Catra's eyes to even find hers. Scorpia wanted to help her sit up, wanted to hug her, but she knew better than to touch Catra right now. Instead, she focused on taking long breaths that Catra could follow, even if her mind was elsewhere..

"It's okay Catra. Look it's me, Scorpia. And you're in your room." Scorpia looked around, "You're on the ground and," she took another deep breath, "you're safe here right now."

Catra shook her head, processing the words slowly. Her breaths started to quicken again, but Scorpia held an even tone.

"Hey, you're doing great. Let's focus on that breath again, just watch me, okay?" Scorpia offered. Catra nodded, swallowing hard.

Scorpia was more cautious this time when Catra's breathing slowed. "What do you need, Wildcat? I'm here for you. You're doing great."

Catra fully focused on Scorpia, chest still haggard and trembling. She wiped her hair back out of her face and mouth. Trying to get the tears out of her eyes, she ran the back of her hand against her face. There was snot and tears everywhere.

Scorpia offered her a handkerchief, "I got you. Use this."

Catra took it and rubbed her face hard, wanting to remove the guilt she felt too. It was sensitive and raw, but she was coming back to her senses.

"What do you need, Catra?" Scorpia asked again, still keeping her pincers to herself and lowering her voice to keep Catra from jumping.

"The disc," Catra choked out. "Did you find it?"

Scorpia was surprised by the question, but recovered quickly. “We found it.” She smiled proudly. “Entrapta is a wizard at finding stuff when she wants to. Crazy considering how disorganized she is.”

“Do you have it?” Catra asked, sitting up and moving closer to Scorpia than she usually did, putting their faces close together.

“Um,” Scorpia said, blushing, “no.”

Catra let out a frustrated grunt and started tearing at her hair.

This time, Scorpia grabbed her hands, gently bringing them down and then releasing immediately, holding on long enough only to stop Catra from hurting herself. “We know where it is, but it’s heavily protected. Look, I think we could get in there but,” she said, “we’re going to need help.”

Catra fell back against the wall, exhausted. “Scorpia, we have to free Adora. We can’t, I can’t . . .” Tears came again. Several times, Catra tried to finish her sentence but sobs overtook her until she was bawling into her hands. She managed to stutter out, “I’m a monster. I did this to her.”

This was a side of Catra Scorpia had never seen. Normally, Catra was so strong. Scorpia steadied herself, it was her turn to be there for Catra. This is what she was made to do. Breaking out a prisoner was not what she had in mind, but, so be it. Adora meant so much to Catra, even if Catra didn’t see it. Scorpia smiled sadly. “Then we’ll free her.”

Catra paused, chest still rising and falling erratically.

“Catra,” Scorpia said, “I’m with you. We’ll get her out. All you can do is make this right now, okay?”

“Why are you doing this?” Catra asked, throwing her hands out in front of her. “I’m a terrible friend, Scorpia. I am not good to you. Why are you helping me?”

Scorpia contemplated her answers. “I care about you,” she paused, “and I know you care about me too, even if you don’t always show it. You’re having a hard time, but a lot has happened. We’re friends, Catra. Friends help each other.”

“I used to be Adora’s friend,” Catra said, slumping in defeat, “look where that got her.”

“Your friendship will get her back out again,” Scorpia smiled.

“I fucked up, Scorpia. Right now she . . . " Catra swallowed and searched Scorpia’s eyes. “I don’t know. Shadow Weaver is-”

“-You can tell me, if you want,” Scorpia said before Catra could fall back into her panic attack, “no judgment. I’m with you, Catra.”

“She’s raping Adora, Scorpia,” Catra said thickly. “She’s doing it right now.”

Scorpia’s eyes blew wide with shock. “I mean, oh my god, what?”

“It’s been happening since we were kids. I mean, I” Catra looked at her shamefully, “I didn’t know until recently. But, I . . . Scorpia! I brought her here! It’s my fault. Everything is my fault.”

Catra’s hands fisted and she smacked them hard into the ground beneath her. Scorpia’s mouth still hung open in shock, but her concern for Catra kicked into overdrive. “Then we’ll save her, okay? And Catra?”

“What?” Catra asked, embarrassed.

“It’s not your fault,” Scorpia said, turning stern.

“What do you mean? Of course it’s my fault!” Catra screamed.

“It’s not your fault,” Scorpia repeated, calmly. “This is Shadow Weaver’s fault. No one makes her do what she’s doing to Adora. Sorry Wildcat, this one’s on her.”

“But I,” Catra said, “it’s-”

“-It’s not your fault, it will never be your fault. Take control of the things in your power,” Scorpia said. “We will get her out of here. It will be hard, but Adora needs you right now. Catra, you. No one else. But,” Scorpia blushed, “you’ll have me too, okay?”

“What if I can’t do it?” Catra asked grimly.

“We’ll do it together,” Scorpia promised. “You, me, and Entrapta. Super Pal Trio, you know? We stick together.” More nervously, Scorpia asked, “Catra?”

Catra wiped her nose again, sniffling into Scorpia’s handkerchief. “What?”

“I just,” Scorpia floundered, “I know the guilt is eating away at you, but you can’t let it consume you. You have to work through this. You can’t let Shadow Weaver use it against you.”

Staying silent, Catra pondered the words. “You’re,” Catra glanced up, “you’re right.”

Scorpia batted a pincer her way. “It’s nothing.”

“I should listen to you more,” Catra conceded.

“I won’t argue with that.”

Catra smiled very slightly before she lunged forward and hugged Scorpia around the neck. “You were right, you are a really good friend.”

Scorpia’s heart warmed and she hugged back. “So are you, Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

> This was the first chapter I cried writing. Friends you trust are everything, ya'll.

Thank you for all of your feedback. It honestly is so wonderful to read all of your comments. When I first started posting chapters to this story, I was really afraid about negative feedback and almost didn't release this at all. As someone who has also been sexually assaulted and is finally dealing with it, this story has been very therapeutic. Hearing that some of you share that sentiment is really amazing. On top of that, hearing from anyone enjoying the story makes me fucking amped. It helps remind me that it doesn't have to be perfect to be good and it stops me from the cycle I normally find myself in: endlessly revising and then giving up because I can't think of the perfect word or make something sound right. Sometimes, it's just about getting it down on the page.

Now that I know how to use it, I occasionally post updates about where I am in the writing process on tumblr.

Also, what? Catra has allies? I did Scorpia dirty in the beginning, but I'm trying to make up for it now. And fuck I love Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio. They needed more story in the show.

Insurrection

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Groggy from poor sleep, Catra turned over. She pulled the thin sheet covering her off and struggled to her feet. With every throb of her heart, a sharp pain struck deep in her bones, threatening to break her. Every time she closed her eyes, she saw Adora with Shadow Weaver wrapped around her, the image burned into her eyelids.

Catra wondered about Adora now, wondering if she was forced to sleep next to Shadow Weaver last night. Wondering if she was waking up now, Shadow Weaver still holding on to her with a death grip. The thought made her tremble. Back when they were cadets, Adora would come back from her so-called lessons with Shadow Weaver trembling and quiet. Catra would open her arms and Adora would fall into them. Catra wished she could do that now. Instead, her bed was quiet and cold. Yesterday, Catra left Adora to face her demons alone.

Trailing her fingers across her night clothes, Catra took them off and stared down at her body. When she pressed down on her skin, it bent around her fingers and turned white, the same color as the scars crisscrossing her back and arms. There had been so many times in her life where she lost control. Either someone would take it, like Shadow Weaver, or Catra let it slip away with no one to blame but herself. Naked, she flexed her hand, claws drawing out. Adora had always been there to pull her out again.

Sighing, Catra pulled her clothes on, feeling more secure as her uniform covered up her vulnerabilities. She rubbed the taunt, thin skin under her eyes, removing the last bit of sleep sticking there stubbornly. Releasing her face, Catra stared at the wall, pensive.

Scorpia had been there through it all yesterday as Catra trudged through menial work like a zombie. Scorpia quietly corrected Catra's mistakes, changing numbers on her paperwork and yelling orders to the troops Catra should have overseen. No one questioned it. Scorpia was, after all, a Force Captain. The only person who seemed to forget that was Catra.

It was surprising. Catra thought she'd find it annoying, but Scorpia was smart. It didn't feel so much like pity when she took Catra's shoulder to steady her. Or when she'd repeat the same question to Catra twice when she had missed it the first time. When lights out came, Catra was about to swallow her pride and beg for Scorpia to stay, but, Scorpia intervening, posed the question instead. Somehow, she even had the ability to look shy as she asked, *"Can I stay a little longer? I could use a little more time with, you know, a friend, to unwind after a hard day."*

Catra had only needed to nod. Scorpia sighed with relief and pulled up Catra's chair, getting more comfortable. She listened to Catra cry and yell and snap at her while showing nothing but patience in return. So many times, Catra wondered why she didn't walk away.

When Catra didn't want to talk, Scorpia would ramble about growing up in the Fright Zone. About how it was her family's kingdom and they had gifted it to Hordak. Catra knew this, but had never really listened before. In return, Scorpia let Catra talk about Adora.

At first, it started with Catra bringing up the events of the morning, but she ended up red-faced and breathing hard until Scorpia could change the subject. Then, it bloomed into something more. Scorpia had asked an innocent question, but it cascaded Catra into a series of stories about her and Adora's friendship. She talked about how they grew up together. Anything and everything about the trouble they got each other in and out of. How they always had each other's backs. Scorpia was a great listener, nodding and laughing at all the right moments, encouraging Catra to smile.

At one point, Scorpia even said, *"You two have something really special."*

Catra blushed, but nodded, trying to move past the fuzzy feeling blooming in her chest as she agreed. Even if Adora left, it didn't matter anymore. Adora saved Catra again.

Catra stretched her back. Today, she would return the favor, no matter the cost.

Eventually, Scorpia snuck back to her own quarters, whispering that Catra should get some rest. Catra didn't. She spent her time dreaming that Adora was there with her, bolstered by the memories of Adora close at hand. That Shadow Weaver was gone. That this was all behind them. Catra didn't have to pretend that she hated Adora anymore. She could show Adora she loved her instead. Maybe she could even say it out loud this time.

As the night went on, the thoughts turned darker. She thought about Adora shivering under Shadow Weaver's touch. How Adora must be awake too. So close, yet Catra couldn't reach her.

Catra clipped her Force Captain pin to her breast. It was time to go. Exiting her room, she felt her nerves building. They built and built until they hit a climax outside the Black Garnet chamber. Her ears flickered in the direction of the door, but she was met with a dead metallic sound. Her duty to escort She-ra to battle had been reassigned.

The orders came last night. Hordak put a request for Catra to see him out for deployment. It had started the entire cycle of Catra's anger and pain all over again. Catra knew Shadow Weaver was behind it. Even worse, Octavia would be handling Adora from now on. The thought made her skin itch. Octavia had never gotten along with Catra, but Adora she had a special contempt for. Like many people, Octavia was jealous of Adora. Unlike most, however, Octavia was her trainer.

Shadow Weaver and Octavia blamed Catra's feral nature for the injury that resulted in Octavia losing an eye. It was a favorite of Shadow Weaver's, to say Catra was inherently bad, unfixable. Octavia took up the lie eagerly, going so far to claim martyrdom for mentoring Catra when no one else would dare.

The truth of Octavia's eye was a much different story. It started when she shoved Adora into a locker. Adora was already exhausted when the blow came, as Octavia had made her run one set of extra drills, and her body fell like a ragdoll against the unyielding metal. Catra had been nearby, waiting for Adora like she always did, as she watched it happen. When Adora cried out, Catra's eyes narrowed into slits.

Adora bared her teeth, like Catra taught her, but otherwise remained silent. Adora wouldn't snitch and she wouldn't strike back. After all, hitting a superior officer was against the rules. Adora took the hit with her chin up. And she took the next one when Octavia slapped her across the face. When Adora didn't shrink away, Octavia grunted and raised her hand to strike again, but the blow never fell.

Octavia's eye did.

Catra earned what seemed like endless punishment for that, but she didn't care. She'd do it again. Adora came clean about the whole thing to Shadow Weaver and the punishment let up after that. Octavia was moved to a different unit after that.

Now, Octavia was back, in control of Adora again. If Adora got hurt, Catra wouldn't hesitate to take out Octavia's other eye.

To ease her tension, Scorpia volunteered to watch over them both. It would annoy Octavia, but Scorpia outranked her. Catra didn't like not being there herself, but Scorpia had assured her if they wanted to keep Adora safe, this was the easiest way to do it. Catra didn't trust anyone else with Adora, but conceded when she lacked a logical argument.

Last night, Catra and Scorpia had reviewed all the details of today. Catra was determined to take a chance to free Adora if they could. Scorpia was determined to help Catra.

And so, Catra stepped past the chamber, though every piece of her body pulled her back. Her tail swished out behind her as she kept walking. Catra wanted to promise herself that yesterday would be the last time Shadow Weaver would ever even see Adora again. Exhaling and straightening her uniform, Catra knocked on the door to the throne room. Automatically, it opened, free of the creak that possessed all other doors in the Fright Zone.

"Good morning, Force Captain Catra," Hordak said, standing in the middle of the room with his hands clasped behind his back. He stood tall, glittering with metallic armor. Standing above her, he looked menacing, but Hordak didn't scare Catra under normal circumstances. It was what he was going to do today that did. "You have brought the piece?" he asked.

"Yes," Catra said. Hordak narrowed his eyes. "Yes, *Lord Hordak,*" Catra edited. She fumbled with the remote in her hands, thinking about smashing it right in front of him, but she did not. Entrapta could make another. In fact, she'd probably made countless other models that were sitting in a box forgotten amongst many other forgotten boxes.

Smirking, Hordak relaxed his posture. "Ah, yes. The power of She-ra will soon be mine." Raising in fist in front of his face, his forearm muscles flexed, the idea of Adora under his personal control intoxicating him. Walking to her proudly, he opened his palm.

Biting her lip, Catra let the device slide out of her hand and into his. It felt like betrayal. She thought of Adora's eyes pleading with her, begging to not force her transformation. And here Catra was, giving someone else that power.

"Entrapta has briefed me on its use, but please," he smiled, this time showing his teeth, "tell me how it feels."

Hordak wanted to know about how it felt to be flooded with the power of the strongest of Etheria's magical users. The thought of answering that question made Catra sick. She focused on the practical, voice falling into well practiced scorn. "You order She-ra to do something and she does it. Pretty simple, Hordak."

"Hmm, I suppose." Hordak lifted his eyebrow and took his chin in his hand. "I look forward to what more she can do in my hands."

Catra let her eyes slide away from his, lowering her ears. Hordak thought too highly of himself. She always thought it would be his downfall.

"Shall we?" Catra asked sarcastically, motioning to the door.

"It will be my pleasure to crush the Rebellion," he said, striding past her with unbreakable confidence.

They walked in silence. Her body was so locked up with emotions that Catra barely felt anything in Hordak's presence. There used to be fear, awe, and, lately, resentment. Now, he was just another threat. Another thing to cause Adora pain.

They entered the transport that housed Adora. Catra breathed deeply, smelling rough disinfectant, oil, and body odor. She frowned when she was unable to detect Adora's scent. Adora never smelled like any of those things, even her sweat was sweeter. Octavia saluted them, looking rumpled and distressed. Scorpia stood behind her, very closely behind her, and smiled at Catra playfully. Catra quirked an eyebrow at her. Scorpia shrugged.

"The prisoner is secured," Octavia heaved, apparently under great effort.

"Very good, dismissed," Hordak said, shooing her away with a flick of his fingers.

The transport started to move. Catra swallowed. Scorpia nodded her head.

“Hordak, hey,” Scorpia said. Hordak looked around in search of the person that Scorpia must be addressing. No underling would speak to him without permission. But, he found no one else in the room. He shifted with agitation, but Scorpia didn’t give him time to bark an order. Catra started to slip away as she heard Scorpia gush, “It is such an honor to be fighting alongside you today. Oh my gosh, you cannot believe how excited we are, well, especially me. Longtime fan of your work.”

Catra’s lip tugged up. Slinking down the hall, she opened the door that held Adora. Silently, she entered and cringed. Adora hung limply by her wrists, her head dangling toward the floor.

“Hey Adora,” Catra said, soft and warm.

Adora groaned and lifted her head. The breakfast Catra forced down this morning threatened to come up again when she saw bruising alongside Adora’s neck. It was a different type than what had been there the week before. The size and shape was smaller. This was no blunt injury. These were marks of ownership. Guts wrenching, Catra pulled herself away, meeting Adora’s eyes.

For a moment, Adora stared blankly. Then, her pupils settled on Catra’s, who waited, careful not to spook her. “Hey,” Adora croaked. Her voice was hoarse and several notes deeper than normal. Weakly, she smiled. “You came.”

Closing her eyes briefly, Catra took a deep breath and told herself Adora didn’t want or need her guilt, not right now.

“Of course, I came,” Catra said, moving slowly up to Adora. “But, I don’t have a lot of time.”

Adora tried to stand on her feet, but, when she pulled herself up with her shoulders, her body shook violently and gave out.

Catra reached out to steady her, but stopped. “Can I?” she asked.

Nodding slowly, Adora consented. Catra slipped her hands under Adora’s arms, taking her weight. Adora’s skin was cold and she

trembled all over. More carefully than before, Adora pulled herself up, with Catra's assistance, and got her feet under her.

"I'm good," Adora said, blushing. Catra dropped her arms. "Catra I," Adora turned her head away, "I'm sorry about yesterday. None of that, what Shadow Weaver said . . . it-"

"-Why are you apologizing to me?" Catra hissed, throwing her hands in front of her. Adora reacted as if she was hit. "No, I," Catra swallowed, recalling some of her intensity, "I mean, you didn't do anything to me." Catra smiled, "Except save my life from that bitch again."

Adora frowned, starting to lose focus again.

"Hey, hey," Catra said. "You're here. You're away from her."

"And onto something worse." Adora's face scrunched up.

"Nothing has happened yet. Don't beat yourself up about it already," Catra said.

Adora shook her head. "I don't know what I'll do if I hurt anyone today. What if I kill someone, Catra? I can't do this. I can't."

"I won't let you." Catra smiled.

Looking deeply into Catra, Adora lost her next words. "You can't."

"Jeez, Adora, how strong do you think you are?" Catra's smile widened. "I can handle it. I've got this."

Sighing, Adora lost some of her intensity. As it left her, she started to droop again.

"Hey, I've got you." Slowly, giving time for Adora to pull back, Catra reached out and rested her hands on either side of Adora's face. Her tail slipped around Adora's shin.

Adora relaxed and let out a ghost of a smile. “It’s good to see you. I’m glad you're okay.”

When Adora leaned into her, Catra skated her thumb down Adora’s cheek. “I’m going to get you out of here.” Pausing she added, “I promise.”

Emotion turned through Adora. One of Catra’s hand slid down to Adora’s shoulder, letting the moment pass.

“You have to come with me,” Adora said, voice cracking as she rested her forehead against Catra’s.

Catra felt heat rise in her face. Licking her lips, she started to respond, but the door behind her slid open and her mouth closed. Catra jerked her hands away from Adora, who jumped, grinding flesh into metal.

“Ah, Catra, there you are,” Hordak said, entering the room.

Catra took a step back from Adora. Even increasing their distance by a step felt like abandonment. “The prisoner is ready.”

“Yes, the mighty She-ra,” Hordak mused. “How the tables have turned.” He addressed Adora, “I saved you as an infant child, then you became my biggest adversary. And now,” he smiled, showing off blood red teeth, “you are my greatest weapon.”

Seconds ago, Adora’s face had been open and vulnerable. Now, it hardened, tight and angry. “You can’t win,” she said, staring him down. With taunt, pale skin and dark bags under her eyes, Adora was not, on her own, intimidating. But, in her, danger lurked. It was enough to make Hordak visibly think twice. He let out a huff of annoyance, looking away to cover what, Catra thought, was uncertainty. Nothing had made him falter all day, yet this half-broken prisoner in chains scared him.

Catra’s tail lashed out, wondering how she never saw Adora’s strength for what it truly was, relentless. Even now, she wouldn’t stop fighting. She might have started to give up on herself, but

she would keep fighting until there was nothing left for everyone else.

"You will ensure that I do," Hordak said. "We will be arriving soon and, while I've been informed that you will remember nothing, I will make a memorable story to recount later." He moved closer, glaring down at Adora in challenge. "Today, we make those princesses suffer. And soon, Etheria will be mine."

Adora's muscles flexed beneath her clothes. She had lost weight, yes, but Adora still packed tightly coiled muscle. Wirier now than she had ever been, the definition showed through her clothes.

"Catra, transform her," Hordak ordered, turning his back.

Catra's own muscles seized up in response. She thought he would want to do this. Classic Hordak not wanting to do any of the dirty work. The sword rested within a cabinet in the room, fetched by some unlucky soldier this morning. She wished she could shatter it right there, unsure that was even possible.

Exhaustion overcame Adora again and her legs gave out, making her fall heavy against her chains overhead. The metal cut into her wrists, but Adora didn't flinch as fresh blood oozed from her wounds.

Catra held the sword in two hands. One circled the hilt and the other held the blade. If only Scorpia and Entrapta had gotten the disc. She could give Adora control of She-ra, who might be strong enough to break them both out. But that was not the case. Catra wouldn't have as much control over what happened the rest of the day, but she was hoping to find a way. Scorpia, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle were all on standby.

Now, Catra swallowed a dry lump in her throat.

"Come on Catra," Hordak said. "We are just about to arrive."

"I promise," Catra mouthed. Adora nodded curtly before shutting her eyes. Catra unlocked Adora's handcuffs, catching her as she

fell, no longer bolted to the wall. Hordak wouldn't question the care Catra was taking. He was barely paying attention, too lost in his daydream of owning the planet. Catra hugged Adora briefly. When Adora hugged back, Catra almost lost her resolve. Grasping Catra's forearm, Adora pulled back and stood, finding strength from a depth Catra knew only Adora had within her.

For the first time since her capture, Adora set her jaw, reached out, and took the sword willingly. Catra's tail wrapped around her wrist as the sword hit Adora's hands. They looked into each other's eyes as Adora's sanity faded to red.

Adora's face shifted from loving to grotesque over a series of long seconds. Not ugly, but twisted into the monster that Catra had come to hate. She-ra in this form felt like the embodiment of all the anger that Catra had built up her whole life and put into Adora.

"Fascinating," Hordak said, pushing past Catra to take a closer look. He examined She-ra's body, touching the red veins that wrapped around her arm, like she was a science experiment, not a person. Just like Adora said, her body was never her own.

Testing the device, Hordak made She-ra walk around the room several times, telling her to start, stop, fight. He laughed in delight. Catra stayed tight-lipped, but the pain in her gut worsened. She had done this to Adora. Just like Shadow Weaver. Just like Hordak.

Like a child with a new toy, Hordak perked up and asked, "Shall we?"

Catra managed a shallow nod before leaving the room, She-ra and Hordak closely behind.

“You cannot come today!” Glimmer shouted. “That doesn’t even make sense, Bow!”

“I’m coming,” Bow said. “I can’t fight, but you need someone on the ground who can help keep everyone organized while you’re busy.”

“I vote, Bow stays,” Mermista said. “If nothing else, he can keep you in line,” she pointed at Glimmer.

“I don’t think anyone asked you!” Glimmer said, steaming.

“Well then, you’re like,” Mermista flipped her hair, “welcome, I guess.” Bow grinned and high-fived Mermista with the hand on his still healing arm.

“So, it’s settled, I’m back on the job!” Bow pumped his fist into the air.

Glimmer crossed her arms. “You can’t be serious.”

“Come on Glimmer, I need to be out there with all of you. I can’t, you know, fight, but I can do other stuff. Plus,” he said squealing, “who else is going to test this baby?” He held up his tracker pad, which had some sort of device attached to it. A disrupter, he had called it.

“We’ll be stronger all together,” Perfuma said. Unlike Bow, her healing had been remarkably quick. Her magical body responded well to Castaspella’s sorceress powers while Bow’s body had to mend his shattered bones all on its own. Her hair was docked short, but she placed flowers in it all the same. Glimmer was certain there was trauma in Perfuma somewhere, but she did not show it. Perhaps the yoga and meditation really did do something.

“Don’t get a mushy about it,” Mermista said.

“He comes,” Frosta said. “As much as I want to agree with you on this, Glimmer, we need a nerd.”

“I am the perfect nerd!” Bow sang, eyes gleaming.

“See,” Frosta said.

“I, for one, am incredibly glad,” Seahawk said, wiggling his mustache, “to have the boys back together again!” Seahawk and Bow fist pumped.

“This is serious,” Glimmer said. “We’re going into a battle, maybe the one with the highest stakes we’ve ever faced.”

“Glimmer, lighten up. If you don’t watch it, you’re going to die young or, like,” Mermista gawked, “go gray.”

“I’m with Mermista on this one,” Perfuma took Glimmer’s shoulder. “There’s a lot of pressure on this battle. We all feel it. But we have each other to rely on. You don’t have to do this alone.”

“We’re a team,” Bow said. “And I do have something to contribute.” He shook the tracker pad in the air in front of Glimmer’s face.

“The grandest team in all of Etheria,” Sea Hawk struck a pose, hand pointing out in the air. “Why, who can stop us?”

“Fine!” Glimmer said. “But if you get hurt again, I swear to GOD,” Glimmer grabbed Bow by the crop top, “I will kill you myself.”

Mermista and Frosta looked at each other, then burst out laughing. Subtler, Perfuma hid her face behind her hand and giggled, saying, “You two are very sweet together.”

Bow and Glimmer turned red. Bow with an embarrassed smile, Glimmer with unhinged rage.

Bow fiddled with the bits sticking out of his tracker pad, avoiding the suggestive smirks of everyone else. Glancing at the clock, he said, “I think it’s about time.”

A collective deep breath was taken. Glimmer wished she could transport them all to the battlefield so they could get there sooner, but that would take her magic out and she needed it on reserve. At the moment, glowing with power after recharging at the Moonstone, she felt unstoppable, but history told her better. She still had too many limitations on her power. Not to mention that she was their last resort. If she went down, everyone else would be trapped.

That was the part no one else understood. Bow and Perfuma had gotten hurt, but didn't die. Why? Because of Glimmer. It was an immense weight on her shoulders. Every time they went to fight, she had to be ready. If she was too slow, there would be consequences. What if there were two people hurt and she had to pick one? What if there were three? What if she had a chance to get Adora but sacrifice someone else? All those decisions had to be made in a split second. What if she made the wrong choice?

Bow pulled her into a hug. "You're incredible, you know that?"

Glimmer tried to smile, but it was weighed down too heavily with her surging anxieties.

"Hey," Bow said tenderly as everyone else prepared to leave. "You've got this. We've got this. We all know the risks we're taking. It isn't all on you, okay?"

"Bow, what if we lose? If the Horde takes the battle today they will have an open door to Bright Moon."

"The Horde attacked Bright Moon once and we survived," he said, smiling.

"We had She-ra then. Now they have her." Glimmer hid her face in Bow's chest.

He tucked her head under his chin, pulling Glimmer closer. "We didn't use to. And we didn't use to have these people," he motioned at the alliance. "We can do this. You can do this. There's no one I trust more."

Glimmer pushed on him so that she could look him in the eyes. “I want to win.”

“Then let’s go win,” he said, leading her to catch up with the others.

Even though Glimmer asked every two minutes what time it was, they did eventually make it. Their last stronghold on the edge of the woods. There had been Horde activity here for weeks, but now it was the only thing stopping them from marching on Bright Moon again, this time with far more firepower.

Rebel scouts had been keeping an eye out, not to mention reports from Spinnerella and Netossa, who were stationed at the camp. Today was the day the Horde would be making its assault.

So, when they arrived at the encampment, all of their own soldiers stood at the ready. Now, it was the princesses turn to find their way to the front lines. Mermista and Frosta prepared together, while Perfuma set snares to catch the first wave of soldiers. Eventually, Netossa and Spinnerella caught up with them, both taking care to tweak each soldier’s position carefully. They knew the area and how to best defend it. Glimmer acquiesced. They would handle the Horde. Glimmer and Bow were to handle She-ra.

Twirling her hair in her fingers, she tried to think of something she could do. She was the Rebellion Commander, why did it seem like everyone else was working but her? She was to conserve her magic, as per usual these last few battles. Her gift might have been strong, but it was so much more limited than the other princesses. Even Bow, who couldn’t fight, seemed to have more to do than she did.

Wringing her hands, she simply stood in front of the team and waited as the Horde marched closer.

Catra was on the ground. Relinquishing her control of She-ra to Hordak had been one of the many internal battles she fought today. Thankfully, Hordak felt she was better suited to fight. It meant Catra could keep an eye on She-ra, who marched next to her like a wild dog about to be let off leash. None of the warmth Adora gave off emanated from She-ra now. It made Catra jumpy, afraid of the monster consuming Adora for good.

The infected veins sprouting from the sword's runestone were so thick. Ever since the first time, it tethered itself to She-ra so tightly that sword and arm were fused as one. Without the remote, Catra couldn't tell She-ra to drop the sword, so she was hoping that someone could knock her out. Scorpia had done it once before, Catra only prayed they could find a way to do it again, even under She-ra's god-like reflexes and Hordak's watchful eye.

Scorpia flanked She-ra on the other side. She kept shooting glances at Catra, trying to make sure she was okay, but Catra was not and there wasn't anything Scorpia could do about it. Catra would never be okay, not until Adora was safe.

The Horde stopped. Across from them, the Rebellion sat with their back to the woods. Their weapons, their magic, was ready. Catra was relieved. They never tried to play around, but the Rebellion was not disciplined, not like the Horde. Losing a slew of battles had certainly prepared them to take necessary precautions as they chose to do now. Even without Adora's leadership, they had grown. Bow and Perfuma were present. Catra sighed, they were okay. Adora hadn't killed anyone. Catra hadn't killed anyone. Maybe Adora could forgive her for that.

Catra shook her head, as the quiet before the storm lingered. This wasn't about Catra's redemption, it was about saving Adora's life.

They pressed on, and, when close enough, the Horde's army came to a halt. Before the first strike, there was always a moment

of silence. Who would attack first? Who would fall? The air became thick with tension. Glimmer made eye contact with Catra across the expanse. Catra wished Glimmer could read minds.

Before Catra had even extended her claws, She-ra took off sprinting ahead of the Horde's first wave, breaking the silence and fueling the yells of war to erupt on either side. Catra's wide eyes met Scorpia's before they took off after her. Fast. She was so fast. Catra thought back again to the times she had fought She-ra. Numerous battles where Catra had come out nearly unscathed. Then there was the one time she fought infected She-ra and, if Scorpia had not interfered, Catra might not have made it. Catra never pulled her punches, but Adora must have. Now, Adora didn't have that choice and was going up against the people she would die to protect. Catra ran faster still.

She-ra tore through the center of the Rebel's ranks, ripping apart plants, slashing at ice, and never losing speed. A wave of water hit Catra and she stumbled back. Growling, she got up and resumed her chase.

The rest of the Horde forces started falling in step. Magic met firepower as the Rebellion and the Horde clashed.

Catra ears flicked, hearing the exact voice she was looking for. "Bow!" Glimmer yelled, "Now!"

Bow smashed a retrofitted button on his tracker pad and waited. She-ra continued to charge. "It's not working! I think I need to get closer."

"I can do that," Glimmer said, using a precious teleport to transport them. They faded and then appeared again right in front of Catra.

"Sparkles! What are you doing!?" Catra screamed, gasping in surprise.

"Catra! What are you doing!?" Glimmer yelled back, eyes scanning Catra's head. "What? Where's the remote!"

Glimmer dropped Bow and grabbed Catra. “I’m not in charge anymore,” Catra said. “It’s a long story, okay, but I want to get Adora out. You were right.” Catra’s face fell. “You were right about everything.”

“You’re going to help us?” Glimmer asked, grip loosening.

“Yes, but we need to hurry. You have to get Adora out of here.” Catra tugged, pulling away.

“We’re trying!” Glimmer yelled. “That’s what we’ve been trying to do literally this entire time if you haven’t noticed!”

“Hi Catra,” Bow waved in the background.

“Um,” Catra said, waving back awkwardly.

“Listen, where is the remote? Bow and I just need to get close. We have a way to shut it down,” Glimmer said.

“You what?” Catra said. “Are you serious?”

“Are you deaf or just dumb?” Glimmer groaned, throwing her hands in the air.

Growling, Catra said, “You aren’t making this easy, Sparkles.” Snorting, she shook out her annoyance and said, “I want to help.”

Bow squeezed Glimmer’s hand. “Then tell us where to go,” he said.

“Hordak is here,” Catra replied. Bow and Glimmer both bit their tongues, stifling fear and shock. “Teleport behind those tanks. He’s in the second wave. He’ll be up top. We’re too close to see him from here, but if you move back he’ll be in sight,” Catra pointed.

“If you’re lying, I will never forgive you,” Glimmer said. She glanced over her shoulder. She-ra was bound by Perfuma, who

was sweating, short hair already clinging to her neck, and yelling to Netossa for backup.

“I’ll keep an eye on them,” Catra said.

“Why should I trust you?” Glimmer asked, darkly.

“You don’t really have a choice, do you?” Catra hissed. “Hurry up!”

“Glimmer, it will be okay,” Bow reassured.

With one more stern look, Glimmer and Bow blinked away.

Catra didn’t have time to spare as a scream sounded behind her. Perfuma was starting to cave under the pressure of facing She-ra one on one. Perfuma was as strong as she was going to get here, a Princess of Power with control over the flora with the Whispering Woods at her back. It was likely the reason she had taken the job to hold off She-ra, binding her tightly with one vine after the next, trying to capture her feet and immobilize her. But, Perfuma did not have endless energy and her strength started to wane. She-ra only looked hungrier as she cut through roots and plants as if they were made of nothing.

Perfuma called for backup again, “Netossa! I know you’re busy but I’m really starting to lose my inner calm!”

Further away, Netossa grunted, back to back with Spinnerella, as they were surrounded by their own insurmountable force. “I’m working on it!” she yelled back, throwing a net to encase a nearby Horde bot.

The platoon made Perfuma their mark. As they snuck closer she said, “No you don’t!” Whipping a hand towards them, she was able to knock them back, but with her attention divided, She-ra pressed forward.

“Catra! They’re singling them out, just like, well, how you taught them.” Scorpia said, averting her eyes.

“We have to stop them,” Catra said, eyes scanning the battlefield for a solution. Off to the right, Mermista and Frosta were smashing artillery, banging up robots, and knocking soldiers down in practiced synchronization. With them, Sea Hawk kept an eye on their back. Catra could hear his voice from here yelling out “Left, right! One behind you, my dear Mermista!” Mermista rolled her eyes, but it was the perfect team.

Catra pointed at them, “Send them over there.”

“Don’t you think they will,” Scorpia grimaced, “know something is up?”

“They’re soldiers, they do what they're told. Come on Scorpia!” Catra pleaded.

Scorpia issued the order and, as Catra said, they complied without another thought, freeing up Perfuma to focus fully on She-ra, but it wasn’t enough.

Catra ran, shouting, “You’ve got this Scorpia!” as she ran to the front line.

Nearly colliding with the troops pressuring Netossa and Spinnerella, Catra commanded, “Move! Military right. Platoon 1124 needs you, now.”

For a second, the troops paused, but they moved towards Mermista and Frosta. Catra hoped she wasn’t putting too much pressure on them, but they were the biggest team right now. She only prayed they would continue working well as the number of soldiers and robots attacking them doubled.

Spinnerella raised an eyebrow at her. Netossa scowled.

“Don’t you have somewhere to be?” Catra sneered as she backed away, looking for the next fire she could put out. Distantly, Catra knew how much she was sweating, but she didn’t have time for that.

“You got it, Force Captain,” Netossa yelled.

Bow and Glimmer appeared in the middle of a flurry. An entire company of soldiers and bots were running, sounding like a stampede as they sped past. Some soldiers didn’t even see them as they appeared, but those who did, jumped back in surprise, knocking into the troops behind them. When they realized there was a princess among them, many gave a wide berth, moving around them, uneasy about facing a princess head on after all the nighttime horror stories they’d heard from the Horde.

One brave soldier whipped out their stun baton and faced them. Glimmer charged her fists, purple light surrounding them. Bow stood behind her, ready to let her take this one, but watching her back. Then, the soldier ripped off his helmet, looked past Glimmer and said, “Bow?”

Glimmer’s fists dropped a little as she moved from ready to brawl to confused. Bow’s eyes went wide. “Kyle?” Bow’s voice squeaked, “Is that you?”

Kyle laughed. “Yeah! Long time no see.” He waved awkwardly.

“You could say that,” Bow grinned, looking away. “Listen, we’re kinda busy right now?”

“Oh, yeah, that um,” Kyle said, letting his weapon dangle to his side, still fully charged, “that makes sense.”

Another soldier punched Kyle in the arm. Without taking off her helmet, Lonnie urgently whispered, “We can cover you, but can you at least act like we’re fighting?” She punched Kyle again, “Kyle watch it!”

Kyle nearly knocked himself out as he spun away from her, but managed to only crack his stun baton against a nearby rock, sending the weapon jolting from his hand.

Lonnie groaned, “What do you need?”

Glimmer watched the whole thing utterly confused. Why, today of all days, were people deciding to be helpful? Was this some sort of trick?

Bow, on the other hand, was nothing but trusting. “Where’s Hordak?”

A third soldier joined the group and slashed at Glimmer. She jumped back reflexively, but it came nowhere near hitting her.

“He’s with us,” Lonnie said.

The soldier who was waving his weapon around was motioning at something. Glimmer thought it was just bad acting but then her eyes snapped up and there was Hordak, eyes fixed far ahead of him on She-ra.

“Thank you so much!” Bow said, practically squeaking with delight. “Here, take this!” Bow threw a small device to Kyle, who fumbled it before pocketing it.

“What is it?” Kyle asked.

“Just in case we need you.” Bow tapped his ear and then Glimmer grabbed his hand again, poofing away before any other questions could be asked. Kyle shrugged and pocketed it.

“Put that helmet back on Kyle!” Lonnie yelled. “I’m not gonna be responsible if you break that fragile skull of yours.”

Above them, Bow and Glimmer teleported to the observation deck.

“Bow now!” Glimmer shouted.

“What is this!?” Hordak yelled, spinning around at the new voices. His cape billowed behind him and his angry eyes burned into Glimmer real fear. Soldiers all around them gaped in shock, but at Hordak’s grumbling, started to descend on them. Wasting no time, Bow clicked the button down on his She-ra remote shutter downer device.

Glimmer looked expectantly up. “Is it supposed to, like, spark or something?”

“Um, I mean, I don’t know Glimmer!” Bow shook the pad, looking for a sign. “I haven’t been able to test it before!”

“We need to go!” Glimmer said, reaching out again for Bow’s hand. Their fingertips almost touched when a force swept Glimmer off her feet. Hordak grabbed her around the throat. Lifting her with ease, Glimmer wondered what powered him, machine or flesh. When his grip tightened, white light flashed behind her eyes. She scrabbled at his hands, only thinking now about how she couldn’t breathe.

“How dare you?” Hordak spat his words, clamping down harder on Glimmer’s delicate windpipe. “You think you can defeat me? You dare face me head on?”

Bow reached out. “Glimmer!”

Hordak roared. “I will show you what a mistake you’ve made. You have made this too easy for me.”

Bow touched Glimmer’s back and ordered, “Teleport now!”

Glimmer didn’t need to think to do what her lifetime best friend asked, her trust in him was reflexive. The three of them teleported.

They landed hard, back at the front line. Hordak, unaccustomed to the nauseating dissociation and sudden reordering of his atoms, fell when he tried to stand. Glimmer wrenched her body away at his loosened grip, backing up and gasping for air as she

reached for Bow. Holding on to her biceps, Bow scrambled, pulling them both backwards.

Glimmer was choking. Her body tried to make up for oxygen depleted, but internally she was screaming at herself to focus. The world was blurry through her tears and rapid heartbeat. Bow, untouched, only felt dread wash over him as Hordak got to his feet, aggravation etched into every crease in his face. His eyes went wide and a grating noise ripped through him.

Hordak's fists balled as he stepped towards them, chest rising and falling with anger the same way Glimmer's was as she reached for air. Bow stood up and in front of her. "Don't touch her," he threatened.

Taken aback, Hordak laughed, dry and crazed. "As you wish," he said.

With Perfuma and Netossa finally connected, She-ra was making slower progress, but the Horde was still closing in, the other princesses having to fall back as the pressure mounted. Catra ground her teeth together, preparing herself to enter the fight.

Then, She-ra's head snapped around and her grin cut across her face like a slash. She ripped through another net and then took off running away from the woods.

Perfuma dropped her hands, too exhausted to question the break. Netossa put a hand on her shoulder. After a few intentional deep breaths, Perfuma looked up and locked in on Bow, She-ra still between them. A swell of energy overcame her, a second wind, as adrenaline told her they were in trouble. Perfuma tried to catch them, but the Horde knocked her back. She was scraping by, trying to reach them, but she would never be fast enough. Perfuma looked at Catra instead, begging.

Catra didn't need to be asked, she followed She-ra.

She-ra stopped on a dime on Hordak's right. He smiled down at Bow, who looked up at She-ra and pleaded, "Adora, it's us! It's

okay. We're going to get you out of this."

"Bow?" Glimmer choked out. Only panting now, Glimmer got her feet and frowned when she considered She-ra's red eyes.

"What's going on?" Catra asked, sidling up next to Hordak.

"We were . . . it was supposed to break the remote." Bow looked down. Catra shot Bow a glance, but he cast his eyes down, shaking his head sadly. "It didn't work!" Bow grabbed his head with his hands. "Glimmer, it didn't work!"

"Oh?" Hordak loomed over them as they fell backwards another step. "You'll find that your She-ra is still very much in my control." Hordak looked at She-ra, who trembled under the strain of holding still. "Allow me to demonstrate."

A shiver worked its way down Catra's spine as She-ra raised her sword. The tip glinted dangerously at Bow's heart.

"Don't let me hurt anyone today." Adora's voice rang through Catra.

A horrible, deep, plunging fear sunk its way into Catra's heart. Icy and hard, knocking her back. She had to protect them. She promised Adora. "You have to go!" she screamed at Glimmer.

Hordak turned on his heel, "Catra, what did you say?"

"I," she stuttered. "We should capture them. They can give us-"

"-Silence!" Hordak yelled. He grabbed Catra by the shoulders and threw her to the ground. "Do not get in my way again. I am in charge here, Force Captain. You will stay in your place."

Catra opened her mouth to argue, but She-ra started to descend on Bow. Popping off the ground, Catra moved back into the fray, ignoring her dirty clothes and throbbing skin where Hordak had touched her.

She-ra raised her sword directly over Bow's head. It shone brightly in the sun as it started to descend.

Glimmer reached out to teleport Bow. But, She-ra pivoted. Instead of slashing down, she pushed Bow aside with her left hand. From the ground, Bow looked up in shock and started to scream.

"Glimmer!" Bow and Catra yelled in unison.

In slow motion, Glimmer's eyes blew wide open, freezing in place as her mind, still recovering from choking, lagged.

Catra's world shifted. The noise of Bow's screaming died in her ears. It was replaced with the slow, drumming sound of blood pumping through her veins and her own shaky breath. Her vision narrowed. The Horde. The Rebellion. She-ra. Adora. It all collapsed on itself into this singular moment. There wasn't time to think, only move. Move.

Only after she was thrown to the ground, kicking up a cloud of dust as she smashed into the dirt on her back, did Catra realize she had done anything at all. A ringing blast through her ears as she tried to focus through bleary eyes.

Glimmer gasped and yelled Catra's name, the shrill noise cutting through the buzz. It was all Catra needed to know. When she had jumped on She-ra's back and pulled back She-ra's twisted sword arm, it had been enough. Glimmer had survived. Now, Catra was staring up at the sky, the brightness of it searing painfully into her skull.

The next noise she could filter out was someone was screaming, but not in fear. This was deep and angry. Stumbling, Catra moved to her feet, nearly falling back over when she found her balance off kilter.

Hordak pointed at her, cheeks flushed red with anger. Then, he did opt to say his command to She-ra out loud, "Seize her!"

Mind still fuzzy, Catra didn't move fast enough for a healthy, enraged She-ra, who grabbed her around the neck with one arm, dangling her above the ground.

"Shit," Catra tried to say.

"Catra!" Bow yelled, reaching towards her as if he could pull her away.

Then, everything went from pause to fast forward. A tidal wave crashed over the troops all around them. Before it washed away, the water cracked, turning to ice. It froze the soldiers' feet, stopping them dead in their tracks. Tanks were speared by dark, tangled roots. Those who did manage to evacuate were thrown in the air in a cyclone, only to come crashing down encased in a magical net, uncuttable by a standard issue knife.

Hordak's hair fell into his face as he lost composure, growling with bared teeth and then yelling at the Horde to fall back.

A vehicle sped towards them. Catra started to go limp, ears still ringing.

"No!" Glimmer said, teleporting behind She-ra, trying to grab hold of her. But Hordak was on her in an instant, smacking her away dutifully as he and She-ra jumped inside the transport and slammed the door closed, Catra with them.

"What just happened?" Glimmer asked, clutching her heart.

"I think," Bow stood, unmoving, "Catra just saved us."

They both stared, watching as the Horde machinery left a trail of heavy dust in their wake. Single soldiers still dotted the field, running back and disengaging with their Rebellion counterparts as the Horde made their exit. Others chopped at their feet with their stun batons, freeing themselves and each other as they ran.

"Woohoo!" someone said behind them. The voice was young and gritty as it rang out again. "Did you see that!"

“Frosta?” Glimmer asked, shaken.

“You distracted She-ra and Hordak and that gave us an opening,” Frosta said, a faint glow still shimmering on her skin. “Mermista and I crushed.”

Perfuma cleared her throat and smiled.

“You did well too, flower girl. Heck,” Mermista said smiling, patting Perfuma on the back, “you took the hardest job.” The bunch were breathing heavy, dirty and tired, but smiling.

Bow took Glimmer’s hands as she started to shake. Glimmer’s face was red and splotchy. They both contorted into looks of pain.

Mermista raised an eyebrow. “So,” she frowned, “what happened to you?”

“I think our best chance at saving Adora just fell through our hands,” Glimmer said, shaking her head.

“How dare you!” Hordak roared. Catra’s ears flattened, both in response to the noise and the fear it put in her heart. “I made you what you are. We were on the verge of greatness and then you saved the Queen’s daughter.” Hordak slammed his fist into the wall, leaving a dent near Catra’s head. “You have failed me.”

Hordak screamed, letting out a cry loud from his diaphragm as he pounded the wall again. The noise ricocheted in Catra’s head, increasing the buzzing until it physically pained her. The lights were blinding and she shut her eyes to them, feeling like she was in the middle of a storm, unable to keep her senses straight.

Two guards shackled Catra into the manacles meant for Adora. Being shorter, Catra’s feet barely grazed the ground. She-ra still

held her up, smiling like a maniac. If only it was Adora here instead, everything would be okay.

Catra almost laughed at the absurdity of it. Her place in the Horde really was so tenuous. She was expendable to them. She had finally done the right thing at the wrong time and it was like the years she had spent here were nothing.

“I’m not sure what I’ll do with you yet,” Hordak said, running his hand through his hair, pushing strands out of his face. He smiled devilishly, burning white-hot with malice, “but perhaps I’ll leave that up to your mentor.”

That was all it took to start Catra shaking. Hordak might have been a fool, but Shadow Weaver knew how to hit her where it hurt. She looked at She-ra again, wishing Adora could just wake up. If Catra had only gotten Adora out. Now both of them were doomed. She hung her head, wanting to weep, but she didn’t have enough air in her lungs to let out a sound.

Fixing his cape, Hordak studied her. He sighed and straightened. “Your days are numbered. This is the end for you, Force Captain.” He spit the last words. “And, mark my words, this war will end soon enough without you.”

With a flare of his nostrils, the sword dropped from She-ra’s hands. The guards made no move to catch her as she fell, even as Adora’s slack body hit the ground.

“What are you doing!?” Catra screamed at them. “Pick her up!” she snapped. The volume of her voice reverberated painfully in her head, but she didn’t care.

And, even though she was chained to the wall, the two soldiers complied, conditioned to fear their Force Captain’s commands. They picked an unconscious Adora off the ground, and bound her hands. When Catra didn’t like how they touched her, she hissed and the soldiers' clumsy hands would become a little softer. They propped Adora up against the wall, her hands tied behind her

back to a column, and left before Catra's wrath held them any longer.

Huffing, Catra looked around the room. Her chest rose and fell quickly, waiting for the next interruption, but nothing came. They were alone. Taking a deep breath, Catra slammed the back of her hands against the wall and kicked it with exasperation. She couldn't even reach out and touch Adora, let alone save her from what was coming next. Between the hopelessness of her circumstance and the inability to focus through the fuzziness of her concussion, Catra fell against her bonds, completely at a loss of what to do next.

The ringing in Catra's head was back. "Fuck!" she screamed, standing on her tiptoes and staring at the only thing that mattered to her in the world, on the ground lifeless in front of her. Banging her head against the wall, Catra cried out again.

Hours passed. Catra's shoulders flared in pain as her body hung from the wall. Adora had come in and out of consciousness several times, but had always been too groggy to do anything but blink, look around, and slump down again. Catra waited for each of those moments, drinking them in greedily.

This time, when Adora's eyes opened, they stayed that way.

"Adora?" Catra strained, blinking through the fog.

"Catra?" Adora tried to move her hands, but found them tied. "Where are we?"

"How do you feel?" Catra asked.

"Fine, just-" Adora shook her head and faced Catra. Her eyes widened in shock. "Why are you chained up? Catra! What happened?" As easily as sleep came to her before, now panic shook through Adora, who tried and failed to get to her feet as the knots held. Adora retched, nearly vomiting as she took in her surroundings.

“Are we past your dumb phase?” Catra asked, flashing a smile that turned into a grimace when Adora didn’t smile back.

“I’m, yeah,” Adora said, looking around, “but we’re still in the I can’t remember what’s going on phase and the,” Adora swallowed thickly, “nauseous phase.”

“Hordak,” Catra choked, the burning in her shoulders spreading to her lungs, “the battle.”

Adora’s eyes moved back and forth like she was reading, trying to remember. “Yeah and . . . that has happened?”

“It’s over,” Catra said.

Adora’s face split into unease. She leaned back and asked, “So why are you up there and I’m down here?” Adora fought to stay calm, but fear started to take her. Her pupils dilated and she waited for a response.

“I,” Catra felt tears sting at her eyes, “I’m sorry, Adora.” Catra looked down. Each tear pattered on the ground lightly.

“What happened?” Adora dropped her voice in attempts to soothe Catra, despite Adora’s own harsh fear.

Catra squeezed her eyes shut, “She-ra, I mean Hordak, tried to kill Glimmer.”

Adora gasped, pulse thudding to a stop.

“But he didn’t!” Catra said quickly, licking her cracked lips. “She’s okay. They’re all okay. The Rebels won.”

Adora let out a sigh of relief, but the comfort didn’t last long. She furrowed her eyebrows as sweat started to dribble off her chin. “Then why are you apologizing and why are you chained to the wall?”

“I,” Catra swallowed, “got in the way. I stopped She-ra. I’m sorry, Adora, okay? I’m sorry!” Shuddering against the wall until the shackles clanged together, Catra wept.

“You can’t,” Adora strained against her bonds, “no.” She looked up at Catra dumbly. “You saved her?”

“I just got in the way, okay? And Hordak saw and now,” Catra shook violently, “I don’t know if I can get you out of here.” Catra’s breath hitched.

“You saved her.” A new wave of dread crashed over Adora and her voice cracked as she asked, “What are they going to do to you?”

“I don’t know, Adora,” Catra said quietly, sagging into the wall.

“This is my fault,” Adora said, glancing away. “I can’t believe this.” Adora hung her head. “We’ll figure this out, Catra. I can help. I can-”

“-No,” Catra said solemnly, stifling her tears.

Adora’s eyes darted back and forth in the room, looking for a solution that wasn’t there.

“Look at me, Adora,” Adora did. The look of determination in Adora’s eyes made Catra grind her teeth. “Don’t do anything. Don’t you dare.”

“I’ll do whatever it takes to save you, Catra,” Adora said.

“I don’t want you to, okay!?” Catra said. “I know you think you can, but you can’t keep doing this. Shadow Weaver is killing you. You’re losing yourself. You don’t have an endless supply to give away.”

Adora huffed and set her jaw. “What’s the point of anything I’ve gone through if I lose you in the process?”

Angry, sad, confused tears kept dripping from Catra's eyes. She opened her mouth, simultaneously wanting to scream at and hug Adora, but she never got the chance.

A group of soldiers came in and started to unsnap Catra from the wall. "Adora!" she cried.

"Catra!" Adora screamed back, loose hair falling on her face as she grunted, straining against the ties that bound her with every muscle at her disposal. Nothing gave. When she started to scream, the Horde soldier pushed her head back, holding her against the column she was stuck to. Strands of hair littered Adora's face as she cried, "Catra! Catra!"

Manacles tightened down on Catra's wrists and feet. She twisted her head to keep Adora in her view as long as she could. "Adora! Adora, please! Don't listen to her!" Catra said before a gag was stuffed in her mouth. She screamed against it but couldn't say the words she wished she could before never seeing Adora again. Squirming, Catra caught one more glance before being pushed out the door. She saw Adora screaming, terror in her eyes.

Catra was pushed forward by the soldiers, still trying to turn around and see Adora again. Then, a cold voice cut through her shock.

"Goodbye, Catra," Shadow Weaver said, materializing out of the shadows.

Catra screamed against the gag, but Shadow Weaver didn't even spare a glance behind as she entered the room Adora was still in. A hard shove to her back forced Catra forward.

Chapter End Notes

I debated ending on a cliffhanger for an hour. Ultimately, decided to do it because? I can?

Comments are encouraging and after the last bunch I really was excited to crank this out fast (for me). I've got the next

one started but it probably won't be released until the first Tuesday in January.

Thanks for reading!

tumblr

Hinge Point

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Catra!" Adora shouted. Her voice broke from a scream into a sob. Wet hair clung to her face, cemented against her by a mixture of tears and sweat. Teardrops mixed with dust and dropped off her chin to the floor as she pulled helplessly at her bonds. Opposite her, Catra fought against weapons and hands pushing her out the door to look at Adora one last time. At first, Adora could see all of Catra's features, holding tightly to each freckle, but then, Catra started to fall away. Adora could only see her eyes, then one single golden eye, and, then, nothing at all.

When the door clicked shut, Adora stared at it wide-eyed. In between wheezy sobs, she pulled more fitfully against the ropes. Every muscle contracted painfully, her body fighting against what her mind could not accept. Catra was gone.

"Adora, you will calm yourself," Shadow Weaver said, stepping between Adora and the door. "This is unbecoming of the Horde."

Shadow Weaver eclipsed Adora's view, a black figure swirling darkness around them. When she spoke, Adora couldn't comprehend. All she knew was that Catra had been here, had defied the Horde for Adora's sake, and was going to pay the price.

Over and over in their lifetimes, Adora and Catra had survived. They'd survived the life of a child soldier, coming out damaged but with a burning flame of humanity, preserved by their friendship. They'd survived beatings and bullying and torture. So many late nights they'd held each other, whispering words of love in a world that surrounded them in hatred. Later still, they had even survived wounds inflicted on each other. Even when they had fought, Adora never imagined it would come to this.

Adora whined. For a minute, she let herself believe there was a solution. Catra was so strong and finally she and Adora were on the same team again. They had always been unstoppable together. Their rekindled relationship was Adora's last lifeline. It was the only reason she still felt anything like herself. Everything else she had given away. Catra was all she had left in the world. The only thing she couldn't give up. Yet now, she was forced to. And it was her fault. Adora should have never let her selfish desires get in the way.

Quivering, Adora whispered, "Catra, I'm sorry."

Her heart slammed against her ribcage. It surprised Adora that her heart could even beat at all when her chest felt so empty. Snot leaked out of her nose and the tears, falling hot before, now slid in a continuous, steady stream down her face.

"Adora," Shadow Weaver commanded, "pull yourself together." Clasping her hands in front of her, Shadow Weaver shook her head. "You are a mess. You will need to clean yourself up immediately upon our return to the Black Garnet Chamber."

Closing her eyes, Adora shook out uneven breaths. Her insides turned with nausea from the infected transformation, from Catra being taken from her, and from her own guilt. But, Shadow Weaver was here now and Adora needed to ready herself for a fight, even if all she wanted to do was disappear. Setting her jaw, Adora let out a long exhale, closed her eyes, and stymied the tears. Her chest rose and fell, ragged breaths loud in lingering silence. Shadow Weaver was absolutely radiating power, but that sparking, red energy was never what scared Adora.

Curling her lip up, Adora showed her teeth. "Let her go," Adora growled.

Shadow Weaver stepped forward and pulled Adora's chin up to face her. "There's nothing I can do and you know it. Catra brought this upon herself."

“Find a way,” Adora commanded. “You’re good at that.” Wrenching herself away from Shadow Weaver’s grasp, Adora stared up, an angry magic of her own clashing against Shadow Weaver’s in defiance.

“Her time is done,” Shadow Weaver said, lifting her hands. Adora flinched as the ropes holding her unfurled, dropping lifeless to the floor.

The skin of Adora’s wrists had been badly chafed and were bleeding freely. Still, Adora reached back, smearing blood on the pillar behind her as she used it to push herself up to her feet. By the time she stood, her panting had doubled. Her legs shook, but she refused to let her knees buckle.

Pushing against the column, Adora took a step forward, sliding her feet across the floor. Her head pounded and her body ached, but she burned fuel from deep within her. She moved until she was close enough to touch Shadow Weaver. But, she did not reach out. Her hands balled into fists at her sides, a small trickle of blood running down one of her knuckles.

“Bring her back, now,” Adora said, eyes burning bright blue.

“Adora, Adora,” Shadow Weaver said, shaking her head. “She saved the Princess of Bright Moon right in front of Lord Hordak.” Shadow Weaver dusted Adora’s shoulder off before gripping it tightly. Pain spiked into Adora, but she stood tall.

“You can find a way,” Adora said as she brushed Shadow Weaver’s hand away.

Unconcerned, Shadow Weaver joined her hands together her again. “Come now, Adora. You are an intelligent girl. Catra is lazy, insubordinate, tactless. Only you ever saw her worthwhile. And that I have never understood.” Shadow Weaver shook her head. “Perhaps had you stayed, led her, she would still be here. Still nipping at your heels for affection, pining after you for love, but alive. Maybe even happy.”

“How dare you talk about her like that,” Adora said, raising her hands.

“Don’t blame me,” Shadow Weaver said, “when you know this is all your fault.”

“This is not my fault,” Adora yelled. Shadow Weaver merely stared at her, as if she could hear the quickening of Adora’s heart.

“You don’t really believe that, do you?” Shadow Weaver asked in a harsh whisper, catching Adora by the elbow.

Angry she couldn’t control it, Adora started to tremble. She could feel it first in the twitching of the features on her face, and then down into her hands, fists uncurling as they shook. Because, Shadow Weaver was right. If Adora hadn’t asked Catra to protect the rebels this wouldn’t have happened. If Adora hadn’t lost control of She-ra, this wouldn’t have happened. Not for the first time, Adora knew the sword had chosen the wrong person.

“Oh, Adora,” Shadow Weaver tsked, “Don’t dwell on it. Princess Glimmer lives. Isn’t that what you wanted? This is for the best. Catra was a distraction. With her out of the way, you will finally realize your true potential.”

Adora jerked herself out of Shadow Weaver’s grip with a feral snarl. She channeled the memory of Catra defying Shadow Weaver. She had always made it look so easy, even though Adora knew she had been terrified. “What do you mean ‘out of the way’?”

Shadow Weaver brushed away strands of Adora’s hair from her face. Emotionless she said, “Catra will not bother you any longer. Ever again.”

Paralyzed, Adora grasped at the fabric over her heart, as the implications of Shadow Weaver’s words resonated in her. They were going to kill Catra. Adora had experienced pain. Her whole life had taught her to be a fighter. She had taken hits from blunt staffs and fists, she’d been shocked, hypothermic, concussed,

sleep deprived. Beyond the physical, she'd been tortured, abused, and manipulated. But, none of it matched the pain that ripped through her soul at losing Catra. It was a hot, jagged, ugly feeling that bolted up her spine and made the color drain from her face.

Watching her, Shadow Weaver said, "Adora, I have protected her as long as I could. You know there is nothing I could do."

At her words, Adora yelled, "That isn't true! He'll listen to you. Have her reassigned. Imprisoned even. She'll work herself back up. She'll-"

"-Adora," Shadow Weaver said, digging her nails in. "She is gone."

Adora staggered back. "No." Louder she yelled, "No! Please. I'll do whatever you want. Just let her go."

"Stop being childish, Adora." Shadow Weaver seized Adora's shoulders. "You're going to do whatever I want either way. Face it, Adora, you are nothing without me. You made a mistake today and it cost you. What else will you lose before this is over?"

"That isn't true," Adora said, shaking. She tried to cling to Catra's words and not listen to Shadow Weaver, but her resolve crumbled as Catra's presence faded.

"Oh?" Shadow Weaver gripped Adora's chin in her hand. Adora tried to shake her off, but Shadow Weaver dug her nails into Adora's skin, forcing her to look into Shadow Weaver's eyes. "Adora, take up your old job. You'll be more help to the rebels. Imagine your influence when they finally surrender. How many more innocent lives can be spared? I can get you there. All you need do is follow my direction."

Shadow Weaver dropped her grip. Grinding her teeth together, Adora looked away.

"Hordak will rule Etheria one way or another. You and I will finally find our place at the top and, perhaps then, you can do some

good for the world. Isn't that what you want? Is peace not She-ra's destiny?"

"This is not the price for peace," Adora spat.

Shaking her head, Shadow Weaver gave Adora a pitying look. "You really do have so much to still learn."

Swallowing, Adora found her mouth dry. If Catra died, so did Adora's hope. Not just her hope in escaping this place, but any hope of happiness after the war. For a moment she had thought they may even have a chance to be friends again, away from the Horde. Catra would have come with her this time, Adora knew it. They could have lived together again at Bright Moon or in the woods. They could have healed together. Maybe they could have even done some of the things they were never allowed under Shadow Weaver's watch.

Fresh tears pricked at her eyes again. Crashing over her were the small moments her and Catra had recently. Their hug in Adora's cell, desperate and fiercely warm, the gentle caress of Catra's fingers, even her sharp claws docile and loving, against Adora's skin, and the promises that had come out of both their lips. There was no one else in this world for Adora. Tears fell again. She had never been strong enough to protect Catra, even when she gave everything she had. Adora would never be enough.

"I will never forgive you for this," Adora whispered, finally turning her head up towards Shadow Weaver again, letting the tears fall. Shadow Weaver thought signs of emotion showed weakness, but Adora found strength in her tears, strength from Catra.

"You might not forgive me, but you will eventually thank me. You will take your rightful place as Force Captain, Adora," Shadow Weaver said coldly.

Adora stared into Shadow Weaver's eyes with unbridled rage, "I won't."

Refusing to acknowledge her, Shadow Weaver turned her back, ushering Adora to follow. Anger crumpled into defeat as black tendrils pressed at Adora's ankles, the back of her head, and, soon, all along her back, leaving icy despair wherever they touched.

Unclenching her muscles, Adora slumped, following Shadow Weaver off the transport and back to the Fright Zone, feeling weaker and weaker with every step.

Three stun batons surrounded Catra, one on her left, one to her right, and one between her shoulder blades. The weapons were so close to her skin she could swear the electricity crackling between their prongs made her hair stand on end. Adora wasn't here to save her anymore. And, even worse, Shadow Weaver was with Adora right now. This couldn't be how this went. This wasn't right.

Catra replayed the day. Hordak's rage. Catra's hands on Adora's face. Glimmer and Bow's shock. Adora's smile. Shadow Weaver's farewell. Adora screaming her name. Adora asking Catra to come with her. Catra almost accepting this time.

Tears pricked at her eyes. Would that be the last time she saw Adora's face? Her worst nightmares had not prepared her for this. In them, Adora had beat her in the war or forgotten her or hated her. Catra thought now she would take any of that if Adora was safe. Not this. Adora was too strong and too good to be broken, but Catra feared that even Adora had her limits. Limits that were being pushed more every passing moment.

Adora did not have a future any more than Catra did now. In a way, they had always been doomed. Someone pulling them apart, pushing them down. The Horde does not give, it only takes away.

Catra had taken too. She took Adora's freedom. Catra's death would solidify that choice. Adora would never be free.

Catra's bottom lip twitched. She had made so many decisions to get herself here. She had always been possessive of Adora, ever since they were kids. Shadow Weaver was right about that. Still, when Adora had reached out her hand and asked her to join the Rebellion, Catra knocked it away. The hatred she'd felt for Adora in those moments was childish. Catra knew now she never hated Adora, only herself. Now, all she wished for was that she could take Adora's hand, hold it, and never let go.

The soldiers stayed silent as they made their way down the hall that was used to transfer prisoners of war to their cells, Catra eventually complying as she became silenced by the weight of her failure. This was the only ending she had imagined for herself anyway. Guilt ridden and alone, condemned by her own spiraling actions.

Instead of proceeding forward as they should, they took a hard left. That didn't make sense. Catra stopped in her tracks, only to be nudged forward by abrasive hands. She made muffled signs of protest, but they pulled and pushed her from all sides. This hallway was dark, every other light burnt out or broken. A trickle of sweat slid down the back of her neck.

One of the soldiers sighed, sick of her incoherent babble, and removed her gag.

"Where are you going?" Catra demanded, voice raspy. Were they going to execute her right now? She swallowed. This was too soon. She had hoped she'd at least find a way to help Adora before she died. How could that have been their last goodbye? She hadn't even told Adora that she-

"-Shhh, can you just be quiet?"

Catra's next question stayed lodged in her throat. Her tail lashed violently behind her, smacking into the person behind her. She

knew that voice.

“I think the coast is clear.” Lonnie slipped off her helmet. Rogelio and Kyle unmasked too.

“What are you doing?” Catra barked, ears flattening.

“I told you she wouldn’t say thank you,” Lonnie said. “You owe me your lunch, Kyle.”

“Aw, man,” Kyle said. Rogelio slapped his face with a gloved hand.

Catra looked at them one by one. It was as if she had been abandoned in the dark, groping around hopelessly, and someone had merely flicked on a light switch to illuminate her path. Her mind felt too slow to keep up.

“Does someone want to tell me what’s going on?” Catra asked urgently, shifting foot to foot as her fear turned into agitation.

“We’re saving your ass,” Lonnie said, crossing her arms. “And I will never, ever let you live it down.”

Catra normally would have said something by now, but she just stared. Lonnie gave her an uneasy look until Catra let out a halfhearted hiss and asked, “And how are you going to do that exactly?”

“The Rebels have agreed to help us,” Kyle said, looking at the ground. His skin was waxy and pale. Lonnie didn’t look much better.

“Who!?” Catra said, spinning towards him. Rogelio started to remove the cuffs that held Catra’s hands and feet. When they released, she threw her hands up in the air and began to pace, tail bristled and lashing.

“Um, the Rebels,” Kyle said, shaking his head.

Lonnie crossed her arms. “Yeah and they’re waiting to receive you right now, so instead of doing all of this,” she motioned at Catra, whose eye twitched, “we need to get going. Like, right now.”

Rogelio grunted in agreement and grabbed Catra by the shoulders to steady her, physically and mentally. Catra’s hands dug through her hair as she tried to shake off the dreadful feeling that she was going to die today.

“Adora thinks I’m in trouble,” Catra said, mouth going dry.

“Well, good. Because we know our girl can’t keep a secret to save her life,” Lonnie pointed. “And this might save her life.”

Catra frowned, tight lipped. Adora was not going to be okay. “Why didn’t you get her out instead? Isn’t that what we discussed?”

“Um, hello,” Lonnie knocked on Catra’s head, who jumped back startled, “Shadow Weaver was like right there! We just about lost it coming to get you. Kyle nearly gave us away like 72 times. Thought he was going to slip in his own sweat.”

“She’s not,” Catra closed her eyes, still trying to get control of her senses, “She isn’t safe.” Rogelio patted her shoulder and let out a sound of reassurance. His large hands were warm against her prickling skin.

“We know that,” Kyle said, smiling sadly. “We’re going to stay here and do what we can, okay? But we need to go right now. You can get the rebels and help them save her. Contact us if you need us. We’ll be ready.”

Catra contemplated this while Rogelio led her forward. Trying hard, Catra shook the image of Adora screaming her name in restraints behind. Survive. She could still get Adora out of here. Nothing else mattered. Catra stopped and glanced behind her. All she saw was a dark, empty hallway of the only home she’d ever known. If she didn’t hurry, she didn’t know if there would be much left of Adora to save. “I’ll be back, I promise.”

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio exchanged a look before Lonnie cleared her throat. “Can you listen for a second?”

Catra swiveled back around with a clearer head. “Yeah, whose plan is this? What’s going on? And has Kyle fucked it up already?”

They all smiled. “Actually, it was Kyle’s idea and you can thank him for somehow making the whole thing happen,” Lonnie said.

“That feels extremely suspicious coming from you,” Catra said, narrowing her eyes.

“Look,” Kyle said, blushing, “We ran into Bow back on the battlefield and he gave me this,” Kyle tapped his ear. Inside, barely visible, was some sort of device that fit into his ear canal.

“A communicator?” Catra asked. “He gave that to you? Does he even know who you are?”

Rogelio puffed out his chest and grunted. Catra frowned at him and nearly rolled her eyes.

“We’ve, um,” Kyle shifted his weight. “We’ve met. When he was a prisoner here, I was in charge of delivering his food.”

Catra rubbed the bridge of her nose. “Are you serious?”

“Maybe after this is all done we can laugh about the details, okay?” Lonnie said, pulling Catra forward. The dim lights in the hallway began to flicker. “But, right now, we’ve really got to go.”

Nodding in unison, they walked down the hallway briskly, exiting a rusted door that only Rogelio had the strength to pry open. Slinking across the wall, they made it to where vegetation started to grow. All around the Fright Zone, the dirt produced nothing alive. The machine pumped poison into the ground, but between the Fright Zone and the Whispering woods, there was a transition into scraggly underbrush. They tread through it now until it gave way to the tall, thick trees of the Whispering Woods.

It was almost the same point which Catra and Adora had snuck out before She-ra's sword had come into their lives and ripped them apart. Now, it could be the same place that brought them back together.

Someone cleared their throat loudly in front of them, stepping out into a clearing. Instantly, Catra fell into a squat, claws out, tail poofed again after just having settled down. When she saw who stood in front of her, her muscles slackened.

"Hey Wildcat," Scorpia said softly. "Didn't mean to frighten you. That's why I, um, you know," Scorpia cleared her throat again.

"Scorpia?" Catra asked. "Why are you here?"

Scorpia ran the tip of her pincer through the hair on the back of her head. "I'm going with you." She smiled. "You don't have to do this alone."

"You don't have to do that," Catra said immediately. "I'll be fine."

"Of course, you will be," Scorpia said, smiling. "You're one of the most capable people I know. And I know I'd usually, you know, ask permission to come with, but, this time, I'm not going to ask. I'm going. Plus, I have the info you asked me for. About the disc."

Catra looked at her puzzled. There was zero reason that Scorpia had to do this. It was dangerous. Catra literally had no other option, but Scorpia was safe here. She had never expressed interest in deserting the Horde. "Why?"

"Plenty of time to talk about that later," Lonnie said, shoving Catra forward. "Right now, you have a *very* important place to be."

"Yeah, yeah," Catra said at a loss for words.

Rogelio pulled at the branches of a tree to reveal a dented and dirty skiff. "This was what we drove today. It was pretty badly damaged," Lonnie said, tucking her hand under her chin while inspecting the transport.

“I can see that,” Catra said, eyeing a particularly deep gash warily.

“We reported it as destroyed,” Kyle chimed in.

“Well, maybe it was destroyed,” Lonnie said, patting it softly. “But Rogelio managed to put it back together. It will,” Lonnie grimaced, “get you where you need to go anyway. But don’t push it.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Catra said, looking at Rogelio. He crossed his arms and glared at her.

“Bow and Glimmer are going to receive you. I’ve got the coordinates right here,” Kyle said, handing Catra a map.

“You drew me a map?” Catra gawked.

“We couldn’t give you a computer, the Horde would know.” he whined. “Maybe if Entrapta hadn’t upgraded our security systems we could still get away with being messy but,” he shrugged “you know how she is.”

“Look, it isn’t far from here, you can read, can’t you?” Lonnie asked, flicking the map with her hand impatiently.

Catra scowled at Lonnie. “Fine,” she said, gripping the map tightly as she hopped on the skiff.

Scorpia jumped up behind her. “Oh wow, Catra and Scorpia’s great adventure.” She hopped into a pose causing the skiff to groan under her weight shift. Rogelio hit his face with the palm of his hand. “Whoops, sorry!” Scorpia said, moving too quickly with her pincers and causing the skiff to whine again. “I will stay right here! Done moving!”

Glancing back towards the creaky, metal mess that was the Fright Zone, Catra took a deep breath. Adora was still in there. She was leaving Adora like Adora had left her. But Catra would come back. She would make good on her promise.

“Catra, it will be okay,” Kyle said. Rogelio kicked something hard and the skiff started to hum with the clinking sound of metal rattling in the engine.

Catra stared back at three of the people she had grown up with. She remembered all the times she’d pushed Lonnie, pranked Kyle, and messed with Rogelio, at least, until he grew to be four times her size. And she remembered how they had made her jealous when Adora became friends with them. Catra had hated them then, but now, she realized, they were something of a family. Catra couldn’t rescue Adora on her own, she needed them too. Leaving them behind suddenly became difficult.

“You need to go,” Lonnie commanded.

“Watch out for her,” Catra said as she brought the skiff off the ground.

“We’ve got your back,” Kyle said, giving an awkward thumbs up. Lonnie and Rogelio joined him, nerves starting to show the longer Catra lingered. Rogelio checked the time again and started to usher them back towards the door.

“Get out of here,” Lonnie whispered.

Taking a deep breath, Catra said, “Thanks,” she said as she started off into the woods, not bothering to look back again.

Flying low, Catra dodged through the trees wondering what could have been different if Adora had never stolen that skiff in the first place. Would they still have been pulled apart? Catra shook her head. Yes, they would have been. Catra had been selfish, that wouldn’t have changed if Adora stayed and became her Force Captain instead. Catra’s jealousy of Adora would have festered or Shadow Weaver would have eventually gotten rid of Catra.

Catra grunted. Shadow Weaver had failed. So many times she had tried to pull them apart, but they would find each other again. They always did.

Catra's mind sharpened. They had a real shot at saving Adora now. Catra didn't care about the risk. She had already risked it all earlier today, what was one more time? All the other feelings she had, the guilt for leaving Adora behind, the fear of leaving her home, were secondary. She was free and her one, singular goal propelled her.

Humming to herself, Scorpia stayed quiet as Catra drove the skiff, giving only directions when she needed. A million questions and stories popped up in her head, but she tied them down. Now was not the time. Once they settled into a rhythm, Scorpia did chance one thought, "I'm really glad you're okay, Catra. I was really scared of losing you today."

Scoffing, Catra looked at her toes. "Why? I've been a terrible friend to you."

Smiling, Scorpia patted Catra's shoulder. "Wildcat, you're one of my best friends in the whole world. I know you're not always," Scorpia raised her eyebrows and cocked her head, "in a good mood, but I care about you."

"Whatever," Catra said. She had never been good at feelings. Even with Adora sometimes Catra couldn't communicate what was in heart. Scorpia looked away. Catra swallowed dryly, "I mean, I care about you too, okay? I just, we have to . . . ."

"We will save her, Catra," Scorpia said confidently, brimming with tears at Catra's vulnerability. "You two are going to get your happy ending."

Catra blushed furiously, taking a left turn so quickly that Scorpia tumbled to the side. "I," Catra stuttered, "we just need to get her out of there. I don't care what else happens."

Nodding, Scorpia turned away, trying to give Catra some privacy. It had been a long day, and, Scorpia imagined, it was about to get longer. Scorpia would never wish these circumstances on anyone, but Catra was finally showing herself, her true self. It was a step

in the right direction. Scorpia knew it had been there the whole time and she was going to fight to protect Catra, that's what friends did.

The skiff started to sputter so Catra and Scorpia abandoned it before it could crash. On foot, they set off on the last mile of their journey.

"I didn't always like the woods," Scorpia said, inhaling the earthy dampness surrounding them. "But now, I think they're kind of charming, aren't they?"

"Like them? We were taught to be terrified of them," Catra laughed. "You must be the only Horde soldier alive who feels that way."

"Am not!" Scorpia said. "There are so many beautiful trees and flowers and oh! Look at that!" Scorpia pointed to a glowing, blue mushroom.

"You really are a princess, aren't you?" Catra asked as a joke, but Scorpia turned red.

"Do you really think so?" Scorpia asked. "Because, you know, I haven't, well, historically gotten along with the other princesses and I'm feeling a little nervous about meeting up with them. Do you think they'll like me?"

"We just abandoned the Horde and you're afraid some stupid princesses won't like you?" Catra shook her head.

"Hey now," Scorpia faked a frown, "they're a tough crowd."

"They'll love you. Anyone who gets to know you would," Catra said. Scorpia blushed again, forgetting to walk for a minute before jogging to catch up to Catra.

As they walked, the woods shifted. Previously dark and foreboding, the forest felt more welcoming than it ever had. Catra looked at the map again, tracing her fingers over Kyle's scrawling

lines. They should nearly be there. The light of day was starting to settle into the glowing light of Etherian nights.

A small crunch of leaf litter made Catra's ears twitch. "Scorpia, do you hear that?"

"Hear what?" Scorpia whispered loudly.

Catra shushed her and pointed her in the direction of the noise.

"Is she even going to show up?!" Glimmer yelled shrilly.

"Be patient, Glimmer. She has to escape from the Horde!" Bow said. "You know that it isn't easy! You've done it before."

Catra and Scorpia approached, stopping to watch Glimmer walk in circles, pulling at her hair and grunting every few seconds while Bow watched her with deep concern from his perch on an oblong rock.

"Hey Sparkles," Catra said, causing Glimmer to teleport in surprise. Bow got to his feet. Both were covered in dirt. Glimmer's hair had lost some of its usual spark, falling limp to her shoulders. One of Bow's shoulder pads was ripped off, exposing a bare shoulder. Between the two of them, they had plenty of bruises and scrapes to share, but around Glimmer's neck was a dark handprint.

Catra cringed involuntarily. This was going to be weird.

"Hey!" Scorpia broke out in a huge grin. "Oh boy, this is a little strange, isn't it?"

Catra rubbed her temples with both her hands. At least Scorpia was here to point out how awkward this was. "Scorpia came too."

Waving, Scorpia said, "I am so sorry about everything, you know, the war and kidnapping Adora and that one time we kidnapped both of you and, well, maybe we can talk about all that later." Catra grimaced. "But we're here now!"

Bow extended his arms, frazzled nerves dropping out of him as fatigue sunk in instead. He smiled generously anyway and said, “Catra! Scorpia! You made it! I’m so glad.”

“I can’t believe you trusted Kyle with my life,” Catra said, trying to calm her nerves.

“That was certainly a gamble,” Scorpia said, enthusiastic about joining the conversation. Her energy bounced off Bow’s, both smiling large in tandem. Catra should have known that Scorpia would love these bubbly princesses and that they’d love her back.

Glimmer glared at them. Catra narrowed her eyes back. Not everyone was as easy to impress as Bow.

“He came through, didn’t he?” Bow’s eyes glittered. “I am so proud of him! He really stuck his neck out for you. I hope you thanked him.”

“Yeah, whatever,” Catra said, examining her nails. The way Scorpia and Bow’s eyes were shining she wasn’t sure how much more of this she could handle.

Luckily, Catra was in good company. Glimmer growled. “As much as I love this, we really need to get going.” Glimmer had dark circles under her eyes. She was hungry and cold and tired. More than anything, she wanted to get home, recharge, and be ready to go get Adora. Bow somehow stayed optimistic, but with each passing day, Glimmer’s heart hurt a little more knowing some and imaging the rest of what Adora was going through.

Catra nodded. “Fine by me. Lead the way.”

Glimmer didn’t move. “You first.”

“I don’t know where I am, Sparkles. What do you think I’m going to do, stab you in the back? I would have taken you out already if I wanted to.” Catra snarled.

“Fine,” Glimmer said, but she still didn’t move.

Groaning, Catra moved beside her and, satisfied, Glimmer began to walk. Catra fell into silence, steaming as the tension between her and Glimmer grew. Meanwhile, Bow and Scorpia exchanged glances, feeling uncomfortable as the silence hit a tipping point.

Glimmer kept glancing at Catra, waiting for her to betray them. Catra kept doing the same to Glimmer.

"So," Bow said, "how was the escape?"

"Smooth enough," Catra said, unwilling to offer any additional information.

"Okay," Bow frowned. "That's good."

Bow looked at Scorpia for support, their fast friendship already growing. To fill the silence, Scorpia said, "Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle contacted me right away and I got the skiff ready. Well, Rogelio did most of the work. I stood guard though and then, bam, they showed up with Catra as planned."

"A skiff?" Glimmer yelped. "Where is that now?"

"Calm down, Sparkles," Catra growled. "It was a piece of junk. It broke down before we got here or, believe me, we wouldn't be walking."

"Are you luring us into some sort of trap?" Glimmer asked, pointing a finger in Catra's face.

"You're leading the way! How could I lure you into a trap?" Catra asked, face turning red. "I saved your life today. You could be a little bit more thankful."

"Glimmer," Bow said, "be nice."

Glimmer growled in response, stepping up to face Catra.

Catra puffed out her chest and met Glimmer's eye. "And I think you're the only one with teleportation powers. Couldn't you just

get us out of here right now?"

"Oh, wow," Scorpia said. Bow just put his hand on her pincer and shook his head.

"It doesn't work like that," Glimmer threw her hands up in the air with frustration. "I'm exhausted after today, okay? I don't have any magic left. You know how much it drains me. I think you exposed that flaw of mine before."

Catra's eyes went wide and she looked at the ground, grabbing one of her elbows. Glimmer looked away too, huffing and crossing her arms.

Bow looked between the them and sighed. These two were too much alike. "How's Adora?"

Catra furrowed her eyebrows. Her mind rushed back to Adora back at the Fright Zone while Catra walked free. "We need to hurry."

"We've been trying to get to her forever, you know?" Glimmer said, harshly, taking heavy steps as she continued without the others.

Bow put a hand on Catra's shoulder. She flinched away and took several steps from him. They could hate her if they wanted, but she had to admit that she needed them to save Adora. That's all that mattered. It didn't mean she had to be nice to them though. They were not her friends and they never would be.

Scorpia ushered Bow forward, but he was already on his way. "Thanks for saving us today," he said.

Catra growled. "It was for Adora."

"Still, you saved Glimmer and me and we really appreciate it. I know what that almost cost you." Bow smiled widely. It was uncanny to her that there was more than just Scorpia who could

stay upbeat all the time. How could two people like that exist in the world? “Right Glimmer?”

“Fine, thank you,” Glimmer said curtly, turning away abruptly.

Scorpia looked at Catra, waiting for a response. “Fine,” she huffed, “you’re welcome.”

“Look,” Bow said, “I know you don’t want to talk about it. But any information we could get on Adora now will help us later. You’re in, right?” Bow asked, suddenly unsure of himself. “For a rescue mission.”

“Oh, oh!” Scorpia raised her pincers. “I’m in. I already committed a few days ago with Catra, right?”

All four stopped walking and Glimmer glared hard in Catra’s direction. Flattening her ears and swishing her tail Catra replied, “It’s the only reason I’m here, right?” She sighed and ran her claws through her mane. “I’ll tell you what I know but we need to keep moving. Deal?”

Bow jumped in the air. “Works for me!”

Glimmer let out a sigh and, finally, let her posture slacken. She was tired. Her near death experience today was doing nothing for her mood. Bow looked at her sternly. “I’ll play nice. All I care about is saving Adora.”

“That makes two of us,” Catra said, malice completely removed from her tone this time. Catra let out a deep breath. “Look, I’m not trying to start a fight with you. We’re on the same side. I don’t care what happens after this. You can hate me, but you need me.” Catra let out a hiss directed at no one. “And, as much as I hate to admit it, I need you too. Don’t make me say it again.”

Bow and Scorpia practically buzzed in delight. “This is going to be so great,” Bow said, pumping his fist.

“Super, um,” Scorpia lifted an eyebrow at Bow with expectation.

“Friend?” Bow added.

Scorpia and Bow looked at each other, clasping hands and said, together, “Force!”

Mouth falling open, Catra looked at the only person she could relate too. When their eyes connected, Glimmer and Catra both let out a small smile before Bow and Scorpia started whooping again. Then, in unison, Catra and Glimmer both shook their heads.

Scorpia and Bow secretly high fived as the air cleared and each step started to feel lighter.

Glimmer offered her vulnerability quietly, “I’m scared.”

Glancing sideways, Catra replied, “Me too, Sparkles. It’s as bad as you feared. I don’t think she will last much longer.”

Nodding with resolve, Glimmer said, “She won’t have to. We’ve got a long walk ahead, what can you tell us?”

With a deep breath, Catra started to tell them what she could. She told them about the layout of the Fright Zone, how she could draw it out for them better later. Skipping over the more intimate parts, Catra told them Adora was being kept in the Black Garnet Chamber. When Catra spoke those words, Glimmer looked stricken, clearly remembering her own time as captive. Catra paused, but Glimmer silently pressing forward.

They didn’t ask for details and, for that, Catra was glad. Some things were only Adora’s to tell if she wanted to and some things, like the way Adora had pressed her forehead against Catra’s, were only for Catra.

Bow, Glimmer, and, even Scorpia chimed in when appropriate, both asking questions and adding useful information as necessary. They might have all been raised differently, but they were all soldiers when it came down to it. Though they were tired, all four were focused on the task at hand.

They could only get so far in their planning without a map. Glimmer said they would need to pull in the rest of the Princess Alliance, making Catra and Scorpia both hesitate, but eventually agree.

Catra found herself surprised about Glimmer's ability to listen and, even more, about her ability to lead. Glimmer was not a strategist, that was Catra's forte, but Glimmer conceded to Catra easily, while Catra found herself trusting Glimmer more to know what her team could accomplish. Up until now, she had seen the Princess of Bright Moon as childish. Clearly, some of that had been a front or had faded as Glimmer matured. Still, Catra was impressed. Glimmer felt the same about Catra. In another lifetime, they might have even gotten along.

Eventually when they had discussed all they could about the rescue mission, Scorpia and Bow started their own chat, falling in with one another easily. Bow was fascinated by Scorpia's history and her powers. Scorpia was absolutely enchanted as Bow told her about his latest inventions and about the pins in his arm.

That left Catra and Glimmer to walk side by side in silence. Clearing her throat, Glimmer asked, "So, what was it like? Growing up with Adora?"

Before she could sensor her answer, Catra said, "Amazing." After the words left her mouth, she blushed and Glimmer looked at her with a cocky grin. "What?" Catra said, "There weren't a lot of good parts to growing up in the Horde. And you know Adora. She's an idiot, but she's . . . ."

"Loyal? Dependable? Loving? Wonderful?" Glimmer said, tears gathering at her eyes. She rubbed them away.

Catra watched and nodded, then laughed nervously. "We did everything together. I don't have any memories growing up where she wasn't part of them."

Surprising even herself, Glimmer reached out and took Catra's hand, who was so shocked she let Glimmer hold it. Catra's hand went limp. Scorpia and Bow gasped behind them, slowing their pace to give Glimmer and Catra some space.

"She cares for you, you know," Glimmer said. "She never stopped talking about you, even if it was because you had been particularly annoying on the battlefield that day." They both smiled. "But seriously, she loves you. She never stopped."

Glimmer's words were consistent with what Adora had told Catra. It made her heart warm and clench at the same time, a constant reminder of what she almost had.

"Even if you are a petulant, annoying brat, I can kind of see why now," Glimmer said smiling at her.

"You're not so bad yourself, Sparkles," Catra said. "Even if you are an entitled princess and you wear way too much purple."

They both laughed, but the fatigue found its way through to them. They dropped each other's hands, Catra tucking her hair behind her ears and Glimmer threaded her fingers together. "Thanks for saving me, really," Glimmer said.

"You're welcome," Catra said. "Can we stop this mushy stuff though, I'm gonna gag."

"You got it," Glimmer replied, letting out a sigh. "We're here anyway."

Glimmer pushed through the last wall of thick trees, stepping through into smaller undergrowth. It sprawled outward but disappeared on the shore of the lake. Up on a hill, they could take in the entire view of Bright Moon. Behind Catra, Scorpia audibly gasped. They had seen it all before, of course, during the battle that took place here, but there was something more enticing when it could be viewed without the red veil of battle.

It was well past dark now, the moons overhead glowing brightly to light their path. They walked up into the castle with more than a few yawns stifled between them. Catra felt discomfort grow with each step. Bright Moon was the opposite of the Fright Zone. It was warm and inviting. It was clean. It was everything Catra dreamed of wanting when she was a kid, but now it left a sour taste in her mouth.

Her feelings were conflicting. As much as she was starting to accept that Adora's abandonment of her was much different than she had previously thought, it still stung. It stung to know Adora was here, safe and comfortable, while Catra was back in the Fright Zone, alone with Shadow Weaver and Hordak closing in on her. They should have been together.

They entered the castle, Glimmer pulling them forward more quickly as her eyes began to close. "Scorpia, we have the guest room for you," Glimmer motioned to the door.

"The whole thing?" Scorpia asked, eyeing the tall door.

Bow pushed the door open, exposing a tall ceiling, pink and purple decor, and a room bigger than Catra had ever seen. "This is it."

"Whoa, wow. You guys really know how to treat a guest," Scorpia said. Her smile vanished, "What about Catra?"

"She'll be," Glimmer paused, "just down the hall. That room there." She pointed to a door that looked the same as all the others.

"I'll be fine, get some rest," Catra said, already making her way down the hallway.

Behind her, the other three exchanged a glance and whispered goodnight. Scorpia closed the door behind her and finally let out a sigh of relief. It had been an easy decision to go with Catra. Catra needed her, even if she wouldn't admit it. Still, the impact of leaving the Fright Zone, abandoning her family's kingdom, even if

it had been changed into the Horde's base, left a pang in her chest. "You got this, Scorpia," she said to herself.

Outside of the door, Bow, Glimmer, and Catra made their way to the room Glimmer had pointed out.

"So, Catra," Bow said, clearing his throat. "Since the entire Princess Alliance is staying here, all of our extra bedrooms are full."

"Are you making me share a room with one of them?" Catra groaned. "Because I'd really rather stay with Scorpia."

Glimmer grimaced. "No, you don't have to stay with them. There is one room free."

Catra narrowed her eyes. "You just said there were no more guest rooms."

Bow reached out and took Catra's shoulder, "It's not a guest room. It's Adora's room."

They stopped in front of the door, Catra feeling like cold water had just been poured down her neck. Bow and Glimmer looked at each other nervously.

"Look, you don't have to stay here. Adora always said if you left the Fright Zone, you would share her room," Glimmer said, sighing. "We thought maybe it'd be more comfortable here for you. We haven't touched it since she left."

"You can stay here or with Scorpia," Bow said. "We just thought-"

"-this is fine," Catra said, succinctly cutting them off. Her palms rested on the wood of the door, feeling it under her fingertips, wondering if Adora had touched this spot before. "She said that? About me staying here?"

"She did," Bow smiled. "She still doesn't like sleeping alone, you know."

Catra held in a sob. “I’m going to get some sleep. We plan first thing in the morning, got it?”

“Got it,” Glimmer responded. “Goodnight.”

Bow smiled big, though it was somewhat strained. “Goodnight.”

Catra let out a noise of acknowledgement, but had her hand on the doorknob already. She turned it, opening to a room similar to Scorpia’s. It was equally ornate, but the layout was different. Adora had clearly arranged the room for function and it was neat as a pin.

When Catra saw the bed, she laughed. So much for the extra soft bed she was looking forward to tossing and turning in all night. Of course, Adora could only adjust to so many comforts at once. Catra walked around the room. Adora had so few possessions. There was almost nothing new here, aside from some Best Friend Squad figurines and several sets of clothing pressed in the closet.

Running her fingers across one of Adora’s shirts, Catra leaned in and breathed deeply. To her disappointment, it didn’t smell like Adora. After sticking her hand under the waterfall, Catra shook her head and made her way to the bed. She sat on the edge of it, one knee up, and imagined Adora sleeping there.

Had Adora thought of her from here like Catra had thought of her from the Fright Zone? Now that their places were switched, Catra’s heart grew heavy. She didn’t belong here, but Adora did. Squeezing her eyes shut, Catra finally let some of her fear creep in. Adora was still a prisoner. Shadow Weaver still had her. She let out a deep breath. They would make a plan. A good one this time.

Climbing up, Catra flopped down on the bed. The air whooshed out of the pillow and then, finally, Catra picked up the scent she was after. It was so deeply Adora that it flooded her senses, calming her as a reflex.

Clutching at the sheets, Catra surrounded herself in the smell, breathing it in desperately. Adora had been ready for Catra to

come here all this time. Ready to share a room with her again, a bed even. Hugging the pillow close, Catra cried into it. Heartbroken and exhausted, Catra shut her eyes, imagining Adora next to her as she fell asleep.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you again for all of your comments. It seriously means so much to me. Each and every comment, no matter how long is so amazing to receive. I really don't think I could have gotten this far without you all. I get very anxious before posting and the comments every time have made me feel a lot more confident.

Seriously, thank you so much for reading. I hope you enjoy this chapter.

Chat with me on tumblr I'll respond. :)

Second Wind

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mermista hated mornings. In Salineas, everyone slept in, unless there was a particularly good swell of waves to surf at first light. Which, to Mermista, felt like a good reason. But, she wasn't in Salineas. She was in Bright Moon, with its loud color scheme and busy hallways where people, apparently, just liked to be sleep deprived and miserable for nothing. And, as much as Mermista hated the morning light burning her retinas, she hated people keeping secrets from her more.

Yesterday, after they had limped out of battle bruised and weary, they had returned to Bright Moon, too tired to celebrate their tenuous victory. In the hours that followed, Glimmer was suddenly rushing with Bow to do, well, Mermista wasn't quite sure.

Glimmer had given the world's worst explanation, saying Bow had connected with two Horde defectors who had intel about Adora. Before Mermista could get ready to, you know, go with them, they had teleported away. So much for teamwork, or whatever. Not that Mermista cared, she only wanted to know why Glimmer could do whatever she wanted and Mermista had to play by these dumb Princess Alliance rules.

Mermista was furious as she charged down the hallways looking for Glimmer or Bow or literally anyone who knew anything about anything. Right as she was about to knock on Glimmer's door, a red, familiar looking tail caught in Mermista's periphery.

"Oh my god," Mermista cried, suddenly very awake. She took off running after it and came face to face with Scorpia. Here. In Bright Moon, just doors from where she had slept last night.

"Oh, um, hi," Scorpia said.

Mermista frowned, eyes blazing as absolute rage radiated from her. “What are you doing here?” Finding her magic, Mermista bellowed as she pulled water out of Bright Moon’s many sources. “Tell me one reason I shouldn’t wash you out the window right now.”

“I was, um, invited?” Scorpia offered, one pincer up. “And that sounds unpleasant,” she grumbled. “It’s kind of a long way down, don’t you think?”

“You’ve got to be joking!” Mermista jumped in the air and came down, knocking into Scorpia’s chest. With the water bolstering Mermista’s strength, even Scorpia, normally towering over everyone, was forced to her back.

“Wait, hold on,” Scorpia said, pincers and tail raised above her head to avoid accidentally stinging or slashing Mermista. “I’m not here to fight.”

“How did you get in here!?” Mermista yelled, pulling at the front of Scorpia’s uniform, while keeping her other fist raised above Scorpia’s face.

“That’s a, um,” Scorpia’s brows furrowed, “kinda a funny story actually. One I would love to tell you in detail at a better time.”

Mermista shook her. “Why are you here? Who else is with you? What’s the Horde planning?”

“Wow, so many questions at once,” Scorpia said, knitting her eyebrows together.

“What’s going on?” Glimmer said, voice high and annoyed as she appeared out of thin air with sleep still in her eyes. Glimmer blinked at the scene in front of her, eyes stretching wide when she registered what was happening. Scorpia shrugged. Glimmer slapped her face with an open palm before pulling Mermista to stand back on the floor, rather than on Scorpia’s stomach.

Not knowing what to do, Scorpia stayed on the ground until Glimmer offered her a hand, helping her back to her feet.

"Glimmer! What are you doing?" Water rose in a wave behind Mermista.

"Hey, we heard something. Is everyone - oh my," Perfuma said, putting a hand over her mouth in surprise.

"Why did no one tell me we were having a fight right now!" Frosta yelled, popping up behind Perfuma, ice fists already materializing.

Perfuma and Frosta called upon their powers and flanked Mermista. "Don't worry, we can take care of this. Glimmer, get behind us," Perfuma said.

Scorpia plastered her body against the wall. She looked back and forth between the princesses and started to whistle to herself nervously. Then, Catra peered out of her room nearby to see what the commotion was about. Relieved at seeing a familiar face, Scorpia waved at Catra.

In unison, all the princesses turned to see who Scorpia was waving at. Catra stood gaping with her hand in the air, midway to waving back to Scorpia.

Mermista grabbed Glimmer and shouted, "Glimmer! What did you do?!"

"So, are we not fighting then or . . ?" Frosta said letting her fists drop. "I'm confused."

"I don't know, *Glimmer*, are we?" Mermista said, throwing her hands up.

Scorpia was still caught in the middle of it, but Catra merely flared her nostrils and walked to the war room, where Bow had just popped his head out. Before he could ask what was going on, Catra grabbed him by the crop top, pulled him inside, and slammed the door closed behind her.

Glimmer looked at all the princesses, scowls etched on all their faces. “War room, now!” Glimmer shouted.

With a huff, they marched to the room, making sure everyone knew how irritated they were as heavy footsteps slapped the ground. At least, that’s what Mermista did. When she glanced over her shoulder, she saw Perfuma *introducing herself* to Scorpia.

“Hi there, I’m Perfuma. I know we’ve sort of met before, but never properly.” Perfuma smiled and held out her hand. “Welcome to Bright Moon.”

Eyebrows raising almost to her hairline, Scorpia stuck out her pincer. Perfuma grabbed it with both hands and shook it delicately while laughing. “Scorpia. Very nice to meet you. I mean, you know, properly.”

“Perfuma! What are you doing? Has everyone lost it?” Mermista growled.

“She’s our guest, I guess, right?” Perfuma asked. Scorpia just nodded, unsure what to do.

“Just get in the war room, both of you.” Mermista demanded, holding the door open for the pair.

They settled in quietly, after some confusion about whose chair was whose. Netossa, Spinnerella, Sea Hawk, and Angella joined in, teleported by Glimmer without, Mermista assumed, an explanation, based on their shocked faces.

All the people who had not witnessed the happenings of the hallway were confused, but the tension in the room was anything but subtle. Everyone was shifting around uncomfortably, but when they found Catra, the source of agitation became immediately clear. Catra slouched as deeply as the hard-backed chair she sat in would allow. It was Adora’s normal seat, which only enraged some of the crowd further.

“Glimmer, what did you do?!” Angella yelled, steam practically pouring off her as she waited for a reason not to ground Glimmer on the spot.

“Did I forget to mention that the Horde defectors Bow and I picked up were Catra and Scorpia?” Glimmer said, laughing nervously.

“Let me get this straight,” Mermista said, pointing her finger at Catra and Scorpia, still in their Horde uniforms, “you brought them here? Like on purpose? What do you want, for us to trust them?” Catra growled. “Did you all forget that Catra, like, kidnapped Adora in the first place? And, like, also kidnapped some of you? Not to mention attacked Salineas, Plumeria, the Kingdom of Snows, Dryl, and Bright Moon. That’s, like, all of our kingdoms.”

Glimmer gave Mermista a pained expression and a shrug while Bow avoided Mermista’s burning eyes entirely. Throwing her hands up and grunting, Mermista sat back in her chair. “This is, like, a terrible idea, but what do I know? I’ve just been fighting a literal war against her, or them, or whatever.”

On her right, Perfuma darted back and forth between Mermista and Catra. Frosta only looked annoyed, ice creeping out from her and coating the seat she occupied.

Scorpia bit her lip. “I promise we’re here to help. We’re really not bad guys. Well, I mean, we were, I guess. Like up until very recently. Very recently actually.” She scowled with her pincer holding her chin. “And we’ve done some bad things, sure. But we want to make that better now.” Setting her jaw with determination she added, “We can make it up to you."

Ever since the session started, Catra had been rubbing her temples in a steady, soothing motion. Now, she grumbled and glared at Scorpia. Scorpia took the hint and stopped talking with an awkward cough.

“You were all there yesterday!” Glimmer exclaimed. “Catra saved me! And Scorpia saved you,” Glimmer pointed at Perfuma, “And,” Glimmer’s voice broke, “the soldiers were directed by both of them to attack our strongest team. You think that was an accident?”

“Not to mention that leaving the Horde is, like, a really big deal, right?” Bow squealed.

“I think we can trust them,” Perfuma smiled at Scorpia, who blushed. “You all heard it, they left the Horde. The Horde doesn’t take kindly to that. Plus, we do owe them for yesterday.”

“Just because they say they manipulated the attack so, by the way, Frosta and I had to do more fighting, doesn’t mean we can trust them,” Mermista said, groaning when Perfuma only smiled in response.

“I certainly appreciated not having to hold off She-ra and all those soldiers at the same time,” Perfuma said.

“That was all Catra’s idea, by the way,” Scorpia said, waving her pincer in the air. “She knew Mermista, Frosta, and Sea Hawk could handle it. You all were kicking butt yesterday.”

“Well, at least she was right about that,” Mermista smirked, flipping her hair behind her shoulder, anger momentarily quelled by the compliment.

“Absolutely! The tale of our daring in the battle was legendary! Did you see how many soldiers I managed to beat?” Sea Hawk said, earning a hard glare from Mermista and Frosta. “I mean, did you see that team work?” Quietly he added, “Yay.”

“They could be spies!” Frosta said, slamming ice fists together. “They are trying to deliver the entire Princess Alliance to the front door of the Fright Zone!” Scorpia’s mouth dropped as she stared at the ice, reaching out to touch it with one of her claws.

“We aren’t spies!” Catra said, voice cracking as she pulled Scorpia’s pincer away from Frosta. “Do you think we need spies to know what you are all up to? Believe me, you are all very predictable.”

“Yeah, um, not really helping your case,” Mermista said, narrowing her eyes.

“If I may interject,” Sea Hawk said, standing. Mermista put her head in her hands. “We could use a larger crew.”

“And someone who knows their way around the Fright Zone,” Netossa said, crossing her arms. “Without Adora, we’re screwed.” Frosta huffed. “Let’s face it, we need them.”

The war room broke out in bickering, divided on what to do with. Frosta stood up on the table shouting and grinding ice together, Scorpia and Perfuma fought to calm everyone down which only added to the noise level, Mermista sniped more words at Catra, and Catra just laughed. Netossa and Spinnerella started to argue about something unrelated. Bow looked at Glimmer who frowned. Angella looked at Glimmer and shook her head.

Several times Glimmer tried to stop them. She knew the reaction would be big, but not this big.

The fighting just went on getting louder and louder until Angella broke her silence, quietly demanding, “Silence.” The room went quiet. Angella motioned at Glimmer. “Explain.”

Glimmer took a deep breath. “I’m the commander and I’m making the call. We can trust them.” It was said with such firm finality that no one argued. “They saved me. They could have won the entire war yesterday, but they helped us instead.”

The room eyed Glimmer warily.

“Look, I don’t like it either, but what other choice do we have?” Glimmer asked.

“Thanks for your vote of confidence, Sparkles,” Catra huffed, clenching her jaw.

Glimmer proceeded, undeterred, “What I’m trying to say is, they’re here to help. I believe them. I,” Glimmer met Catra’s eyes. “I know they’d do anything to save Adora.”

Catra sat down casually. “I’m not here for you to like me. And I’m not here to like you either. I don’t care about that.” Mermista raised an eyebrow at her. “All I care about is that we get Adora out of the Fright Zone. Unless you have any other ideas, Scorpia and I would like to lay out our plan.”

Mermista and Frosta looked at each other before letting out exasperated sighs while settling back to their chairs. Perfuma smiled at both of them, though her eyes settled on Scorpia, who smiled back.

“The floor is yours,” Bow said, gesturing widely.

Catra pushed down on the table. Even earlier this morning, Bow had given her instructions on how to use and edit the maps function. She had been pleasantly surprised when she did not have to spend much time modifying. The map she found of the Fright Zone was perfect. When she examined it, she had found no flaws. Adora had clearly charted it out when she had first arrived. The thought made Catra smile. Catra merely needed to edit the newer additions and the blueprints were complete.

Pointing a pincer Scorpia jumped up in excitement, “That’s my room!” A table full of eyes looked at her, causing her to blush and sit down.

“A lot of you have paid the Fright Zone a visit once or,” she sent a cold stare Mermista’s way, “twice.” She zoomed in on the Black Garnet chamber. “This is the Black Garnet chamber. Glimmer was held here and that’s where Adora is being kept. It is centrally located, only making our job harder.”

Glimmer shifted uncomfortably in her seat at both the memory or her own imprisonment and at Shadow Weaver being that close to Adora. Bow clasped her shoulder, squeezing until Glimmer gave a curt nod.

"It's good news and bad news that we don't have to break Adora out of the cell block. For one, the Black Garnet chamber isn't littered with guards, but on the other hand, Shadow Weaver is there and will be at her most powerful if we have to face her. But that isn't our first target," Catra said, "first we need to destroy the tech infecting the sword. Scorpia?"

"Oh, me?" Scorpia said, looking over both her shoulders. "Are you sure?"

"You know where the disc is. We've already talked about this, tell them what you know," Catra ushered. "It's a good plan."

Scorpia blushed. "Oh, okay. Um," she said, standing up and nearly knocking over her chair. "Right, the disc,", she clicked on the map as Catra had to zoom in, having to adjust as her pincer struck the wrong spot at first. Perfuma smiled at her encouragingly. Gaining some confidence, she continued. "It's in a safe deep in the storage unit. The disc has to stay away from any First Ones' tech, you all know why." Scorpia blushed. "Entrapta and I tracked down the disc and it is being held right here."

At the mention of Entrapta's name, the princesses slumped in their chairs. There was nothing worse for them than a reminder of their failures. Scorpia stopped talking and looked around the room. "Did I say something wrong?"

"It's just Entrapta," Bow smiled sadly. "We all feel responsible for leaving her there."

"Oh, Entrapta is great. We're best pals, right Catra?" Scorpia said.

Catra remained silent, unease growing.

“Well, Entrapta is who we can thank for this,” Scorpia said. “She wanted to help Adora too.” The room brightened, just a little. “Like I said, the disc is here. It’s deep underground. The outer doors are guarded, but the inside is not. No one goes in there really. There are shelves and shelves of stuff, armor and weapons and bombs. Anyway, lucky for us, we have someone who should be able to get us past the guards and to the safe location easy, right Glimmer?”

“Of course,” Glimmer said, flexing her hands, “that’s my specialty.”

“It should be a piece of cake. Team 1: Scorpia, Glimmer, Netossa, and Frosta. Netossa, you and I can neutralize any rogue guards with our, uh, unique abilities. Frosta, you’re going to be our body guard if things go awry. Those ice powers should knock anyone off their feet in that space.”

“Yes!” Frosta said, shooting ice into the ceiling as she stood. Glimmer scolded her. “Oops, sorry Glimmer.”

Catra stood, taking command with a much easier confidence than Scorpia, “Listen, you need to be careful. If you trigger the alarm, you’ll be sitting ducks. Glimmer can get you out, but if you get separated, you’re in trouble. There are all sorts of things in storage that could hurt you. Focus on the disc. When you find it, break it immediately. Right there. No hesitation.”

Frosta, now only excited about being called a body guard and being on a team with Glimmer, nodded once. Mermista groaned again, still not sold on the plan though it seemed all the people around her were much more eager to forget that yesterday Catra had been their enemy.

“Step two,” Catra resumed. “We get the sword.”

“Is that really that important?” Perfuma said. “Shouldn’t Adora be our priority?”

“She is our priority, but Adora is our heaviest hitter,” Catra said. “I don’t think we can make it out without her, not from the center of

the Fright Zone. Team 2: Catra, Mermista, Perfuma."

"Alright, continue," Mermista said, interest piqued at the mention of her name.

Catra detailed the plan to retrieve the sword, knowing this job was much more dangerous than the disc as it was held in Hordak's sanctum, which is why she wanted two of the strongest princesses with her. Hordak depended on the absolute loyalty of the Horde, instilled into them by fear. His greatest flaw was his arrogance. That flaw was what Catra was counting on. The sanctum would be empty, with, at most, only Entrapta and Hordak inside. Hordak was a lot to deal with, but if they were smart, they'd have a window without extra guards. They only needed to get the sword and get out.

"Team 3: Spinnerella, Sea Hawk, Bow." Catra turned to Bow, "No offense but you're not exactly in top fighting form, but we need you. You're our best shot at getting through to Entrapta. I need you to try and hack security, Entrapta will respond so all you need to do is convince her to help you. You're the best person for that job. There's an access port here," she pointed, "that should give you decent cover.

"Spinnerella and Sea Hawk, you'll be stationed here," she pointed at the map. "Sea Hawk, you have to protect Bow, but Spinnerella, I have an even bigger job for you." Sea Hawk's eyes positively shined when they met Bow's and they fist bumped across the table. Spinnerella nudged Netossa in the ribs, who stuck her tongue out.

"Right," Catra said, eyebrow raised, "If anything goes wrong, you're our backup. We'll all have earpieces and be able to trigger a distress signal. If you hear that, stealth mode is off. You're going to bust in there and knock any enemies back, connect with the team that contacted you, and be off. In the small space of the Fright Zone hallways, your powers will be unbeatable."

Catra drew several lines, converging at the center point. “If everything goes smoothly, Team 2 will get to Adora first and deliver the sword, but Team 1 shouldn’t be far behind with Glimmer there to teleport. We enter the Black Garnet Chamber, free Adora and leave. Nothing else, you got it? This is not a time to win the war. It’s time to bring Adora home. The quieter, the better.”

When Catra looked up from the map, all eyes were on her. She swallowed and sat down. She’d always imagined the Princess Alliance as underqualified for war or, really, almost anything. This morning when all the fighting broke out, she doubled down on that thought. Now, they looked at her intelligently, asking follow-up questions with a focus that surprised her.

Maybe they still had a lot to learn to be soldiers and leaders, unlike Catra who had spent her entire life on it, but they certainly had made progress. It made Catra think of Adora again. Of course, she could see the strength in this prissy crew of princesses when Catra could not. Adora had always brought out the best in people, Catra knew that first hand.

“Sounds good, or whatever, I guess. Much better than Glimmer and my plan anyway,” Mermista said. “I’ll be watching you though,” she said, looking at Catra.

“Can’t wait,” Catra smirked.

Frosta jumped up again and said, “When do we go? I’m ready to make them pay.”

“I thought you’d never ask,” Catra said grinning. “The longer we wait, the longer the Horde will come up with a plan against us. Hordak is angry after his loss yesterday, but he’ll be even angrier when he knows Scorpia and I are gone. Not to mention that Shadow Weaver might go ballistic. We need some time to rest and prepare ourselves, but we strike tomorrow night after dusk.”

“That soon?” Perfuma asked.

“If we want this to work, we can’t give them too much time to alter their security,” Scorpia said, shrugging. “Even if they get new assignments by tomorrow, the soldiers will have to adjust to their new schedules and that gives us a window of opportunity.”

Perfuma nodded and, then, so did the rest of the Alliance. Catra felt their eyes on her again and she blushed. “We can do this.” Scorpia nodded at her, it was a good plan for a short timeline, but they needed more. Before Catra could give the order, Glimmer stood.

“Breakout sessions with your assigned team,” Glimmer said. “We’ve got a lot of work to do today. We’ll reconvene this afternoon.”

“Good work, Glimmer,” Angella whispered as the teams shuffled around, pulling up their own schematics. Angella clasped her daughter on the shoulder. “I am proud of you. I will contact all the kingdoms and prepare them for battle in case of retaliation. With your permission, of course.”

“Let’s do this, mom,” Glimmer said, hugging Angella tightly.

Adora didn’t know if it had been hours or days since Catra had been taken. Everything stopped the second the door slammed shut between them. Adora felt out of place, like the world she was living in no longer knew what to do with her. She certainly did not know what to do with it. Time kept moving, but it left her behind, stuck in a reality too painful to be real. Part of her felt dead already and the other part wanted to be.

Just to try and feel something, she moved, twisting her body from its spot on the floor. She registered the pain somewhere in her brain, but it felt too subtle, too menial to actually hurt compared to the dire ache in her heart.

Rubbing her face, Adora looked around in a daze. She was locked in the Black Garnet chamber with her hands and feet immobilized by glowing ropes, outside of Shadow Weaver's bedroom. Closing her eyes, she could still see the dark light of the Black Garnet behind her eyelids, sometimes startling her when it would flicker violently.

No one came. There were no more visits from Kyle. Adora wasn't sure if she slept anymore, but if she did, Mara made no more appearances. There had been no more bumbled rescue attempts by the Rebellion. Even Octavia hadn't been around to escort Adora. And, worst of all, there was no Catra. No sarcastic words or tender looks that Adora had come to depend on in the last few weeks. A howl fell from her lips as she started to tremble, burying her face in her hands as she shook her head back and forth.

Even when she knew she was hallucinating, Adora would sink in, trying to convince herself it was real. At the best times, she could hear Glimmer and Bow laughing. She could see Mermista look at her, roll her eyes, but then smile confidently. If she listened, she could hear Frosta letting out a competitive roar or feel the comforting press of Perfuma's hand on her shoulder. At times, she could hear the tune of Sea Hawk and Swift Wind's songs, but, when she tried, she could never remember the words.

When Adora stared blankly ahead, sometimes she'd swear the air would change and a breeze would blow past her skin. In those moments, her heart would beat again, sure that it was Catra coming back for her. She'd wait for Catra's hands to find hers or Catra's tail to wrap around her wrist or Catra to just stand in front of her and say, "Miss me?" in that cocky tone Adora craved. Relief would wash over her and she'd smile. But, when she'd pick up her head, nothing was there. A sickening feeling poisoned her when she remembered that Catra would never share her warmth with Adora again. All Adora knew now was the burning cold of loneliness.

Other times, Adora would cry. It never made her feel better, but she didn't know what to do when the pain of loss became too

unbearable. When her crying would end, she'd turn numb, hoping she was crawling another moment closer to peace, but it never came.

She would think of memories, holding on to them desperately as if she could find Catra there and bring her back to life. So many times before, she thought she would lose Catra, but not like this. And she never knew what she'd do with herself afterward, Adora had never even thought that was a possibility. If Catra was gone, Adora assumed she would have been beside her and they would calmly exit the world together.

A shiver ran down her spine as Adora remembered a day not so long ago when she felt that fear, but they had gotten through it, waking up together in each other's arms. Adora closed her eyes as the memory washed over her.

Catra rubbed her hands together, trying to bring feeling back into her fingers as she shivered. "It's freezing."

"Just a little longer," Adora responded, quickening her pace. "Come on, Catra. This is the last one and we can go back."

A howling wind blew by them, cutting straight through their Horde jackets and chilling them to the bone. Knitting her eyebrows together, Adora looped a rope through itself and pulled tight. She stuck her hands under her shirt, shocking the air out of her lungs as her fingers took the heat from her core.

Beside her, Catra's hands shook violently, her rope still untied. With her smaller hands, Catra's knots were always tidier than Adora's, but today she'd gotten progressively sloppier as the cold sank in.

Glancing behind her, Adora sidled up next to Catra when she saw no one behind them. She pulled her hands out of her shirt and covered Catra's with them. Catra's hands were so cold it burned, but Adora held tight.

Catra's shaking amplified. "I can barely feel it anymore, how am I supposed to tie it?" Tears froze to her eyelashes.

"Catra, you're going hypothermic," Adora said, teeth chattering together. "Why is it so cold? This doesn't seem right."

"Put your hands on my skin, let me do this," Adora said, tucking Catra's hands onto the bare skin of her back as she bent over the rope. Catra's hands shocked her even more than her own had, causing her to take a sharp, pained intake of breath.

"Adora," Catra said, but her breath was starting to slow. "S-so cold."

As Adora looped the rope through itself, she started to tremble. The wind screeched past them again. Behind her, Catra was starting to fade, slumping to the side and unable to keep contact with Adora's body.

Without another thought, Adora ripped her coat off and placed it around Catra's front, hoping some of the heat left in it would transfer. Without her jacket, Adora was left in nothing more than a thick, long sleeve shirt. The little heat Adora had left her in an instant as if she had plunged through thin ice.

"Adora what are you doing?" Catra slurred, trying to shove the coat back onto Adora.

"Stop. You need this more than me right now," Adora said, shortening her breaths to keep the cold from permeating her lungs. When she finally pulled the rope taunt, Adora let out an exasperated sigh. "That's the last one. We just need to get to back."

Catra nodded, but did not get up as she nuzzled into Adora's jacket.

"Catra! Get up," Adora tucked her jacket more snuggly around Catra's frame and pulled at her to rise. "Catra!"

With Adora's help, Catra made it up with a grunt. As soon as she did she started to fall, only to be caught by Adora's arms. With her own body shaking, Adora fell to the ground underneath Catra, sprawling them onto the ice away. Catra let out a quiet whimper when the snow touched her body.

"I got you," Adora said, lips starting to turn blue. She rubbed at her arms to bring life back to them as she hefted herself and Catra up. Halfway to her feet, Adora's thigh seized and she fell in a lunge hard on one knee. The ground was unyielding and it sent an icy shock through her femur making her gasp.

Grinding her teeth together, Adora pulled them up and took a step forward. She held Catra to her chest tightly, "Can you talk to me?"

"You're such an," Catra sunk in further, "idiot, Adora." When she spoke, her breath was barely visible in the dark air. Catra tried to smile. Adora held her tighter.

"Something's wrong," Adora said, but Catra was only half listening. Catra's eyes started to close, but Adora jostled her, "Don't you dare."

With a whistle, the wind whipped again, making Adora's eyes water. She blinked away the tears as they froze and hobbled ahead. When she started, she thought the intensity of the physical labor would help get her blood pumping, but the cold air pervaded her senses. Every breath sent stabbing pain into her lungs. "We're almost there," she rasped.

Catra could only nod in return as she fought to keep her eyes open.

Finally, Adora made it to a door. With her elbow, she pushed into the control console. When the door swooshed open, a hot whoosh of air hit them. Once past the threshold, Adora crashed to the ground, taking the brunt of the impact on both knees as she cradled Catra's body to her own.

The lights turned on, illuminating the simulation room foyer.

“What took you so long?” Lonnie asked.

“C-can’t talk right now,” Adora said, unwrapping Catra. Adora fell back against the wall and pulled Catra into her chest, covering them as well as she could with their jackets. As she circled her arms around Catra, Adora rubbed at her skin furiously.

Lonnie’s eyes widened. She hesitated only a moment before helping Adora settle in, adding her own jacket to the pile on top of her teammates. “Are you okay? Is Catra?”

“What happened? Where were you?” Adora said angrily, still trying to get feeling back in her fingers.

“You said you had it handled!” Lonnie accused, tapping her foot on the ground.

“We did it,” Adora growled. “It got colder.”

“Cadets, what’s going on?” Grizzlor asked, entering the room. Seeing Adora and Catra, his eyes widened. “Get the medic,” he said to Kyle, “right now.”

“What’s going on?” Adora asked between clenched teeth. “The program was bugged.”

“Just a normal survival simulation cadet,” Grizzlor said, leafing through his clipboard.

“No way,” Adora said, still trying to kick feeling back into her and Catra’s skin. “C-check the logs.” Catra turned in her arms, trying to get closer. “I’ve got you, Catra. Medics are on their way.”

“Don’t,” Catra swallowed, “go. Please.”

“I’m right here,” Adora said. “I’m not going anywhere.”

Grizzlor lazily flipped through the computer console. “Oh,” he uttered. “Looks like you’re right, cadet. The system is on the fritz.

Looks like the cooling system kicked into overdrive the last cycle. I'll report this out."

"And what? That's it?" Adora said, shaking now more from anger than chill.

"You passed. That's all that matters," Grizzlor said. "I'll make sure to note that your team dealt with extremes no other team did. It should help your scores."

"Our scores?" Adora scowled. "That was dangerous. Catra is hypothermic."

Grizzlor hovered over her. "Watch your tongue, cadet. We'll get her help."

Adora held in her response, knowing she had nothing polite to say to her superior officer. The medics rushed in, giving them both reflective blankets and steaming cups of water. The medical bay was nearby and, after a substantial effort, Adora and Catra were ushered onto two cots. Adora was given more blankets, while the medics slipped a mask over Catra's face and pushed an IV into her arm.

They'd been to the medical bay many times, but Adora had never seen Catra look so out of it. Her body looked lifeless. Adora was scared and defensive. She asked the medical team, "What are you doing?"

"She'll be okay," they reassured. "We're giving her warm air and fluids."

The staff checked both of their vitals before leaving, seeming satisfied. "Stay wrapped up. We'll monitor you, but let us know if anything starts to worsen. Sit tight, you'll both be spending the night here. We'll have dinner sent in."

Once she was sure they were gone, Adora wrapped her blanket around her shoulders and settled on the edge of Catra's stiff cot. "Hey, it's me. Are you okay?"

“Adora?” Catra asked, fogging up her mask. “What happened?”

Adora took a deep breath, “They messed up the configuration for the survival simulation. I’m sorry. I should have called it off when I suspected something wrong.” She shivered. “I didn’t know,” she scrunched her eyebrows together, “you went downhill so fast.”

Catra paused, but lifted the mountain of blankets covering her to let Adora in. Still dejected, Adora hung her head and clutched her own blanket more tightly. “Get in here, dummy,” Catra said, smiling up at Adora from her back.

With a sigh, Adora dropped her blanket and crawled, facing Catra on her side. Adora let out another shiver when she connected with Catra’s skin. Catra wrapped her arm around Adora’s shoulders and encouraged her to move closer by gently pressing on the small of her back. Adora complied, tucking her head under Catra’s chin and lying on Catra’s chest. With her free arm, she put her hand on Catra’s waist and hugged her tight. They sat in silence for a while, as Catra became more lucid.

“Well, did we pass?” Catra asked.

“Seriously? That’s what you care about right now?” Adora said, running her fingers down the fabric covering Catra’s rib cage.

“It’s all the Horde is going to care about tomorrow,” Catra said, exhaling sharply.

“We passed, but we should have just taken the fail,” Adora said. “I’m sorry. I - I wasn’t thinking clearly.”

“It’s not your fault. I’m not mad, okay? You got us out of there.” Catra said. “The best thing you can do for me right now is stop feeling so guilty. Otherwise, we both know you’re going to be squirming around all night and I could get some sleep.” Catra laughed.

Adora smiled back and said, “Hey! That isn’t fair.” With her fingers, Adora found her way to the delicate skin on Catra’s side

and tickled her lightly.

Catra laughed again, calling mercy until Adora let up. They settled in closer than before and Catra's eyes started to shut.

But, Adora was wide awake. "Don't scare me like that again, okay?" Adora said.

"I wasn't trying," Catra said, detangling herself from Adora and turning away, minding the needle in her arm. "I know I'm no good in the cold." Her ears flattened. "If you hadn't saved me I might be worse off."

"That's not what I meant," Adora said, propping herself up on one elbow and grabbing Catra's shoulder. "I just mean," she trailed off. "Seeing you like that, like this, it scared me. I can't lose you."

"It was just a simulation, Adora," Catra said. "They would have stopped it."

"They didn't even know there was a problem," Adora whispered. "And you know that cadets have died before in less dangerous circumstances."

Catra snorted. "Stop worrying. You're never going to lose me," Catra said, flipping back over to look at Adora. "You're stuck with me."

Catra's tail wrapped around Adora's wrist. With a whump, Adora fell back against their shared pillow, and tucked Catra's head under her chin, breathing her in. "Always, right?"

A purr rumbled from Catra's chest. "Always."

Adora grasped at her chest, unable to fully close her hand as she found her wrists restrained in the empty hall of the Black Garnet Chamber, the sound of Catra's purr fading.

Adora turned over. A rattling sob came from deep in her chest. All she wanted was to go to sleep and never wake up. It was a

thought she had often that left her feeling guilty. It wasn't fair for her to give up when so many others were still fighting. The Horde had taken so much from her, but there was still more to lose. Somehow there was always more to lose.

The Rebellion was out there. There had to be a way for her to help them. Anything. She'd sacrifice anything. She looked around again and cast her eyes down. Adora groaned. What did she have to offer? She wasn't strong enough. She never was.

The door slid open. Adora did not even react as Shadow Weaver stepped through, closing her eyes and hanging her head instead.

"Now, now Adora, I know you're upset," Shadow Weaver said, "but that does not excuse bad behavior. Catra is gone and you have already spent too much time dwelling on it. You have more important things to think about."

Adora swallowed hard. This wasn't the first time Shadow Weaver had come to her. Opening her eyes, Adora met Shadow Weaver's image, looming above her. "How can you talk about her like that?"

"Adora, as I've said before, we are done talking about Catra," Shadow Weaver said. "For the last time, she is no longer relevant. You would be wise to stop making me repeat myself."

"Relevant?" Adora gasped. "How can you say that?" Before she could protest further, a hard slap connected with her face, echoing endlessly in the chamber.

Narrowing her eyes to slits, Shadow Weaver bent down and took Adora's chin in her hand. The skin where Shadow Weaver's palm had connected with Adora's face rapidly turned red. Adora's eyes stung and her ears rang. The Black Garnet sputtered in the background.

"I'm not here to talk about Catra, I'm here to talk about you." Shadow Weaver said, forcing Adora to look up at her. "Lord Hordak is very angry. He means to take She-ra out for another battle imminently."

"No," Adora cried, fear making her focus. "I can't. Not again." Her voice sounded dry and desperate and so unlike her own.

Shadow Weaver let go of Adora's chin and caressed her bruising cheek lightly instead. "There may be another way."

A buzz of words screamed in her head.

"Adora, please! Don't listen to her!"

"Shadow Weaver is killing you. You're losing yourself. You don't have an endless supply to give away."

Adora shook her head, tears already threatening to fall again. What choice did she have? The Rebellion was out there. Just because her soul had left when Catra did, didn't mean she could stop trying.

"What can I do?" Adora asked, finding it harder to push down a life a pain than it had been a week ago.

Shadow Weaver snapped her fingers and Adora's bonds fell away.

Adora rose to her feet. Last time they had this conversation, Shadow Weaver had given Adora Catra's Force Captain badge. When Adora threw it across the room, Shadow Weaver relentlessly tore into Adora, reminding her of all her shortcomings and weaknesses. It had hurt and Adora had been left a mess on the floor, guilt eating away any sort of self-worth she had found while part of the Rebellion. It was her fault, after all, that Catra was gone.

Gently, Shadow Weaver reached out for Adora again, who obediently let Shadow Weaver trail her nails over the angry, red skin of Adora's face, a handprint perfectly outlined there.

Shadow Weaver took Adora's free hand in her own, sliding the badge into Adora's palm. "This is your destiny, Adora. You're the only one who can help them now."

Adora tried to drop the badge, but Shadow Weaver firmly held her fist shut.

“You can still be good, Adora,” Shadow Weaver said. “I will help you.”

Adora couldn’t mask the tears that came as Shadow Weaver closed the space between them.

“Please, sit,” Angella said, motioning at the chair across from her desk.

Catra’s left ear twitched, but she did as she was told, slouching deep into the plush cushions. Avoiding Angella, she inspected the room instead. It was grand by every measure. Tall ceilings, massive desk, and, of course, it fit the stylistic choices found in the rest of the Bright Moon castle. It was purple, pink, and entirely too soft. Catra had better things to do than be here. Sure, the planning session for Adora’s rescue mission had ended for today, but Catra would work well into the night. She’d look at the plan from every angle. They still had time to alter it tomorrow if she exposed a flaw that had previously been missed.

“Glimmer has told me a lot about you,” Angella said, folding her hands in her lap.

“I’m sure that review was glowing,” Catra responded, claws unsheathing. Catra wasn’t sure what to expect when Angella had pulled her aside earlier today to request this meeting. If they had an issue with the plan, they had all damn day to address it. And if they were thinking of double crossing her, imprisoning her, they had another thing coming. Nothing was stopping her from going back for Adora.

“Without you, it is possible the Horde would have been defeated by now,” Angella said. “You nearly destroyed the Moonstone. You did destroy the Whispering Woods. And you found a way to defeat She-ra.”

Catra hissed, low and threatening. “Are you here to condemn me?” she asked.

"I’m here to tell you that you’re brilliant.” Angella smiled. “I’m glad your second trip to Bright Moon was as our guest, not our enemy.” Angella held out a cup. “Tea?”

Catra’s ears flattened. “No thanks. Can we just get to the point? What do you want?”

Biting her bottom lip, Angella rested her chin across interlaced fingers. “Glimmer isn’t the only one I get information from. Adora has spent a lot of time in this office, in that very chair.” Angella pointed. Catra moved uncomfortably in the seat, heat rising up her neck. “She talked about you frequently.”

A blush stood out on Catra’s cheeks and she looked away, trying to hide it. “Yeah, and?”

“You mean a great deal to her,” Angella said quietly.

Catra wrapped her tail around her shin. “Why are you telling me this?”

Angella narrowed her eyes. “You need to know that she never once gave up on you.”

Pulling her knees up to the chair, Catra wrapped her arms around them, making herself small. Angella didn’t need to say it out loud. Everything that had happened since Catra had come to Bright Moon made her believe it a little more. She woke up in Adora’s bed and she’d return there tonight. A place Adora had saved for her.

“I will be honest with you, I often encouraged her to move on,” Angella said. Catra scowled. “At first, I thought it would weaken her, but she always did as she said despite having to fight you. And now,” Angella reached across the desk and grabbed Catra’s hand, “I owe you my daughter’s life.”

Flinching back, Catra pulled her hand away. “It’s not a big deal.”

“You have shown there is more to you than the Horde. When you say you want to rescue Adora, I believe you,” Angella said, unwilling to break eye contact.

Catra started to stand up. “Well, thanks for the vote of confidence I guess. If you don’t mind, I have more work to do.”

“Sit down, we are not finished yet,” Angella said with a stern, motherly tone.

Gulping, Catra plopped back into the chair.

“You know that rescuing Adora does not end once we remove her from the Fright Zone,” Angella continued. “She may try, but she will be in no condition to take her place as part of this Rebellion.”

“What are you saying?” Catra hissed, standing up and sinking her nails into the wood of Angella’s desk.

In response, Angella raised an eyebrow and sat back. “Bow, Glimmer, and I are the only people who are aware of what tortures Adora is currently facing. You know more about that than I do and Adora, I’m sure, has even more secrets.”

Catra’s nostrils flared. “That’s Adora’s business, not yours.”

“I don’t doubt it,” Angella said calmly.

“Look, if this is about you wanting Adora back so she can be on the Rebellion’s front lines again, I’m here to tell you that I don’t care about that.” Catra showed off her fangs. “I am responsible for her capture and I’ll work with you to free her, but that doesn’t

mean I support you. I see the way you've treated her. I'd be happy if Adora never had to fight again."

"What do you mean?" Angella asked.

"You and the Alliance act like she's some savior. Like this war is all up to her. Do you know what that does to her? Adora already thinks she has responsibility to everyone but herself. Believe me, I know. I exposed that flaw repeatedly. It's why you lost so many battles," Catra sneered.

Angella huffed, but waited for Catra to continue.

"Adora is human too," Catra said, sitting back down," but no one treats her like one. That's all I'm saying."

"It seems we are more on the same page than I thought," Angella said, thoughtfully folding her wings down.

Puzzled, Catra watched her through knitted brows.

"What I've brought you in here to discuss is what happens to Adora after she returns." Angella let herself soften.

Catra ground her teeth together, unwilling to accept that concept. "Adora can do whatever she wants. What does this have to do with me?"

Angella cleared her throat, "Adora cares about you. You were there with her through this. You spent a lifetime together. Adora is going to need you."

Catra growled. "Adora doesn't need me, she has all of this. You said it yourself, I am your enemy."

"After this, you will no longer be," Angella said with finality.

"Is that an official pardon?" Catra asked with a biting tone.

“I don’t plan on imprisoning you. You and Adora are tied together,” Angella said.

Catra let her eyes fall as the back of her neck grew hot in anger. “Quit acting like you know anything about us.”

A moment of silence passed as Angella punched a hard stare into Catra, heat rising to the surface of her own skin. “My husband Micah was a student of sorcery at Mystacor. He was under the tutelage of one known as Light Spinner.”

“So, what?” Catra said, tail lashing in annoyance.

“You may know her by a different name,” Angella said darkly.

“What does this have to do with me or Adora? I’ve got work to do,” Catra said standing up again.

Angella flattened the creases of paper folded on her desk. “Shadow Weaver.” The muscles flexed in Catra’s throat as she swallowed dryly. “Light Spinner and Shadow Weaver are one in the same. Adora may be the latest abused by Shadow Weaver, but she was not the first.”

Catra turned and gripped the back of the chair she had previously occupied. Her claws ripped into the back cushion.

“You may have proven your worth to Glimmer, me, and the rest of the Alliance, but I am keeping my eye on you. Prove your worth to Adora.” Angella slid a pile of books to Catra.

“Why aren’t you giving these to Bow and Glimmer or Perfuma? They’re more equipped for this than me.”

Angella ran her fingers along the book spines. “You will find that they are not.”

Catra quickly scanned the titles and stood rigid. “These are specifically targeted for the partners of people who have been sexually abused.”

“So, they are,” Angella said, waving her hand dismissively, ushering Catra out the door.

“Adora and I are not,” Catra blushed and shook her head, “we’re just friends. Or were. I don’t know. I don’t know if she even wants me around anymore.”

“We shall see,” Angella said, spinning her chair around to look at the dusky sky.

The only thing that moved was the pounding of Catra’s heart loud in her ears. She stood, eyes locked on Angella’s back for some time before gathering the books in her arms and exiting. Catra spent her whole life with Adora and, yeah, there had been times where they felt a little more than best friends, but this whole castle was acting like it was something else. It unnerved her. They didn’t understand her or Adora, but Catra did.

When Catra entered Adora’s room, she placed the books on Adora’s desk, careful not to disturb anything there. Catra leafed through a few pages before sighing and closing the cover. It was presumptuous to start working on being a good partner when she and Adora were not friends. And the larger, blaring problem that Adora was not even here.

Though, Angella seemed to think this was important. The curiosity of what exactly Adora said to Angella pulled at Catra. If they got out of this, she and Adora could have the rest of their lifetimes to talk about it. If Adora wanted. Even though she fought it, a hopeful pang plodded through her. She shook her head and growled.

Tomorrow morning, she’d ready the room for Adora. She’d clean up her papers and the few clothes Glimmer was able to find for her and leave it as Adora had, tidy and sparse. Lingering by the bed, Catra sighed. She needed to clear her head.

Unlocking the window, Catra moved up to the roof. Lying back on uniform tiles, she crossed her hands behind her head and gazed

up at the moons. It had been Scorpia's idea to wait a day for the mission. She was right, everyone was still recovering, but it had taken every ounce of self-control for Catra to get through this day, she didn't know how she could get through the next one too.

If everything went right, Adora would be back tomorrow night. Breathing deeply through her nose, Catra let out a sigh. She knew the risks involved, but she couldn't help but hope that they would be successful. They had to be.

This was the first moment of clarity Catra had since finding out Adora was being abused by Shadow Weaver. Everything had been frantic and urgent. It still was urgent, but the plan was good. She didn't have to do this alone. She couldn't. Her pride would have been injured if she had any left. She only prayed Adora could hold on another day.

Wrapping her tail around her ankle, Catra let herself dream. What would it be like if they saved Adora? Part of Catra felt warm at the idea of staying here in Bright Moon, but a bigger part said that was not a possibility. This was all her fault. She'd make it right, but that didn't mean she should get a happy ending.

She reached out her hand, pretending Adora was there to hold it, laughing with her as they looked up at the dark clouds, edges colored green and red by the surrounding moons.

"We're coming, Adora," Catra said. "I promise."

Electricity cracked violently around Shadow Weaver. "What do you mean she's gone?"

"The prisoner's cell was found empty," a trembling voice said.

“How long has it been unoccupied?” Shadows from every corner of the room stood tall, closing in around them.

The messenger gulped. “I’m not sure, Shadow Weaver.”

“And why are we just finding out about this now?” Shadow Weaver growled, energy shooting through her fingertips.

“All the paperwork was filed correctly. She was reported delivered, but patrol just noticed minutes ago,” the messenger said, taking a step backwards, only to feel a chill shoot up their spine. “This was an inside job.”

Shadow Weaver screamed, power erupting from her. “You will find the people responsible or it’ll be your head. Am I clear?”

“Yes ma’am,” The messenger said, eyes darting to Shadow Weaver, to the electric heat, and to the icy shadows closing in on them.

“You are dismissed,” Shadow Weaver said, biting.

The soldier ran out of the room, and, when she shut the door behind her, she could hear a feral scream, making her hair stand on its end. The yell was followed by a bang, red light surging between the cracks in the door.

Shadow Weaver’s hair stood straight up, barely blowing as her power tipped to its greatest capacity. Catra would be back for Adora, and Shadow Weaver would be waiting for her.

Chapter End Notes

This Adora scene made me S A D to write. Sadder than usual.

I stopped writing flashbacks in italics since I just found out that is hard for some people to read, which totally makes sense. Late to the party, I know. Hopefully that 1. Helped with readability and 2. Was clear when there was a flashback.

I'll go back and fix the rest of the chapters to remove big blocks of italics eventually.

Next Time: The rescue mission begins. Been waiting for this for a long time, folks.

Fright Night Part I: The Descent

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Take these," Bow directed. He handed out earpieces, placing each delicately into a line of open palms. "I'm setting the channel to public. Any message you send, everyone will receive. Press down on the side button to engage your microphone. Scorpia, yours is slightly different. I made the design similar to your Force Captain badge. Communicator still in your ear, but there's an external button to pin to your shirt."

"Oh, wow," Scorpia said, turning red. "Pincer friendly and everything!"

"Reminder to keep us updated," Catra commanded, ear twitching as she fitted her specially shaped communicator. "When we start this operation, you know how far apart we'll be. Communication is our lifeline."

Scorpia and Perfuma looked at each other. Last night, Scorpia lingered at the dinner table, watching as everyone else retired to their rooms. Only Perfuma remained, relaxed and unhurried. While Scorpia searched for words, Perfuma simply said, "I think I could use someone to talk to before I can calm my mind enough to sleep. Are you interested in staying a little longer?"

Blushing, Scorpia complied. The pair talked late into the night, excusing themselves only because they needed to be rested for today's mission. Perfuma walked Scorpia to her room and, before walking across the hall to her own, hugged Scorpia goodnight. It was the reassurance Scorpia needed. Until then, she hadn't been so sure the Princesses would warm up to her, even if they were successful in rescuing Adora. Now, she felt she had a place among them. It had happened far faster than she could have anticipated, but she was prepared to go deep into the Fright Zone with three

other princesses watching her back. And Perfuma to watch Catra's.

"Angella, I opened a comm channel in the war room for you. It'll be on the same frequency. You won't be able to send messages, but you'll receive them." Bow pressed a button on the table. "You'll be able to track our position here too."

With a tight nod, Angella wrung her hands together. The table before her displayed a zoomed-out map of the Fright Zone, ten blinking dots at the edge of the map representing each member of the team. Once they got closer, those dots would start to move if the signal was strong enough.

"The Bright Moon guards and I will be waiting for you when you get back," Angella said, stifling nerves as she fixed on Glimmer, who merely adjusted her gloves again, as she had been all afternoon. "Make it to the Whispering Woods and we can aid you."

Catra eyed the map. Before first light, she had been in the war room, pouring over the plan. Not long after, Glimmer had joined her, neither able to sleep. Glimmer gave Catra more detailed information of each member of the Alliance, something they hadn't had as much of a chance to discuss in the broader audience yesterday. Catra oversaw the plan, but Glimmer was the commander and she knew her team down to their last weakness and strength.

The rest of the day was spent preparing and, mostly, waiting. Every few minutes, Catra checked the clock, longing for their agreed upon deployment time. When Scorpia caught Catra tapping her feet and growling, she'd place a pincer on Catra's shoulder. It helped some, but Catra couldn't stand the thought of Adora in danger. And every minute that passed was another she was. By the afternoon, everyone shared Catra's restlessness. Mermista got cranky. Bow started rapping his fingers against his knees or his tracker pad or anything he could get a hold of. Spinnerella and Netossa started to bicker. Tension bore its way into everyone's shoulders as the beginning of the mission neared.

Now, that time had finally arrived. A different anxiety pulsed through the group. Catra felt alert and focused. This is what she had been waiting for. It was what everyone had been waiting for. Today, they would bring Adora home.

Netossa and Spinnerella kissed, whispering words to each other before parting to stand alongside their assigned teams. As they touched, Catra watched curiously, her ears fluttering. Open affection was prohibited in the Fright Zone. Catra and Adora had grown up hiding, never able to exchange anything physical with the lights still on. With a final squeeze, Spinnerella dropped Netossa's hand before standing next to Bow and Sea Hawk, who both clamped her on the shoulder.

"It's go time," Glimmer said, meeting Catra's eyes. Catra straightened her mask and nodded.

"Good luck," Angella addressed the room. She raised a glowing fist in the air, sending a light to hang over them. "For the Rebellion and for Adora."

"For the Rebellion," Glimmer said, punching her own brilliant hand upwards.

"I will see you all back here soon," Angella said, "no exceptions."

With a deep exhale, Catra grabbed the door handle and exited the room. They descended the stairs together until they made it to Bright Moon's hangar. The teams started to break apart to their assigned craft. Netossa settled herself at the controls of one skiff and Sea Hawk took the pilot's seat in the other. Checkout started, with most team members taking stock of their transport from various angles.

While the process continued, Scorpia found Catra and, in a hushed voice said, "It's weird going back already, isn't it?" Catra bit her lip. Scorpia smiled softly, "We've got this though. Everyone here wants this and they trust us, they trust you. It's a good plan."

“Keep everyone safe, Scorpia.” Catra looked over her shoulder at her own transport, where Sea Hawk barked orders that had Frosta groaning. “I,” she said, looking away, “I can’t thank you enough for this. I don’t know what I would do without you.”

“Thank me when we’re done,” Scorpia winked. “I’ve got you, Wildcat. And, uh,” Scorpia blushed, “just keep an eye on Perfuma, okay? I mean, keep an eye on everyone but, um, you know.”

Catra smirked in response, raising an eyebrow.

Scorpia laughed nervously and started to turn around. But, before she could leave, Catra hugged her. With a gasp, Scorpia hugged back.

“Don’t make a big deal out of it,” Catra said, pushing away almost as quickly as she had started. “Be safe out there.”

Scorpia stood tall and set her face with determination. “You too.”

As soon as Scorpia left, Glimmer replaced her. “Catra?”

“What do you want, Sparkles?” Catra said, eyes now trained on her skiff, keeping watch on that sea pirate.

“I, just,” Glimmer swallowed, “get her out, okay? Even if something happens, we have to get Adora out.”

“Planning on it,” Catra flashed a grin, showing off her fangs. “And if I can’t, you will. Right?”

“Of course,” Glimmer said uncertainly. “Catra?”

“What now?” Catra said, letting annoyance trickle into her voice.

“I’m scared. What if we don’t make it? What if someone else gets captured?” Glimmer said, shifting uneasily from foot to foot.

The air puffed out of Catra. “We have to. There is no other option. Even if the plan goes to shit, I am not going down without a fight.

And you better not either."

Glimmer took a deep breath. "Promise you'll be careful."

"Don't do anything stupid," Catra warned, wagging a finger in Glimmer's face.

"Deal," Glimmer said, grinning.

"Deal," Catra replied, letting the edge of her mouth quirk up.

The whir of an engine kicked into life behind them. "It's time," Catra said, giving Glimmer one last nod before boarding her skiff. "I'll see you on the other side," she called out. Everyone boarded their assigned craft and gave a thumbs up. The hangar door opened and they were off, zooming into the darkness.

Sea Hawk and Bow chatted by the controls, with Mermista and Spinnerella not far from them. For all his absurd arrogance, it turned out Sea Hawk was as good at sailing a skiff as he was a boat, as long as Mermista was there to keep him in line. Catra stood at the nose of the craft with her hands behind her back. Trees in unbroken rows passed below, illuminated vaguely by the faint light of red and green moons. It was a quiet, windless night and they sliced through the air delicately. The earthiness of the woods filled Catra's nose, her senses sharp as her claws. They drifted away from Team One's skiff. And, soon, it disappeared completely as their trajectories diverged.

Perfuma put her hand on Catra's arm and said, "I'm proud of you."

Catra's fur fluffed up under the touch. She didn't bother to look at Perfuma. "Proud of me? You almost died because of me." Catra's features darkened, feeling the memory of flames wicking the moisture out of her skin the day she gave the order to burn Plumeria.

"You're here now." Perfuma remembered her own near-death experience, but she believed she had come back stronger from that day and so could Catra. "I know you're guilty, but all Adora is

going to want after she gets back is a friend. And not just any friend," Perfuma turned to Catra. "She needs you."

"No one needs me," Catra said. "I'm here to get Adora out and that's it. It's too late to fix everything else."

"You can fix a lot more than you think," Perfuma pressed. "Keep your heart open and you may even find that you can find a way to forgive yourself."

Catra snorted through her nose. "Yeah, whatever." This was not a conversation she was ready to have now, or ever.

"I'll have your back today and I trust you to have mine," Perfuma said, releasing Catra. "If you need to talk, I'll be meditating right here." Without waiting for a response, Perfuma sat down, crossing her legs, sitting tall, and closed her eyes. "And I'll be here tomorrow too."

Catra hissed, her tail lashing out. Perfuma was unaffected as she folded her legs beneath her.

"I heard you and Scorpia are getting along," Catra taunted, happily changing the subject.

"Scorpia is very brave," Perfuma said, shutting her eyelids and humming absently. "You're lucky to have a friend like her."

"I know that," Catra said, tail bristling.

Perfuma cracked open one eye. "She's lucky to have a friend like you too."

Snorting out through her nose, Catra turned around, ears twitching to pick up a small giggle coming from Perfuma's mouth. Whatever Catra had expected when she walked out of the Fright Zone, this was not it.

Idle conversation continued, lulling naturally as they sped towards the Fright Zone. Catra wished she could do something with her

hands. She willed them to go faster.

Catra pressed her hand to her earpiece. “Team One, status report.”

A crackling filled her speaker before Glimmer cut over, “No issues so far. We’re about fifteen minutes out from our landing point. You?”

“Team Two and Team Three also no issues,” Catra radioed.

“Thirty minutes out,” Bow said, pressing a button on his tracker pad. “I don’t know about all of you, but these have been some of the longest minutes of my life.”

“I’ll echo that,” Glimmer said, accompanying her words with a long sigh she didn’t bother turning her mic off for.

“It’ll be over soon,” Scorpia said, voice loud enough to make Catra cringe a little. “We’re almost there. We’ll be on our way back before we know it!”

“Copy that,” Bow said, triumphantly.

The last minutes crept on, but, eventually, Glimmer’s team dropped from the air and to the ground. Wanting to keep one skiff well hidden, they landed in the thick of the woods, expertly maneuvered into a small clearing by Netossa. After the journey, Glimmer sprung off, bending her knees to recalibrate for solid ground.

“How’s everyone doing?” she asked.

“Feeling fine. Feeling great,” Scorpia said, flashing a smile. “Glad to be here with all of you.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Frosta said, jumping down beside Glimmer, “Time to kick some bad guy butt.”

Netossa brushed her coat off. “Let’s do this.”

Glimmer stuck out her hand. On top of it landed Frosta's, then Netossa's, and, lastly, Scorpia nervously placed her pincer. Glimmer shut her eyes and used one of her valuable teleports to move them closer to the target. When they outlined the night, they knew Glimmer's limited resources were some of their most critical. Using a teleport now and moving three others with her did not come lightly. In the end, they figured having a skiff that would almost certainly avoid destruction was worth it.

When her eyelids fluttered open, they were in the Fright Zone.

Following not far after, Catra's crew landed their skiff amongst towering piles of scrap metal on either side. Around them, blaring spot lights scanned the area. Any closer and they'd be able to see guards out on patrol. Unable to talk or risk being detected, Bow, Sea Hawk, and Spinnerella waved goodbye. They took off in the direction of the nearest tech port and Catra could only pray they'd make it or this was about to get a lot harder.

Catra, Perfuma, and Mermista had a longer walk ahead of them. And a more dangerous one. Catra mouthed, "Ready?"

Perfuma nodded, while Mermista mouthed back, "Obviously."

The next time the searchlight passed them, they ran, slinking low to the ground and finding shelter wherever they could behind broken beams and discarded robot shells. The longer they stayed hidden, the less fighting they had to do, the more likely they were to succeed. To Catra's pleasure, Perfuma and Mermista moved gracefully. Silently, she thanked Glimmer for not leading her astray lest she end up with Sea Hawk or Frosta on her team. Without Glimmer here as a safety net, their only option was to remain undetected.

The area in front of them was all jagged rock and debris. Further ahead was shattered glass, but behind that was a wall that would conceal them. Perfuma took a step forward, but before her foot touched down, she was jerked back by a hand. Mermista covered her mouth and pointed. “Careful, I almost missed them too, but the entrance is crawling with guards.”

“Thank you, Mermista,” Perfuma grinned beneath Mermista’s fingers. “I knew you cared.”

“Don’t mention it,” Mermista said, pulling her hand back and wiping it on her pants. Perfuma’s smile remained unbroken. Mermista groaned, “Seriously, don’t.”

“It looks like you were right, Catra” Perfuma said. “They’ve increased security.”

Mermista took stock of the guards. They were all over the perimeter, dressed in full gear. Between them and the lights, it would be nearly impossible to breach the outer wall without help.

“If we can get to that next wall,” Catra said, heartrate falling back to normal speeds, “we should be safe for a while. Let’s move.”

Sinking low, Catra crawled across the expanse. It was a slow process, Mermista and Perfuma grunting from the effort of bending down. Another light passed before them, so close Catra could reach out and touch it. With a leap, Catra made it to their sanctuary for the time being. The other two followed.

“Bow, what’s your status?” Perfuma said, muffling her voice as much as possible while breathing in gasps.

“Working on it,” Bow’s voice came out through the speaker, hushed and breathing hard. “Give us a minute.” Bow looked around, exhaling in relief.

Sea Hawk pulled his sword out of a robot. Around them, four more small droids were cut in half or dented, but the sparks emitting from them died down and the bots lied still. “The threats

have been eliminated!" he whisper-shouted to Bow and Spinnerella.

Bow wiped sweat off his brow, "Let's not send that message over the comm."

"Agreed, Netossa wouldn't let me live it down that we were the first ones to draw attention," Spinnerella said with a closed fist before rubbing the back of her head and pointing. "But look, we made it. You two move in, I'm going to get to a better vantage point."

Spinnerella made a small cyclone and propelled herself to the top of a stack of hissing junk. After finding a steady place to stand, she crouched into a low squat. Out here, there was nothing more than surveillance bots and, with those Sea Hawk already destroyed, there were few close to their position. Using the communicator, she said, "You're clear to move in, Team Three."

"Heard," Bow responded. He and Sea Hawk looked around before walking to an overhang that covered the port. The searchlights were less focused on this side as it would be physically impossible to breach this tall, doorless wall from this side. The bots had been somewhat of a surprise.

"What a daring adventure!" Sea Hawk said, slapping Bow on the back when they made it to the interface.

"Hope this works," Bow said, taking a deep breath and jamming a wire connecting his tracker pad to the old port. "Come on," he said, biting his nails as he waited for the connection.

Sea Hawk peered over his shoulder. "Is it working?"

"I don't know yet," Bow whined. Catra had assured him he could figure this out, but clearly Bow's idea of technology and Catra's were different. The port here was old, but it wasn't unlike the Horde to have these sorts of things all over. The Fright Zone was constantly changing, growing so fast that not everything could be kept up with. Still, Scorpia said that ports like these gave access

for patrolling guards to check in with their superiors and get updates as their duties changed. It should work. He just had to figure out how.

Typing into his tracker pad and wiggling around his adapter, the machine hummed to life. "Yes! I'm connected. I'm just passing through the firewall now. It shouldn't be long until -"

"- Hello?" A small screen in front of them blinked to life. Bow jumped into Sea Hawk's arms and they both clung to each other. "Oh, hello Bow and," Entrapta grabbed her chin and moved her eyes closer to the screen, "have I met you?"

"Entrapta!" Bow said. "I am so happy to see you."

"Sea Hawk! The greatest sea captain in Etheria! Certainly, you've heard tales of my daring," Sea Hawk flexed, pushing Bow out of the camera's frame. He twisted his mustache and flashed a brilliant smile.

Entrapta stared blankly. "Doesn't ring a bell!"

Bow pushed a dejected Sea Hawk out of the way. "Entrapta, are you alone?"

"Of course," Entrapta said. "Well, aside from Emily and all of this," the camera panned behind her to show a dozen half-finished projects. Entrapta grinned and her eyes gleamed wildly. "Bow, you wouldn't believe what sorts of things I've made here. It's incredible!"

"Entrapta, we need your help," Bow pleaded, trying to keep Entrapta's attention.

"What do you mean? Also, why are you here? I can see you on the southern end of the Fright Zone." Entrapta's hair moved in a flurry, clicking keys. "Kind of an odd place to hang out, not that I haven't spent some time there myself. Did you see that giant pile of broken tech!?"

“We’re here to rescue Adora,” Bow said, cutting Entrapta off. “Catra and Scorpia talked to you about that right? And, Entrapta, if you want, you could come with us too. Back to Bright Moon, I mean.”

“Come with you? But why would I do that?!” Entrapta said. “Everything I need is right here. Well, in Hordak’s lab. He’s my lab partner, you know. Though he did tell me to leave his lab and never come back.” She tapped a hex driver on her chin.

“Maybe we can talk about that later,” Bow said, pulling the collar of his shirt away from his throat. Sea Hawk shrugged, still clearly upset that Entrapta had not heard of him. “But right now, do you think you could shut down the security system?”

“Why would I do that? It was a little bit of a challenge,” Entrapta said, smearing oil on her forehead. “I mean, just two days ago Hordak wanted the whole security system revamped but,” she cackled, “I did it. Do you want to see what it can do?”

Flood lights turned on all around them and, from the ceiling, a laser gun shot out from a small hatch.

“Bow! What’s going on?” Catra cried over the comm channel. “This is the opposite of helping!”

“Just stay low!” Bow replied, sweat starting to bead on his forehead afresh. “Entrapta! This is all,” Bow cringed, “amazing, but -”

“- we’re on a treasure hunt!” Sea Hawk declared, sticking one hand out in the air at the laser gun. “And we need to keep it quiet so that we can, um, we can,” Sea Hawk looked to Bow.

“So, we can discover the, um, the secrets of the deep Fright Zone tunnels!” Bow finished, wiggling his fingers.

“Ooh, what sort of treasure,” Entrapta said, eyes going wide as she moved even closer to her end of the camera. “Is it tech?”

“Turn these lights off and I’ll tell you,” Sea Hawk said, grinning and running his fingers through his hair. He placed one of his feet on a nearby box and posed with a smirk on his face.

The lights came off instantly. Bow let out a scratchy, heavy exhale.

Sea Hawk grabbed the screen. “I believe Scorpia said you were on a search for a great treasure, buried deep in the Fright Zone storage vaults!”

“Oh! The virus!” Entrapta clapped. “Yes! We located it, but we never finished the task.” Entrapta scratched her head. “Is that why you’re here? We’re going to finish the tech hunt! You know, when I scrounged for it I found out that it’s being stored with all sorts of other fascinating items. First Ones’ tech, abandoned weapons, broken parts, and even some mysteries I haven’t gotten to uncover!” Entrapta glowed. “It’s a scientist’s dream!”

Sea Hawk practically had stars in his eyes. “Exactly! A trove just waiting for us to unleash its secrets!”

Bow looked back in forth between the two of them and threw his hands up in frustration.

“So that’s why you want security offline. Why didn’t you say so?” Entrapta said, tapping buttons at a superspeed rate using both her hair and fingers now. Distant search lights flipped off and the hum that had been in their ears since they stepped off the skiff left their ears in deafening silence.

“We’re in,” Bow said, holding his hands to his earpiece.

“Finally,” Catra said over the radio. “Glimmer, Team One can move in. Team Two is also approaching. Team Three, keep an eye on Entrapta and make sure we don’t run into any surprises.”

“Heard,” Bow said. “Hey, Entrapta, do you think you could show me what you’ve been up to? I’d love to see what you’ve, um, done with the place?”

“You want to see what I’ve done?” Entrapta asked. She squealed in delight.

Sea Hawk and Bow just shrugged. Behind them, Spinnerella dropped her fists, which had been encased in swirling wind since the lights came on. As far as she could see, no new threats approached. “All is good with Team Three, for now,” she radioed.

“We’re in position. Team One going radio silent,” Glimmer said with a click. Lowering her fists, Glimmer took a deep breath as she took stock of her team.

“That could have been smoother,” Netossa said, glancing at the net behind her holding in two unconscious Horde soldiers who had gotten a taste of Scorpia’s venom.

“We’re here, aren’t we? And no one else is coming,” Glimmer said.

“As far as we can tell,” Netossa pointed out, tossing a net from one hand into the other.

“Well then we better get moving.” Glimmer rubbed her forehead. From the woods, they walked until they were nearly on top of the storage unit they would have to climb down into. The guards picked them out almost immediately, but Frosta was faster. It had been a close call, but their schedule remained unaffected. The deeper they went, the easier it should get. Break the disc and get out. It was easy, the easiest task of the groups, but it was an important one. Glimmer wanted it done quickly so she could join what was likely going to be a much more dangerous fight for Adora’s life within the Black Garnet Chamber.

“It’s this way,” Scorpia said. “The closer, the better, right?”

“Right. If we can get closer, I can teleport us into the correct storage unit. I’ve studied the map enough, anyway,” Glimmer smiled sheepishly, “I think.”

“We can’t keep waiting around,” Frosta urged. “Bodyguard says move!”

Scorpia flashed her version of a thumbs up before slinking off to the nearest door. With security offline, it was a matter of knowing which buttons to press. She fumbled initially, but the door slid open. Glimmer caught herself sighing again. At this point, almost every breath felt like a relief, but they had a long night ahead of them.

The door opened to a narrow hallway, much smaller than the halls Glimmer had seen before and much older looking. The walls were a sleek, dark green, etched with scratches and misshapen in places. There were lights studding the ceiling, dim and held in cages to prevent breakage as items were hauled in and out.

“How long has this been here?” Glimmer asked, tracing her fingers on the walls. “This pre-dates the Horde, doesn’t it?”

“You bet, this is from the ancient Scorpion Kingdom!” Scorpia said. “Not that I know much about it, actually, at all. My grandad was the last real king, you know, before the Horde. Anyway, time to go down!” Scorpia opened a door on her right. Behind it was a stairwell even more sparsely lit than the hallway. The light above the door flickered violently. The handrail of the first set of steps was broken, hanging loosely and swaying on the crumbling stone path. Scorpia scooted ahead and held it aside. “Sorry about that! Oh, wow, this stairwell really doesn’t get much use, does it?”

“I guess not,” Netossa said, touching her forefinger to the wall. When she came in contact, some of the stone fell away. Frosta’s fists flared to life, but Netossa grabbed her shoulder. “Keep calm for now. No one’s bothered us much so far.”

Glimmer glared at Netossa.

“And Spinnerella and I might have bet on who would trigger the alarm first.” Netossa’s hands flew in the air. “What? I bet on our team succeeding long before anything else happened. Just so you know.”

“Wow, that’s, um,” Scorpia rubbed the back of her head, “very nice of you? I mean, I certainly feel better.”

Glimmer shook her head. “Let’s go.”

The metal and stone groaned and broke beneath their feet as their descent began. Frosta, bringing up the back, turned around, ears searching for something other than the creaking noises of the stairs. Nothing came. She narrowed her eyes and took another step down.

“Catra, your team should be good to proceed,” Bow said.

“Um, what makes it your team?” Mermista said, pointing at Catra’s chest.

Catra snarled. “Look, I don’t care. I named it Team Two, but no one seems to remember that. Would you rather we call it Team Friendship and Rainbows?” Catra threw her hands out, or she would have if her elbows weren’t currently crammed into her ribs.

“I think that’s nice,” Perfuma said, folding her hands.

Mermista scoffed. “No, I’d rather be called the, oh! Salineas Saboteurs.” Mermista fisted her hand and then dropped it. “There’s this *really* good book called - wait,” Mermista scanned Catra, “you probably, like, have never read a book, right?”

“I’ve read books!” Catra said between her teeth.

“But like, probably not anything good. Like, oh,” Mermista’s eyes went wide, “have you read any Mer-mysteries books? They’re my favorite.”

“Why would I have read that? Sounds like a waste of time,” Catra said, pushing past Mermista as she leaned to peer at the obstacles barring them from their entrance.

Mermista huffed. “Once we get out of here, you’re going to read them. Then you can admit how good of taste I have.”

“Fine,” Catra said, pulling her hair, “whatever.”

“I’m holding you to that,” Mermista smiled. “No taking my books, holding on to them for years, and never reading them. And don’t give me any shit about it. You basically just promised, or whatever.”

Flattening her ears, Catra hissed, but Mermista only smiled. “Are you always this annoying?” Catra asked.

They had been waiting for Bow to get Entrapta in line forever. Crammed into this wall, all three of them started to sweat, knowing their time of staying hidden wouldn’t last long if they couldn’t get moving. Together, they bent closer to their crappy shelter every time a guard walked by. Now, all the adrenaline inside them could be put to good use. Catra flexed her fingers, claws unsheathing dangerously.

There were soldiers and robots practically crawling all over this side. If there was another way, Catra would retreat and find it. But, there simply wasn’t time.

Perfuma smiled at them. “Ready?”

“I guess so,” Mermista said, but she smiled dangerously.

Catra nodded and watched as both princesses summoned their powers. In an instant, a tall wave bloomed out of nowhere.

“These sewers are sort of my jam,” Mermista whispered in Catra’s ear before she threw the water down, flooding the ground in front of them in a torrential blast.

Perfuma’s plants were not far behind. Many of the Horde soldiers were taken out before they even knew to react. Perfuma tied them up and moved them behind trash piles. Someone else would find them later. By that time, Catra hoped they would already be gone.

Catra ran out, looking for traces of anyone they missed. Right around a corner, she came face to face with a maskless soldier whose hand was frozen right above their own earpiece.

“No you don’t!” Catra said, lunging at them. Catra knocked the soldier to the ground and pinned their hands above their head. “Not a word,” Catra showed her fangs and ripped their earpiece out, cracking it in her claws. The soldier went limp and wide eyed beneath her.

Vines wrapped around them, starting at their ankles and working upwards. When they struggled, Catra smiled and jumped off them, letting Perfuma finish her work, leaving a fully bloomed flower over the soldier's face.

Smugly, Catra crossed her arms and looked around. Then, a splash hit the back of her head. Turning on her heel, fists at her side she snarled at Mermista, who lowered her hands behind her back innocently.

“Sorry, thought I saw something,” Mermista said, running fingers through her hair.

“Let’s just go!” Catra said, taking off running again. The other two caught up right as the door opened. When Catra looked down, she saw a familiar hallway. If she went left here, she’d be at her old room in a minute. If she went left and took the second right, she’d be back at the cadet barracks. A few days ago, it would have been as easy as that. Now, she was somehow fighting alongside the Rebellion she fought so hard to defeat.

She stared for a moment before Perfuma placed her hand on her shoulder. “Come on, we’ve got your back,” she said.

“We’re inside,” Mermista said into the comm. “On our way to the Hordak’s weirdo Sanctum. Who calls it a Sanctum anyway? Seems pretentious.”

“Bow, how are you?” Catra asked.

A long crackle went through the comm. “Um, just fine. Can you please hurry? It’s getting weird here.”

“What do you mean?” Catra asked, almost spitting.

“Um,” Bow looked around. From the other side of the screen, Entrapta was rummaging around the lab, using her hair to swing from pipes and grab items, while Sea Hawk sang a song about her every move. “Never mind, we’re fine. Just go!”

Mermista pulled at Catra’s sleeve and jerked her head down the hall. With a deep breath, Catra led the way through the hallways she’d known her whole life, squatting low to stay in the shadows. They stayed quiet, making their way slowly to Hordak’s Sanctum.

Frosta whipped around again.

“Is something wrong?” Glimmer whispered, still descending what felt like an endless staircase. Somehow, the lights had become even more sparse. What had started as normal fluorescent bulbs, transformed into dull red light, glowing more with what felt like old magic than electricity.

“I just,” Frosta paused, looking up the stairwell again, “I keep hearing something. But, when I look, nothing is there.”

“It’s just these old stairs,” Scorpia said. “Hordak built a lift system here, you saw it on the map. Obviously, that is used much more frequently which is why we took this way. But, um, yeah, you

already know that. I just don’t think anyone comes this way anymore. A lot of what was here before the Horde has been buried or transformed, but underneath, there’s this. It’s like going back in time.”

Scorpia tapped the wall, causing a panel to fall loose. Netossa pinned her up against the wall immediately. “Stop doing that.”

“Oh, sorry,” Scorpia said, blushing.

Glimmer glanced around. The lower they went, the more nervous she got. Frosta wasn’t the only one hearing things. Every shadow started to look like a bot or a soldier, or even Shadow Weaver. How could Adora have grown up here? Surrounded by all this danger and disrepair? It was downright creepy. Granted, Scorpia and Catra said they’d never set foot down here. There were stories, of course, of soldiers that were reassigned to guard the storage who never came back.

A shiver started with the small hairs on Glimmer’s neck and ran down her back, the sensation making it feel like someone was trailing their fingers down the backs of her arms.

They moved downward, turning at every landing to face the opposite direction. Everyone glanced around more than they had at the start. It kept getting quieter, their steps louder, and darker as they got further and further underground. Several flights of stairs earlier, the air had started to feel stale and, several flights above that, it had started to get cold. Now, the stairs were steeper. Instead of sand and dust shifting beneath them, full pieces of concrete broke off, sending Glimmer sprawling once on a particularly fractured area.

There was condensation on the walls. Glimmer ran her hand through it and they came back smeared with a brown, oily substance that looked bloody under the lights. The sensation that they were being watched grew stronger.

The stairway ended abruptly. One, single lightbulb sputtered at the bottom. When it flickered out, the shadows ran to them and, when the light flickered on, it washed them in the coldest light Glimmer had ever felt.

"I guess we open the door now," Glimmer said. Her voice, quiet as she tried to be, echoed around them.

Netossa visibly flinched. "This is getting super creepy. Let's go get this thing and get out."

"Yeah, you know" Scorpia rubbed her chin. "I've never been down here. The Fright Zone has its fair share of spooky corners, but this might take the cake. Who knows the last time these stairs were used."

"I think we should keep moving," Frosta said, staring up into the abyss now covering them.

Glimmer grabbed the door and turned the knob, rust coating her hand. She wiped it on her leg, leaving an iron smear. She placed both palms against the door and pushed. The door grinded against the floor. Glimmer groaned, straining against it, until Scorpia added her strength. Together, they pried it open.

The door was wide open now. Glimmer squinted. "It's . . . dark."

"I don't like this," Frosta said, staring up again.

"Are we sure this is the right way?" Glimmer asked, looking up to Scorpia.

"This is it," Scorpia frowned. Lifting her pincer to her ear she said, "Hey, Team Three, breaking silence can you see us?"

Their communicators only returned static. "We thought that might be a problem," Netossa said.

"Yeah, but we also didn't think we'd have to walk down an abandoned shaft," Glimmer said. With a heavy sigh, she lifted her

hands. “I can help.” Pink light started to surround her and she extended it just enough to light a few feet in front of them.

“Are you,” Scorpia looked at Frosta, “I mean, is that a good idea?”

“It doesn’t use that much energy. What other ideas do you have?” Glimmer took a step forward. “I’m not going down there blind.”

Netossa took a step forward. “Let’s hurry.”

Frosta looked up again, a distinct creak bellowing down to them from above. She turned around once more before slipping into the hallway, pushing the group forward.

Catra’s chest heaved, moving up and down rapidly. Another soldier laid at her feet, slowly being dragged away with vivid, flowered plants under Perfuma’s command. Beside her, Mermista brushed stray hairs behind her ear that had flown out of their normal place in the scuffle. Coming around the corner, Perfuma rubbed her hands together, dusting off the dirt that had been kicked up in the hallway.

“That’s the last of them,” Perfuma said, sucking in large slices of air.

“Are we getting any closer?” Mermista strained, collapsing against the wall of the small alcove they were pressed into.

Catra pinched her nose. “I told you, we’re making progress, but it is slow. If we could just keep moving, you wouldn’t have to be bothered with updates.”

“Now, now,” Perfuma said, grabbing Catra and Mermista’s hands, “we are on a team. We need to trust one another.”

Mermista rolled her eyes. “I’d trust Catra more if she didn’t flinch every time I used my powers.”

“Hey! If you had better aim, I wouldn’t have to keep dodging,” Catra said sticking out her tongue.

Perfuma frowned, eye twitching. This day was already long enough without her team, who were supposed to be friends, fighting. Her patience exasperated she frowned, a shadow descending over her. “Get along,” she commanded darkly.

Mermista and Catra looked at each other and gulped. Mermista nodded.

“That’s more like it,” Perfuma smiled. The shadows that were previously there, left, leaving Perfuma’s face shining and content as it usually was. Mermista and Catra eyed her again before shrugging their shoulders towards one another. The flowers in Perfuma’s short hair seemed to bloom even more fully as she said, “Alright then, should we keep moving?”

Motioning over her shoulder, Catra led the way. This was the second time they’d had to stop to catch their breaths. The guards kept coming. So far, they were keeping up with them, but their luck was going to end soon. The crisscrossing hallways of the Fright Zone only became more convoluted ahead. There were too many doorways. Too many turns. They were going to get caught, but the closer they could get without detection, the closer they would be to getting Adora out without a confrontation with Shadow Weaver.

They were running now. Catra opened a few doors along the way, checking behind each one for signs of movement. The cameras, at least, she didn’t have to worry about anymore. Whatever Bow was doing, it was keeping Entrapta quiet.

There hadn’t been a message from Team One in a long time now. Catra kept listening and waiting, but nothing came. She cursed Glimmer under her breath, while knowing full well it wasn’t the

princess's fault. Catra reminded that no news was better than bad news. But, no news could also mean failure. Or that someone was hurt. Even if they got Adora out, would she be able to recover knowing one or more of her friends died saving her?

Hissing again at Glimmer, Catra focused on the ear that didn't have a device jammed into it. Any footsteps or breaths she could detect now, could save her team later.

Catra spared a glance behind her to check on Mermista and Perfuma. The same dreamy smile that dotted Perfuma's face was there. And, then, it wasn't. A scowl took over instantly. Mermista's eyes went wide. Catra's ears flattened against her scalp as the Horde alarm trumpeted around them. Red lights flashed intermittently over the top of bright flood lights that had ignited with a heavy thunk, exposing them right as they came to the heart of the Fright Zone.

Soldiers came out from every direction, flipping on stun batons until they crackled dangerously, spitting out uneven bolts of electricity between their prongs. They were surrounded in an instant, their backs to a wall.

"Fuck," Catra said, raising her claws. She bared her teeth and was ready to spring when Mermista pushed her backwards.

"You ready for that thing?" Mermista said, smiling at Perfuma.

"You know it!" Perfuma responded. In tandem, the princesses let the magic of Etheria flow through them.

"What are you doing!? What thing?" Catra shouted. A soldier moved closer. With her free hand, Perfuma pushed Catra behind them, pinning her between the wall and their bodies. "Let me go!"

"Don't move!" Mermista said with hard eyes. She raised her hands and hot water vents broke, buckling the pipes until steam was pouring out of them. With a yell, Mermista stopped the droplets motionless. They hung in the air, fighting gravity in suspended

animation. It was otherworldly as the droplets were pushed above the heads of the Horde, a raincloud ready to fall.

Sweat ran down Catra's cheek. Instead of falling to the ground, the droplets fell upwards, joining the storm cloud overhead. Catra gawked. Mermista's sweat joined the cloud, flying off her face in droves and she held the water above them.

While Mermista's body shook, Perfuma hummed, sending only one single vine out from her feet and into the masses. With a grunt, Mermista dropped the water, letting it splatter harmlessly to the floor. Mermista kept the Rebels dry, pushing outwards from them, but the soldiers around them got soaked. It annoyed them, but they seemed, otherwise unharmed.

"What are you doing?!" Catra yelled, trying to scramble out from behind Perfuma and Mermista's.

"Just watch," Mermista said over her shoulder.

The Horde started to yell a battle cry as they closed in, sloshing through the water that sat up to their ankles. That is, all but a soldier standing front and center. Perfuma's plant slid against her ankles. The soldier yelped and kicked down hard, crushing the root into the ground. Instead of breaking, the creeping plant twisted around the guard's foot. She yelled, drawing the attention of others surrounding her and causing confusion in the back. Perfuma flexed her hand, pulling her fingers down to her palm. With a jerk, the plant pulled forward, taking out the legs of its target and causing her to hit the ground.

Catra's eyes widened as she realized what was happening. The stun baton of Perfuma's victim touched and then tore through the water Mermista placed around them. Mermista was still deeply focused, creating a barrier so that not even a drop would hit Catra or Perfuma. Every soldier crumpled to the floor, paralyzed. Before the current could keep ripping through their bodies, Mermista pulled the water away, shoving it down one of the many pipes she'd broken. She wiped her brow and said, "Phew. Cool, right?"

Every single soldier in the hallways was on the ground, bodies twitching.

“Nice one,” Perfuma said, high fiving Mermista.

Catra just gaped at them.

“We have a few tricks up our sleeves too. Don’t act so surprised.” Mermista said, putting her hands on her hips.

“Yeah,” Catra said looking at the ground, “okay.” Catra had not been expecting that. Not even a little. Maybe she should have been more afraid of these two when she was fighting them. Perfuma had held off She-ra, after all, and Mermista, what the fuck had she just done?

“Ugh, come on,” Mermista grabbed Catra’s hand and pulled her forward. “We’re here now, aren’t we?”

Catra stopped in front of the door. Hordak’s Sanctum. She activated the communicator. “We’re in. Team Two is in.”

They were far enough away from the stairwell now that the only light source was Glimmer. Around them, they could hear leaking water through the walls, but they didn’t see anything but pools of it under their feet. Scorpia’s hair grazed the top of the tunnel, giving her a creeping feeling that ran down the backs of her ears. Between the drips of water was a slow, scratching noise. It was constant, like the sound of a creature scraping their claws against the stone as they walked endlessly through this labyrinth. Every so often, one of them would jump when they hit a rock or thought they heard something deeper, hidden beneath the surface.

Any sense of time they previously had was gone. It was just one step after the next, each one simultaneously like a great

accomplishment and a horrendous mistake.

The muscles of Glimmer's forearms started to feel fatigued from the force with which she clenched her fists. The cords in her neck strained as she swept her eyes side to side, searching for something, anything, but all she saw was endless darkness and her own breath fogging in front of her. How far underground were they now? It was abandoned and ancient here. She wondered if even her mother knew of this place. It felt more like they were passing underneath a mountain than under the Fright Zone.

Her breath quickened. What if they got trapped down her and she couldn't teleport them out? She only sort of knew where they were in the long hall. When she had seen it on the map, it looked like any other hall, not this. This tunnel seemed to stretch on and on. Without knowing her place in it, it wouldn't be safe to teleport. A hand fell on her shoulder, spooking her.

"Sorry about that," Netossa said, "It's okay Glimmer. We're here together. So far everything has been right where it's supposed to be. This is right. We have to trust that this is right."

"I guess so," Glimmer said, trailing off. It was more than her forearms that felt fatigue now. She could feel her magic being depleted. Fighting against every instinct, she dimmed the lights. "Nothing's changed, I'm going to conserve my strength." Glimmer hoped they couldn't hear the shake rattling through her body in her voice. If Adora or Bow were here, they would be laughing. But they weren't. She had to find strength on her own.

The rest of the walk was interrupted only by small gasps of surprise or deep sighs sounding behind her. She might not be able to tell time, but if they weren't going to arrive soon, she was going to turn them around and find another way.

As if her wishes had been granted, Glimmer came to a halt. "Here's the door," Glimmer said, grasping for it like it would disappear if she didn't hang on. "I never thought we'd make it."

Scorpia laughed nervously behind her. “Nope, the door was here just like we knew it was all along, right?”

Glimmer opened it. Thankfully, behind it there was a lit hallway. And not just red, eerie lighting that made everything look a little more severe, but warm yellow giving the impression they were closer to the surface than they were.

“Let me in front,” Frosta said. “I’m the bodyguard and we know there’s going to be guards ahead. I get to take care of them.”

They took off running, wasting no time now that they could see more than a meter ahead. And, soon enough, ran into the guards Frosta recalled from this morning’s briefing. She handily incapacitated them, leaving them locked into ice until Scorpia stung them and Netossa tied them up.

With the threats removed, they finally took in the room in which they were standing. The ceilings were impossibly high above them, stretching out until they faded away into blackness. The walls were cracked and covered in the Horde emblem, but beneath that there were huge murals, faded with time. The depictions showed humans with pincers. Rows and rows of them, stretching down the corridor endlessly.

There were tall wooden doors, towering over Glimmer’s head, but they even looked huge next to Scorpia.

“Whoa,” Scorpia said. “I knew my family’s kingdom had massive underground vaults, but wow!” She laughed. “This is gigantic. Who knew the Horde was using these? Good thing Entrapta knew where to look, we would never have found this without her.”

“Scorpia, this is amazing,” Glimmer said. “Someday, we can come back, maybe use the more traveled path. We could find out so much about your family from these paintings.”

“I think I would,” Scorpia smiled sadly, “I would really like that. Wow, I can’t believe they built this. They must have been really

powerful. Once, long ago, anyway. Nothing like now." She cast her eyes aside.

"Who knows, if the Rebellion takes down the Horde, maybe we'll see just how strong the Scorpion Kingdom really is," Glimmer said.

"To think I'd never have come here if, well, you know," Scorpia blushed. "Anyway, we have a mission. Time for all of this later."

"Glimmer, we're close enough here, teleport us in," Netossa said, sticking out her hand. The four of them joined manus in the center.

"Team One," Glimmer radioed. "If you can hear us, we're in."

Waiting a breath, Glimmer hoped for a few encouraging words from Bow or even Catra, but the line stayed dead.

After pausing for an inappropriately long time, Glimmer blinked them away. They hit the exact location Glimmer had been memorizing for days. When it appeared around them, Glimmer pumped a fist in joy, not bothering to stifle her laughter in the massive cavern, even as it echoed dully. There were bookcases gigantic and bending over them. The shelves were packed with things Glimmer could not imagine the use for. It was like being in a large, abandoned library, but for junk and mysteries as old as Etheria itself.

Dust blanketed everything. As they walked, they left footprints in it. "This is unreal," Glimmer said. "Is this really all stuff from the Horde?"

"Some of this must still be from my family," Scorpia said, "I can't believe it. I sort of, well," she craned her neck up, "I didn't think there was anything left. I've never heard anything about this place until we went hunting for the virus."

"That's probably why Hordak put that piece of First Ones' tech down here though, right?" Netossa offered. "The Horde has been so active lately that most of their equipment probably isn't retired

as often anymore. Hordak had to start somewhere. Guess he remembered this place but didn't have a lot of uses for it."

"I guess so," Glimmer said, walking forward.

As they walked, they gaped up at the surroundings. Endless shelves lit in deep blue light in what felt more like a place hidden at the bottom of an ocean or at the core of Etheria than beneath the Fright Zone. A beat up, red rug flowed the length of the vault, leading them right to an enormous safe. Glimmer examined the door, tracing the lock with her fingers.

"So, Glimmer do you just like," Frosta knocked on the safe wall, "teleport in there, break the thing, and that's it?"

Glimmer looked at Scorpia who shrugged. Netossa nodded her head.

"We did it guys!" Glimmer said, giggling. "This will be over in just a sec. Be right back!"

Glimmer disappeared. Scorpia smiled at Frosta who gently swung up an ice fist for a fist pound from Netossa.

"I'm ready to get out of this place," Frosta said, "no offense to your family, but it's creepy down here."

Scorpia put up her pincers. "Oh, none taken. This place would be a nightmare to renovate. You should see the old palace sometime though. Not that it is exactly, well, whole anymore."

Netossa folded her arms. "What's taking so long?"

On cue, Glimmer popped up, looking like she had just been pulling out her hair. She turned several shades paler.

"What's wrong?" Scorpia said, jumping to Glimmer's aide.

"It's," Glimmer swallowed down tears, "It's not there. The disc isn't here!"

“Are you sure? Maybe it was like in a barrel or something? Don’t you think it could have been hidden?” Scorpia asked, grasping Glimmer by the shoulder.

“It is empty! It’s completely empty,” Glimmer yelled, enraged. “This is Team One,” she spat into her mic, “It isn’t here. The disc isn’t here.”

No response came from the other end. But, something did happen.

The door they teleported past swung open, creaking on its old hinges and sending out a cloud of dust to blind them. On the ceiling above it, electricity hummed, filling the space with a low note, scratching the bottom of their hearing range. A flash lit up the area. A deep thunk vibrated at their throats and then another light turned on, closer to them this time. Frozen in place, they felt the vibrations grow stronger and stronger, until it rang in their ears, deafening them. Another light. And then another. And, then, the light was on them, illuminating them so brightly Glimmer felt her eyes burn.

The scrape of metal on stone, like a chain sliding on slate, filled the room. The sound bounced off the high ceilings and echoed all around them. Eyes finally adjusting, Glimmer searched the room for its source.

“Look!” Frosta pointed at the ceiling. “I knew someone was following us!”

“Or something,” Netossa suggested as she shielded her eyes.

Dust and bits of rock started to crumble above them. It cascaded out in a thick fog of particulate, settling heavily in the dusty room.

Glimmer squinted into the light, following the trails of dust. “What is that?!”

The dust started to settle. Glimmer searched the sky, blinking away the afterimage burned into her retinas by the bright lights.

Tension and fear permeated her body, sinking deep into her back muscles until they started to burn.

The scraping returned, louder this time. Then, a large object fell from the sky, landing with a deafening crack in front of them. Gasping, Glimmer took a step back. Scorpia pulled her back further still until they were all almost touching the back wall.

The metallic hunk started to change, untwisting long limbs away from its core. From far away, it would look like a massive spider, eight separate, multi-jointing legs jutting out of a thick body. From close, it was much more terrifying. Red eyes littered its frame, blinking slowly and what could only be described as long fangs dripping with some sort of mysterious green ooze. It was covered in thick metal plates. But, on top of the armor, were sharp spines that almost looked like hair except for the dangerous glint on the tip of each one. Along the left side, the spines were covered in some sort of dull substance, appearing matte and red instead of brilliant and metallic. Glimmer felt bile rise in her throat.

When it rose to its full height, it was the only thing that adequately filled the room.

Glimmer tossed a sparkling, pink energy blast towards its prominent center eye. The blast gleaned of it, carelessly. The energy ricocheted on to a nearby wall, blasting it to pieces that slid to the ground in a landslide.

Staggering back, Glimmer's eyes widened.

"Glimmer!" Netossa pulled Glimmer back. "Get us out of here now!"

Glimmer, shell-shocked, stared at the beast in front of them. Along its body, she could see long lines and shapes accented with diamonds and dots. This behemoth was powered by First Ones tech.

"Now!" Netossa screamed.

Before Netossa even finished the word, Glimmer teleported them out, breathing heavy. “I don’t have enough power to get us back to the top. We need to warn everyone.”

“Bow!” Netossa yelled. “Bow! Please come in!”

Nothing. A jangling sounded at the door behind them before the lock plummeted to the ground and the door was blown off its hinges.

“Run!” Scorpia said, pulling them along.

“And that’s what I - oh,” Entrapta said, averting her eyes to a large computer screen. “Oooh,” she smiled.

“Entrapta?” Bow asked. No response came. “Entrapta!”

“Oh, hmm?” she asked, typing something idly. “Are you talking to me?”

“What’s going on!?” Bow said. “Did something bad happen?”

“Bad?” Entrapta asked. “Why would it be bad!?” She stood up, hair bolstering her even higher as she laughed. “I haven’t had a real test run yet. Fascinating.”

“Entrapta, what are you talking about?” Bow squeaked.

“TARANTULA. It stands for Technical Assault Robot and - oh, maybe,” Entrapta’s eyes went wide, staying glued to one of what, Bow had found out, was many screens in her personal lab.

“That doesn’t sound good!” Bow said.

“It’s one of my projects! Hordak said it was too big to transport, but I knew we’d find a use for it in the underground storehouse.

That place is huge!”

“The storehouse? Entrapta, is there something down there!? Glimmer is down there, remember? And our other friends!” Bow said.

“Oh,” Entrapta said. “And that’s . . . bad?”

“Very bad if that thing is a weapon!” Bow said.

“It isn’t a weapon,” Entrapta replied. Bow let out a giant sigh of relief. “It’s so much more than that! Magic resistant armor. Strength unmatched by anything else in our arsenal. Agile and flexible enough to move around quickly. Laser guns. Venomous spines! It even works underwater! The tech I got in the Northern Reach is at its core.”

Bow cried out in panic. When he looked at Sea Hawk, he just shrugged. “Spinnerella, you need to get down there immediately!”

“Heard,” was all Spinnerella replied before taking off towards the vaults. It was a long way, but she had been waiting all day to go save her wife. Now that real danger was here, she felt more worried than smug as she pushed with the power of a cyclone and maneuvered to her destination.

“Entrapta, please,” Bow begged, “Call it off!”

“I don’t think I can do that,” Entrapta said.

“Why not?” Bow asked. “Please Entrapta. What if one of our friends gets hurt?”

“I don’t mean I won’t. I mean I can’t!” Entrapta said. “There isn’t an off button.”

“You can’t be serious!” Bow gripped the screen tightly.

“Why would I not be?” Entrapta asked, cocking her head slightly to the side.

“Bow! What’s going on?” Catra’s voice, angry and stressed, cracked over the comm for what Bow felt was the millionth time. Bow jumped, almost dropping his tracker pad in the process.

“Team One is in trouble. We need to move faster,” he reported.

Catra grunted over the comm. “Fine,” she said and then cut out.

“This isn’t a good idea,” Kyle whispered, loud enough that it echoed around them.

“Cut it out, Kyle!” Lonnie said, jabbing him in the ribs.

“Ow,” Kyle moaned.

When the prison alarm had gone off, they, along with Rogelio, had been called to immediate action. Their orders were simple: find the intruders and kill on the spot. They had, to Kyle’s ever-growing anxiety, dismissed those orders. They suited up along with their squadron, but when the time came, they snuck away.

There could be only one thing Catra had come back for and that was Adora. They probably would have been better prepared for action had Kyle not lost the communication device Bow gave him two days ago. Rogelio had endlessly berated him for it and, to his credit, Kyle felt terrible. Also to his credit, their barracks had gotten surprise searched several times in the last few days and, if it had been found, there would have been hell to pay.

“It’s just so,” Kyle cringed, “creepy in here! I can’t believe we’re doing this. Are you sure we should be in here?”

Rogelio nudged him in the back and made a few soft noises. They kept working their way against the wall, nearly at their destination.

“Rogelio is right. Our time is running out anyway. Sooner or later they would have found out we were the ones who freed Catra,” Lonnie said.

“Is that so?” someone asked from in front of them.

Startled, they all froze, huddling together.

Kyle started to quiver and lost his footing. “Oh no!” Kyle cried, pulling his hair and tumbling out into the dim light. Rogelio nimbly followed him, helping Kyle to his feet.

Lonnie stepped from behind Hordak’s throne, igniting her stun baton and shielding Rogelio and Kyle. “Show yourself.”

In response, another stun baton ignited, illuminating a familiar eyepatch. Octavia soon was flanked by four other soldiers creeping up out of the darkness. “Feeling bold today, aren’t you cadet?”

Kyle stared at them. “Lonnie, we should go!” Rogelio batted Kyle lightly on the side of the head.

“Listen to you boyfriend,” Octavia said, “and maybe I won’t kill you.”

Lonnie growled. “Kyle! Do what we came here to do! I’ll take care of her,” she said, charging straight at Octavia without a shred of fear. Rogelio yelled and joined her, swiping the feet out from under one of the soldiers before they had even raised their fists.

A stun baton came down hard at Lonnie’s head, but she blocked it, falling to one knee for extra support. Sparing a glance backwards she screamed, “Kyle, go!” Octavia punched Lonnie in the face, causing blood to stream out of her nose.

Another soldier punched Rogelio in the stomach, making him cry out, but not double over. Rogelio picked him up and threw him at the soldier who had just recovered from being tripped.

Behind them, Kyle's heart pumped quickly. His best friends in the world were in danger and he was frozen to the ground.

Throwing Octavia off, Lonnie aimed a kick at her side. Ready for it, Octavia caught her and twisted Lonnie's leg. As she fell, Lonnie jabbed a fist out, connecting with Octavia's knee. They hit the ground together, struggling to gain the upper hand.

"You little traitor. You think you're going to get out of here alive?" Octavia spat, catching Lonnie in the ribs and pinning her down.

"If I go, I'm taking you with me." Lonnie slammed her head into Octavia's, sending them both reeling.

Rogelio looked at Kyle and gestured at him before taking and giving another blow.

With teary eyes, Kyle set his jaw and gave a terse nod.

The scuffle carried on as Kyle finally willed his feet to move. "The sword. I'm just supposed to get the sword. And then," he panicked, slapping his face to stay focused. "And then, ugh, what are we doing? Where is this stupid thing?"

Kyle spotted it. The sword was sitting upright, basically on display, in the center of Hordak's lab. He walked up to it, looking over his shoulders repeatedly until he stood at arm's length. The sounds from the fight only grew louder as he gazed at the sword in awe.

He plucked it from its spot and it immediately dropped to the ground. It clanged loudly when it hit the tiled floor. "How does Adora carry this thing?" he said, sucking in breath. He bent to pick it up, this time prepared for its weight.

"And what exactly," a voice sounded behind him, "do you think you're doing?"

The sword clanged out of Kyle's hands before he was even upright. As he scanned his eyes upward, his fear and anxiety

came to a peak. Hordak. Of course, Hordak was here. That made sense, right? This was Hordak's lab in Hordak's Sanctum.

"Oh, um," Kyle stuttered, "sir. I came to, um," Hordak lifted an eyebrow, "to, bring the sword to She-ra." Kyle coughed and then, remembering himself, saluted.

"Is that so?" Hordak asked, anger tilting nearer to the surface now.

"Yes, there are intruders, you see and I -"

"- You think I don't know that?" Hordak yelled, coming a step closer. "You think I wouldn't know if I had made that particular order?"

Kyle hid behind his hands. Momentary silence filled his ears. "Okay, okay, Kyle! Breathe," he said to himself. Inhaling, he stood taller. "You can do this, Kyle! What else do you have to lose?"

Hordak was taken aback, confused by the display in front of him. He faltered for a moment before returning with spitting anger. "How dare you question my authority. You are nothing to me."

Gulping, Kyle raised his fists. Even he could see them shaking, violently jerking so much he could hardly keep his fists closed. Tears pricked at his eyes. He shook his head and tried to be brave like Lonnie or Rogelio. Or even like Adora or Catra. But that just wasn't Kyle. He wasn't smart or strong or good at things.

Hordak laughed at him, taking another step forward, which caused Kyle to jump back and knock off a pile of metal objects from the table from behind him.

"Yeah, well," Kyle said, hearing Rogelio's battle cry, "y-you're not very nice!"

Hordak laughed. "It's time for you to go."

Kyle's mouth went dry. He heard Lonnie yell again. They were his friends. They were in trouble. Still shaking, Kyle raised his fists back up, grinding his teeth together. Fine. If he was going to die, the least he could do was stand up for them.

Pulling back his fist, Hordak aimed at Kyle's face, throwing his weight into the punch.

In anticipation, Kyle ducked, years of training finally coming to fruition as muscle memory he didn't think he had clicked into place. With his eyes closed and a feral yell, he threw his own punch harder than he ever had before, aimed straight at Hordak's diaphragm.

His fist collided into Hordak so hard it hurt. Opening one eye and then two when no retaliatory hit came Kyle gasped. Hordak staggered.

"Did I do that?" Kyle asked, eyes wide in utter disbelief. He pumped a fist in the air. Confused and overwhelmed, he yelped, suddenly terrified.

Hordak didn't move. He didn't even respond. Kyle curiously took a step closer, biting his nails. Something pink crawled across Hordak's back. Looking closer, Kyle took another step forward. When he realized what it was, he fell flat on his ass. Flowers started to bud up from a green vine wrapping around Hordak's shoulders and neck.

"I like to think we did it together," Perfuma said. With another burst of energy, she slammed Hordak across the room. "I can finish the job, just get the sword to Catra!"

Looking at Perfuma and then back down at his own hand, Kyle nodded. He picked up the sword, half dragging it to the next room.

Lonnie and Rogelio were panting hard as more guards came. Under Lonnie, was Octavia's body, breathing, but unmoving. There were more people fighting on their side now too. Catra and

Mermista were taking out guards, piling up unconscious bodies as more joined in.

“Catra!” Kyle cried, “I have it! I have the sword!”

“Kyle? What the hell?” Catra said, glancing at him. “Hurry up!”

Out of the shadows, more Horde soldiers and robots flooded into the sanctum. Catra’s ears twitched at the sound of guards circling around them.

Kyle scrambled on his hands and knees to avoid the crossfire, hefting the sword with him. He nearly dropped it and cut his hand in the time it took him to get to Catra. He pushed it into her hands, “Hurry.”

Catra grabbed it, hoisting Kyle to his feet. Behind them, Rogelio roared, grabbing two soldiers by the throats and tossing them across the room. He was about to take a hit from behind when Mermista grabbed the ankle of the assailant, tossing them into the pile of stunned bodies in front of Rogelio.

“We need to get out of here, now!” Catra screamed, retreating.

“What’s wrong with it?!” Mermista said, sparing a glance down. “It’s still red!”

“They must not have gotten the disc yet,” Catra said, under her breath. “Come on, we have to get out of here.”

“You go,” Perfuma said, voice straining as she jumped back into the fight. “We’ll hold them off.”

“What?” No!” Catra said, tugging at her arm.

“You need time to get Adora. Hurry up,” Mermista said, letting out a war cry as she threw more water into nearby enemies. “Don’t make me beg you!”

“Catra, stop being an idiot and get out of here!” Lonnie yelled, punching another soldier in the face. Her clothing was ripped at both shoulders and her nose was still bleeding, staining her teeth red.

“I’ll get her, I promise,” Catra said, backflipping over a mess of limbs and weapons.

“We got it. Bye.” Mermista waved unenthusiastically before elbowing an unfortunate soul in the face, breaking their nose.

Perfuma thumped a giant root down on the ground, clearing Catra’s path. She took the chance and exited, running down the hall as fast as she could, sword in hand. This part of the Fright Zone was empty. After a few seconds, she had cleared more distance than she had in the last hour. Her heart pounded heavy in her ears, drowning out the sound of the sirens wailing all over, as she approached the Black Garnet Chamber.

Her team was gone. She didn’t know where Team One was at. The alarms were blaring. She had to get to Adora. She was the only one who could do this now.

Coming to a halt before a familiar door, Catra wasted no time. She smashed her hand into the console and the door slid open. Ignoring the horror that quickened in her blood, she entered. Adora’s scent hit her nose. She was here. Adora was here. That was enough to give Catra the courage to move through and past the memories of her own tortures held in this room.

“Adora!” Catra yelled, tearing up as she burst forward.

Adora stirred, eyes half closed. “Catra?”

“It’s me, Adora. We’re here. We’re going to get you out,” Catra said breathlessly. Not wanting to slow, Catra slid on her knees, skidding to a stop right in front of Adora, who sat on the ground with her arms held back by chains and her feet tied beneath her. The sword flew out of Catra’s hands, skittering on the ground nearby, a safe distance away from Adora’s skin.

“Catra?” Adora said again. Adora’s eyes were wide and confused as they flitted between Catra and the sword. She stared. Then, she held her hand up. Before she could reach Catra, her arm started to fall, shoulders wrecked with fatigue. Midair, Catra grabbed Adora’s hand and held it to her own cheek. Tears ran from Catra’s eyes, streaming freely down the back of Adora’s hand.

Adora stroked her fingers carefully over Catra’s skin, still unsure if she was imagining this or not.

Catra placed her own hand over Adora’s. It was warm. Not just warm. It was hot. Bursting with life. When all that was around her was death and darkness, Catra felt like a radiant light.

“How? I thought you died? I saw you,” Adora closed her eyes, shaking her head. “I don’t understand. Why is the sword here?”

“Time for that later,” Catra said. “I’ll take care of everything from here. We’re going home.”

Catra needed to break Adora’s chains. She stood up, claws extended. With a smile, she leaned forward. They were going to do this. Adora was going to come home. Would the invitation to stay in Bright Moon still be open? Would Adora still want Catra around? More tears came down Catra’s face. It didn’t matter. Adora was going to be okay. They were going to get out of here.

When Catra was an inch away from the manacles shackling Adora to the wall, her body stopped.

Catra’s pupils shrunk into slits. Again, she told her hands to move, but they didn't respond.

Adora’s breath stuttered.

The air crackled with red lightning.

Chapter End Notes

Phew.

I have been looking forward to this chapter since I started writing this story. I hope I did it justice. Leave me a comment and tell me what you think.

Follow me on tumblr!

Fright Night Part II: Staying Power

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The holographic map of the Fright Zone sprawled the length of the war room table. On it, ten lights blinked in and out under Angella's scrutiny. Since the mission began, the markers stayed fixed in one spot on the edge. The palace guard surrounded the table, clustering around the places on the map of interest: Hordak's Sanctum, the storage vaults, and the southern sector that housed the targeted electronics port.

Four of the markers flickered away, reappearing, this time, at the entrance point to the storage unit. Around the room, occupants began to point.

"Team One in position," a Bright Moon soldier reported, gesturing to the group of four markers representing Glimmer, Frosta, Netossa, and Scorpia. These lights coasted over the ridges of the map's topography, slowly, but without showing signs of stoppage.

Her gaze fixed, Angella did not break from watching the lights and straining her ears for any word from the rebels in the field.

"Teams Two and Three have just made the jump," a different soldier said.

Turning her head, Angella saw the other six lights hop from the sidelines and onto the map. So far, everything was going without a hitch, but the errand had only just begun.

The Bright Moon war room settled into a rhythm. The lights continued to blink in time and, every so often, the radio would cut in to deliver a message from a faraway voice. Aside from some mumbled commentary and nervous shuffling, the only noise Angella heard was in her head. She counted from one to ten internally, scanning her eyes across each dot.

When the markers stayed in one place too long, the knot in Angella's gut tightened. Just as she'd start to panic, they would move again. She folded her hands on her lap, fidgeting beneath the table. This would be one of the longest nights of her eternal life.

A guard stood and pointed to a spot Angella knew well. "They've entered the storage unit," they said.

"Team Three is in position," another replied, causing the hologram to fizz as their hand passed through it.

"Team Two has breached the outer wall. They're on their way to the sword."

And, then, four lights disappeared. Midway through sliding her eyes to Bow's team, Angella's stomach clenched. Sure she'd missed them, she waited. She stared longer than she knew she should have to for them to reappear. Voices started to buzz as everyone experienced the same disruption. The disappearance of almost half the team hit a sharp note of discord in the previous cadence.

The hum of the white noise grew louder. The other six dots were unaffected and continued to move and blink in time. But, the other four, the four that represented Scorpia, Frosta, Netossa, and Glimmer did not return.

Angella refused to look up, returning her eyes to the place where the four dots should come back. They had to come back. The other occupants of the room abandoned their own obsessive scanning and sought out each other's eyes instead. Four people had fallen off the map. Soon, all eyes crept across the table to Angella.

Someone cleared their throat, "Perhaps, the scale is wrong."

Wordlessly, Angella whipped her fingers across the controls, zooming in. Nothing. She zoomed in further. It was just more

hologram, unchanging and devoid of life. A crackle in the static made Angella stiffen.

“General, explain,” Angella commanded, voice higher than it should be. She leaned on her palms, zooming out on the map to ensure the other six dots were still present and the tracking system still functional.

“They went underground. They must have hit the threshold of the signal’s capabilities,” Juliet replied.

Angella slammed her fist on the table, breaking the clipped peace. “What does that mean?”

“I,” Juliet paused, “I don’t know.”

Angella threw her hand out to the side and raised her voice. “So, if they run into trouble, they won’t be able to contact us or each other?”

“No ma’am, they won’t,” the General replied.

How long had it been since Glimmer had messaged about going radio silent? How much longer would it be until they were trackable again? Angella felt her anxiety rise like thick, heavy lava up her spine. What if they never came back? Angella fell into her chair.

Juliet approached her. “We knew this was a risk going in. We have to trust them to complete the job. Bow’s team is in position and Catra’s team is nearly to their target. We are on track.”

Angella closed her eyes, listening for something, anything to come through the speaker to tell her they were okay. This was the role she accepted. Her place was to sit here, safe in Bright Moon and wait for others to be the heroes.

Returning to her feet, Angella leaned closely into the map. The radio came to life, cutting through her fear.

“We’re in. Team Two is in,” patched through in Catra’s voice.

“What of Team One? Of Glimmer?” Angella yelled. She thought she would be able to hear them and watch them. Of course, she wouldn’t be able to do anything if they hit a snag, but she had hoped they would not. The illusion of control started to slip.

No one replied. They weren’t equipped for anything else. None of the Bright Moon guard had the knowledge or special skills the princesses and their companions on this rescue mission had.

Angella felt the weight of her failures slam into her. She had been the one to let the previous Alliance fold. She had been the one that let Micah die. Would she be responsible for the destruction of the Alliance her daughter had breathed life into too? Would she let Glimmer follow her father to the grave?

Angella had seen more than a lifetime of sadness. She’d watched nations rise and fall. She’d seen war and peace. When the Horde rose from the dust, despite the protests of others, she kept to the sidelines. And when the time came for the Horde to erupt into the largest danger Etheria had ever seen, threatening all she held dear, her response was to stay walled up in Bright Moon. It was safe here, she thought. She had a family to protect.

Then the Horde had attacked Bright Moon. Without the Alliance, the kingdom would have fallen. She owed them, and especially Adora. She owed them her life, her kingdom, and her whole world.

There had always been better, stronger, and braver options to fight the war Angella was afraid of. But now Micah was dead, She-ra was captive, and Glimmer had fallen off the map.

Angella’s eyebrows quivered as she stared at the blank space her daughter should occupy. Glimmer, who had come to her crying countless times in the last months feeling weak and defeated. If only she understood how wrong she was.

The Horde symbol was emblazoned over the top of the map. The whole of the Horde army was there. Hordak was there. And Shadow Weaver was there. Shadow Weaver, who Angella feared above all else. If she could break Micah and Adora, how quickly would she tear through Angella?

"Come on, Glimmer," Angella said again, rotating the map.

The longer she waited, the more desperate Angella felt. She closed her eyes. Unless she did something, she was sure they would fail. The scale was tipping to the Horde's favor again, just as it had in the past. Her heart beat loudly in her chest and her hands began to shake. A chilling feeling passed through her.

Angella opened her eyes. Her wings fluttered out. Sounding braver than she felt, she ordered, "General, you are in charge while I'm away."

"Where are you going?" Juliet asked, dumbstruck.

Angella strode to the door, turning over her shoulder to say, "To the Fright Zone."

"But you -" Juliet started.

"- You are in charge. That's an order." Fearing that she would stop if she hesitated, Angella opened the door and strode out. Juliet called after her, but Angella was already running. She ran to the balcony and with a mighty jump, flew off it and down into the woods, through them, and on her way to join the fight.

"Watch out!" Netossa grabbed Scorpia and pulled her out of the way of a snapping, spiny leg. Even with her efforts, the mechanical beast smashed into Scorpia's exoskeleton, leaving a devastating gash.

“I’m okay!” Scorpia yelled as they continued to run down the hall. “It’ll buff out.” Scorpia examined the cut, “Yikes. I think it’ll buff out.”

Frosta turned on her heel and threw up a wall of ice behind them. Before it had reached the ceiling, it shattered into shards, falling to the ground like broken glass. She’d tried several times, but it was never fast enough to create a barrier solid enough to slow the bot.

“We have to get to the lift!” Glimmer yelled. “It’s the only way we can get out of here.”

Scorpia led the pack down the twisting hallways. She looked over her shoulder and said, “It’s this way, come on!”

Thudding turned into skittering as the spider moved from the floor to the ceiling, dropping dust and rocks on top of them. The hallways opened up to a cistern, lit with blinking yellow lights of a broken chandelier, tilted on its axis. Moving like a shadow over them, the bot jumped to the light fixture, causing it to crash to the ground with a deafening blow. The entire room shook, cascading an avalanche of rock and glass around them.

Glimmer gasped, shielding her eyes. There was no time. Knowing the cost, Glimmer grabbed on to her companions and teleported them ahead as far as she dared. It wasn’t far enough to keep them safe, but it gave them back the few steps they had lost in pursuit. Bending over with her hands on her knees, Glimmer heaved great, long breaths trying to find energy from stores she had long depleted.

“Glimmer! You can’t keep doing that,” Frosta said, panting herself as she pulled Glimmer upright.

“What choice do I have?” Glimmer huffed. “We can’t fight this thing!”

“Keep moving,” Netossa urged, pushing them from behind. “We have to keep moving.”

“We’re almost there!” Scorpia said, grabbing Glimmer’s hand and pulling her along. When Glimmer started to fall behind again, Scorpia scooped her up. “I’ve got you, little buddy!”

Images flashed past them of a different time. Back before the Horde ruled, the Fright Zone hadn’t looked so different from the rest of Etheria. The pictures showed a kingdom that was lush and alive. Scorpia wished she could pause to take it in, but Glimmer’s slick skin against her chest kept her sharp. Her family had given up their kingdom for this. This spider bot monster that chased them was her family’s legacy now. No matter what, she would not let down her new friends because of their mistakes.

The bot was gaining again. Its spikes slid across the rock until they could feel it getting closer and closer. Scorpia brought up the back and could feel the air shift around her neck.

“Turn left!” Scorpia yelled. She slammed her pincer into the wall, slicing and pulling a loose tapestry that was already hanging by a tattered edge. The fabric fell on top of the bot, tangling threads in poisonous spikes.

Scorpia quickened her pace, cringing as the fabric shredded apart behind her.

“There!” Netossa said. “Frosta, one last barrier, come on!”

Frosta and Netossa threw their hands out together, weaving together ice and net. They yelled with effort as they released as much magic as they could muster.

Scorpia ran past them, Glimmer’s breath finally steadying. Glimmer stood on her own and looked up. The elevator was one large platform. The shaft they had to climb was immense. Based on what Glimmer had seen down here, it was no mystery why. Squinting up, she couldn’t even make out the top. Knowing how many stairs they’d climbed down, that did not shock her either.

“Hurry!” Glimmer yelled.

Working frantically, Scorpia worked the controls. Flipping a switch, lights in the shaft began to light up, starting from the bottom and extending past their sight into the space above them. The platform hummed to life with a clunky whirring noise.

Before Scorpia could reach out to the rest of the team, an angry cry echoed around them.

"Frosta!" Netossa shrieked.

Glimmer gaped at Scorpia before she took off running.

Turning around, Netossa said, more loudly, "Glimmer!"

When she heard her name, Glimmer teleported to them. Upon her arrival, she grabbed them and teleported them back to the platform. It was only then she saw the cause for alarm. Frosta had been hit by a sharp rock, the flesh of her leg torn wide open and bleeding terribly.

Netossa jumped to her feet, but Glimmer couldn't get up, sinking to her hands and knees instead. Her eyes were half closed when she said, "Dress that wound!"

Leaving Glimmer to recuperate, Netossa pivoted to Frosta, who was whining. When she looked at the blood oozing out her leg, she bit her lip, trembling. Unfettered, Netossa made a small net and wrapped it around Frosta's leg, staunching the flow.

Frosta cried out as the bandage tightened around her bruising leg.

"Hold on!" Scorpia said, pressing a button. A buzzing noise emitted from the control panel as the lift started to move.

Glimmer turned her head to say, "Frosta! It's going to be okay. We're going to be okay."

Frosta winced, but gave a thumbs up. She was doing her best to hold in tears as Netossa added another net to her leg.

Scorpia let out an exhale, “Oh man. That was a close one. I don’t know what we would have done if -”

A tearing, thrashing noise clanged around them. Whipping her head back to the entrance, Glimmer watched as the bot scampered through the opening right before they moved past it. Grunting, Glimmer pulled herself to her feet. Voice breaking, she said, “Do you see that? It’s in here with us!”

The lights flickered again. The bot climbed until it reached past their vision, creeping into the prevalent shadows. The elevator rose with the grinding of metal on metal, but Glimmer searched the air for the more subtle sound of tinny, sharp spines.

“We’re going to run into it eventually,” Netossa said, brushing off her coat.

Frosta grimaced, “Glimmer, what are we going to do?”

Scorpia knelt beside them, hugging them together. “We’re going to be okay.”

A metal panel fell from the sky. Scorpia grabbed Frosta and tumbled out of the way, while Netossa pulled Glimmer roughly aside. Where the panel struck, sparks flew. Netossa threw a net above them, knocking several loose bits of rock and metal and trapping them against the wall.

Above them, glowing red eyes continued to move about, biding their time.

“We’ve got to be ready for it.” Netossa said as she took a knee, throwing nets whenever she saw a twitch of movement above them.

The platform moved upward slowly. Glimmer felt a trickle of sweat run down the back of her neck. She just needed a minute. Just a minute to recharge and she could get them out of here. Even as she thought it, she started to fall. Scorpia caught her.

“Not trying to, uh, be rude, but you seem pretty tired,” Scorpia said, releasing Glimmer.

Glimmer gulped and stared upwards.

“Entrapta!” Bow yelled, “You have to do something!”

Entrapta typed on what looked like three different keyboards while biting her tongue. “I can’t turn off the attack robot, but we can track them.” She paused, scanning over the interface in front of her. Red light from the manually triggered alarm system blinked in and out, bathing her in crimson. “You may have noticed that the vault is too far below the surface to send and receive radio signals, but the cameras live on the network. I can get visual.”

Bow hung his head. Glimmer had been his best friend for so long he could barely remember a time before her. He had to know she and his other friends were okay. He kept telling himself to stay positive, but, ever since his injury, it had been hard. Before he could at least help or be there with them to meet their fate together.

Sea Hawk sidled up next to Bow and offered a genuine smile. “They’ll come through; they always do.”

Entrapta sputtered away and was replaced by grainy, gray lines that materialized into video of the vault. When Entrapta clicked a key, the image changed, jumping from camera to camera, giving them a warped visual of the underground. Squinting, Bow made out a dark place whose shelves held treasures that outshined his dads’ library. If they could see this they would freak out. Meaning he would not be telling them about this place any time soon.

Entrapta’s voice cut over the video as it flashed once again. “It’s empty. They must be out of the vaults!”

Bow searched for signs of life in the low-quality footage. “Can you track movement in the footage?”

“Can I ever!” Entrapta said. “Give me a second and - oh! Here’s where they last were!” Entrapta zoomed in on the visual, causing the quality to drop dramatically. “Do you see that? An ice net! Fascinating.”

“Frosta and Netossa!” Bow said, tracing the thick slab of ice through the screen with his thumb. It was massive, blocking the camera from seeing anything through it.

Entrapta played the video in slow motion. Even still, the moment when the ice shattered happened fast. When it fell, the next frames of the video exposed the biggest bot Bow had ever seen. His mouth fell open. “Is that the bot?!” he asked.

“That’s her alright,” Entrapta said, patting her computer and nodding proudly. “Isn’t she beautiful?”

“That certainly is,” Sea Hawk said, gulping, “one word for it.”

Bow gasped. “Can you follow them?”

“This video is delayed, but let me - got it!” Entrapta said, pumping her fist though only Emily could see.

Sea Hawk and Bow hunched even closer to the screen, watching it play as blobs roughly the size and color of their friends moved frame to frame. It was hard to figure out what was going on between the dim lighting, magic being thrown around, and the spider superbot obscuring the shot.

The video continued to play until a distinct shot of Glimmer popping in and out of screen in the span of a few seconds played.

“That’s Glimmer!” Bow cried. “What time was this taken? How long ago? And where?”

“That brings us up to the last sign of life. It was, hmm,” Entrapta cocked her head, “0.42 minutes ago. This video is from the security camera right outside the lift system. It’s a massive, clunky thing. Hordak won’t let me touch it. I keep telling him we could make it better but he doesn’t want to waste any -”

“Is there a camera in the lift?” Bow questioned, cutting her off.

“No, but I should be able to,” Entrapta grimaced. “Oh.”

“What? What’s going on?” Bow said, voice cracking into a high panic.

“They made it in the elevator shaft, but it looks TARANTULA followed behind them. They’re all stuck together until they reach the top!” Entrapta scratched her head. “Certainly, weight won’t be an issue. That lift was designed to carry *a lot* of mass, but it is slow. They will be in there for a few minutes at least.”

“That is not good. Entrapta! Is there a door or something we can open for them?” Bow asked.

“No, the elevator system only has two stops. Top and bottom.” Entrapta responded, rubbing under her chin with her hair. “I can’t believe it’s the first time TARANTULA will be out and I won’t even get to see it! Who knows what kind of data I’m missing out on!”

“Spinnerella, Sea Hawk here,” Sea Hawk said, engaging his radio while puffing out his chest, “they’re in the main lift shaft. Onward!”

Spinnerella’s voice flickered in faintly. “I’m almost in. I -” it cut out abruptly.

Bow waited as audio returned, but all he could hear was garbled words before it was replaced by nothing.

“She must have just dropped off grid,” Sea Hawk said, mumbling to himself.

Bow's pulse thrummed in his ears, making it hard to hear the string of words Entrapta was saying as she popped back up on the screen. They were okay. Or at least they were a few minutes ago. But now? They were trapped in a room with a spider superbot powered by one of the biggest pieces of First Ones' tech he'd ever seen. If only he was there. His arm throbbed where the metal pins still held his bone together. Every time he moved his fingers, he could feel his muscles working hard as they learned how to function again.

"We can't just leave them down there," Bow said. "We have no idea if they're okay."

Sea Hawk's mustache slumped as he lost his words. Usually, he and Bow were chummy. Today, darkness captured both their hearts. Why, Sea Hawk apart from Mermista was barely whole. He hadn't heard her voice in some time and also was starting to worry.

Bow and Sea Hawk looked at each other, both feeling the other's pain. Sea Hawk braced Bow's shoulder as tears gathered in both their eyes.

The constant clicking of Entrapta's keyboard became abrasive against the hum of the Horde port and the crackle of white noise over the video. Bow slid against the wall, bringing his knees to his chest.

"What are we going to do?" Bow asked.

"Maybe we can ask Queen Angella," Entrapta said, not looking up from her computer.

"I told you, we can contact her, but we don't have the capability to receive messages from Bright Moon," Bow said.

"Bright Moon? She isn't in Bright Moon," Entrapta said.

"What? Why not?" Bow asked, wiping tears aside.

Without looking up from her screen, Entrapta pointed behind Bow with her hair.

Both blinking, Bow and Sea Hawk turned. Queen Angella stood behind them with a speculative look on her face. “Hello,” she said.

Spooked, Sea Hawk jumped into Bow’s arms. Bow, shocked himself, nearly fell over and said, “Queen - what? Queen Angella?”

Sea Hawk cleared his throat, making no attempt to get back on his feet, and shrugged. “No one can sneak up on Sea Hawk!”

“What are?” Bow put Sea Hawk down. “Why are you here? How long have you been standing there?”

“Long enough,” Angella said, tossing her hair. “Bow, where is Glimmer?” Angella said, scanning the area around them.

“They’re on the main elevator. They’re coming back up, but we hit a problem,” he said, shrinking away.

On cue, Entrapta pulled up the diagnostics of the TARANTULA, complete with a rotating diagram of the thing. “This is TARANTULA!” Entrapta said, clapping her hands together, “It’s - I mean,” she coughed, “it is very dangerous - and amazing - and, it’s trapped in the elevator shaft with them.”

“What on earth is that?” Angella said, pushing Bow and Sea Hawk aside to examine it.

Entrapta started to respond, “It stands for -”

“- it isn’t good,” Bow said. “We haven’t heard an update from them. All we have is video before they got trapped in there. Now we have no idea what’s going on. Spinnerella went after them but we lost contact with her too.”

“I will go,” Angella said. “Which way?”

“It’s -” Bow was cut off by another radio message. “Hold on,” he said, pressing his palm against his free ear to better make out the muffled words.

Catra’s voice came high and strained over the comm, “I need backup. Now!”

“We don’t have anyone left,” Bow messaged back. “Where are Mermista and Perfuma? Aren’t they with you?”

Catra’s radio cut out. “Catra?” Bow asked. “Catra!”

Bow looked at his tracker pad, which had been abandoned in the midst of Entrapta’s pet project attacking his friends in an underground dead zone. He traced it to Catra’s position. “She’s in the Black Garnet chamber! The others are back in Hordak’s Sanctum still, look!”

“She’s,” Mermista thwacked another guard over the head, “She’s alone, okay? Perfuma and I are,” the radio cut out as Mermista dodged a hit with Rogelio’s help, “It’s Catra, if she’s asking for help, she needs it. And she needs it right now. We can’t -”

“Why aren’t you with her?” Bow asked, squeaking.

Mermista threw yet another wave over water at two soldiers. “Are you deaf? The alarms have been going off forever now. We’re fighting a war here!”

Perfuma chirped in, “We ran into a,” Perfuma cracked out to thank Lonnie for throwing a soldier off her back, “some issues. But we are dealing with it! If Catra needs help it’s because she or Adora are in -”

“Spinnerella already left to help the other team. There’s,” Bow looked at Sea Hawk desperately. “There’s no one left.”

Angella stared forward. “Bow, what’s going on?”

“Catra and,” tears spurted at the edges of Bow’s eyes anew, “Adora. They’re alone. What are we going to do? Spinnerella is already after Glimmer’s team! Sea Hawk and I can’t get there in time. What if they don’t make it?”

Angella stared at him, searching his face and searching her heart. Time was running out.

Adora was so close. All Catra had to do was reach out and break her chains. Catra tried to extend her claws, but invisible hands kept them sheathed. Even the hair on Catra’s tail laid flat despite the icy dread running down her skin. This couldn’t be happening. Catra needed to reach Adora. With every shred of her will, Catra fought to move. Instead of forward, her arms were pulled backwards.

Only then, did Catra scream.

A flare of purple light shot from the Black Garnet that shrouded the room in deeper darkness. Electricity, red and dangerous, flashed, casting them in a million shadows. The hair on the back of Adora’s neck stood on end. Catra was falling away. Adora reached after her, but, even with all of her strength, the bonds held.

“Catra!” Adora yelled. “Catra!”

Adora’s shackles shook. As she fought, the chains rattled, scraping link against link. Still, the manacles did not budge. The scabs on Adora’s wrists broke open as the edges bit into her flesh. Blood started to drip out, dying the cuffs of her clean shirt red.

“Adora! It’s going to be okay!” Catra said, even as fear forced itself under her skin.

Adora's eyes had even darker circles under them than the last time Catra saw her. Her cheeks looked hollow and her eyes dull. Adora was out of time. Catra had to get her out of this. She fired her nerves to move, but, again, she was yanked back. Not just her hands, but her whole body this time.

Eyes wide in understanding, Adora's expression shattered into pain. Her heart pounded in her chest, painful and sharp and so different than the dull ache that had been there before. Catra was here, but she was getting ripped away again.

A sob escaped Catra's lips as distance was forced between them. The pain of being dragged from Adora was as real as if Catra's arm was being pulled from its socket. The memory of Adora's touch against her cheek from barely a minute ago burned. She had been so close.

"Well, well, you always were persistent," Shadow Weaver said, twisting Catra in the air until her eye contact with Adora was severed. "At least, when you wanted to get in the way."

Catra let out a ferocious growl, humming from deep in her belly and roaring out her throat. "Let Adora go or I'll tear you to shreds."

"You're in no position to be making threats," Shadow Weaver replied coolly, twirling Catra's body in a slow roll. "How dare you come back here."

Catra opened her mouth for a scathing retort, but Shadow Weaver flicked her wrist, forcing out a wail of agony in its place.

"Stop it!" Adora yelled, finding her words as fog in her head cleared, fueled by adrenaline even as tears ran down her cheeks. Catra was here and she was alive. Adora wouldn't let Shadow Weaver take her away again. Mimicking Catra's growl, Adora showed her teeth to Shadow Weaver. "Leave her alone."

Shadow Weaver bent her hand into a fist and Catra cried out again as lightning flashed around her. Shadow Weaver watched

for Adora's reaction. It came at once. Adora flinched against the wall, horror etched deeply in the lines of her forehead.

"Let her go and I -" Adora swallowed, "I'll do whatever you want. I'll be a Force Captain. I'll stay here. I don't care! Just let her go."

"You will do that regardless of what happens to Catra," Shadow Weaver said evenly. Spinning her pointer finger, Catra rolled again, nearly hanging upside-down now.

"The entire Alliance is here. You're running out of time," Catra threatened. "Let us go and maybe they won't destroy you."

Shadow Weaver laughed. "Your precious rebels seem more than occupied at the moment."

"What more do you want from me?" Adora yelled.

Shadow Weaver paused as if to think. As she cocked her head, a gleam of light caught her eye. There, not even a meter from Adora's boots, was the Sword of Protection. It throbbed, absolutely overcome with infection.

"Obedience," Shadow Weaver said with finality as she relaxed her hand, allowing Catra to crash to the floor.

Adora looked at her puzzled. "What are you doing?" she asked cautiously.

"Providing an opportunity," Shadow Weaver replied. She snapped her fingers and Adora's shackles gave way.

Adora stared into Shadow Weaver's face. Shadow Weaver merely folded her hands behind her back. Never breaking eye contact, Adora moved to Catra and offered her a hand. Catra took it instantly, hoisting herself up to her feet.

"Adora, don't make deals with her," Catra whispered. Her tail and claws lashed out now that she regained agency.

“I’ll ask you one more time,” Adora said, eyes gleaming, “what are you doing?”

Shadow Weaver floated closer, until she stood in front of Adora. Catra slunk into a fighting crouch, ready to pounce, but Adora held her hand up.

“All I want is what’s best for you, Adora.” Shadow Weaver reached a hand towards Adora. “End Catra,” Shadow Weaver said, “and I will let the rest of the rebels walk out now.”

“What?” Adora said, jaw set. She took a step in front of Catra, shielding her. From behind, Catra held Adora’s hand, leaving small half-moon pricks as she squeezed. “No.”

Catra seethed, “She’s lying.” Catra wrapped her tail around Adora’s shin, something she hadn’t done publicly since they were children. “The rest of the team is fine.” Catra began to tremble, but Adora’s hand held hers with certainty.

“There’s no reason for this,” Adora said. “Let them all go. You already have what you want, don’t you?”

With a mirthless laugh, Shadow Weaver said, “Not yet, but I will.”

“Stop it! Why are you like this?” Catra yelled.

Adora balled her free hand into a white knuckled fist. “I am not killing Catra. Now let us out of here or I’ll -”

“- Or you’ll what?” Shadow Weaver taunted. “You gave the incorrect response, Adora. But, I suppose, by now, Catra has her claws deep in you. But you will do this,” she tucked her hand into her robes and pulled out a familiar piece of First Ones tech. “One way or another. I pulled this from the vaults. Look familiar?”

“Give that to me,” Catra ordered. “It shouldn’t even exist.”

“But you let it, didn’t you?” Shadow Weaver said, holding the tech up to shimmer in the low light of the chamber.

“It was a mistake. I should have destroyed it the second I found it,” Catra said. “And that’s exactly what I’m going to do once you hand it over.”

“A mistake,” Shadow Weaver said. “And yet you deliver the Sword of Protection to this very room while infected with the virus?”

Adora’s eyebrows furrowed. She followed Shadow Weaver’s gaze to the floor where the sword that had, all at once, given her so much and taken so much away, sat idle.

“What? Did you think you were really so clever? I knew you’d return. You never did know what was good for you. And now, it’s time you paid for your role in delaying Adora from her destiny. It does seem fitting that She-ra be the one to destroy you, doesn’t it?”

“What are you -?” Adora’s eyes went wide, glancing back at the sword again. “You wouldn’t.”

“I promised you I would make you great, Adora,” Shadow Weaver said, closing her fist around the tech.

Adora’s voice shook. “Y-you can’t. I already told you I’d stay. I’ll do what you want. I’ve always done what you want.”

“No, Adora!” Catra said, pulling at Adora’s sleeve. “You’re not going to make Adora do anything she doesn’t want to.”

“Adora,” Shadow Weaver shook her head, “this is bigger than just you. You will do this.” She shrugged towards the sword, wrapping a shadow slowly around its hilt.

Tearing her hand away from Catra’s, Adora crawled backwards. She had to put distance between herself and the sword. Catra reached out for her again and called, “Adora!”

“Catra, stay away from me,” Adora said, tripping. “You need to leave!”

“I’m not going anywhere without you,” Catra said, running back towards Adora.

“And so, it shall be your end,” Shadow Weaver said. “How very fitting.”

Adora fell down as the sword balanced in front of her eyes. Catra jumped in front, knocking the sword away and sending it flying across the room. Helping Adora to her feet, Catra growled again.

“There is no use resisting.” Shadow Weaver grabbed the sword with her fingers this time, throwing out a dark shadow to wrap around Catra’s throat. “You will not even remember her last moments, Adora. It will be easy. Painless.”

“Catra! No!” Adora fought against the tendrils encasing Catra, breaking them over and over even as they regrew to tighten around Catra’s neck. All the while, Shadow Weaver gracefully hovered over the floor, inching closer and closer as the sword started to pulse faster.

“It is time to move forward, Adora,” Shadow Weaver said. Adora held Catra to her chest, still frantically fighting the shadows as Shadow Weaver pushed the sword to her.

“It’s okay, Adora,” Catra said, between huffs. She fought to say more, but the words would not come out. Instead of clawing at the dark magic, Catra wrapped her arms around Adora and took in her scent with one final breath.

“No, it’s not. None of this is okay,” Adora said. Clenching her eyes shut, Adora hugged Catra tightly. “I never got to -”

Adora’s sentence was cut off abruptly by the sound of a blast. Her eyes flew open. There was a purple beam directed at Shadow Weaver, who threw up a hand to cast it aside. Catra took a loud inhale as the shadows retreated from her throat.

Another blast came, bigger this time. Shadow Weaver dropped the sword, leaving it to clatter across the floor. With both her hands,

Shadow Weaver countered the attack. When her dark magic collided with the light magic, a wave of energy threw Catra and Adora apart, stunning them both.

With a grunt and spin, Shadow Weaver threw the purple energy ball against the wall, causing deep fissures to crack around the crater it left.

“What is the meaning of this?” Shadow Weaver yelled into the room obscured by dust refracting the light of the Black Garnet. Lightning crackled all around them.

When the particles settled, Angella stood in the doorway, chest rising and falling quickly.

“Queen Angella, what an unexpected surprise,” Shadow Weaver said, wild eyes scanning the room. “And you’ve come alone.” She relaxed, passively pulling energy from the Black Garnet and rising further off the ground.

Angella sneered. “Release them both at once.”

“What are you going to do if I don’t?” Shadow Weaver said, stepping towards Angella and leeching power from Black Garnet now in large droves. “I know you. You might put on a brave face, but you are no hero.”

Angella bared her teeth. "I do not fear you."

“Please,” Shadow Weaver laughed, "I can see you trembling from over here."

Angella threw her hands in front of her and sent out two parallel pink beams of magic. Shadow Weaver backhanded the attack, knocking Angella’s energy away as if it were nothing but a minor inconvenience.

"Perhaps if you hadn't squandered half your runestone’s power on your daughter you would be a match.” Shadow Weaver flexed her hands. “You're too weak."

Angella's breath caught in her throat. Flickering her eyes back, she caught Adora and Catra's, who were recovering from the ringing in their ears and the lack of air in their lungs from the impact. She lit her hands up again. She had to find a way.

"And what do you know of strength?" Angella asked. Her voice was shaking.

"I have power beyond your imagination," Shadow Weaver said. "Something Micah knew well."

The Black Garnet buzzed as blurry vision started to clear for both Catra and Adora.

"Do not speak his name," Angella growled, now glowing with anger.

"Who do you think he had to thank for his power? And Adora? I've brought it out of them. The rest of you," Shadow Weaver looked back at Catra, who was coughing and holding her ribs, "are merely obstacles."

Angella's powers flared anew. "Love is not a distraction. But you," Angella threw another beam at Shadow Weaver, "you are a monster."

Shadow Weaver deflected lazily again. "Spare me," she said, "love is weak. Only fools cling to it."

Angella stiffened, starting to feel her adrenaline ebbing. Shadow Weaver had knocked her best shots away easily. She could already feel her energy waning. Without the element of surprise, she would be no match. A droplet of sweat ran down her forehead.

"You wouldn't know," Angella shot another beam, pressing into it with all her might. She thought to Micah. To Glimmer. To Adora and Catra, who needed her right now. With a yell, Angella doubled down. Shadow Weaver had taken too much from too many people. It was time for this to end.

Shadow Weaver held up her hands to counter. Her eyes widened in surprise when the beam hit her own. With a groan, she lifted both hands. A powerful black aura circled her as she screamed in response to Angella.

“It is not enough, I’m afraid,” Shadow Weaver said, tossing the magic aside with a grunt. “True power will win out in the end.”

Angella gasped, doubling over in exhaustion. She was panting now and nearly falling off her feet. Meanwhile Shadow Weaver crackled, power still growing.

“I - I’ve failed,” Angella realized.

“Well, well, aren’t you full of surprises? Stronger than you look, but not strong enough.” Shadow Weaver said. With a cry, she sent out her dark magic, encircling Angella. “We shall end this quickly.”

Angella froze on the spot, shadow closing in on her and snuffing out her light. It got tighter and darker, pressing in on her from all sides until she could no longer contain a scream. Her worst fears were realized. She was not strong enough. She never had been.

Micah had promised her once that he would be the one to end Shadow Weaver. That he would stop her from hurting anyone else. Angella had believed him. But Micah was not here. Perhaps if he was, none of this would have happened. Angella closed her eyes.

“Angella!” Adora cried, getting to her feet. “You have to fight it! You can do this.”

Adora. Angella’s She-ra. How had she survived what had happened to her? How had any of them? Why did she believe in Angella?

“You’re stronger than you know,” Adora yelled. “Shadow Weaver is wrong. Please.”

From a deeper part of her mind, Angella heard the voice of her husband, *"Come on, Angie. One more go."*

Tears fell down her eyes onto the ground. Darkness surrounded her, choking out everything she once held dear.

"One more, my love," she whispered to herself. "I can do one more."

With everything she had, Angella pushed outwards. Micah was not here, but Angella would finish what he started. Light came not from just her palms, but emitted from her entire body, ripping across it as if she was encased in flame. The dark magic surrounding her bloated, filling to the brim until it exploded into light.

"You will not hurt anyone else!" Angella screamed. She was glowing, surrounded in so much bright light that it hurt Shadow Weaver's eyes. Angella stacked her palms together and channeled her energy into one shot.

It hit its mark. Shadow Weaver's energy flared. The sound of the Black Garnet thrummed deeply. Angella's magic knocked her out of the air and down hard into the ground. Out of Shadow Weaver's robes, flew the disc, skittering to a halt by Adora's feet.

Still fighting dark against light, Shadow Weaver screamed. Out of her mouth flew dark, red energy. It snapped and crackled in the air, striking the very edges of the room before hitting Angella in the chest.

Instantly, Angella's eyes returned to their normal color. She was knocked aside, fighting to breathe with a choking sound. She tried to lift her hand, but her energy was spent.

The lightning struck near Adora's head, who had dropped to her stomach to avoid it. She clambered, pulling her body along with her arms until she gripped the disc. She looked at Catra, who smiled and nodded.

“Not so fast,” Shadow Weaver said, hacking as she drew energy to float above the ground once more. With one hand, she sent a black shadow to curl around Catra’s neck and, with the other, she ensnared Angella, who could do nothing to fight it. “Adora, if you so much as chip that disc, I will break their necks.”

Adora froze, eyes flitting to Catra.

Catra screamed against the tendrils, which cut off her voice. She shook her head violently, even though the motion made it rattle.

“Come now, Adora. This is for the best. After all, did you really think they’d want you back after this? This is where you belong. This is what you were made for.” Shadow Weaver said, moving towards Adora until they were face to face.

Muffled cries filled the room. Adora tried to find Catra again, but her vision was blocked and taken over by Shadow Weaver.

“Haven’t you hurt Catra enough? She paid for every single one of your failures. And then, you left her here all alone. And the Rebellion? Well, what good are you to them? Even with She-ra you never did quite measure up, did you? And now the Queen of Bright Moon has even abandoned her post for you. And for what?”

Adora stared at the disc in her hands. Yelling broke out in the background until Shadow Weaver threw her arms out, tightening Catra’s gag until she choked on her words. Adora took a step, trying to find Catra, but Shadow Weaver wrenched her by the chin.

“Look at me, Adora,” Shadow Weaver seethed. “They don’t need you anymore. You have failed.”

The trembling of Adora’s fingers stopped. Her head fell and she looked down and held the piece of tech that had infected her a lifetime ago. After the first time her powers were tainted into something catastrophic in Dryl, she thought she’d never let herself lose control again. Now, she had lost count of the number of times she had transformed into the most hateful and destructive

force on Etheria. She'd imagined, but Adora didn't even know the extent of the damage she'd done.

"I -I can still make things right. I just have to work harder. I can still save the world. I can -"

"Adora, why lie to yourself?" Shadow Weaver asked, caressing Adora's cheek. "You have a destiny. This," she motioned back at Catra, "has gotten you off track. You cannot both be the person you should be and keep your distractions. You do not have a choice. You never have had a choice."

It was as if Shadow Weaver had reached into her chest and squeezed her heart until it gave out. Adora's vision started to darken around the edges. The acrid smell of burning hair hit Adora's nose, straight from a memory. A thousand bumps, bruises, and scrapes that she had bandaged for Catra. Catra crying in her arms. Adora pushing Catra away after Shadow Weaver's hands had run the length of her body. The Rebellion losing battles. The Horde burning towns and killing innocent bystanders. The war raged on while her friends got hurt. It was all her fault. Adora swayed on her feet.

"It didn't have to come to this, but, in the end, you have condemned them to death." Shadow Weaver dug her nails into Adora's cheek. "If you had let them go, perhaps they wouldn't suffer today. How could you have been so selfish? How many more lives must you destroy?"

Shadow Weaver was right. It was the part that hurt the most. Adora knew that Shadow Weaver was right. She did not deserve Catra or Angella or any of them. If she could not be strong enough to defeat the Horde, what good was she to them? All she could do was save them now.

Catra fought, "Adora! It is not your fault!"

"Silence!" Shadow Weaver said, slashing a black vine into Catra's ribs until she cried out.

When Shadow Weaver had turned around to strike Catra, Adora had seen her eyes. They said all the things she couldn't say out loud. After all this time, how was Catra still here? There was so much pain between them. But Catra came back for her. And came back to the place that held so much trauma for her.

A whispering in the back of her head, made Adora look over her shoulder. No one was there, but the words still came, just like they had in a dream.

"You are brave and strong. You have always fought for what is right. I know you'd do anything for Etheria. But Adora, you are also worth fighting for."

"Adora, give me the disc. There is no need for further delay." Shadow Weaver extended her hand.

Adora's hand started to move. Vaguely, she could hear Catra weeping in the background.

She stopped, frozen. The graying of Adora's vision collapsed. The Black Garnet Chamber faded and everything went quiet. Startled, Adora took a step back, no longer feeling Shadow Weaver's hands on her.

Confused, she looked back and forth in the space until her eyes settled on someone familiar. Before her, stood a shorter, scrawnier, adolescent with a black eye. She was blonde and growing so fast her shirt was tight in the shoulders.

Adora grasped at the fabric over her heart with one hand and, with the other, she grabbed the hem. She ran her fingers over the material. It felt real. It felt as real as that black eye had the day she earned it so many years ago. Adora was used to seeing flashbacks from the past in the Crystal Castle, but none of them had been memories like this.

"Adora! What do you think you are doing?" Shadow Weaver, or, at least, this version of her said.

Adora's muscles stiffened at the same time as her younger self's did.

Young Adora responded, "I-I'm trying my best."

"Your best is not good enough," Shadow Weaver said, gritty and angry. "I don't know why I even try with you. It's always the same. I give you a simple task and you fail to deliver."

Adora's face muscles quivered. This was a conversation she remembered, though she wished she did not. Watching it now hurt her as if it were fresh.

"Do you think this is a game?" Shadow Weaver bit.

"I didn't mean to. I -"

"- Do you think this is what they want?" Disappointment emanated off of Shadow Weaver. "You think they'll accept you when you have nothing to offer? Adora, you have a destiny so much greater than you could imagine. And here you are squandering it. And for what?"

"No!" young Adora said. "I will be better. I am better." Adora mouthed the words as they came out of her counterpart, high and desperate.

Shadow Weaver dusted off her clothing, resuspending her hair until it reached towards the sky, defying gravity. "Perhaps I was wrong about you."

"No, you weren't!" Young Adora said, clenching her fists. "I-I won't be distracted. You'll see, I can do this."

Scoffing, Shadow Weaver turned away. "You are worthless to me, Adora."

Young Adora's lip trembled, but she bit her tongue. Shadow Weaver got smaller and smaller as she walked away.

While young Adora stared at Shadow Weaver, adult Adora tore her eyes away and, instead, examined her younger self. With fists tight, the small girl shook, visibly forcing her tears to not fall down her cheeks. Right now, she was trying to convince herself she could give more. That Shadow Weaver was right, Adora had underperformed that day. She could be better, she just had to work harder, be more dedicated, be perfect.

This was around the same time that Shadow Weaver had brought Adora in for extra lessons, which Adora knew now, were times where Shadow Weaver had started sexually abusing her, grooming her for what was to come. Adora had run toward the opportunity as a kid, only ever wanting the positive feedback she craved. And she took it in any way she could find, even if that was naked and shivering and scared.

Now, Adora grabbed her younger self's shoulder, crouching down to look into her eyes. To her surprise, young Adora reacted, wiping at her eyes viciously and putting on a stern expression, jaw tight.

All the fear and pain that had bloomed as Adora grew was there. In this younger version, it was still a seed, but soon it would take over every move. Every day of training would become a competition for self-worth Adora never did find. Every day she displeased Shadow Weaver felt like a blow. Every time she wasn't perfect, she'd rip out and throw away another piece of herself until there was nothing left.

And then, she'd find the sword. For a while, she'd believe it made since that it had chosen her. She never found contentment. There were only new and more devastating mistakes to be made.

Still, when Adora looked at the child in front of her, she knew those feelings were undeserved.

"You're going to be okay," Adora said. "Shadow Weaver doesn't," Adora hesitated, "care about you. But you'll find people that do."

Young Adora's tears sprouted fresh. "No one cares about me."

Swallowing back her own tears, Adora said, "Shadow Weaver's a bad person. No matter what you do, she'll always take more. She will never stop until there's nothing left."

The tears did come from both of them then and Adora hugged her younger self tightly. "You're going to make friends, best friends, who will take care of you and who you'll take care of. You," Adora's voice caught in her throat, "you are worth something."

"You mean it?" Young Adora said. "Shadow Weaver says -"

Adora grabbed her younger self by the shoulders. "- I promise. You can be happy too."

Gapped toothed and red in the face, Young Adora clung to Adora for life. They cried together for what felt like hours, but eventually they parted.

Young Adora smiled and then ran down the hallway. Before she faded away, another hand grabbed hers and they both ducked around the corner laughing.

When Adora stood back up, she turned around to face Shadow Weaver with tears staining her face back in the Black Garnet Chamber of the present.

Shadow Weaver bore into her, raising her hand in Adora's direction. Adora felt her shadows wrapping around her feet, but she stood surefooted.

Adora felt the edges of the disc hard and cool against her palm. It would be so easy. She squeezed, letting them dig into her skin. She clenched her fist even harder, setting her jaw. Eventually, the disc gave way with a crunch. The pieces fell to the ground in small clinks. And it was gone. No one would use She-ra again.

"How dare you," Shadow Weaver said, red bolts of lightning erupting from her with a force more powerful than any Adora had

ever seen.

But, Shadow Weaver had always underestimated Adora.

Adora broke away from the ropes of darkness pulling at her arms with renewed strength. The burning white pits of Shadow Weaver's eyes widened. She dropped the hold she had on Angella and Catra to face the oncoming attack.

Kicking into her fastest speed, Adora felt clarity. She rammed her fist into Shadow Weaver's mask, shattering it into as many pieces as the disc. The force of the blow knocked them both off their feet.

Arms behind her hauled Adora to her feet. Catra kept a hand on Adora's waist and the other on her shoulder as she stood behind her.

"All my life you told me I needed you to be stronger, faster, smarter to be worth anything at all." Adora ground her teeth together as she looked at Shadow Weaver beneath her. "You were wrong."

"Adora," Shadow Weaver said, malice hidden underneath the surface of the same condescending tone Adora knew so well. "You are making a mistake." Shadow Weaver scoured the remains of her mask for the red gem.

"The only mistake I ever made was listening to you in the first place," Adora said. Catra stepped on Shadow Weaver's bastardized runestone, cracking it two.

"Even without the runestone, I am greater than you," Shadow Weaver said, drawing a symbol in the air and throwing it towards Adora and Catra.

They were both knocked against the wall, Catra falling when she tried to rise. Adora forced herself to her feet, breathing heavy.

“Adora!” Angella screamed, now free but unable to get up. Adora forced her eyes open as she recovered from the blow. “The sword!” Angella pointed.

Knowing the sword as only a device to control her, Adora flinched back. Then, she saw it gleam in the light. It was pure and good, no longer did the veins of infection litter it. The sword was free and so was she. She reached for it.

The shadows constricted her as Shadow Weaver got to her feet, an aura of black energy erupting around her as she screamed.

Adora turned to look at Catra. “Catra, I,” Adora swallowed.

“Not right now, Adora!” Catra hissed, helping Adora close her fingers around the sword from the floor.

Their eyes met and Adora nodded, feeling whole as her grip tightened around the hilt. She raised the sword and shouted, “For the honor of Grayskull!”

Chapter End Notes

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Counterattack

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora transformed. Her body flooded with golden light. It spilled out through her fingertips, scattering shadows with its rays. The magic radiating off Adora was ancient, as old as Etheria itself. Its virtue clashed with the manufactured strength of the Fright Zone, but light won out. Even the Black Garnet, no longer under Shadow Weaver's control, pulsed with a different energy. It resonated inside Catra too. Adora was the one bringing out She-ra, but Catra felt as if the magic was some of her own.

It was exactly the opposite of the metamorphosis Adora underwent when infected by the virus. That was a brutal, ugly thing. A monster bursting out from under Adora's skin, ripping her apart until all that remained was a grinning, sadistic killer. The true and unmarred transformation into She-ra was magnificent. And, best of all, beneath this She-ra, was Adora.

She-ra held her sword out in front of her. Bending her knees, she sank into a fighting stance. Beside her, Catra imitated the motion with the part of her brain that wasn't in complete shock over Adora punching Shadow Weaver. It was something Catra imagined doing for years, her whole lifetime even. And, here, in one of the darkest moments of their lives, Adora triumphed. The evidence was there, under her foot. Whatever that gem Shadow Weaver kept on her forehead was it was gone now. Catra pushed down with her foot again, feeling the course shards of it grind into the floor like sand. The magical chains holding Catra released. Shadow Weaver couldn't take over her body's movements anymore. And she couldn't pull Catra away from Adora. Never again.

Across them, Shadow Weaver finished screaming, finding a dangerous calm instead. Without her mask, her emotions were

laid bare. Her mouth formed a tight, thin line, jutting out where the seams didn't match. But underneath her skin was a barely contained rage. She held it in her jaw. It was shut so tightly that her muscles were jerking. The cords of her neck bulged and her eyes, damaged by a power she had so badly wanted to possess, burned.

Catra had only seen Shadow Weaver's eyes a handful of times before and never at length. Now, she could examine the bloodshot whites and irregular pupils in the silent moments that followed. A fear clawed at Catra, desperate to make purchase. They were not out of this yet.

When those eyes shifted to She-ra, Catra bared her teeth. Shadow Weaver opened her mouth and said, "Look at you, such incredible power but no idea how to wield it."

Shadow Weaver's hair had fallen down like dirty straw on her shoulders. Her feet, so unused to the ground, were loud as she dragged them forward. She-ra slanted her eyebrows down until they knit together. When Shadow Weaver approached, She-ra's hair flared up higher.

"Adora, you've already lost control once," Shadow Weaver said, glancing at the shattered piece of tech. "What makes you think you won't again? You need instruction."

She-ra's eyes gave her away. The stern look she had faltered. Her eyebrows rose up. She was afraid. Catra glanced at her before Shadow Weaver spoke again.

"No one knows Etheria's magic like I do," Shadow Weaver said with finality. "Let me help you."

"No one needs you, Shadow Weaver," Catra said fiercely, heart thumping against her ribcage. "Least of all Adora. Stop acting like you don't want her power to yourself. Why else would you keep her locked up?"

Shadow Weaver folded her hands. “Catra, you have no idea what Adora’s been through or what she has yet to go through. Someone like you could never understand the immense burden placed on Adora’s shoulders.”

“And you do?” Catra hissed, flexing her claws. Shadow Weaver eyed her, but did not flinch.

With a deep breath, She-ra spoke, “Stand down, Shadow Weaver. This is over.”

“It will never be over,” Shadow Weaver grinned. “Even if you dispose of me, your destiny will find a way to show you that I was right. By then, you may lose a great deal.”

A shadow passed over She-ra’s face. The marrow deep in her bones turned icy cold. There may have been no physical lasting marks of Shadow Weaver’s words, but Adora’s insides were littered with scars that would never fade. They lit up now, burning her with doubt.

“Cut it out!” Catra yelled before turning to She-ra to grab her free hand. “Adora, it’s time to go. We don’t need to waste any more time on her.”

“How sentimental of you, Catra.” Shadow Weaver sighed. “And, I suppose, you are happy now? Do you really think you’re going to get everything you’ve wanted?”

Catra gritted her jaw before jutting out her fangs. “This isn’t about me!”

Shadow Weaver spared Catra a smug glance. “Are you sure? You were so desperate for Adora to come back home that you decided it was better to make her a captive than let her leave you again. Come on Catra, you never cared about the Horde winning the war, all you wanted was to stop feeling so lonely.”

Catra's hand went rigid. She-ra squeezed her hand for comfort, but Catra retreated into herself.

Shadow Weaver arched a brow and met Catra's eye. "Let me give you a little advice," she said, "the harder you hold on, the harder she will pull away. In the end, you'll wind up alone, just like me."

Catra's ears pinned backwards as she dropped She-ra's hand. Face fully exposed, Shadow Weaver smirked.

"Just," She-ra frowned, "just stop talking. Catra's right, it's over. We're going home." She stalked to where her previous shackles were still bolted to the wall. With one eye still on Shadow Weaver, she pulled at the chains until they came loose. Deftly, she reshaped the chain links until she held a pair of makeshift handcuffs.

"Do you really think that will hold me?" Shadow Weaver said, crossing her arms.

"They'll hold you long enough for us to get you on a transport to Beast Island," She-ra replied. She walked up to Shadow Weaver, who made no move to attack. Before Shadow Weaver could feel her trembling, She-ra grasped, uncrossed, and pulled Shadow Weaver's hands behind her back. She-ra's skin crawled on contact. The room felt cold as panicked sweat rose to the surface of She-ra's neck.

"You can't be serious," Shadow Weaver said, smile vanishing.

"Do we need to gag you too?" She-ra said. She willed her voice to sound booming and commanding, but it came out wavering. She flared her nostrils in embarrassment.

She-ra clicked the manacles roughly on Shadow Weaver's wrists, trying to pour her rising anger into the motion. But, before she could let go, Shadow Weaver closed the distance between their bodies, pressing herself into She-ra. Leaning up towards She-ra's ear, Shadow Weaver whispered, "You can try, but I'll never really go away."

Biting her tongue to keep from crying out, She-ra shoved Shadow Weaver away. The caress of Shadow Weaver's breath was gone,

but the feeling that sunk deep into She-ra's pores lingered. Like Shadow Weaver had bitten her instead, leaving a lasting mark. She wiped her hands on her shorts, trying to erase the feeling of Shadow Weaver against her and the nausea boiling in her stomach. "Don't touch me."

Shadow Weaver twisted her lips into a grin. "You are so naive."

Catra made her way over, still shaken, but now fueled anew by anger. "Stop it," Catra said, shoving Shadow Weaver to the door. "You heard Adora, you're going to Beast Island. Hope you had time to pack."

Sweeping her eyes from Catra to She-ra, Shadow Weaver raised her eyebrows, but kept her mouth shut. She-ra bristled under her scrutiny, feeling naked before her. Her bright blue eyes went wide before Catra pushed Shadow Weaver again away from her.

Angella shuffled in the corner, drawing She-ra's attention. "Angella, let me help you," She-ra said, jogging over to Angella. "Can you stand?"

She-ra offered a hand to Angella, who took it. While pulling Angella to her feet, She-ra began to glow. "Um, I don't know what's going on," She-ra said, eyes darting side to side.

Angella rose, much steadier than Adora had anticipated. In She-ra's grasp, Angella's hands began to glow with a faint purple light that started to run its way up her arm and through the rest of her body. Angella jerked forward. When She-ra put up her other hand to anchor Angella, she was stopped by Angella waving her hand. "That will be quite enough."

With a quick tug, Angella pulled back her hand, massaging it where She-ra had held.

"What just happened?" She-ra asked. The purple glow faded from Angella and then She-ra's golden light followed it moments after. "I'm sorry. Are you okay?"

“I am more than okay. It seems that you have transferred some of your magic to me. This must be related to your healing powers.” Angella examined her hands again. “I feel refreshed. Thank you.”

She-ra rubbed the back of her neck. “Don’t mention it.”

“We’re kind of on a schedule here,” Catra said, tapping her foot.

“Right,” She-ra said, looking back at Angella. Angella nodded. “Let’s get going.”

“You too,” Catra commanded, pushing Shadow Weaver. “Let’s go.”

The group converged at the exit of the Black Garnet chamber. Angella gripped Shadow Weaver’s arm like a vice. Shadow Weaver let out a grunt and Angella smirked, pulling her along. “I’ll take care of this one. You two have had quite enough of her.”

Shadow Weaver let herself be led out the door and into the hallway, where the alarm lights still flashed. Behind them, She-ra and Catra stood side by side. They looked back at the Black Garnet. It still shuttered, even without Shadow Weaver influencing it. A red streak of lightning cut across its form. Even if it was no longer obeying orders from their torturer, it made them both shudder. This place only held haunting memories.

With She-ra’s gaze fixed, Catra shut the door. She-ra blinked in surprise. When she left before, she thought she’d never see the Black Garnet again. She was wrong. What if she was wrong again?

Catra interrupted her thoughts. “She’s right about me, you know. I-I’m not a good person.”

Clumsily, She-ra reached forward. She fumbled with Catra’s fingers unused to using her bigger hands for delicate tasks. “She’s not.”

Catra scoffed, but did not pull away.

“And Catra?” She-ra said, waiting for Catra to look up at her. “I think you have a promise to make good on.” She-ra smiled. “Let’s go home.”

Searching She-ra’s eyes, Catra nodded slowly. She looked away, but not quickly enough to hide her half smile from She-ra. With a claw, she pressed a button in her ear, engaging the communicator. “She-ra is back. I repeat, She-ra is back.”

“Ugh,” Mermista gasped as she received Catra’s message, “finally!” Her clothes were in tatters. There were gaping holes torn out of the knees of her pants. Her shirt hung off one shoulder since the shoulder pad pinning it together on the other had been ripped off. A number of burns, cuts, and bruises littered her body. Needless to say, she was ready to go home. And not to Bright Moon to hang out for another sleepover and get woken up before dawn, back to Salineas. Back to the ocean and the tide and the waves. And she’d do it knowing her kingdom would be safer with She-ra out of the Horde’s grasp.

Mermista, Perfuma, and their new Horde friends were back-to-back in the center of Hordak’s Sanctum, Horde soldiers strewn at their feet. Perfuma’s chest rose and fell quickly as she wiped a streak of blood off her face. “They did it! I’m so proud.”

“Hey now, don’t underplay our role,” Mermista responded. “I swear I’ve never beat up this many people at one time. They should be thanking us.”

“What are you blabbing about?” Lonnie shouted, breathing heavy herself. Another wave of soldiers was coming at them. “Oh, here we go again.” She ignited her taser. Rogelio, purple blood oozing out of his mouth, slammed his fist into the open palm of his other hand and let out a growl. Kyle hid behind him.

“The She-ra has returned!” Perfuma said with a warmth that felt out of place in the room. “We can finally go home -,” she slapped an oncoming soldier in the face with a plant, “- and, wow, am I ready for that. Bright Moon has been,” her eyes screwed up in thought, “wonderfully quaint, but I’m ready to see Plumeria again.”

“Come on traitor friends, let’s get going,” Mermista said. “You’re coming with us, right?”

“Doesn’t look like we have much of a choice!” Lonnie yelled, stepping back as her bruised fists dislocated the jaw of her closest target. She rubbed her knuckles and winced.

“Love that enthusiasm,” Mermista drawled sarcastically. “Okay, blondie, time to bust out of here.”

“I thought you’d never ask,” Perfuma smiled sweetly.

“I didn’t - ugh, whatever. Let’s get out of here.” Mermista raised her hands. She was exhausted, but all they needed to do was create a path out. And no way she was giving up now, not when they’d torn through the literal mountain of evil Horde soldiers piled in front of her. Perfuma threw her fists in the air alongside Mermista. In a straight line to the door, they knocked the soldiers aside. Mermista grunted as she created a barrier to protect them all the way to the door. “I can’t hold this forever,” she said, renewed sweat pouring out her face, “So you better -” she slipped a little, “- run fast!”

Kyle was the first one out the door, but the rest followed closely. Mermista looked left and saw the hallway packed with soldiers. “Not that way,” she said as she turned on her foot to run the other direction. “Can you get us out of here, or what?” she asked, breaking into a panicked sprint.

“Follow me!” Lonnie said, overtaking lead of the pack, even though her ankle had been turned in the wrong direction at some point in the battle. “Where’s your transport at?”

“It’s at the edge of the woods,” Perfuma said, huffing and now fighting to keep a smile on her face, even though a bruise was beginning to force her eye to swell shut.

“Are you serious?!” Lonnie asked, running a hand down her bloodied face. “Let’s just take one of ours!”

“Lonnie, that’s strictly against the rules!” Kyle piped up. “We could get in huge trouble!”

“Kyle! Are you serious?” Lonnie yelped as she took a sharp turn. “You literally just punched Lord Hordak. Do you think he’s just going to forget about that?”

“Oh no!” Kyle said, grabbing his head in his hands.

Rogelio let out a string of exasperated grunts and sighs.

“So, you all seem like you have some *major* issues to work through,” Mermista said.

“I can help!” Perfuma chimed in. “Once we’re home anyway. This place is really starting to get on my nerves.” With a pained sound, Perfuma blocked the hallway behind them with another pull of magic. Her hair, normally full of bounce, was plastered against her neck and forehead.

“Great, thanks,” Lonnie said, sarcasm oozing out.

Mermista laughed, but Perfuma perked up and said, “You’re welcome!”

Rogelio pointed for the group to turn and, sooner than expected, they made their way into a small, mostly empty hangar.

“What is this place?” Mermista asked.

“It’s one of our deployment rooms for protecting the perimeter. It’s mostly empty because, well,” Kyle fiddled with his hands, “we

were protecting the perimeter. From you. And now we're with you. Deserting our home."

"Kyle, can it!" Lonnie yelled, almost giving in to the desire to bang her head against the wall. "There's a few transports in here. Rogelio is going to get it going and then I need a nap and time away from all of you."

Kyle looked forsaken, but Mermista held out a fist to Lonnie, "Word."

Confused, Lonnie bumped Mermista's fist with her own. Rogelio shrugged before bending over a skiff and firing it up. It whirred to life in an instant and they began to pile on.

"We're on our way out with some Horde nerds," Mermista radioed. "We're abandoning our skiff and using one of theirs instead. Feel free to grab it for us, or don't, or whatever."

Lonnie put her hands on her hips. "Who are you calling a nerd?"

Mermista and Lonnie's eyes snapped to Kyle, then Perfuma, and then back to each other. The hangar echoed with their laughter. They both smiled while the rest of the crew sank down into any part of the skiff they could claim as their own.

Rogelio hit a button to open the hangar door and they were off.

Scorpia and Glimmer huddled together with Frosta between them. Frosta was pale, but with Scorpia and Glimmer propping her up, she did what she could to protect them from the onslaught, mostly by shooting small icicles to knock debris away from Netossa's blind spot.

They were close to the top of the elevator shaft now and none of them knew what to do once they collided with the beast. Frosta could see it clearly now. It had wound a web at the top, blocking them from the door. It was eerily similar to Netossa's nets, but the thread was thinner and it glowed with an evil looking green color, the kind of shade that did not exist in nature. If she squinted, Frosta could see sharp glints like razor wire strewn into the web. Her breath was short, as if she had already been caught in the monster's clutches.

Netossa stood on her own in the center of the platform. She shed her coat and wrist gauntlets long ago. They rested in a heap at her feet. It left her arms and shoulders bare. Veins and muscles popped out as she strained to keep them alive. Sweat ran down her shoulders and dripped off her elbows in cascades. Netossa was their last line of defense and she took her job very seriously.

She tried pushing back against the monster's web with her nets, but it was no use. The superbot's web was impenetrable by her strength alone. Netossa knew why now the spider had crawled to the top. It was doing what its biological equivalent did best, laying a trap. A trap that they had no hope but colliding with. Netossa didn't want to think what would happen if they got caught, but the possibility edged closer and closer.

In the center of its web, the TARANTULA sat. It was no longer moving about on its powerful and hideous legs. Only its eyes flickered over them, waiting patiently to ensnare its prey. Netossa stared back, breathing heavy. They were frozen for a moment in time, taking each other in. The cranking of gears and the platform sliding upwards sounded around them in the darkness.

Scorpia nudged Glimmer. "How are you doing?"

"I -" Glimmer looked at her hands and grunted. "I don't think I have enough energy left to teleport us." To emphasize her point, she tried to light up her hands. A faint light glowed at the tips of her fingers but fizzled out. "I'm sorry! I'm so sorry. The one time everyone needs me and I fail."

“Hey, hey, it’s okay,” Scorpia smiled. “We got this.” Scorpia looked up and frowned. “I’m sure we’ll think of something.” Scorpia bit her lip.

“Netossa?” a voice cried from above.

Netossa went pale before tears sprung from her eyes. There was no sweeter sound in all the universe. “Spinny? Are you up there?” The bot shifted, creaking as it searched for this new intruder.

“I’m here!” Spinnerella said, floating out of reach above them and above the web. “What’s going on?” Where she was positioned, light shone brighter, making the darkness beneath her even harder to cut through with her eyes.

“Don’t come down here Spinnerella!” Netossa shouted. “There’s a giant spider bot. It’s weaved a web and we’re going to run right into it. If you come down, you’ll get caught too.”

“Are you kidding?” Spinnerella yelled back. “Quit trying to do everything on your own.” Netossa heard as wind started to pick up at the top of the shaft. A cyclone started to form, picking up momentum as it spun. Even the limbs of the bot started to detach from the web. With a metallic hiss, it weaved its limbs in between separate threads, burying itself deeper. “What do you need?”

“We need to break the web!” Netossa yelled. “I-It’s too strong for me.”

“Together then?” Spinnerella said, strain present in her voice.

Netossa smiled, finding her second wind. “Yeah, together.”

In tandem, Netossa and Spinnerella yelled. Their powers flared, filling the room with a crackling energy. With all the force she could, Netossa shot a net to one side of the shaft. From her end, Spinnerella did the same with a forceful gust. Their powers met on either side of the web, pushing against it, trying to breach it and reach each other. The bot skittered away to the opposite side, avoiding the onslaught.

Netossa dropped to her knees now, looking as if she was holding up the entire world on her shoulders. Her teeth gritted together until she thought they may crack. Muscles on fire, Netossa only yelled louder, pushing herself beyond any limit she had ever known.

"I'm coming!" Spinnerella said, redoubling her efforts. The noise was almost unbearable. But the web did not give.

"It's not breaking!" Glimmer said, gasping. Prominent veins stood out on Netossa's neck as tears fell down her eyes. Glimmer could see her pulse pounding in her arteries.

Frosta stared. They would not go down like this. "Help me up," she said, voice weak. "They need me."

Glimmer's eyes widened. "You can't -"

"- either I get up or we die. I'm fine! Help me up!" Frosta commanded.

"O-oh, okay," Scorpia said. "We got you." Bending down, Scorpia picked Frosta up off the ground and placed her carefully on her feet. When Frosta cried out and started to crumple, Glimmer grabbed her hand to steady her. With a grunt, Frosta rose. Blood started to trickle out of her leg and she could feel it run into her boots, soaking into her socks. The bandage Netossa had made was breaking apart, but Frosta locked her knees and looked to the sky.

Her knee started to buckle and she let out a hiss of pain. Scorpia steadied her and gave a nod. Glimmer watched in awe, eyes meeting Scorpia's in astonishment. How did they keep finding more strength? But, Frosta knew. She might be bleeding out, but she was far from out of magic.

With a deep breath, Frosta lifted her hands. From the deepest depths of her belly, Frosta released a cry. Ice spread up from the floor until it covered her legs, locking her into place. Scorpia took a step away and placed her arm around Glimmer.

Glimmer let out a gasp. The air that left her lips puffed up in front of her face as the temperature sank.

Frosta's eyes started to glow with power as the ice rose up, encasing first her injured leg, and then her entire body.

"It's not enough!" Netossa yelled, starting to bend under the forces of magic and machine working against her. "Spinny, I-"

"-One final push, come on Netossa!" Spinnerella yelled. "Don't give up on me now! You can do this."

Netossa pushed, tears hitting the floor as she shook. But, this time, a beam of ice shot up next to her, with Frosta at its base. Frosta's cry grew louder as crystal upon crystal built up, creating an underground ice cap. It rose slowly at first and then, in a blast. Netossa forced her fingers to the sky and Frosta matched with her fists. A loud rip echoed around them.

And then, it all came tumbling down.

The web broke. The bot clung to the remaining shreds of its web, crawling quickly to the wall away from the hole. The web sunk, losing its taunt pull. Spinnerella fell down the hole at super speed, colliding with Netossa a little too hard for them to both stay standing.

"Way to make an entrance," Netossa said, breathing heavy, but smiling up at her wife.

"Anything for you." Spinnerella put her forehead against Netossa's as they both regained their breath.

A crackling sound brought them back to reality. The ice pillar was tall and strong, but there was only a girl holding it up by strength alone. Cracks ran down its sides, sending small fragments to shatter around them. A louder crack followed by a thunk sent the entire thing to start toppling towards them.

"Frosta!" Glimmer shouted.

Frosta, at the base of the pillar, fell aside, separating her body from the ice. She was unconscious and her entire lower leg was dyed red with blood.

“I’ve got her,” Scorpia said, scoping Frosta up.

“We need to go!” Glimmer yelled.

The bot smelled blood. It abandoned its web and started to crawl down toward them.

Spinnerella ran up to them. “I can get us out, but I need help.” She glanced back at Netossa. “This pillar is going to fall on us unless we do something about it.”

Netossa nodded and gathered nets in her hands as she ran up beside Spinnerella. “If we’re lucky, it might hit someone else,” she said grinning. Standing shoulder to shoulder, they knocked out one last attack. Creaking, the pillar began to move as they forced it to fall away from them instead.

They strained, but, at best, the pillar was standing straight. Scorpia, hardened her features and, with all her might, pushed against the pillar with muscle. The column gave. Gravity did the rest of the work as it fell faster and faster until it hit the wall, cascading the bot in sharp crystals of ice.

“I don’t think that will kill it, grab on to me!” Spinnerella said.

Exhausted, they all grabbed on. With a grunt, Spinnerella whipped up a cyclone beneath them and flew them up and through the opening at the top of the shaft. Glimmer closed her eyes to try and keep her motion sickness at bay. She was not used to moving through the world quickly, only instantly.

When she opened her eyes again, they were under the sky, the light of the morning moon starting to peak out of the horizon.

“We did it!” she said. Then horror fell over her face. “Oh my god, what’s even happening? Where’s Bow? Where’s Adora?”

Scorpia turned Frosta back over to Netossa and Spinnerella, who went to work repatching her leg. Netossa felt for a pulse. “She’s okay, but she’s lost a lot of blood.” Softer, she said, “Don’t know what we would have done without you, kid.”

Pushing a button on her chest, Scorpia connected with the radio channel. “Um, hello can you hear us?” White noise increased in volume so suddenly that Scorpia almost ripped out her earpiece.

“Scorpia! Is that you? Are you okay?” Bow called back.

“We’re um, well,” Scorpia scanned her crew.

“Scorpia!” Bow yelled.

“We’re okay! We’re alive anyway. Wow do we have a story for you. We made it to the top of the shaft. Our team is in bad shape. We need to get-”

Then, not over the radio, but in person, Scorpia heard Sea Hawk’s voice above them. “Did someone ask for a rescue?”

A skiff was hovering above their heads, with both Bow leaning over the edge and Sea Hawk at the helm. When they landed, Bow jumped off and hugged Glimmer, who melted weakly into his arms. “You’re okay,” Bow whispered. “I was so worried.”

Glimmer smiled. “I-” a bang underground jostled her feet beneath her. “We need to go! What is that thing?”

Bow jumped back in the skiff and offered a hand to Glimmer. “Entrapta called it TARANTULA.”

“Of course,” Glimmer replied, eye twitching as she placed her hand in Bow’s. “Of course, it’s one of Entrapta’s pet projects.”

Sea Hawk helped the remaining passengers board, with Frosta resting on Spinnerella’s lap while being monitored by Netossa.

Another thump sounded beneath them. “Not trying to rush anyone here,” Scorpia said, “but I think it would maybe be a good idea to get as far away from here as possible. That thing gives me the jeebies!”

“Roger that!” Sea Hawk said, turning a key and bringing the skiff back to life. They floated above the ground and shot into the sky.

Glimmer collapsed against the ground. Bow squeezed her shoulder. “Where’s everyone else?” Glimmer asked. “Are they okay?” Now that she was no longer under the stress of dying, she found her fear placed elsewhere.

“They’re okay,” Bow said. “At least the last I hear. Mermista and Perfuma are with Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio. They stole a Horde skiff and are retreating to the woods. Mermista says she gets to keep it.”

Glimmer’s eyebrows furrowed, “Where is Catra?”

“She’s with Adora. And, um,” Bow scratched his head, “your mom.”

The sigh of relief Glimmer had started was rudely cut off. “My what?!”

All the occupants of the skiff looked to her with tired eyes.

“Look, I don’t know Glimmer! Queen Angella just showed up and decided to get in on the action. And she scared the crap out of me and Sea Hawk,” Bow grumbled.

Sea Hawk stood proudly, “I knew she would come all along! All part of my great plan.”

Glimmer bent her head up to look Bow wickedly in the eye, “Where are they?”

“They told me they have a pit stop to make but we’re going to pick them up.”

Glimmer grabbed her hair and pulled. “A pit stop? For what!?”

She-ra made her way through the Fright Zone, shuffling away from the center of the fight to skirting around its edges. Angella kept her grip on Shadow Weaver tight, ready at any moment for her to turn into smoke and waft away. But she didn’t. Without the power of the runestone, Shadow Weaver was left drained and, though she tried to hide it with the way she held herself, it was clear she was at the point of exhaustion.

They didn’t talk as they walked. The corridors and rooms they passed were familiar to all but Angella and She-ra would be glad to never see them again. Still, she skated the fingers of her open hand along the walls, somber and still not quite believing that she’d leave today. And even if she did, her future seemed dark, destined to be riddled with pain.

Catra squeezed her other hand. She-ra blinked, missing a step in their tandem rhythm before giving Catra a soft smile. Catra was ready to get out of here. She had insisted that She-ra wait for Bow while she and Angella took care of Shadow Weaver, but that argument had been short. Catra hadn’t said the reasons that Adora should not come, not in front of Shadow Weaver. They had to walk through the prison block to get to the prisoner transportation dock. They wouldn’t walk past Adora’s cell, but the units all looked the same.

Pointing Angella in the right direction and keeping her eyes on Shadow Weaver’s back, Catra pulled at She-ra to stop walking. “You don’t have to do this,” she whispered.

“It’s fine, Catra,” She-ra responded, bristling. “I need to make sure she doesn’t try to pull anything.”

“The outcome will be the same either way. Why do you need to go through this too?” Catra said, grumbling.

“Because, I,” She-ra swallowed. Catra was worrying too much. Sure, as they approached, Adora thought of waking up in her cell alone and cold, but sweating. And the times Catra had come to visit her just to gloat. Or when her lungs had burnt like fire in her chest, not letting her breathe at all. But the worst was when she had been in control, but not fully aware of what was happening. She didn’t want to know how many hours had passed where she felt nothing at all. “Come on, let’s just get this over with.”

They took quick steps to catch back up with Angella as they started to walk through the prison block. Catra’s ears fell shyly against her head. Adora stared at the floor. Their footsteps felt heavier here, weighed down by invisible chains.

“Hey,” Catra’s tail perked up, “remember when I tried to break you out and, instead of leaving, you set off the prison alarm? You’re such an idiot.”

Shadow Weaver made a scolding noise in front of them, but Angella jerked her forward before she could say anything.

She-ra’s eyebrows furrowed and then she smiled. “Oh, and I’m the idiot in that scenario?” Then, in a bad replication of Catra’s voice, she said, “I’m Catra and I’m here to save you but I don’t actually have a plan.”

“Shut up!” Catra laughed. “I had a plan. You just broke it trying to be all noble or whatever.”

She-ra looked at her fondly, nearly forgetting the glow of the prison cells surrounding them as they passed through the middle of the massive chamber. Catra’s smirk fell off her face and was replaced with something kinder.

“Which door?” Angella asked, trying to keep her eyes straight ahead.

“Oh,” She-ra blushed, “we’ll show you.” Casting her eyes downward, She-ra let go of Catra. She-ra moved forward to lead the way while Catra was left behind, frowning.

When She-ra moved to the front, Shadow Weaver decided it was time to break her silence. “Do you really think this is a good idea?” she asked, arms still tightly bound behind her back.

She-ra turned around to respond, but before she could, Catra’s growl filled the air. “No one has ever come back before. You’re nothing special.”

Shadow Weaver’s eyes flitted to She-ra, who squirmed under her gaze. “Quite the gamble to take, isn’t it?”

“We can just kill her now and end this,” Catra said with annoyance as they crossed through a door out of the prison block itself. “I’d be more than happy to be the one to do it.” To make her point, Catra’s claws extended dangerously.

“That isn’t right, Catra,” She-ra said with a sigh. “We’re doing this.” Not that ‘this’ left She-ra feeling good about herself. Her feelings about Shadow Weaver were confusing. She knew she couldn’t just kill her old mentor, but she couldn’t just let Shadow Weaver stay either. Beast Island was the only option that felt possible.

Catra grunted, but ushered them towards a pod. These pods were small, meant for one passenger only. There were several of them in a neat line, small lights blinking green and red. As far as aircraft go, there was nothing special about them. All commands were made at the docking station by the computer, not giving inmates a chance to tamper with the coding. Of course, when Entrapta had worked on them, she had hacked them from the inside immediately, but not everyone had Entrapta’s hair or brains. Plus, Entrapta had improved them. It had been a day project for her, but she’d quickly lost interest when Hordak didn’t allow her to add any new capabilities. Their function was simple: a one-way trip to Beast Island.

Catra wrenched the door open for the pod closest to them. Inside was a hard bench and a small window you couldn't fit a fist through. "Help me with this, would you?" she gestured at Angella rudely.

Angella raised an eyebrow, but put her hands on Shadow Weaver's shoulder, forcing her to duck into the pod. Shadow Weaver's hair was flat and hung loose down her back. It unnerved She-ra to see her like this, looking weak and exposed without her mask. Shadow Weaver had never given off anything other than power and malice. Though, there were still edges to her now, glinting treacherously.

"At least take these off me," Shadow Weaver rotated so her wrists were exposed. Her head was bent as waited. "You are already sending me to my death. At least spare me my discomfort."

"No way," Catra said, grabbing the door and ready to slam it shut.

"Catra wait," She-ra said, sticking her hand out. "She's right."

"Adora," Catra hissed, tail lashing uncomfortably behind her. "You don't owe her anything."

"I know," She-ra said, "but I'm going to give it to her anyway. It's the right thing to do." She turned to Shadow Weaver. "I'll take them off, but if you try anything funny, I won't hesitate," She-ra said, eyes glowing.

"I merely want to relax in my last moments," Shadow Weaver said with a flat expression.

She-ra grabbed the manacles and crushed them beneath her fingers. Shadow Weaver shuffled inside, pressing her back against the interior wall with a sigh. She rubbed her wrists where the metal had chafed. Glancing around the pod, Shadow Weaver showed no signs of fear, only disinterest.

She-ra lingered, staring at the woman before her. Shadow Weaver raised her. Shadow Weaver hurt her, but hadn't she taught Adora

to be strong too? She-ra's skin burned with the dark memory of Shadow Weaver's touch, but tears also pricked at her eyes. Embarrassed at the conflict in her heart, She-ra coughed and wiped her eyes. She bit her lip, but, still, stared.

Interrupting her thoughts, Catra took her hand and pulled her back from the door before swinging and locking it shut. "We should get going," she said softly, but her eyes were hard, looking at the pod.

She-ra took a step back, but otherwise stood rigid. Catra dropped her hand while she typed controls into the interface. "Adora, we're ready to go."

She-ra nodded in acknowledgement. At Catra's words, Shadow Weaver's eyes locked on hers. They were soft. Softer than the white pits of the mask had ever been. "Why did you do it?" she asked, leaning forward.

Shadow Weaver scoffed and shook her head. With genuine emotion she said, "You've never understood." She ran a hand along the window, reaching out for She-ra. "You mean the world to me, Adora."

Searching Shadow Weaver's eyes, She-ra found all the affection she used to, or maybe still, craved from Shadow Weaver. All she had ever wanted was to make Shadow Weaver proud. Why now? She grinded her teeth together, feeling like she was about to explode from the injustice. How could Shadow Weaver say that after everything that she'd put Adora through? The words kept replaying in her head and, she knew, they'd haunt her for the rest of her life.

Catra's fingers tightened into fists. "Come on, Adora."

"And you," Shadow Weaver said, shifting her gaze to Catra. "Best of luck." She smiled and then laid her head back in her hands and closed her eyes. Catra blinked hard, tail bristling as she fought to contain a shake.

She-ra hit the button to initiate the launch sequence so hard, the plastic surrounding it splintered. She shook the tears out of her eyes. “Let’s get out of here.”

Angella took several steps back to the door before she realized no one was following her. She-ra and Catra stayed behind, hand and hand until the pod released from its launch station and then propelled into the sky in a delicate arc. It flew through air, becoming smaller and smaller until all they could see was a spark of light retreating on the horizon.

She-ra pulled Catra into a hug, turning back into Adora as she did. When the light cleared, her face was pressed into Catra’s shoulder. Adora knew they didn’t have time for this, so she stifled her tears into a few long sobs, desperately breathing in Catra to calm her enough to get out of the Fright Zone. Though she was more reserved than Adora, tears leaked out of Catra’s eyes too, even though she didn’t know why. She clung to Adora.

“She’s gone. She won’t hurt you anymore,” Catra whispered. Adora continued to sniffle. Every time she tried to calm herself, another wave would come over her, but now was not the time or the place.

Adora placed her hand on the back on Catra’s head, pulling her tighter. “You either,” she said, muffled into Catra’s neck.

But even as she said it, all the poisonous words Shadow Weaver had whispered to her that day came tumbling back. She squeezed her eyes shut and held Catra closer.

With Adora’s head still buried in Catra, Catra reached up to her ear. “Hey, Arrow Boy, come pick us up.” Her voice broke with emotion. She coughed to hide it. “We’re ready for you now.”

They walked out of the room and outside. There were no guards over here, Mermista and Perfuma had done their job well, but that didn’t mean their time was endless. Eventually the Horde would relocate them. Angella crossed her arms while they waited for

their pick up. Catra had her arm around Adora's waist protectively, holding them together. Tears were still running down both their faces, but they wiped at them when a skiff came into view.

Catra let Adora go. "They're going to be all over you and, believe me, I don't want any part in that." She wiped her nose again and smiled.

Adora cocked her head at Catra before hugging her again. "Thank you for coming back for me."

Catra smiled. "That's what friends are for."

Before Adora got a chance to say anything else, Bow was off the skiff and launching himself around her. The surprise touch made her stiffen before Bow's laughter filled her ears to relax her. "Adora! I missed you so much."

She spun around and picked him up in a hug, "Bow!" New, happier tears fell down her face. She didn't think she would ever see them again.

More slowly, Glimmer skidded up to her and joined the hug. "Adora!"

"Best friend squad back in action!" Bow exclaimed.

The embrace was soft and warm, but it was also foreign and stifling. Adora felt her breath hitch as she pulled back. Instantly, her eyes found Bow's scar. "Bow, your arm," Adora said, color draining from her face. "Is that from-"

"-it's nothing, Adora. I'm fine." Bow smiled broadly. "And most importantly, you're fine. I can't tell you how good it is to have you back."

"I'm so sorry, Bow, I didn't mean to - I," Adora stuttered, feeling overwhelmed. Would there be a lot of moments like this? She was going to have to face all the terrible things she had done under the Horde's control.

“Adora, it wasn’t you. Come on,” Glimmer ordered, “we should go home. We can all talk this out later.” Adora gave her an uncertain look. “Adora,” Glimmer said with a more commanding tone, “it wasn’t you who hurt Bow, okay? We know that, you need to learn it too. But right now, I just want to go to bed. I’m grumpy and no one wants that.”

Bow and Glimmer smiled at Adora, but the guilt had already hit her and she tore away from them. Catra saw it all happen. She came up behind Adora and grabbed her shoulder, trying to ground her. Bow and Glimmer came in for another hug, but Catra pushed them back gently. “Let’s get out of here and then you can do your weird friendship thing.”

Adora shot her a thankful glance. There were many things that, as much as Adora wished, were no longer the same. Physical touch, something she had learned to love from her friends, felt distant and reminded her too much of the other touches she’d felt without permission.

Another skiff landed beside the first one. A whole new pack of eager bodies came with it. “Wildcat!” Scorpia scooped Catra up in her own hug.

“Ack!” Catra responded, already pulled tightly into Scorpia’s chest.

“Oh, um,” Scorpia said, placing Catra back to the ground, “Glad to see you.”

“You too,” Catra smiled. Shaking her head, she slanted her eyebrows down, “Who is all here right now?”

“Um,” Bow said, looking behind him and starting to count. “Everyone but Mermista and Perfuma. They went with Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio.”

“Wait, what?” Adora said, scratching her head.

“It’s a long story,” Catra said, “I’ll tell you everything later, okay?” Catra smiled at her again, and Adora’s eyes widened. Taking

Adora’s hand again, Catra led them both up on the skiff Bow and Glimmer had come from. Bow took his position at the controls while yelling starting to break out between the Queen and Princess of Bright Moon.

“And you,” Glimmer screamed at her mother. “What are you doing here?”

“I don’t think I need to answer that,” Angella responded, narrowing her eyes as she sat down, folding her wings in.

“This was not part of the plan!” Glimmer exclaimed, finding it difficult to pace as the skiff started to rise.

“Neither was you falling off the map, Glimmer! What did you want me to do, just wait to get news of my daughter’s death?” Angella crossed her arms. “Is that what you wanted?”

Glimmer went silent before sitting and scooting nearer to her mother. “Y-you came for me? But we were fine! I mean, well . . . .”

“Glimmer,” Bow said, reprimanding her, all while his eyes never left the sky.

Angella shot her a look. “You have a lot of explaining to do when we get home.” Glimmer looked down, but, the next thing she knew, Angella wrapped her arms around her. “I’m so glad you’re alright.”

“You too, mom,” Glimmer said. They stayed like that until tears ran down both their faces. “And if you came for me, how come you ended up with Adora and Catra?”

“That is,” Angella said, putting a hand on her chin.

“Also, a long story,” Bow said, firing up the skiff.

“We shall have a debrief,” Angella said while Glimmer groaned, “but it can wait until tomorrow.”

Sea Hawk brought the other skiff into life. He was at the helm with Frosta, Netossa, and Spinnerella neatly tucked into the back. Frosta had woken up and now gave a weak thumbs up to Adora before letting her head fall back into Spinnerella's lap, utterly spent.

"Frosta!" Adora shouted, started to clamber over. "What happened?"

Catra held Adora's hand firm, keeping her from jumping off a skiff that was already too high in the air.

"She's okay, just tired," Spinnerella said quietly. "We're all ready to go home, I think."

"Then let's go!" Sea Hawk said, pushing lever on the skiff. They rose up higher into the sky and took off toward the direction of Bright Moon. Morning was coming and Adora saw, for the first time in a long time, the rise of light as the day moons peaked over the horizon.

Catra jerked Adora's arm and forced her to sit down. "They're okay. Everyone is going to be fine."

"This was all because of me," Adora said, staring at her palms. "I didn't mean-"

"-Shut up," Catra said, bumping her shoulder. "Just come here." She sat down and patted the space next to her. After looking below, Adora sat, unsure she could keep standing on shaky legs now that her adrenaline was cut. She sat, wincing at the sharp pain circling her wrists and ankles and at the dull pain that ached over her entire body.

Catra motioned Adora closer. "Relax," she said.

Everyone was alive, at least. And Adora was tired. She'd find a way to make this alright tomorrow. Breaking into a grin, she said, "Are you sure you don't like me?"

Caught off guard, Catra scowled before growling playfully. “You had to make it weird!” Before she could cross her arms, Adora fell into them, surprising Catra with a loving hug. Adora giggled and Catra pretended not to like it, but they didn’t move.

Catra’s ear flicked. She spun around to see Glimmer whispering something in Bow’s ear. Bow just smiled and said, “So cute!” Catra scowled, but still did not let go of Adora.

Eventually, they parted, finding it more comfortable to be slumped side by side as the woods rushed beneath them. Adora laced her fingers in between Catra’s. As fatigue overtook her, Adora leaned her head on Catra’s shoulder and closed her eyes. Adora whispered, “You came back.”

Catra nuzzled her cheek into the top of Adora’s head. “Of course, I did. I promised, remember?”

Adora moved their joined hands into her lap. She placed her free hand over Catra’s forearm and stroked the skin with her fingers. For the first time since Adora found the sword and left the Fright Zone, Catra purred.

Chapter End Notes

Yeah, so the chapter count changed again. In my outline, they should have gotten out of the Fright Zone like last chapter, but things have their way of changing and I'm not trying to rush it.

The hardest part of writing a story is the climax. Getting it right and making it worthwhile to the readers is a huge deal. When I started this, I wanted all the characters to show moments of strength and come through in one way or another, especially if they never were given the shot in canon. This story really is about inner strength and finding agency. I'm glad I was able to do that (and I hope it was done well), but I am ready to be done trying to keep 17+ characters in character with several plot lines happening simultaneously for

now. : D I really appreciate all of you giving me the feedback you have over the last few chapters. And, I know we're coming to a close here soon, but I just want to say thank you again before then because I do deeply appreciate it.

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Absolution

Chapter Notes

TW: PTSD, Panic attack

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The skiff cut across the brightening sky. When it passed the Fright Zone's limits, it flew easier, as if its passengers had suddenly grown lighter. The pinks and reds of morning caught in the sail, scattering the colors in every direction. Catra filled her lungs up with it and, when she let it go, it was as if she was the one flying.

After take-off, Glimmer promised she'd tell the story of her adventure beneath Etheria later. For now, she was content to be sailing high above the planet's surface, far from the Scorpioni vaults. With sleepy eyes, she settled down and, within seconds, was snoring softly into the passing breeze. Her body was twisted up in the middle of the deck, her arm jutting out beneath her in a way that could not possibly be comfortable, but did allow her to rest her hand on Bow's boot.

Bow was standing, though barely, as he steered them home. Every so often, he'd readjust his position, blinking repeatedly as the wind dried his eyes. In his shuffling, he was always careful to leave his feet unmoved so as to not disturb Glimmer. Like the rest of them, he was tired. Almost losing not one, but many, of his best friends in one night had given him a fatigue he had not expected. Days ago, when they first planned the mission, he'd agreed to take driving duty on the way home. As tired as he was, he was glad to do this. He was glad they had made it to this part of the plan at all. He looked down at Glimmer and smiled. All he had to do was deliver them home.

With her legs dangling off the front, Angella sat, hair blowing behind her as she waited for Bright Moon to come into view. Though she had not been gone long, she was desperate to be

back within its grand halls. Her wings could have carried her, but Glimmer's presence pulled her to stay with the group. Even though her daughter was sprawled out asleep, Angella took some peace in her presence. Glimmer was, after all, her last living family member. But what Angella truly longed for was to be held. To go home to Micah's arms at last.

In the moment that Shadow Weaver had her bound, Micah's voice came to her calm and clear. Without him, Angella was sure she would have given in. Micah had not let her be a coward then. She owed it to him to be brave on her own now. Still, when his memory faded, like it always seemed to, she was left lonelier than before. She fought to remember the cadence of his voice and the exact way his lips would curl at the edges when he looked at her. She mourned the loss of his touch and of the way the light hit his eyes, leaving her with only a poor memory.

Placing her palms flat against the deck, she leaned back and looked skyward. Rays of warmth hit her skin, erasing the goosebumps that trailed across her skin. She willed the heat to enter her bones and remove the chill there too. The light helped, but the darkness would never be fully extinguished.

Behind all of them, sat Catra and Adora facing backwards. The Fright Zone faded into obscurity, leaving only a fiery light in the sky to mark its presence. The murky smells of oil and decay retreated, replaced by the bright, living scent of the Whispering Woods. To Adora, it was surreal. Her hands had been chained for so long, she didn't remember what it was like to move them freely. The space was too big when all she knew was a single room. Even the colors didn't make sense. It was so vibrant here it blinded eyes that had only learned to see gray.

Where Adora's grip had been confident it now went limp in its place twined between Catra's fingers. Coming back to the world was less like a rebirth and more like plunging into dark water. Even the fall of Catra's chest beside her seemed out of place. Like Adora had broken and her jagged edges didn't fit into Catra's smooth ones anymore.

Catra nudged Adora with her elbow. “Good riddance, right?”

Adora’s eyebrows drew together, focusing on the last view of the Fright Zone before it slipped below the horizon. Catra squeezed her hand.

“Yeah,” Adora said, “good riddance.” She turned her head to look at Catra, who smiled. Adora tried to return the gesture, but struggled until giving up. Her head fell back against the skiff. This feeling didn’t make sense. Catra, Glimmer, Bow, they were all here. Shadow Weaver was gone. Even so, Adora could not suppress the feeling that everything was out of place.

“You can get some sleep,” Adora said, swallowing. “You must be tired after . . .” she trailed off, blinking up until the sky swam over her.

Catra ran her thumb over Adora’s hand. “I’m okay. Your bed in Bright Moon might not be as soft as Glimmer’s, but it’s a definite upgrade from the Horde.”

“My bed?” Adora asked, squinting as light hit her eyes.

“Yeah, your bed,” Catra said lightly. “To be honest, I was expecting more from the room of a princess, but it was an okay place to crash for a few days.”

Adora bit her bottom lip. How many mornings in Bright Moon had she woken up grasping at empty sheets for Catra and found nothing? And before that, when they shared a bed almost every night instead of sleep in their proper bunks. Adora was sure those things had happened, but most of her could not even fathom a night of sleep. She slept in uncomfortable spurts, dreams and reality overlapping until she could no longer distinguish between them.

When Adora didn’t respond, Catra’s tail lashed underneath her uncomfortably. “It was just a few nights. I cleaned up, don’t worry about it. You won’t know I was ever there.”

When Catra pulled her hand away, Adora's eyes went wide. "Of course, it's fine. I'm glad. I . . . told Glimmer a long time ago that . . . . I'm," she bit her lip harder, "sorry, I'm . . ." Instead of finishing her apology, she let the sentence hang.

For a second, Catra waited. When nothing came, she crossed her arms, flattened her ears, and turned away.

Behind her, Adora rubbed rough fingers over her eyebrows and temples. "Catra?" she whispered, "Glimmer was right to . . . I mean I'm glad you stayed there." The tension in Catra released. "I'm sorry," Adora sat back, "It's just . . . I can't . . . I don't know how to explain." Her voice became lost in the wind as she sat back.

Turning back around, Catra watched Adora slump into the ground. Her heart slowed and warmed. "It's okay," she said, half to Adora and half to herself. The line between Adora's eyebrows got deeper. "It's okay," Catra soothed, voice softer, as she stretched towards Adora.

Catra brushed stray hairs behind Adora's cheek. Her fingers lingered, tracing small lines down Adora's face. Adora closed her eyes, giving Catra a chance to examine her. Adora looked worn. The tan she used to have was faded. She'd always had light skin, but now it was ghostly. In contrast, the circles under her eyes were dark and deep. With the light of day hitting her, equally dark bruises speckling her temples and neck were exposed. Catra cringed at the implications.

It was worse than when Catra had left her. It could have been that Adora's face was half hidden by dim lighting during their infrequent encounters, but Catra didn't think that was the only reason. Adora had faced new horrors, she had to have, and it made Catra's skin crawl. Catra brought her hand down, hugging Adora's arm to her chest.

Adora's eyes opened again, showing off the redness running through and around them. "I thought you were," Adora's throat

worked, trying to eat her discomfort. “When you got taken away, I thought that was it. I thought you were,” she breathed, “gone.”

“You’re not giving me very much credit,” Catra joked, but Adora did not smile. Instead, her mouth turned into a hard line. Catra sighed, “Look, me too, okay? I was . . .” she trailed her claws across the back of Adora’s hand, “I thought I’d never see you again.”

“What happened?” Adora asked, bending down to talk softly in Catra’s ear. “How did you get out?”

“You really can’t wait for this until later, can you?” Catra asked, snuggling in closer when Adora put her arm around Catra’s shoulders. “Why does it matter? We’re here now, aren’t we?”

“Catra,” Adora scolded.

“Okay, whatever,” Catra said. “I can’t believe you’re making me say this but,” she grunted, “Kyle saved me.”

“Wait,” Adora gaped, “what?” Catra flared her nostrils. Adora snorted out a laugh. “That’s so embarrassing for you.”

“Shut up, I know. I told you this wasn’t a good story,” Catra growled playfully. “The Horde soldiers who came were actually Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio. I never even went to a prison cell. I went straight to Bright Moon with Scorpia and Arrow Boy and Sparkles.”

Adora looked even more confused than she had before. “That explains . . . some things. But how did you -”

“Look,” Catra grunted. “I know you have a lot of questions. I’ll answer them. Or at least someone will,” she nuzzled into Adora’s shoulder. “But, aside from Glimmer being hard to live with,” Catra smirked, “we made it. And we put our shit aside to get you out. That’s all that matters to me.”

Adora massaged her eyes. “I don’t understand why you all went through the trouble.”

“What’s there to understand?” Catra asked, hissing a little as she did. “You were in trouble. We got you out. Everyone is okay.” She cocked her head and grinned, “Well, maybe not the pile of Horde soldiers Mermista and Perfuma beat up.”

Again, Adora didn’t smile. Catra wasn’t used to that reaction. Since Adora wasn’t going to laugh, Catra took a deep breath and did something much harder. She let herself be vulnerable, “We couldn’t lose you, Adora. I-,” Catra sunk a canine into her tongue, “I couldn’t lose you.”

Beside her, Adora stiffened. Catra started to back away. This is exactly why she hadn’t wanted to talk about this.

Adora took a steadying breath, glimpsing Catra’s disappointment, though misinterpreting it. When Catra tried to let go of Adora’s hand, Adora held. With her other hand, Adora scratched the base of Catra’s ears. Catra slunk back down, wrapping her arm tentatively around Adora’s torso. When Adora didn’t move away this time, Catra let her body relax.

Adora didn’t say anything then and, so, neither did Catra. The air was crisp, full of things she could not distinguish on their own, but together made up the distinct smell of the woods, ancient and so Etherian. Beneath it, was something so powerfully connected with her, she would not have registered it if it hadn’t been missing for so long. She took another deep inhale, sinking deeper into Adora’s scent.

Between the soothing rise and fall of Adora’s chest and the lazy scratching of her ears, Catra drifted off. Some time passed, but she could only feel it in the warming of her skin as the last bits of night disappeared. It could have been minutes or hours, but, now that Adora was safe, time meant little to her.

Eventually, they hit a blip of turbulence and started to slow. Catra stirred, rubbing her eyes.

“Hey, you’re awake,” Adora whispered. “We’re just about to land.”

Catra reached her arms out above her to stretch. Adora pulled her hands back into her lap and moved away politely. Catra scowled. She reached out, covering Adora’s hand with her own. On contact, Adora flinched back with an intake of breath. She wiped her palms on the front of her shirt and muttered an apology.

“It’s okay,” Catra frowned, hand still hanging in the air. “Did you sleep at all?”

Adora absently rubbed at the raw skin circling her wrists. “I’m fine.” The wounds were closed, but left the skin around the scabs puckered tightly.

Catra narrowed her eyes. The skiff passed into Bright Moon’s transportation hangar and touched down. The whole vessel shook as they landed. Bow grimaced in a way that said that landing was unintentional. Glimmer bolted upright with raised fists, only to have her eyes flutter halfway shut when remembered the fight was over.

Sea Hawk’s skiff, along with the one stolen by Mermista, was already neatly parked and abandoned. Angella deboarded first. Bolstered by She-ra, she had energy fueling her muscles unshared by the rest of the crew.

A nearby castle guard saluted Angella. “Everyone has arrived safely?” Angella asked.

“They’ve all retired to their rooms and have asked we make accommodations for travel back to their respective kingdoms,” the guard replied, dropping their hand.

“What about the injured?” Angella said, picking dust off her uniform.

Juliet appeared and responded. “In medical. The Princess of the Kingdom of Snows required several staples for her wound, but should be okay to depart once rested. The others have received medical care for various sprains, strains, and wounds, but nothing has given lasting damage. Mostly, they just need sleep.”

“Good to hear,” Angella nodded. “They got news of the debrief?”

“They did and are willing to stay until end of day tomorrow,” Juliet answered. Angella looked behind her shoulder, seeing Glimmer and Bow helping each other off the transport. Juliet smiled, “Welcome back, Queen Angella.”

Angella turned and returned the smile. “It’s good to be back.”

Catra struggled to her feet. Her neck and back were sore all over. She was tight in a way she hadn’t been since, well, since she last fought She-ra at the Northern Reach. Facing Shadow Weaver and half the Horde army left her with a share of hurting body parts. Moving her head side to side, she tried to stretch out some of the kinks before looking over to Adora.

Adora’s legs were unsteady and, more than that, she looked shaken, like she’d woken up in a different place than the one she’d fallen asleep in. A few guards came to greet and help her, but Catra hissed at them until they backed away.

Glimmer approached with a huge yawn and said, “Welcome back home, Adora.” She itched the back of her scalp, showing off her more than extreme case of bedhead.

Bow came behind her, eyelids falling closed as his normally excellent posture slouched. “I could sleep literally anywhere.”

“No point in waiting,” Catra said, examining Adora. “Shall we?”

Adora had been gazing off elsewhere, but, as the silence continued to stretch on, she noticed the group waiting for a response. She cleared her throat. “Yes.”

Glimmer and Bow led the way, climbing the stairs on tired feet. Catra wondered to herself if Glimmer had climbed more stairs in the last day than she ever had in her life. The way she did it looked unpracticed and awkward. Then again, when Glimmer's magic was depleted, she was almost useless. It was surprising she was even on her feet now.

Adora skimmed the handrail and looked at the wall as they ascended. Glimmer babbled something only Bow was listening to. Even tired, he gasped at all the right times. Catra battled her own guilt for even being here with her growing concern for Adora.

Adora fell to the back of the group. She had been in this part of the castle so many times. Yet, it felt unfamiliar. Like it had somehow changed without her. Or maybe she had changed without it. It reminded her of the first time she had stumbled into Bright Moon. Then, she was scared and excited and overwhelmed. She ran her tongue over her teeth thinking, unsure what it was she was experiencing now. With an open hand, she reached behind her, and pulled the sword into her hands. It almost looked as strange now as it did the day she found it. The idea of being She-ra again, even a She-ra under her control, made her skin itch. She ran her hand over the hilt. There was no other option, she would find a way.

They wound up the stairs and down the hallway to the sleeping quarters. The doors seemed much bigger than they used to be. Adora could smell herself in all this open air. She smelled metallic, greasy and human. Bright Moon smelled clean and floral. Her dirty boots, her nervous sweat, her damaged body, they did not belong here.

Catra paused, looking back at Adora, who had stopped walking to put her sword on her back again. Adora stared at one of the many murals that covered the walls. Then, looked down at her hands. They were covered in soot and smeared with dried blood. She closed them into fists.

When Adora's eyes glazed over, Catra took a cautious few steps back to her. Glimmer was still yammering, but, sensing the loss of an audience, turned around with a, "Huh?"

"Hey," Catra said. Adora didn't acknowledge her. "Adora."

Adora's head snapped up, eyes wide. Catra frowned again. "Sorry," Adora said, looking at her feet. "It's just," she looked up at the mural again, "it's good to be back."

Adora's voice was thin, like it was too small to fit in her body. Catra reached out to her and Bow and Glimmer made their way over.

"I know this is probably pretty overwhelming," Bow said, "but we're here for you, okay? Let us know if you need anything. Even if you don't ask, we'll still be around." He smiled broadly.

"You have no idea how much we missed you," Glimmer said, approaching Adora for another hug.

As Bow and Glimmer descended on her, Adora's muscles tightened. Catra stepped in between, stopping the hug. "Can all this mushy stuff wait until later? All I want to do is go to bed. We have tomorrow, right?"

"Fine, whatever," Glimmer said while stretching her neck. "So, sleepover in Adora's room or what?"

Adora looked around and opened her mouth to speak, but Catra cut her off with a groan. "Go to your own room, Sparkles." Softer, she added, "We'll talk later."

"What?" Glimmer blinked.

Bow put his hand on Glimmer's shoulder and nodded to Catra. Whispering, he said, "I think they need some time alone, Glimmer."

Glimmer frowned, but with eyes snapping fully open, she took in Adora's appearance for the first time. Without meaning to, her mouth fell open. "Adora, do you . . . do you need to go to medical? Because if you do, we can stop there first."

Adora grabbed her arm by the elbow and glanced away under Glimmer's gaze. "I look that bad, huh?" Adora said with a forced half smile.

"No that's not -" Glimmer stuttered.

"- I'm fine, really. Nothing I can't take care of myself," Adora said, blushing. Glimmer gave her a disapproving look. "Glimmer, I'm fine."

"You know where to find us," Bow said, ushering Glimmer away. "Even if it's a middle of the night snack raid."

"I think it would be middle of the day snack raid at this point," Glimmer said, some of her grumpiness returning. "It's morning, remember?"

"Our sleep schedules are going to be such a mess!" Bow exclaimed, earning a small laugh from Adora. "But really, Adora. I remember when I came back from," he paused remembering his own time as a Horde prisoner, "you know, it was hard. You helped me get through that and we will help you with this now. You're not alone."

Regaining some of her focus, Adora replied thickly, "I'm okay, really. Don't worry about me. I just need to get some sleep. I think we all do."

"We'll talk when you're ready, okay?" Glimmer added. She reached out automatically, but stopped herself when Catra shot her a steely glare. She exchanged a glance with Bow before looking back to Adora. "Can we hug you?"

Adora nodded slowly. Bow and Glimmer approached her more carefully this time and stretched out their arms. Adora met them.

Someone was crying softly and Catra would put money on it being Bow.

Pulling back slightly, Bow said, "We're so glad you're back, Adora."

"Me too," Adora replied. "It's so good to see you both again."

"You too, Adora." Glimmer stepped back and yawned. "Now, if you don't mind, I am going to fall asleep standing up if I don't get to bed soon. If I'm not in my room when you get up, I'll be up at the Moonstone. My powers have literally never been so depleted."

Bow laughed. "Alright Glimmer, we better get going. We love you, Adora. We'll see you later."

Adora waved. "Bye."

Adora and Catra stayed put as Bow and Glimmer retreated to the nearest room. Adora's eyebrows pulled down. "Now what?" she asked.

"Well, I know this is your room, since I was using it the last few nights, as discussed" Catra said, striding forward and opening the door wide. When she realized she already had one foot in, she stopped. Now that she was here, she wasn't sure what to do. Adora paused next to her, letting a silence descend. Catra stepped backwards from the entrance. "I, um, I guess I'll see you later. I'm going to go crash in Scorpia's room." Catra pointed to a door further down the hallway. "I have a feeling she might not be in there anyway."

Adora arched her eyebrow. "Where else would she be?"

"Her and Perfuma," Catra smirked, "well, let's just say they've gotten close."

That earned her a mischievous smile from Adora that made Catra's heart stutter. As quickly as it came, it disappeared and the silence returned. Catra jerked her head. She had done what she

came to do and, now, the best thing she could do is leave. Catra started to walk away, leaving Adora facing her room alone.

Adora looked inside the room and listened to Catra's hesitant footsteps. Sucking in a breath, Adora reached out behind herself and caught Catra's hand mid swing. They stood facing away from each other, barely touching. "The offer still stands," Adora said quietly.

The hallway was empty and Catra could swear she heard the pounding of her heart echo. Slowly, she turned, fingers tightening on Adora's. "You want me to stay?"

"If you want to," Adora said quickly, shrugging. "It - I mean, it's your room too. Now. Right? That was the deal."

Swallowing hard, Catra nodded. "It was a deal you made with yourself, not me. I don't think you're held to contract."

For the first time since Catra had seen her today, Adora's eyes brightened. "It was a promise." Catra's mind went blank. Before she could argue, Adora pulled her inside.

Before she got far, Adora stopped. The gentle slide of water down the waterfall filled the space between her ears that had grown accustomed only to the low whir of machinery and her own stilted breaths. Birds were chirping outside, adding emphasis to her shock. Adora stared at the bed. Her bed. It looked so soft and, in the morning light peeking behind the blinds, everything was so welcoming.

With a click, the door shut behind Catra. "You okay, Adora?"

"Yeah, I'm," Adora breathed, eyes catching on yet another detail. Remembering she had not finished her sentence, she added, "fine."

Catra extended a hand, landing on Adora's shoulder. When Adora flinched, Catra started to pull back in alarm. "Adora?"

All her life, Catra had known Adora. Catra had even seen her scared. It had become less over the years, but now it was like Adora was a kid again, coming back to their bunk after a brutal day. Catra's mouth went dry. Today wasn't so different from those days, except Adora had not had just one brutal day, but a physically, mentally, and emotionally abusive series of them. Before, though, Adora had always sought out Catra's touch. A lot had happened. It made sense that would change too.

"It's just . . . I'm just tired," Adora said.

"Adora," Catra retreated, running her hands down the sides of her own neck. "I know this is a lot. I-"

"-I don't," Adora stammered before groaning. "I just don't -" Catra could see tears pricking at the edges of Adora's eyes before she turned away.

"Adora, you're safe here. You're not there anymore," Catra said. In an instant, the air in the room shifted and all the tension contained in Adora's muscles snapped to the surface.

Adora fractured into anger. "I'm fine! Okay, Catra?" she yelled. Her voice reverberated in the room, making the quiet that followed deafening. "I told you," she ground her teeth together, "I just need to sleep."

Catra was taken aback. The hand she had been reaching out with turned to shield her face instead.

When Adora saw Catra jump back in defense, her features softened. She let go of the fists she'd made and gestured with open palms instead, trying to convey that she would not hurt Catra. "I-I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. I'm not . . . ."

Eying Adora, Catra used both hands to pop off her mask and set it down on the desk calmly with a clack. Brushing her hair aside, she tried to think of how to be patient, but lost the battle. Her words came harsh and loud, "Adora, you are not fine. And no one expects you to be. Can you just cut the bullshit for once?"

This time, Adora flinched back. She held her eyes open stubbornly, but some of the tears gathered at the edges started to fall. She cleared her throat and cast her eyes to the floor.

Catra's eyes stung at Adora's reaction. She swallowed hard. "Well, if you're not going to say it, I will." She growled. "I'm not fine. I thought I was going to lose you. I was more scared today than I've ever been in my life. Okay?" Her own angered burst when she jibed, "What do you think about that?"

Adora's world narrowed on Catra and she turned her head.

Losing her edge, Catra said with a sigh, "This whole thing is my fault. Adora, I never wanted," Catra's face contorted as she fought to speak. "I'm sorry. You can be mad at me. You can ask me to leave. I will." She sniffled. "I owe that to you, at least."

"Leave?" Adora said, straining. Her hand grasped at her shirt, pulling it away from her heart, which felt too restricted to work properly. Catra caught the panic as Adora's words dropped into hurried breaths. "Please," Adora begged.

Without hesitation, Catra ran to her, holding Adora together in her arms. "I'm not going anywhere unless you ask me to. I just meant -" Catra tried to smooth Adora's hair off her tear-stained face, "I'm right here."

"You really thought-" Adora huffed, "-after all this? You think I want you the leave?"

Catra rubbed Adora's back. "You weren't really giving me a lot of reason to feel otherwise."

Adora shook. "It's like you came back from the dead," Adora stammered into her chest. "When I saw you, I thought I had died too. I thought that was the only way I'd ever see you again." Adora fought for breath and Catra's heart missed two beats.

"Don't say that." Catra shook her head. The image of Adora's face as Catra had been dragged away from her all those days ago

surfaced. Her pulse quickened. What would have happened to Adora if the rescue had failed? What if Catra had seen Adora die in front of her eyes? A strike of pain hit her gut. What else had Shadow Weaver done?

Adora came closer and brought her hand to Catra's face, wiping away the tears as they fell. "It's true. I'm not as strong as everyone thinks I am."

"No," Catra said, placing one hand on top of Adora's. With the other, she moved to cup Adora's face. "You're much stronger."

Tears dripped off Adora's chin. She shut her eyes. Her molars ground together in the back of her mouth as she fought to push her bubbling emotions down. "If I was stronger, this would have never happened. She would have never hurt you."

Catra's blood ran thick. "She can't hurt either of us now. She's gone, Adora. We made sure she was gone."

Adora wanted to believe Catra, but she didn't. Focusing on the warmth of Catra's hands and face, she tried to forget Shadow Weaver's icy touch. Every time someone had reached out to her, she felt Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver was on her skin, in the air she breathed. And her venomous words pulsed with every heartbeat.

Stepping forward, Adora wrapped her arms around Catra in another tenuous hug. "I'm sorry," she said "for everything."

Tears flowed freely down Catra's face now, mixing so much with Adora's it was hard to tell where they came from. All the tears she held back over the day, all the fear she had about losing Adora, it was all coming up. "Me too," she choked out. There were a million things Catra wanted to say. She wanted to tell Adora to stop apologizing to her. To say that she wanted to take all the bad things back she'd done and said. That she would do her best to make it up to her. That Adora was right and Catra was wrong. But,

none of it came out amidst the sobs that tore out her throat instead.

As Catra broke down, Adora sharpened. It was a welcome distraction to her own pain. Her own tears still fell, but not at the rate that Catra's were coming out now. Feeling Catra's weakening limbs, Adora led them to the floor, folding her legs beneath her. Catra only moved closer, burying her head under Adora's chin and clenching her fingers in Adora's shirt. Adora pushed her cheek down on the crown of Catra's head, holding her tightly by the shoulders.

"I've got you," Adora whispered. Catra cried harder.

After a minute, Catra stifled her sobs. Adora should not have to comfort her, not when this whole thing had been Catra's fault. Controlling her breathing, she said, "We should get some sleep."

"Yeah," Adora let Catra go, "I guess we should."

Standing, Catra walked away and rubbed the back of her head. "You can, um, shower first."

Still on the floor, Adora nodded. "Yeah, okay."

Catra stood in the middle of the room, unsure what to do. "Hey," she said. "We can talk more later, okay? I," she inhaled quickly, "I have a lot I want to tell you."

Adora nodded. "Okay." She turned to the bathroom and turned the doorknob. Before entering, she looked back at Catra. "And Catra?"

The ears on Catra's head stood at attention. "Yeah?"

"I'm glad you're here." Adora stared back at Catra for a long moment before entering the bathroom and closing the door behind her. This time when Catra's heart rate increased, it was for a different reason.

Adora leaned up against the door between her and Catra. Finally alone, Adora couldn't stand the thoughts that hit her next. She slid to the floor, unable to stay on her feet any longer. Her hands were trembling and she knew everyone else could see it. It didn't make any sense. She was back home. It was in the safest place she'd ever been, but she still was as if she was chained to the wall in the Black Garnet chamber.

The room didn't feel familiar anymore. On the ground, Adora shook her hands and shucked off her shirt. Wadding it up, she threw it hard into the opposite corner. Shirtless, she laid back against the door, hoping the coolness would calm her. Instead, it prickled at her skin, at all the places Shadow Weaver had visited until Adora was back on her feet, backing away.

She grabbed the sink and splashed water into her face. This was Bright Moon, not the Fright Zone. Shadow Weaver was on Beast Island by now. Catra was okay and, even better, she was staying here. In Adora's room. She-ra was back. Adora turned the facet until even colder water spilled from it. The feel of it made goosebumps pop up along her neck.

After a minute, she turned the water off, gripping the sides of the sink tightly with both hands and breathing hard. It would be okay. She was just tired and shook up. A shower would be good. Her bra came off with her boots. Reaching down, Adora undid her belt and let it drop to the floor with her trousers. Water from her neck slid in small droplets down her back, making her shiver.

Then, she looked in the mirror. She hadn't seen herself in a long time and what she saw sent her straight into shock. Pale. Gaunt. Weak. Pressing her fingers into her skin, she traced marks and bruises along the way. With each tap of her fingers, her mind flashed back to hands that left burning trails. The flashes were slow at first but then faster and faster until she could feel her heart beating in her ears and her vision grayed.

Stumbling, she turned on the shower and crawled into the bathtub, haphazardly pulling the curtain across the tub's edge.

The water sprayed over her and she did not register the temperature. It could have been scalding her or freezing, but all she could think about were hands on her skin that she did not invite. Beneath the hiss of the showerhead, she heard a voice.

"You can try, but I'll never really go away."

Adora gasped, water sliding into her throat, choking her like an invisible hand wrapping around her throat. She could feel as all of the air in her lungs turned into fire. The fire in her lungs moved to her heart until she thought it would explode. The water kept beating down on her like a million stabbing knives, but all she could think about was Shadow Weaver coming back for her again.

She had been so stupid. Beast Island wouldn't hold her. Shadow Weaver was too strong. She would be back. And what would happen next time? She'd kill Catra in front of Adora. She'd kill everyone. Adora should have killed Shadow Weaver when she had the chance. Instead, she'd risked everyone's safety. They would pay for it, she was sure.

When Shadow Weaver came back, what would she do to Adora? It was hard to imagine anything worse than had already happened, but Adora found the means to. She had barely tolerated a few months; how would she survive years? Shadow Weaver had held her before, it wouldn't be hard to again. Maybe She-ra was strong enough, but Adora wasn't She-ra. Adora was just this. A shaking, skinny body in the bathtub who couldn't cast out a single demon.

A light rap came at the door, send Adora scrambling backwards, though she had nowhere to go. "Adora? Are you okay?" Catra's voice came muffled through the door and the sound of water. "It's been a while."

Adora swallowed thickly, unable to process. "I'm fine," she called out, voice breaking and too quiet to be heard over the water.

The door handle twisted and Catra poked an ear through. "Adora?"

This time, Adora couldn't respond. She didn't even have enough air to breath.

"I'm coming in," Catra said. She made her way in swiftly, making sure to keep her eyes on the floor. She listened and could hear Adora's gasps and choking from beyond the curtain.

"No," Adora rasped. She raked her nails across her chest, clawing at her lungs as if she could force air inside through her skin. Her anxiety grew until she was unable to say anything else.

"Adora?" Catra asked. No response. "Adora, just listen to me, okay? I'm not going to do anything without your permission. I'm standing right by the door. I won't move unless you tell me it's okay. And I'll leave if you want, just stick your hand out of the shower or something to let me know."

Trying to ground herself, Adora wrung her hands together, but the sensation wasn't there. They didn't feel like her hands anymore. All she knew was she was drowning and that Shadow Weaver would come back for her and take the little of her that she had left.

"This is going to be over soon. You're in Bright Moon. All of your friends are safe. You're safe. I-I'm safe." Catra's own heart was pounding at her ribcage. Her ears flickered, trying to hear whatever she could to monitor Adora's status. Catra thought back to her own panic attacks and how Scorpia had helped her through her last one. Scorpia was good at that stuff. Catra took a deep breath. She could ask for advice tomorrow, but she was going to have to wing it today.

"I'll be right here," she offered. "I'm not going anywhere." She clenched her jaw, fighting the urge to reach out. "Adora, just keep breathing. If you can, turn that water off. If not, we can wait."

The water stayed on and Catra's nerves doubled down.

“Inhale, Adora. I didn’t think I’d ever get used to Bright Moon,” Catra said conversationally. “Exhale. But it’s only been three days and I think the food has me convinced. Inhale again.” Catra searched for anything to talk about. “Except, the other day, whatever day it was. Exhale,” Catra pushed air out of her own lungs before taking another inhale, “Glimmer tried to get me to eat this nasty dessert stuff she said you like. It was kind of jiggly and orange.”

The water shut off. Adora’s panting continued, but Catra could hear her fight for a rhythm. “It’s -” Adora inhaled, “not gross.”

“I don’t know, Bow agreed with me. Said only you and Glimmer think it’s any good at all,” Catra said, wrapping her tail around her own shin for comfort, trying not to feel too relieved in case Adora’s panic continued.

“You just,” Adora huffed, “you just don’t have g-good taste.”

Catra laughed in earnest. “Says the person who doesn’t even chew their food when they eat.”

“At least I,” Adora leaned her head back, poking it out behind the curtain, “don’t eat all the food off your plate before even touching mine.”

“In my defense, it always looked better further away,” Catra smiled, fangs glinting by the half-shrouded light through the blinds. “Horde food has that effect.”

Adora shook her head and sighed, letting her arm rest outside the bathtub. Water streamed off her, pooling on the floor, but the tile felt good against her skin. “I didn’t,” she frowned, “exactly take a shower.”

“No shit,” Catra grabbed a clean towel from a pile, “but, it’s good enough for now. I think you used up half of Bright Moon’s water anyway.”

“Don’t be dramatic,” Adora snorted. “They’re literally in a valley surrounded by water. I think they can cope.”

“Well, if you’re all finished, I’d like to use some of that amazing Bright Moon water and get some of this grime off me. Think you can part with your favorite lounge spot?” Catra let some of her tension go. This was not the night - or day - she’d imagined, but Adora was almost breathing normally now.

“I guess so,” Adora said. She took a deep breath and rose to her feet. With a pull, she moved the curtain aside and stuck her head out fully. “Are you going to stand there or are you going to hand me a towel?”

Catra’s ears flattened to her scalp as a different heat creeped up her neck. Her claws extended on their own, sinking into the fluffy cotton of the towel she held. Cautiously, she approached the shower, “Here,” Catra said, shoving the towel into Adora’s hand while pointedly looking away. “I’ll be out there waiting so hurry up.”

Catra was out the door before Adora could say another word. Adora let the air out of her lungs, glad they were finally functioning again. She was going to have to get over this and fast. Using the towel, she rubbed the water off her skin, trying to take with it some of the feelings left with her from the Fright Zone.

She dried off and wrapped the towel around herself, not wanting to redress in her rotting clothing. She looked at herself in the mirror again, hair still dripping and shook her head. After a few attempts, she combed some of the knots out of her hair with her fingers and exited the bathroom.

Catra sat on the window sill, staring off in the distance. Her tail swished and ears perked when Adora came out.

“It’s all yours,” Adora coughed. Shyly, she glanced away, “Thanks, for, you know. I guess I’m not over it yet.”

“Adora,” Catra said, hopping off the ledge and striding up to her, “you got back like ten minutes ago. Quit being so hard on yourself.”

“But,” Adora said, eyebrow furrowing again. “I-”

“Stop,” Catra said. “Whatever you were going to say, I don’t want to hear it. You deserve rest. If you don’t lie down soon, I’m going to start telling you all about Kyle’s new hobbies.”

Adora conceded, “Okay.”

“I’m,” Catra bit her tongue, “I’m going to go take that shower now. Don’t wait up for me. I’m not leaving though, okay? I’ll just be on the other side of the door and then I’m coming right back here.”

Adora nodded, unmoving until Catra entered the bathroom. She slid her fingers underneath the tucked towel and pulled at it. When it came undone, she stared down at her body again. Grimacing in distaste, she wrapped herself back up before walking to her dresser. Never in her life had she had such a strong disconnect with her body.

As quickly as she could, without having to see parts of herself she would rather not, Adora pulled on a pair of shorts and a tank. Only then, did she pull off the towel and fold it over the back of her chair. The fatigue she had learned as her new normal tugged at her, but instead of closing her eyes and praying for sleep on a cold, dungeon floor, she crawled into her bed.

It was so much more welcoming than she ever remembered it. It was both an uncomfortable amount of space and a warm reminder that she no longer had to share space with someone who she did not want. She let her eyes shut and waited for sleep.

Catra finished a quick shower, redressed in some of Adora’s old clothes, and came back into the main room. When she spotted Adora in bed, her heart longed to be there with her. Adora’s breathing was coming steady, close to sleep. Catra looked away.

Things were not what they used to be. She couldn’t just crawl into Adora’s bed anymore. It had been too long and, with all that happened, Catra wasn’t sure Adora would want anyone in her bed again.

Catra made her to the long bench beneath the window. She rearranged the pillows there until she could curl up comfortably. The blinds were all shut, but the bright light of a clear day still filtered through making everything hazy. Her eyelids were heavy and she let them fall.

Sometime later, Adora stirred. Tossing a few times without finding sleep, she sighed and stood up. Her eyes scanned the room until she found Catra on the other side. She dragged the comforter off the mattress and pulled it along with her to the floor below Catra’s perch. Staring for a moment, Adora laid down, bunching her blanket around her as quietly as she could. Just before shutting her eyes, a hand extended downwards towards her. Adora looked up. One of Catra’s eyes opened, but it quickly shut again. Adora reached for Catra’s hand and held it against her chest. Together, they wafted off to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> I know this is the longest I've gone without an update, but we got here finally. I mentioned on my tumblr, but I've had a pretty stressful few weeks and haven't been able to write as much as usual. No one bugged me about updates, which I appreciate, but I know it's hard to wait sometimes, especially when we're right at the end of the story. Thanks for staying with me and I really hope you enjoy this update. Thanks in advance for the comments. Even if I don't respond, I read every single one. I picked up a few new readers in the last week who left comments on the last chapter and wanna shout them out for giving me the final push to motivate me past all my anxiety blocks to get this chapter done!

My tumblr

Scar Tissue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Get up,” Adora commanded. She shoved her hands into the grass, down past its roots, and into the soil. Dirt smeared her fingertips and wedged under her nails as she pushed against it. “Get. Up,” she grunted again. Sweat pooled around her temples then ran down her chin until it dropped off her shaking jaw. Her mouth was open, devouring any oxygen her lungs could source. Every muscle quivered, but Adora wasn’t sure which one failed her first, as she collapsed.

Face down in the lawn, she groaned. After extricating her arms, she turned over and threw them out wide. She blew out a gust of air before her breathing went ragged again. The sky above her was already darkening. The night moons were rising and starting to cast a gentle shadow as the day moons slipped away. Adora fisted her hand and pounded it into the ground. The ground gave, letting her sink in.

A breeze passed and she closed her eyes, letting it bring her body temperature down. When she did finally sit up, dusk had passed nearly into night. Her shirt was dirty and soaked through with sweat.

Above her was the room she left behind almost an hour ago now. If she craned her neck, she could see the balcony that attached to it. She pressed into her eyes with the palms of her hands. She needed to go back upstairs. The wind blew again. This time, she shivered.

In the moments before dozing off, Adora was warm and happy. She thought she would sleep an easy, dreamless sleep. It was comfortable, inviting, and Catra was there beside her. Then, as if only a second had passed, Adora woke in a frenzy. The comforter

she'd taken to the floor with her twisted up, restraining her legs. She kicked at it, screaming, until Catra's hands found her shoulders. It had taken a full minute before Adora could even hear Catra speaking over the adrenaline screeching through her veins. When she did, her fear started to subside. Adora clung to Catra, until her heartbeat turned from a torrent into a trickle.

Catra talked to Adora through it. In between pants, Adora caught snippets of it. "You're safe." And, "Just breathe." There had been softer phrases in between too. "I got you." And, "I'm here."

When she could finally speak, all Adora had responded to Catra with had been, "I need air." The words had been jumbled and desperate, coming out of her all at once.

Before Adora could see the disappointment she was sure was appearing on Catra's face, she scrambled out of their embrace like an animal let out of a cage, got to her feet, and exited. Outside the door, Glimmer was standing, face full of concern. Adora brushed past her with her head down. Glimmer called after her, but Adora only ran faster. Before she'd left the main hall, she heard Catra's voice again, sad this time, saying, "Let her go."

So, Adora ended up here, out under the sky. When the crisp air hit her skin, a massive weight lifted off her chest, letting her lungs expand and contract unfettered. Blind terror turned into burning anger when she could start to see clearly again. Everyone was already worried about her and, now, she was waking them up for no reason.

It started with a few quick exercises. Just burning off nerves, Adora told herself. It ended in a rigorous workout that left Adora lying motionless on the ground. She'd pushed so hard her muscles had stopped responding on numerous occasions, but the frustration made her push harder. If she failed, she would do it again. And again. Her limits came earlier than expected and they came often. By the end of it, Adora was yelling at herself. She just needed to try harder.

Now, past physical exhaustion, her mind still raced. Sitting up, she let her arms rest on her knees while she looked down at her skin. Her clothes were big, even for sleep clothing. The room between her skin and the cloth used to be full of muscle. Now, it was empty space. She lifted her shirt and scowled. She let it fall again, feeling her muscles shudder. Even before, Adora had felt weak. Now that she was reduced to this, she was frail. That would do no good for her friends or the Rebellion.

Adora took a deep breath and swallowed. She needed to get a handle on her body. Once she did that, she could figure the rest of this out. The panic and the nightmares and the flashbacks. All of that didn't matter. Winning this war, being a good She-ra, protecting her friends, that's what she needed to focus on. There was a job to do.

Adora stood. Deep lines appeared on her forehead as her knees started to buckle. She reached out toward the castle wall for support. Pretending her feet were lighter than they were, Adora dragged herself up the stairs back to her room. Sweaty palms grabbed the railing when she stumbled, but, soon, she'd reached the top. Her feet tapped the ground gently, trying to make sure not to disturb anyone else as they rested. She passed Mermista's usual room, Perfuma's usual room, where she heard some muffled whispering, and finally, Glimmer's room. That left her facing her own door again. She held her breath as she creaked the door open as quietly as she could.

Catra stood in the middle of the room. Dark circles were under her eyes and her skin sheened with nervous sweat. When Adora entered, she crossed her arms. Catra had a full scowl on her face when she asked, "You done?"

"Sorry for waking you up," Adora mumbled, brushing dirt off her hands. Instead of approaching Catra, Adora moved over to her bedside table where She-ra's blade rested.

Catra waved her hand dismissively, watching Adora intently. "Yeah, sure." After examining Adora's red face she said, "What

were you doing anyway?”

Adora kneaded the back of her neck with nervous fingers. “Just couldn’t sleep.”

“Mhmm,” Catra said, walking up to her. “And decided to, what,” Catra scrunched her nose at the sky and sniffed, “take the world's sweatiest nighttime stroll?”

Adora shifted uncomfortably from foot to foot. “Something like that,” she said.

“Adora,” Catra reached for Adora’s hand, pulling it away from the sword. Adora’s eyes stayed fixed on it, as if in a daze. With a sigh, Adora folded Catra’s hand into her own and tore her eyes away. With a dry mouth, Catra continued, “You just got back. I know you suck at it, but you need to rest. You’ll get your strength back. There’s plenty of time for that.”

Adora scowled and ushered at She-ra’s blade. “There’s no time. The Horde is still out there. Hordak isn’t just going to let up because I’m tired. We need to - I need to be ready.”

“You aren’t doing this on your own,” Catra glowered at her, but squeezed her hand in reassurance. “I know you think you have to, but you don’t.”

When Adora averted her eyes, Catra touched her face. For a second, Adora tensed, still looking down at the sword. But eventually, she loosened and brought her eyes up to meet Catra’s. Catra swept Adora’s hair away, sliding her hand away after affectionately tugging Adora’s earlobe between her fingers. “You aren’t alone,” Catra whispered.

Adora leaned forward and, this time, Catra was the one to tense. With closed eyes, Adora raised her hands to take Catra’s face and rest their foreheads together. “I know.” Adora sighed.

“But?” Catra asked, voice cracking.

Adora fell away. Even as they still touched, Catra's face screwed up against Adora's still one. Adora's hands started to slip from Catra's face, so Catra leaned into it, trying desperately to remind Adora that she was here. That she would be here no matter what. It didn't work. Adora let her hands drop until they drooped at her sides, forgotten. Adora gazed out the window at something far off that Catra couldn't see.

Catra wanted to hug her again, but she didn't. All she could do was watch Adora's eyes darted back and forth, searching for something she couldn't find.

On her next inhale, Adora came back, catching Catra's concerned look. Adora forced a smile, trying to be reassuring, but Catra scowled at her. Shocked, Adora's smile dropped off her face. "You should try and get some sleep."

Catra's ears flickered. "Adora?"

Adora smiled sadly. "I'm okay." Her eyes went back to the sword. Catra stiffened as Adora stepped back from her and took the blade in her hand.

"Adora? What are you doing?" Catra asked, concern threaded through each word.

"I'll be back soon." Strapping the sword to her back, Adora made for the door. She leaned her forehead on it before turning the doorknob. As she started to step through, Catra snagged her hand. They stood, a doorway apart.

"Please, Catra," Adora said without turning around.

Every instinct told Catra to hold on, to tell Adora ever reason why she should stay. Instead, she felt every nerve on her fingertips as Adora slid away from her.

Adora paused briefly and then took her next step. Catra watched as she moved down the hallway. Before disappearing completely, Adora was shrouded in a bright light, burning the back of Catra's

skull. Catra stared at the space in front of her until even the afterimage of She-ra was gone.

A pod crashed on the beach. On contact, the door hissed open with a hydraulic whir, releasing steam as it did. After tossing her hair behind her, Shadow Weaver stepped out and on to the beach. Around her, other pods lined the sandy coast like forgotten gravestones. Some had turned green from algae, some were dented and chipped, and yet some still held their shine beneath their salt-caked hulls. The water lapped at them, weathering, until they all met the same fate. Shadow Weaver scanned the beach and then turned toward the island's center. There were no signs of human life. Like others before her, she would have to venture into the island's depths if she was to survive.

With the connection to the Black Garnet severed, Shadow Weaver could no longer skim above the surface. Instead, each shoe dropped against the ground, slapping and sucking as water filled her footprints, erasing her away. Water ran into her shoes along with fine grit sand. Once out of the shallows, she sat on the beach and removed her shoes, rinsing them out as well as she could before sliding them back on to her feet dripping. Standing up again, she brushed loose sand off her robes and scanned the horizon.

She stared up at the hot sky and out over the ocean. Both went on forever. She narrowed her eyes and turned away from the shore. Before her, Beast Island glowed with a dark, artificial light. She had ordered plenty of less competent cadets and other war criminals here, but Shadow Weaver had never set foot on Beast Island herself. From her time at Mystacor, she had heard stories. She'd even retold the same stories to her wards. They might have feared Beast Island, but Shadow Weaver did not.

Most of those sent here wouldn't last a day on their own anywhere, not to mention a place like this. But Shadow Weaver had survived before and she would do it again. Stepping forward, she pushed through the craggy brush and into the woods. Before her stretched dark trees twisted with light up their trunks, the blue and red light refracting to make the shadows swirl darker around her. The wind whistled behind her, but once she stepped through, the island turned silent.

As she walked, she thought about what it was she was looking for. A way out? And where would she go? Shadow Weaver pushed a vine aside, causing a group of centipede-like bugs to scuttle away into the darkness. Lifting her hand, she drew a rune to light her crooked path. It didn't matter where she would go next, she would find a way. Etheria had many secrets. All she needed was one. There were things she'd learned at Mystacor, the Fright Zone, and even her childhood she could turn to. And now, after being connected to the Black Garnet for so long, Etheria was connected to her too. There was more here than anyone knew, she simply needed to find it and bend it to her will.

And then there was Adora. Shadow Weaver shook her head. The girl had been foolish, led astray by those silly princesses and a dream beyond her capabilities. They had no idea what Adora would be put through. Only Shadow Weaver could help her. Shadow Weaver would find her way back and make things right, her and Adora, without the crutch of the Horde or Mystacor or the Rebellion. Just the two of them, the way it should have always been.

And Catra. Shadow Weaver tightened her fist. Catra would always get in the way. Shadow Weaver had been foolish too, if only for ignoring instinct and letting Catra live from their first meeting so long ago. Not for the first time, Shadow Weaver cursed herself for being soft for Adora's sake. Shadow Weaver would not fail like that again. She must trust her instincts. She knew what was best for Adora in the end.

She stopped at a narrow clearing. Above her were fallen sticks, stuck in the low branches of a gnarled tree like impaled limbs. They crisscrossed, almost creating a roof. Shadow Weaver sighed. Impatience pounded on her skull, but that was a weak impulse and a sure way to wind up dead. She was tired and needed to rest. With unshaking hands, she gathered fallen wood, stacking them in a pile before settling down to the ground. With her back to the knotted trunk, she drew a rune in the ground and a small fire took. The wood crackled and popped, exploding small sparks into the air, illuminating her face in red.

Resting her head backwards, she thought. All her life, people had been holding her back. Not first, but most recently had been Hordak. Without her, he would fall. She did not care. Others had come before him. Nations rose and fell and so would the Horde. Perhaps her leaving had not been so untimely after all. Not with the new strength of the Princess Alliance and She-ra.

A rustle in the bushes startled her. Without thought, Shadow Weaver went on the offensive and sent a beam of magic in the direction of the disturbance. There was a choked cry and then a lasting sizzle. With a calm confidence she inspected the area. Lying dead was a creature she had never seen before. With a prod, she examined it. The shell popped off. She smelled it before picking it up and moving back towards her barren campsite. Raising an eyebrow, she peeled it open, cleaning as best she could before eating its tender flesh. She tasted nothing when she swallowed.

With an apathetic flick of her wrist, she discarded the remains, tossing it towards the bush. The world never would understand her, but she was stronger than it was. If she had to eat bugs and survive an island that no one else had returned from, then so be it. It was not the worst situation she'd ever seen, she thought, as she prodded the fire with a stick, blackening the tip.

Shadow Weaver drew idly into the ground, smearing ashes and dirt together. When she connected the lines, it glowed faintly before Etheria absorbed it. Clenching her fist, she let the fire burn

out too. The cold wicked at her hands and feet, so she tucked them tighter. Without the light, the darkness fell heavy. It was tangible, like a deep snow coating the ground, hiding good and evil alike. The darkness of Beast Island was permanent, but Shadow Weaver had always thrived in darkness.

Catra stood in front of Glimmer's door, ears flat against her scalp. When she left her and Adora's room, she had been resolute. She'd come here to ask Glimmer and Bow for advice. Somehow, in the short seconds it had taken her to walk over, she grew skeptical. Glimmer and Bow were in there, she could hear them chatting. That wasn't the problem. The problem was this was stupid.

She pulled her hair and growled at herself. The muted sound of Bow’s voice stopped on the other side. "Shit," she said as she started to back up and away.

Before she could get far, the door cracked open and Glimmer eyed her up and down. With a hushed voice and demeanor far cooler than Glimmer’s normal conduct she said, "We've been expecting you."

Catra threw her hands out wide. "What do you mean expecting me? I was just walking by."

Bow peeked out behind Glimmer and waved. "Hi Catra! I got some of those snacks you like." He shook a box, letting the candies inside knock against the container. Catra’s tail lashed out behind her. They’d known each other for three days and they were acting like they were friends. Her nose twitched. They were not her friends.

Glimmer stretched her arms above her head, as if trying to wake herself up for this conversation. She was still in what Catra prayed were pajamas. Pale, purple, and loose fitting. Nothing in the color

or shape Catra would ever wear. Bow was sporting similarly relaxed clothes, but, thankfully, his neutral colors helped mute Glimmer's loud ones.

Glimmer widened the crack in the door and smirked at Catra’s obvious discomfort. "You wanna come in or are you too busy growling at the wall?"

Catra didn't move. Glimmer let out an exasperated noise and grumbled something about Catra “being no fun” before pulling her inside by her elbow. Bow closed the door with a soft click behind them. That was the last straw before Catra’s tail puffed up.

Before she could smooth the fur down, Bow let out a gasp. “Are you serious?” To ensure he would not get any closer, Catra wound her tail loosely around the back of her calf and snarled. The warning did nothing to hinder Bow, whose eyes only filled with more hearts.

“Why are you all so weird?” Catra asked, letting her hands form fists. Bow and Glimmer looked at each other, shrugged, and offered her the snacks they had promised. She glanced sideways at Bow’s extended hand before snatching the box away from him and tossing a handful of its contents into her mouth. She chewed loudly, waiting for someone else to broach the subject.

“So . . .” Bow started. Of course he did. Catra was being too stubborn and Glimmer was, somehow, being even more stubborn. When Catra turned red, Glimmer let out a relaxed sigh and smile. Bow shook his head at both of them before finishing his question. "How's Adora doing?" He lifted one of his eyebrows. "Actually, where is she?"

Catra crossed her arms and hugged herself. She tossed back a few more sweets and swallowed without chewing. “I don't know. She left last night. I haven’t seen her since.”

Bow and Glimmer did that thing again where they communicated without saying anything. To Catra’s relief, Glimmer’s arrogant

mood dropped, replaced with concern. Bow shook his head.

“Sit,” Glimmer said, motioning to the bench on the window sill. When Catra didn’t move, Glimmer made the gesture more prominently. “I insist.”

With her shoulders hiked up to her ears, Catra sat down, continuing to eat with her eyes fixed across the room. Bow plopped down next to her. “You want to talk about it?” he asked.

Catra’s jaw made a cracking noise as she chewed. “Talk about what?”

Glimmer rubbed the bridge of her nose. “This doesn’t have to be so hard, you know. We want the same thing you do.”

“And what do you think that is?” Catra growled.

Bow smiled before putting his hand on Catra’s shoulder. Catra flinched, running her eyes from his hand, up his arm, and settling on his face. When he caught her eye, his smile broadened. She huffed and turned away again.

“Look, we heard what happened last night,” Bow said. “Adora says the walls aren’t as thin here as they are in the Fright Zone, but she’s never provided proof.”

Catra started to stand. “Well, if you already know, then you don’t need me here.”

“I don’t want to talk about this either,” Glimmer scolded. “What happened to her. What happened to you.” Glimmer hesitated when Catra hissed in her direction. “It was all terrible. And no one deserves it.”

“That includes you, Catra,” Bow said with sincerity. “And, even if there’s things you don’t forgive yourself for, we forgive you.” Glimmer gave an enthusiastic nod. “And Adora forgives you too.”

"Why would you do that? That's stupid." Catra's claws came out as she sank back down, this time digging her fingers into the edge of the bench, down to the wood. "And, you're wrong, she doesn't forgive me. Last night she ran away from me and I haven't seen her this morning. I don't think she wants to talk to me."

Bow and Glimmer's eyes connected. "You know you're the only person she's talked to, really, since she got back, right?" Glimmer asked.

Letting his wrists rest on his knees, Bow exhaled. "Adora is one of my best friends and one of the strongest people I know. But she's hurting right now. I would take it all away if I could, but I can't."

Glimmer placed her hand on top of Bow's. "Me too."

Catra's eyebrows knit together. "Me too," she whispered. Tears sprouted from her eyes and she pressed her palm to her forehead as if to press them back in. "But I don't know how. How can I when I'm the one who did this?"

"We all feel like we failed her," Glimmer said. Catra stared at her puzzled. With a frustrated moan, Glimmer continued, "I can literally teleport." She accentuated this point by popping across the room and back, making Catra jump. "And I couldn't even get close enough to grab her. I tried so many times and failed. Not to mention it was my fault she got captured in the first place."

"And I feel guilty too," Bow said. He held his arm out in front of him. "Infected She-ra hurt me because I wasn't fast enough. Every time Adora sees me, she stares at the scars. I can see the pain and conflict there. I want her not to worry, but she does." He lowered his arm, touching the flesh below. "I spent so much time trying to help, but it wasn't enough. I made a disrupter that didn't work. I couldn't even fight. I had one job during the rescue mission and it almost," he looked at Glimmer, "went very badly."

Catra's looked at them puzzled. "Not trying to be argumentative at your benefit, but that's all pretty small stuff compared to *being*

the captor.”

“I’m not trying to be harsh about this,” Glimmer said, standing straighter, “but your reasons for feeling guilty sound stupid to us too.”

“What do you know?” Catra stood again, teeth bared at Glimmer, who put her hands up in surrender.

“Look, everyone messes up and I’m not going to say you didn’t mess up really bad,” Glimmer gestured at Catra. “But you did the right thing in the end. You’re the reason Adora is safe.”

“I was the reason she wasn’t safe in the first place,” Catra barked. “And I couldn’t have done this on my own,” she mumbled as an afterthought.

“Do you really think Shadow Weaver would have ever stopped trying to get to Adora?” Bow asked. The question took Catra by surprise. “You didn’t know and when you found out, you risked everything to change it. It means everything to us. And it means everything to Adora. You two are best friends. That doesn’t just go away.”

“Can vouch,” Glimmer added. “I told you, she’s been waiting for you. You don’t know how conflicted she felt fighting you all those times.” Glimmer pointed to herself and to Bow. “We do.”

Catra curled her knees up to her chest and wrapped her arms and tail around them. She rested her chin on top and looked between both of them, searching for authenticity.

“Adora trusts you,” Bow said as Glimmer sat on the other side of Catra. “I know she ran away last night, but what happened before that? What happened when you got back? She felt okay enough to try and sleep. She felt okay enough to have you in her room with her. Think about all those times you were back in the Fright Zone with her when you were trying to help her escape. She trusts you.”

“So what? She still ran away.” Catra said, shooting Glimmer a mean look.

Bow stood and put one hand on each of their shoulders. “Adora feels really vulnerable right now. She isn’t used to being the one people are worried about. She isn’t used to having to ask for help."

"She’s not very good at it,” Glimmer replied.

“Damn right she’s not good at it,” Catra grumbled.

“Catra,” Bow and waited until Catra looked up at her to speak again. “I know you care about her and I know she cares about you. And we want to help, if you’re okay with that.”

“I’m not saying I want your advice,” Catra pushed her fingertips into her forehead, “especially not yours,” she pointed at Glimmer who pouted, “but if you were going to give me some anyway, what would you say?”

Bow practically split the room in two with his smile. “Try opening up to her,” he said. “Tell her something she might not know. Talk to her about something you’re worried about. Anything. It’ll make her feel safer. She might not open up right away, but it’ll be a good start.”

“Me?” Catra scoffed. “She already knows everything about me. All the worst things I’ve ever done she’s seen. She’s been on the receiving end! How is that going to help?”

Glimmer lifted an eyebrow and looked into Catra’s soul. “I think you’ll think of something. We see the way you look at her, you know. It’s the same way she looks at you.”

Bow scolded Glimmer, who shrugged with a look that said, “someone needed to say it.”

Catra blushed and clenched her teeth. With extended claws, she pried off Bow’s fingers. Glimmer smiled warmly and Catra’s blood

burned. “This has not been as helpful as advertised.”

“You’re the one who came knocking at our door,” Glimmer said, putting her hands on her hips and smiling with satisfaction.

“I was just walking by minding my own business!” Catra growled, clenching her fists again. “Get over yourself.”

“Never!” Glimmer cried, laughing.

Bow joined in the laughter and Catra even smiled, a little bit, letting her ears perk up. Of course, Adora had gone off and found the stupidest friends in the world. They were so annoying, but, maybe, someday they’d grow on her. Glimmer looked at her again with that cocky confidence. Today was definitely not that day.

“Seriously, though,” Bow said, putting on his most genuine front, “we’re here for Adora and we’re here for you. Anything, and I mean it, anything you need, we’re here. This is going to be a long journey, but we’re family, you know?”

Catra’s expression went blank. She blinked and felt the heat in her face return. Before Glimmer could point it out, she turned around. “Whatever,” she said, walking out and slamming the door behind her. With their eyes finally off her, she let out a sigh of relief. It had been annoying, but maybe they didn’t have the world's worst idea.

She looked down the hall, poking her head into Adora’s room. Still empty. She was going to have to find Adora first.

Shadow Weaver walked and walked. Her robes caught on bramble and broken tech, but she pushed through until it tore the fabric apart. Distantly, a dull, droning noise started to knock at the edges of her mind. Shadow Weaver refused to answer the call. So

far, all she'd come in contact with was degraded tech and odd creatures who had adapted to the environment by evolving to have large eyes or no eyes at all. The last wreckage she'd inspected had taken hours and all she had to show for it was a long scratch down her arm. It wasn't from an ambush, but her own mistake in handling a thin piece of sheet metal. That mistake wouldn't happen again.

Inside her pocket, Shadow Weaver's hand curled around a single vial. It was her most precious possession. Within it, a fine blue powder jostled in sync with her steps. It glowed and pulsed with Etheria's respirations. So many times, she had been pressured to use it. All of those times, she had chosen to endure instead. There had been pain. There had been long stretches of time where she didn't know how she would live, but she had. All of that had been worthwhile to have it now.

It was a fallback, a safety. But it was her last one. She could use it now, she thought, but she wanted some insurance that it would be enough to get her off the island. She had never transported so far before and was concerned she'd end up in the ocean without any of Etheria's own magic to bolster her.

So, she marched on. The wide path became crowded with vines and sticky leaves. If she could find some remnant of usable tech or anything she could control, like the Black Garnet, she would be able to get off this island. She would be able to rise from the ashes once again. Until she was sure of success, she would endure more.

She passed corpses, both partially and fully degraded, bones half buried. There were beasts and there were Etherians too, all caught up in some sort of web that had ensnared them. Shadow Weaver kept a close eye on her ankles, always burning some magic, to keep anything from sneaking up on her. She would not go down so easily. Nothing as simple as Beast Island could take down a sorcerer of her caliber.

The light of day, or whatever it was here, ebbed. Creatures with glowing eyes and sharp teeth appeared in branches, croaking until the woods echoed their nightmarish lullaby. The droning in the background ever present. It was so dense here that Shadow Weaver had to find shelter soon if she wished to get any rest. Too many enemies on too many exposed sides would be enough to end her.

Eventually, she came across a rock outcropping. With a naked palm, she ran her hand across it until she discovered a slab jutting out, creating a small shelter.

"And they call this place inhospitable," she said to herself above the cry of the darkness.

What Shadow Weaver had not expected was a response.

She jumped when a quiet, gristly voice said, "Get out." The words came out inhuman, more of an extension of the island's sounds than of language.

Regaining her balance, she laughed, spun around, and called upon her magic to produce a bright, dangerous flame in front of her. It grew, engulfing the shadows to show both her imposing figure and light up the new threat before her. If it was like most scurrying creatures here, it would flee before her. That was not the case.

For the second time, she was caught off guard. In a perfect reflection of her spell was another just like it, but purple flamed instead. She frowned. Only a trained sorcerer could produce that sort of magic and, to match her, they must have contained great power.

The figure removed their hood, erasing the last shadow between them. Working his mouth, he tried to remember how to speak. When he did, he croaked out, "Light Spinner?"

Shadow Weaver turned her blaze down. So did the man across from her. The best she could, with her scarred skin stifling her, she

gasped. She extinguished her light completely. “It can’t be. Micah?”

She-ra walked in the woods. The Sword of Protection hung at her side, nearly scraping against the ground as she moved forward. When she got to the Crystal Castle, she stopped. It stood in front of her, imposing. Her eyes flitted to the sword in her hand, then back to the entrance. A breeze blew by, taking her hair with it, shining golden against the sky’s light.

Birds chirped, small mammals snapped twigs, and the dead leaves were given new life as the wind hit them, sending whispers into the air. The soil beneath was ancient, even the ground itself magical. She-ra took the blade and tossed it in front of her. The thud sounded on its own, stopping the movement of the forest for a brief moment of time.

Not for the first time today, she clenched her fists. Her heart ticked up from a steady drum to a frantic, unmetered beat. When Adora had left Bright Moon, she’d transformed into She-ra immediately. When the light faded and left her standing taller, it was a rush. Her tired muscles turned tireless. The best part, though, was Adora no longer had to see her sallow skin or her fragile hair, which broke at every slight bending. Bodies, like minds, have memory, and she wanted to forget all the stories stored in her skin. There was nothing in She-ra to remind her about how she had been swallowed, used, and left to stand in the shadow of her former self.

The problem was, Adora had never been completely at home inside of She-ra either. Adora liked the feeling of her own body, at least before, more. It was smaller, faster, and less awkward to maneuver. She-ra’s stacked sinew made her feel bogged down, even if her legs had strengthened to bare the new weight. The

mass on her torso made her lungs feel like they didn't work properly. It was all mental, of course. Adora knew that in She-ra's body, she also had She-ra's lungs, which could power her oxygen consumption all day. She might have known it, but Adora never did fully adjust.

And then there were the clothes. They were inherited and felt like any other hand-me-downs. The shirt might have fit her perfectly, but it was clear someone else had picked it out. The shorts made her feel ridiculous. The cape made her jumpy, touching the back of her thighs with a tickle she was unaccustomed to. It was one of the reasons Adora never changed her uniform. It felt safe, the white shirt, Horde style combat pants, and the red jacket. She-ra touched her head, fingernails clinking against metal. And the tiara. She thought it was as stupid as Catra did. Adora had never worn jewelry in her life. It had no place in battle.

She-ra transformed back into Adora, who watched her hands shrink and her skin turn dull. Her stomach lurched at how bony they were. Even the brightest light couldn't make her skin shine. With a sigh, Adora put a hand in front of her eyes and looked at the position of the celestial bodies in the sky. She needed to get back to Bright Moon. She'd been out here all night. Adora let her hand fall to her forehead, covering her eyes.

There were people back there that needed her. Or, at least, they needed She-ra. She bent down to pick up the sword, leaving an imprint in the soft grasses as she did. Halfway through standing, she froze. It was just like when she had picked up the sword, finally free from infection, in the Fright Zone. Slowly, her knees unbent. She remembered the feeling of the disc in her hand. How she almost let it go. Adora twirled the sword in her hands.

It had felt so good, the disc breaking in her palm. How flakes of metal pressed against the flesh there, how the sound of it cracking had been unreal and the most honest truth at the same time.

Adora held the hilt to her sternum in both hands. It pressed into her skin the same way Catra's claws had in the Black Garnet Chamber in their final stand against Shadow Weaver. Adora freed one of her hands from the blade and ran it over her shoulders, remembering Catra helping her to stand when she was chained to the wall. Her fingertips ran down her cheek. It elicited the same flutter in her chest as when Catra gently touched her there, promising to rescue her.

The sword dropped from her hands as Adora traced a whisper of a touch on her palm. She remembered the first time that Catra, after finding out about Shadow Weaver's abuse, had stormed into her cell. Adora had told Catra to leave her alone then. Catra had refused and reached out to her. Adora hesitated, but they touched briefly. It had been the first time in so long that wasn't meant to hurt. Adora ran her hand over the spot again.

Words swam through her head.

Adora thought way back to before all this, before the Northern Reach, when Glimmer had found out about what happened to Adora as a child and her first response had been, *"It's not your fault."*

Next, it was Bow's voice in her head from yesterday, *"You aren't alone.*

"Adora, you are also worth fighting for," came in Mara's confident voice.

And, finally, her own words, uttered silently to her younger self. *"You are worth something. You can be happy too."*

And then, instead of sounds, it was images flashing in front of Adora's eyes like snapshots. It started with Catra smiling at her, a picture framed beautifully by the backdrop of the sky on their ride back to Bright Moon yesterday. Then, the memories flew by. Catra hanging upside-down from the top bunk. Catra splitting a ration bar in half to share with her. Catra wrapping up with her after a

faulty simulation almost froze them to death. Catra letting the barrier to her cell drop. Catra standing in between her and Shadow Weaver. Catra breaking her bonds. Catra taking her home.

"I'm here. I always will be."

Those were Catra's words from a long time ago and, when Adora remembered them, she smiled through tears she hadn't known were dropping. Her blood was pumping and her palms were sweaty, but she wasn't scared. Her heart felt like it was going to burst. Only after refocusing on the world around her did she realize she was still standing in the woods.

Adora looked over her shoulder at the direction of Bright Moon. "I need to get back," she whispered. This time without hesitation, she picked up the sword, and ran.

For a walk that had seemed so short on the way out, the run back went on forever. At some point, she transformed into She-ra to make sure her body could handle it, ignoring all the discomforts as she was fueled by a singular goal. As she broke through the tree line, she changed back to Adora and trotted up to the grand door of Bright Moon castle.

With leaves and dirt clinging to her, she made the way up to her room. When she threw the door open, Catra was waiting.

Adora's brusque entry had startled her, evident by a tipped over glass, the contents of which were still seeping across the floor. They stared at each other, unsure what to say next. Adora shut the door. The sound of the latch moving into place broke the tension, but with that gone, it creeped back in.

Catra pulled the collar of her shirt from her neck. Well, it was Adora's shirt. She still hadn't gotten fitted for new ones of her own. When she'd left the Fright Zone, she only had the clothes on her back and those were in a heap in the corner of the room. It was strange to have her arm and neck covered. She didn't know

how Adora could stand how tight the shirt fit, but Catra was glad it hung around her loosely. Right now, though, the collar against her throat felt constricting. She tugged on it again, cleared her throat, and finally spoke.

"Hey Adora," Catra bent over to tip the glass upright, "what's the rush? You've been gone all day."

Adora's eyes went wide, heart thudding in her chest.

"We've got that dumb debrief or whatever soon," Catra said, crossing her arms and looking away. Quietly, she said, "I've been looking for you all day, you know."

Adora's smile faltered when she saw the lines on Catra's face. "Sorry," she said, "I didn't -"

Catra cut her off with a sigh. "It's fine." She ran her hand through her hair, still riddled with irritation. Catra hadn't put her mask back on since bringing Adora back to Bright Moon. It made Adora think of when they were younger and it brought a glimpse of a smile back.

"Can we talk?" Adora asked, stepping up to Catra.

"Talk about what?" Catra said, scolding her.

"You said you have a lot to tell me," Adora said softly, "and I have a lot to tell you too."

Catra blinked and looked Adora in the eye for the first time today, catching Adora beaming at her. Catra's expression softened. Without warning, Adora hugged her. Catra let go of a breath she'd been holding and melted into the touch. It annoyed her, but she saw Bow and Glimmer in her mind giving her a thumbs up.

Then, it was just Bow, ushering at her to open up. Catra readied herself, but it all came crashing down when Adora bent down and put her lips next to Catra's ear. Catra tensed as Adora's warm breath passed to her.

“Nice shirt,” Adora whispered.

Catra groaned. “Why do you always have to ruin it?” she asked, but she squeezed Adora back before releasing.

Adora laughed and smiled a big, dumb, smug grin. Catra returned it, but tried not to, grumbling as she grabbed Adora’s hand and sat them both down. “You said you wanted to talk, so let’s talk.”

Adora blew air out of her mouth and swallowed, losing all the steam she had created on her way here. She had planned out what was going to happen next, but she was already thrown off. “Okay,” she said quietly.

“I want to say something first,” Catra bit her tongue. Adora reached out, but Catra pushed her away. “Just let me talk.”

Adora backed off and nodded. She folded her hands in her lap and waited expectantly.

“I wanted to tell you,” Catra shut her eyes, “that I’m scared.” She opened her eyes one at a time and saw Adora squint in concentration. This being vulnerable thing was already not going as planned.

“Is something bothering you? Because we can -”

Catra’s nostrils flared as she thought about destroying Glimmer’s room. “- no, Adora. No one is bothering me. It’s just - ugh,” Catra ran her fingers through her hair. “Just listen, okay?” Adora shut her mouth and relaxed her shoulders. “I’m scared. Not because I left the Horde or about the war or about people not liking me. Well, maybe the last one a bit.” Catra looked at Adora quickly before looking back down at her lap.

Adora blushed in response. “You can talk to me.”

“I know, I’m trying,” Catra said, exasperated. Her claws extended, ripping small holes into the sheets. “I’m scared that Shadow Weaver was right.” Adora went pale. “I mean - shit - I mean about

me. All those things she said about me. About how I wanted . . .” Catra squeezed the blanket hard as tears started to collect at the corners of her eyes, “How I want you to myself.”

“I don’t understand,” Adora said, scrunching her face together.

“I’m trying to explain, okay?” Catra’s voice scratched. “I didn’t capture you at the Northern Reach because I wanted to impress Hordak. I didn’t even care about the war. I don’t know if I ever did. Don’t you get it? I just wanted you to come home.”

“Catra, I -”

“- No, Adora, let me finish. When Shadow Weaver, I mean,” Catra swallowed thickly. “When she said I was jealous, she was right. I hated it when you became friends with Lonnie and Rogelio. I hated it when you became friends with Glimmer and Bow.” She started to choke up. “You always felt like you were slipping away, so I held tighter. And then, one day, you were gone.

“So, when I had the chance to bring you back, even in chains, I took it. I-I’m sorry, Adora.” Catra forced herself to look at Adora, whose eyes were gleaming. Catra wrung her hands together, “You are the most incredible person I’ve ever met,” she half-smiled, “but part of what makes you great is that you are generous and loving and I” she reached for Adora’s hand, “I never want to take that away from you. And seeing Shadow Weaver do it I – I never meant to do that to you. I messed up. I’ve been trying to make up for it ever since, but nothing will ever feel like enough. I’m just like her.”

The last of Catra’s walls came down and the wave of tears crashed against her. She pulled her hands to cover her face and sobbed. Her skin was hot and her hair caught in her mouth, but she didn’t care. Then, another pair of hands joined her, putting her back together. They stroked her cheeks. They pulled her hands away and swept away the tears.

“Catra, I,” Adora swallowed.

“You should hate me, Adora,” Catra said, her body going limp.

“Hate you?” Adora said, shocked. She pulled Catra to her chest. “I could never hate you.” Instead of responding, Catra let out more muffled cries into Adora’s shirt. Adora rubbed her back.

“I didn’t know at the time,” Adora started, “but I do now.”

Catra craned her neck to look at Adora’s face again in confusion. Adora smiled and rubbed Catra’s face with her sleeve.

“All that time in the Fright Zone gave me time to think,” Adora said, tightening. Catra tugged her sleeve to keep her focused. “Catra, look at me, you might have brought me there, but I know you didn’t want to hold me. You are nothing, listen, you are nothing like her. I don’t know how many times you let me go. Shadow Weaver would have never done that. You almost died saving me.”

“It doesn’t matter. Didn’t you hear what I just said?”

“You know I did,” Adora said. “I’m the one who never felt good enough for you.” Catra gave her a disbelieving look. “I couldn’t even protect you from Shadow Weaver.” Adora joined Catra in crying. “How could I be worth anything to you?”

Catra tugged on her sleeve again. “You’re so dumb.” Adora looked at her, tears brimming over her eyes. “You’re worth everything to me,” Catra said faintly. Everything was hot. Her face was hot from the tears and feeling exposed. Too much was bubbling near the surface. Too much that she had held inside for so long.

Reaching out, Adora wiped away the tears that hung at a standstill on Catra’s face. The silence was back and it hung between them. Adora readied herself for what had been running through her head ever since she left the Crystal Castle. If she was honest, the words had almost come out so many other times. When Catra had come to the Black Garnet chamber to save her the first time. When Catra saved Glimmer. Yesterday on the skiff. The moment when Shadow Weaver fell.

“I love you,” Adora said simply.

Red-faced and puffy, Catra gaped. “Y-you what?”

“I love you,” Adora laughed, running a hand through her hair. “I don’t think there’s ever a time I didn’t. When you tried to break me out of my cell, the first time, I thought I was dreaming. It was like getting another chance.”

“Adora,” Catra stuttered.

“You don’t have to say anything,” Adora said. “I was waiting for you. To leave the Horde. To come here. I don’t know.” She frowned, “In the end, you came and got me instead. A lot has happened and I-I’m not the same as I used to be. Shadow Weaver, she,” Adora started to shake as she bit back the memories, “I just - I thought you should know.”

Catra ran the back of her claws up the sides of Adora’s face. Adora looked at her. “She hurt you, but you’re still you.”

“I don’t feel like me,” Adora said.

“Then let me remind you,” Catra responded, leaning closer. “You’re not just She-ra. You’re not a tool. And you’re not a sacrifice.” Adora’s eyebrows knitted together as she held in tears. “You aren’t what Shadow Weaver said you are. And you’re not what the Rebellion says you are either. I know you. I’ve never not known you.” She took a deep breath. “I never cared about that other stuff. You’re all I ever needed, Adora. Just the way you are.” Catra swallowed. “I love you, too.”

“You do?” Adora gasped, placing her hand over one of Catra’s.

“Your friends picked up on it instantly,” Catra said. “I can’t believe it was ever a secret.”

“Do you remember,” Adora bit her lip, “when we were younger? I almost, we almost . . . .”

“How could I forget?” Catra asked shyly. “The day Shadow Weaver caught us in the hallway. We were . . . right?” Adora nodded, both of them timid and blushing now about the shared memory of the time they’d almost kissed. “I never understood why you pulled away from me after that.” Conflicting emotions ran over Catra’s features. “I do now.”

Adora nodded, remembering herself. “I was trying to protect you.”

“You don’t have to now,” Catra replied. “You’re safe now. We both are.”

Their eyes met, seeing each other new again. The muscles in Adora’s throat worked, but did not do their job. Her mouth felt dry. Barely above a whisper, she asked, “Can I?”

Catra leaned forward in response. Adora closed the distance. With her eyes closed, she kissed Catra. They’d been close all their lives, but never had they been this close. A moment of fear pulsed through Adora, but when Catra caressed her cheek again, she relaxed and sunk in comfortably. Shadow Weaver had kissed her before, but it wasn’t like this. It was cold and detached, this was full of life.

They pulled apart, messy in their tears and confessions.

“I’m sorry about last night,” Adora said.

Catra shook her head. “This isn’t going to be easy, but we can get through it together, okay?”

“Okay,” Adora said, smiling.

This time, Catra leaned in to kiss Adora.

Micah threw his staff out in front of him. “How many times do I have to get rid of you?”

Shadow Weaver stared at him, puzzled. Then, Micah began itching at his scalp, as if trying to dislodge some uncomfortable memory from his brain. “Micah, it’s me. I’m here for real.” She put her hands up.

“That’s what you always say,” he responded. “And every time I tell you the same thing. Even if you’re real, especially if you are, you are not welcome here.”

“And why’s that?” Shadow Weaver asked calmly, bringing back her fire. “I trained you. Molded you into what you are today.” Both his fists glowed with new magic. Shadow Weaver dropped hers. “Micah, I don’t wish to fight you. Please, let’s talk about this.” Shadow Weaver conjured the image of a pink crystal and moved it across the ground just as she had all those years ago. “For old time’s sake.”

“What are you doing?” he asked. With a wave of his hand, he put an end to her illusion. “I know what you did to me. Get out of my head.”

“Micah, please listen. I was cast out, the same as you,” she said. “We aren’t so different, you and me.”

Micah pressed his hand to his face as if trying to push Shadow Weaver back inside. “Stop it.”

Shadow Weaver opened her palms and conjured a weak image of Angella. “I know you want to get off this island. She’s there waiting for you. I saw her just recently.”

“Angie?” Micah said, feet pulling him forward. His eyes flickered back and forth quickly over the fading image in Shadow Weaver’s hands. Shadow Weaver closed her fist. “Bring her back!”

“Your daughter, too, has grown,” Shadow Weaver said, bringing up a new image of Glimmer.

When he saw it, he gaped. “That is not my baby girl,” he whispered.

“Micah, much time has passed since your,” she looked at him, “disappearance. Everyone thought you were dead. I admit that even I made that mistake. Look closer.”

He did as she commanded, before shooting a magical beam straight at her heart. “What did you do to her?”

She deflected it, eyes wide. “Micah, Micah,” she grabbed his shoulders and he flinched backwards, breaking her grip. “Glimmer and I have barely met.”

He brushed his clothing where she had touched, eyes wide in terror. He drew a rune in the air. Before shooting the magic her way, he held back, with a quivering hand. “How can you touch me?”

“Micah, I told you, it’s me.” Shadow Weaver folded her hands in front of her. “And if you and I work together,” she pulled the vial of blue powder from her robes, “we can get off this island, for good.”

He moved towards her quickly. “Where did you get that? It can’t be.”

With her hand, she took his and opened his palm. His skin was tough, beaten on by the elements. “Take it. See for yourself.” Without flourish, she placed the vial in his hands. It glowed on contact and Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. His power was still strong.

He closed his fist around it. “What game are you playing?”

“Our goals are the same,” she said. “You want to get back to that family of yours and I want to get back to mine.”

She placed her hand on his shoulder again. Under her fingers, he trembled, but did not back away. With a shaky voice he said, “You

can’t do this to me anymore.”

“I helped you become this strong,” she said, grabbing his other shoulder. “You would have never survived out here without my training. And you’ll never make it back to Bright Moon without me either. Things are the same as they’ve always been.”

He knocked her hands aside. “I’m not a little boy anymore.” He growled ferally. “I looked up to you, you know. You took something from me that I will never, ever get back.”

“Ungrateful,” Shadow Weaver tsked. “But nevermind it, I have no interest in you except to get off this island. Then we can part ways. What do you say?”

He eyed her cautiously. “How did you get out here?”

“Does it matter?” she asked slyly. “All that matters is that I get back. I have someone dear to me also.”

A jolt of panic went through Micah, as physical as if a spear had been thrown through his chest. It had always been his greatest fear that Shadow Weaver would haunt someone else the way he haunted her. “What did you do?” Shadow Weaver raised an eyebrow at him. His anger spiked. “What did you do?” he asked, loudly, voice scaring off several small beasts.

She frowned. His wild eyes searched her damaged ones. Heavy, raw air hung between them. The constant buzz at the back of Shadow Weaver’s mind started to grow. She had actively ignored it, but now it broke through a barrier. She put a hand up to hear ear, trying to muffle the noise.

“So, you can hear it already,” he said, smiling a wicked grin that did not fit on his face. Micah had never been cruel, not even in the slightest. When he bared his teeth now, he looked murderous.

In her moment of distraction, vines so like the ones Shadow Weaver used to employ to trap her adversaries circled her ankles. She fought them, grunting and kicking until she was screaming,

“Micah, help me! We must leave now!” The droning noise rose like a wave, crashing inside her mind until her thoughts washed away. “No. No!”

Micah backed away as she called his name again. If this was really Light Spinner, he could finally make things right.

“I did everything for you!” She yelled. “Why does no one,” she sank to her knees and her voice dropped into a whisper, “understand. All I wanted to do was make you great.”

The ringing in Micah’s head got louder until he was screaming next to her. “You never wanted to help me.” With his staff he sent a ball of fire into the oncoming vines behind him. “And I don’t need you. I never did.” He clenched his fist, still holding the vial, and took one last look at Shadow Weaver before retreating into the darkness around.

Vines curled up Shadow Weaver’s body, suspending her arms and trapping her like prey in a spider’s web. Finally, the vines circled her neck. “No one understands.” Her head fell limp and her thoughts went silent.

The room was hot and, around the war table, there were extra chairs packed between the regular seats, making room to accommodate all the extra company. Catra almost sat in Adora’s chair, where she had sat during mission planning, which earned her an amused look from Adora. Blushing, she shifted her weight and plopped in one of the guest chairs instead. Adora sat, but kept Catra’s hand in her lap. Across the table, Glimmer’s eyebrow quirked up to the sky and Catra buried her face in her free hand. Bow whispered into Glimmer’s ear, only making her grin more unbearably.

Others began to file in. Kyle gave an awkward wave to Adora, while Lonnie came over and hugged her. Rogelio lifted them both up. When Catra looked to Adora to see if she was okay, she just nodded and hugged them back. Everyone took a turn in their own way.

Frosta hobbled over and gave Adora a fist pump. Mermista pushed against Adora's shoulder and said, "Hey, we missed you or whatever. Glad you're back." Scorpia, despite never having a positive interaction with Adora before this, burst into tears at the sight of her. When Adora didn't know how to console her and shot Catra a desperate look, Perfuma took over after hugging Adora for too long. Sea Hawk picked her up and immediately challenged her to another arm-wrestling match, saying that first he "needed to heal" from their latest adventures.

Netossa and Spinnerella waved from across the room, giving her space. Spinnerella looked at Adora, then Catra, then winked at Adora, which made heat flood up her neck.

When Angella entered the room, Bow coughed fakely in warning. "I don't want to keep anyone here too long, but I'd like to get the story straight," Angella said in greeting. She slouched a little more in her chair, "And I wanted to thank all of you one more time for everything you've done for the Rebellion. You deserve my deepest gratitude."

Adora froze as discomfort settled in. Catra gripped her hand tighter and moved her lips to Adora's ear. Though Glimmer strained to hear it, she couldn't. When Adora laughed out loud, everyone's curiosity was piqued.

"Sorry," Adora said, sending a chastising look Catra's way. "Please continue." Catra laid back lazily, a smug look on her face.

"Very well," Angella said, amused.

What was promised to be a quick and easy debrief of the rescue mission turned to chaos the second Mermista was given the floor.

Perfuma smiled as Mermista stood quietly when, nearly shocking Perfuma out of her seat, Mermista slammed her foot on the war room table and pointed to the sky. With every twist in the plot, she sauntered around the room, shaking the chairs of unsuspecting occupants when a particularly exciting turn of events unfolded. The swell of her voice grew and grew until Perfuma would interject with a small detail. Then, Mermista would start the cadence over, building the tension anew. Lonnie only egged her on, which Mermista took in stride.

Rogelio shook his head. And Kyle somehow made the fact that he punched Hordak seem lame, though Mermista swooped in to save him as if she had witnessed the event. After a few corrections by Perfuma, who had actually been there, Mermista moved on, talking more about the pile of Horde soldiers they'd taken down than about anything else.

Catra sighed and blushed as the highlights of their valor were overstated. When it came her turn to discuss what happened in the Black Garnet Chamber, she kept it tight. When she finished her account in under thirty seconds, Mermista slumped in her chair and said, "Way to not, like, deliver on the climax." Adora fell back into her chair in relief.

On her side, Netossa couldn't get a word out about the trip underground over Frosta and Scorpia, neither of whom could tell their story in a linear order. They jumped all around until everything was so scrambled they weren't even sure where they were. When Glimmer took over, she used her hands to speak more than her words, using gestures to communicate while she made unintelligible noises that only Bow seemed to understand.

And Bow, poor Bow. He started out with brief facts, Sea Hawk nodding behind him. When Bow missed a key detail, Sea Hawk jumped, standing on his chair. From there, Sea Hawk couldn't be stopped. He embellished their daring adventure and Bow did all he could to discount the less true parts of Sea Hawk's narrative.

In the middle of a long inhale by Sea Hawk, Angella cut him off. Mermista relaxed in her seat, glad as she was almost certain she had just been spared one of Sea Hawk's shanties. He looked disappointed, dropped back to his chair, and muttered to Mermista that he would "make sure to give her the full song of his feat" on the trip back to Salineas.

Mermista groaned loud enough to silence the rest of the room, which heard her say, "Why do you think you're coming back with me?"

Angella cleared her throat and, largely, most things and people calmed down. Like Catra, Angella kept the details very few. The room grew solemn and Adora could feel the way everyone was looking at her, even if they weren't using their eyes. Her skin grew hot and, when Catra reached for her hand under the table, she shied away.

There were a few closing remarks, which Adora did not hear as she thought through everything her friends had put on the line. At the end they welcomed her back, but the lump in her throat was too big. After a choked moment, she was able to say, "Thank you. You have no idea how thankful I am. You're the best friends I could have asked for." She meant it. This time, when Catra reached, Adora took her hand.

Everyone stayed in their chairs for a moment and then, slowly, they began to rise. There were a few lingering goodbyes that Adora stayed for as the princesses readied themselves for the long trips back to their respective kingdoms. Or, in Scorpia's case, back to Plumeria, "just for a little bit," she had said blushing profusely when Catra gave her a sly smile. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle were going with Mermista. Perfuma had welcomed them to come to Plumeria, but the trio shied away wanting to give Scorpia and Perfuma some alone time for now.

When only Bow, Glimmer, Catra, Adora, and Angella remained, Angella commanded, "Adora, a moment if you will."

The knot in Adora's gut wrapped around itself and pulled. Glimmer eyed them both and started to sit down. Angella coughed, "Alone."

"We'll see you after, okay?" Bow whispered. Bow pulled Glimmer out of the chamber, leaving Catra scowling.

"After this," Adora promised Catra. "I'll find you, okay?"

After this morning, Catra wasn't sure she was ready to leave Adora's side again. The fur on her neck started to rise up.

"I promise," Adora said, trailing her fingers down Catra's face. "Right after."

Catra turned toward the door and, after a brief hesitation, pulled the door open and stepped through. Adora sighed and faced Angella, "What can I do for you, your majesty?"

"No need for such formalities, Adora," Angella said, retaking her seat. "Please, sit." Adora did, shifting uncomfortably. The chair hadn't even lost its warmth yet. "I wanted to talk about my expectations for you going forward."

Adora straightened. "I'm ready for duty. She-ra's sword is no longer corrupted-"

"-That's not what I mean, Adora." Angella said, opening her hands. Adora broke eye contact as her mouth went dry. "We don't need to talk about what happened." Adora's face paled. "I'm sorry - I don't mean to resurface memories." Angella cleared her throat, "I'm not going to tell you that you cannot fight, Adora. Certainly, we need She-ra, but more importantly, we need you."

Adora tapped her fingers on her lap. "So, then what's this about?"

Angella considered her, lacing her fingers together. "Adora, I hope you consider Glimmer, myself, and, if I may be so bold, Bow, as family. I certainly think of you that way."

Some of the tightness in Adora's shoulders faded. "You do?"

"Of course, I do. The things you've done for us." Angella shook her head, remembering. "The things you've done for me. But, it's not just about that. We take care of each other. We always will. I just want you to know that we'll always be here for you. And, as I understand it, so will Catra."

When Angella said Catra's name, Adora's chest tightened and her ears burned. She let it all out in a great gush that earned her a raised eyebrow from Angella. Caught, she stumbled on her words, "I - thank you."

Angella waved her away. "Adora, you must know that you are not alone. I am sorry that this," she bit her tongue, "that any of this happened to you." She looked at Adora, who looked back with watery eyes. Angella placed her palms against the table, "Now, I believe there is someone back in your room who wanted a word with you."

Standing, Angella moved towards the door. Adora swallowed. "Angella? I mean it. Thank you. You and Glimmer," she bit her lip, "you mean everything to me."

With a smile, Angella responded, "And you to us, Adora." Her smile widened. "She's waiting for you, go to her."

Adora opened the door and, when she did, a popping noise sounded and then, in front of her, Bow, Glimmer, and Catra appeared. Glimmer and Bow grinned sheepishly while Catra's ears were laid flat against her skull. Adora smirked, "Were you all listening?"

"Of course not," Catra muttered, sulking away.

Glimmer itched the back of her head, "Pfft, no. Why would we do that?"

Adora's eyes fell on Bow, who gulped. "We maybe caught a little bit of it at the end."

“Bow!” Glimmer cried, pushing him playfully.

Adora laughed. Everyone perked up at the sound, laughing themselves. Still cracking up, Adora threw her arms around them. When they did the same, it felt good. It was in stark contrast to the day before, but Adora took it in, heart feeling light.

“I missed you so much,” Adora said, laughter and tears intermingling now. “All of you.”

“We missed you too, Adora,” Bow said.

Glimmer snorted through her nose, “And now Catra even likes us.”

“Don’t push it,” Catra said, pressing herself as close to Adora as she could. “I still don’t trust all the glitter.”

Gradually, the embrace fell away. At least, Bow and Glimmer moved back. Catra stayed firmly under Adora’s arm.

“What’s that sound?” Bow asked, glancing back and forth between them.

Catra blushed. “I don’t hear anything. Quit making stuff up.” But the sound only grew louder.

“Are you purring?” Glimmer gasped. “You can do that?”

“Shut up!” Catra bellowed, hiding her face in Adora’s shoulder, which only made the purr louder.

Bow tucked his hands under his chin and gleamed. “That is so -”

“- don’t say it!” Catra yelled.

Bow threw his fists in the air. “Cute!”

Adora laughed and held Catra even tighter, languishing in the smell and feel of her.

Glimmer gave one of her famous shit-eating grins again. “Well, you know what my mom said,” she nodded to Bow, “Adora and Catra need some alone time. Catra has been waiting after all, isn’t that right?”

“Glimmer!” Bow said, but his smile was bursting out of him. “Be nice!”

She threw her head back and laughed again as Catra hissed at her. Trying to shut Glimmer up, Catra went to her tiptoes and kissed Adora on the cheek. Adora brightened. Glimmer audibly gasped. Bow nearly burst into tears.

Glimmer reached out for Bow and he took her hand. “You can have the rest of the day, but I’m going to be on your case tomorrow.” Before they blinked away, Glimmer winked again.

“They’re idiots,” Catra said, grumbling, purring, and lashing her tail all at the same time.

Adora tilted Catra’s chin up with a gentle touch. “They’re not idiots. And they’re not wrong. You are cute.” Adora kissed her and the purr rumbled back.

Catra pushed Adora away, blushing even more as she looked around the hallway. She slid their hands together and led Adora back to their room. When they entered, Adora hugged her again.

They stayed that way. All Adora could think about was Catra here, with her, and how they were both finally free.

In the corner of her eye, Adora caught the younger version of herself, the same one she’d comforted in the Black Garnet chamber. Gaped toothed, she smiled up at Adora. Adora smiled back.

Chapter End Notes

The End.

Thanks for reading.

Tumblr

Author's Note

The response to this story has blown me away. I never thought we'd go over 1000 kudos. I never thought it'd have any significant following. I started writing this to help me process some of my past trauma but was amazed that it aided others too. On top of that, the story itself was well received. The story ended in April but I still read these comments and I'm happy that this meant so many things to the readers. To thank you all, I wrote a short oneshot that follows the events of Waxing/Waning. It is called Gibbous Moon. I hope you enjoy a glimpse into Adora and Catra's healing as we only began to touch on it in Waxing/Waning. Thank you!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!